



LB TAURIS

Religion, Enlightenment and the Sexual Revolution



SEX^{AND}
THE
CHURCH
in the
LONG EIGHTEENTH
CENTURY

WILLIAM GIBSON AND
JOANNE BEGIATO

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‘This is a ground-breaking book which makes a convincing case that the Church and sex were much more closely linked than previously recognised. The authors have made a case that demands attention and re-evaluates our view of religion and sexual behaviour in the period of the Enlightenment. It is an important work which deserves to be widely read.’

Jeremy Black, Professor of History, University of Exeter

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*Religion, Enlightenment
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WILLIAM GIBSON AND
JOANNE BEGIATO

BLOOMSBURY ACADEMIC
LONDON • NEW YORK • OXFORD • NEW DELHI • SYDNEY

BLOOMSBURY ACADEMIC
Bloomsbury Publishing Plc
50 Bedford Square, London, WC1B 3DP, UK
1385 Broadway, New York, NY 10018, USA

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First published by I.B. Tauris in 2017
Paperback edition first published by Bloomsbury Academic 2019

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A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library.

A catalog record for this book is available from the Library of Congress.

ISBN: HB: 978-1-7845-3377-9
PB: 978-1-7883-1987-4
ePDF: 978-1-7867-3157-9
ebook: 978-1-7867-2157-0

Typeset by OKS Prepress Services, Chennai, India

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PREFACE AND ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Preface

This is a book about sex and religion in England and Wales in the long eighteenth century, broadly the period between the revolution of 1688 and the repeal of the Test and Corporations Acts in 1828. It does not address Scotland and Ireland, though in some cases Scottish and Irish events were cited in England and Wales. The ‘Church’ referred to in the title is the Church of England, so the book focuses on Anglicans, only considering those who dissented from the Church, either Protestants or Catholic, when their experiences and roles help to illuminate the predominantly Anglican culture of the period. When nine in ten of English people were Anglican we can regard ‘religion’ and ‘the Church’, for the most part, as interchangeable. We also recognise the important distinction between theology and the Church’s teaching and behaviour – though they were in a close relationship; theology was both a cause and a consequence of social attitudes to sex. Both reflected the intensely Protestant and Anglican mind-set of most people in England.

The term ‘sex’ in the title includes beliefs and teaching about sexual acts, attitudes towards people’s sexual practices and sexualities, and only peripherally considers sexual identities. We do not intend to reify penetrative sex as more significant, or qualitatively different, from other forms of sexual behaviour. Tim Hitchcock has demonstrated why such an approach is inherently problematic. ‘Sex’ in our approach includes a

number of different and distinct things: reproduction, marriage as a religious forum for reproduction, sexual behaviour, and sexuality, by which we mean the experience of desire; and sexual identity both in public and to the individual. There is a danger that, since the Church was heteronormative in its teaching, that we adopt this as a lens through which we view sex in the eighteenth century. In fact heteronormativity is challenged at various points throughout the book, not just in chapter seven where we discuss same-sex behaviour, but in the attention that we pay to the experience of women. Women's experience of sex and sexuality is integral to our discussion of erotic writing, to evangelicalism and to marriage.

Given its attention to theology, advice, and discipline, the book often considers the elite. Some of the chapters, especially those on evangelicalism and on the public sphere, for example, pay specific attention to leaders and those at the top of English society, or to organisations such as Methodism, which was directed and controlled by leaders such as John and Charles Wesley and George Whitefield. Moreover, England was a deeply hierarchical society in this period and one of the features of the period we are examining is the degree to which sexual attitudes and behaviour were socially differentiated. As such this survey includes people beneath the elite, in the lower and middling ranks whose voices were heard in institutions like the church courts and whose actions were visible at individual and collective level in court cases, community action, and popular culture. They participated in communal and self-policing of morals, instrumentally deployed the church court's services, and consulted clergymen to serve their own ends. We consider both the beliefs of the Church expressed by its leaders and clergy, and we also examine the ways in which popular belief and ideas of both religion and sex related to them. Overall, our purpose is to show how powerful and pervasive religion was in the world of sex in this period, and to argue that historians of sex and of the Enlightenment have been too quick to appropriate sex into the world of rationalism, modernity and science.

Acknowledgements

We are grateful to Mike Harkness, Senior Search Room Assistant, Durham University Library Archives and Special Collections for speedy

assistance with references. We would also like to thank those colleagues and friends who generously took the time read the book, or parts of it and comment on it. These include Jeremy Black, Michael Brown, Peter Forsaith, Elizabeth Foyster, Diarmaid MacCulloch, David Nash, Jessica Parr, Tim Hitchcock and Daniel Reed. Of course they are not responsible for any blemishes that remain.

INTRODUCTION

Silencing the Church on Sex

This book argues that the Church played a vital role in the formation of social, cultural, and individual attitudes towards sex in the long eighteenth century. It is a view that has not attracted much scholarly attention. The influential relationship between sex and the Anglican Church has been overlooked for several reasons. Historians of the period, predisposed by Victorian historiography¹ and influenced by the Enlightenment and secularisation agendas, have assumed that the eighteenth century saw the waning of the influence of faith.² Although historians of religion have challenged and largely despatched the myth of secularisation in the eighteenth century, it, or at least the notion of declining faith, continues to exert a pull over historians of sexuality.³ For example, Tim Hitchcock's otherwise excellent study of *English Sexualities, 1700–1800* excludes any discussion of 'religious discourses' relating to sex.⁴ At the same time, historians of the Enlightenment, however it is defined, have presented the era as one of reason and the development of scientific models of behaviour.⁵ For some, the Enlightenment preoccupation with rationalism suggests that sex became a matter principally of individual choice and conscience, of medical knowledge, and one dominated by the print culture of the period.⁶ In parallel, they see a collapse in the significance of community, traditional moral teaching, and of the roles of superstition and religious belief in eighteenth-century discussions of sex. Moreover, Enlightenment sensibilities explored ideas closely associated with sexual appetites and behaviour: luxury, indulgence, self-identity, imagination, and consumption.

For many scholars of sexuality, therefore, the Enlightenment transformed sexual culture. Thomas Laqueur boldly claims that ‘modern masturbation can be dated with a precision rare in cultural history’ to the first decade of the eighteenth century, in his book on masturbation, *Solitary Sex*. For Laqueur, Samuel Tissot’s *Onania* ushered in the sexual Enlightenment, in which masturbation reflected ‘Enlightenment’ notions of imagination, selfhood, secrecy, pleasure, female agency and indulgence.⁷ In apparently consciously writing religion out of his account of eighteenth-century masturbation, Laqueur ignored, first, that Tissot’s work was adopted and abridged by John Wesley, thereby reaching a wider, and religious, audience, and, secondly, that successive editions of *Onania* included quasi-conversion religious narratives in which contributors described their experience of masturbation. In one typical case a man described how he indulged in masturbation in a barn at night and became increasingly weak, but by immersing himself in prayer he repented and was able to ‘deny the devil’.⁸ Similarly, George E. Haggerty’s *Men in Love, Masculinity and Sexuality in the Eighteenth Century*, a literary account of homosexuality, does not even mention religion as a source of popular ideas about sex. It seems that for several historians of sex in the eighteenth century religion is a last bastion of Whig historicism. Even in *Origins of Sex*, which acknowledges religion’s powerful influence on attitudes towards sex, Faramerz Dabhoiwala sees social and intellectual factors as dominant motors for change in the eighteenth century. Indeed he argues that ‘the sexual revolution was a central part of the European and North American Enlightenment’.⁹ However, Dabhoiwala’s Enlightenment turns away from religion.¹⁰

It is equally the case that historians of eighteenth-century religion have not addressed issues of sexuality.¹¹ Recent historians of evangelicalism have considered it, notably Henry Abelove in *Evangelist of Desire, John Wesley and the Methodists* (1990), and Brett McInelly in *Textual Warfare and the Making of Methodism* (2014). For the most part, however, historians of all denominations have tended to regard the history of sexuality as irrelevant, a marginal aspect of Anglican clerical activities, or even sordid and prurient. They confine matters of sex to discussions of the church courts’ regulatory jurisdiction over illicit sexual behaviour over the course of the eighteenth century, or consider sex as one of the bodily temptations that individuals struggled with, for

example in clergymen's diaries or the conversion narratives of the laity.¹² The absence of work on sexuality also reflects scholars' embarrassment and self-consciousness, a position challenged most recently by Ronald Hyam in *Empire and Sexuality*; and some church historians' personal faith has led to defensiveness and a desire to present the Church as divine in origin.¹³

The situation has not been helped by churches' silence on matters of sex. Diarmaid MacCulloch argues that this was due to institutional embarrassment and the sexually transgressive nature of some religious movements, such as the Anglo-Catholic movement of the nineteenth century. This impulse led to a 'self-editing' in Christianity, like John Wesley's self-censorship.¹⁴ Silence was thus a means by which sex and its morally troubling aspects could be written out of history and an idealised, if bland individual and institutional past constructed; indeed, an earlier generation of scholars who discovered inconvenient truths about leading Christian figures were prepared to leave them undisclosed. Examples include the expurgation of obscene passages from John Thomlinson's diary mentioned in chapter eight and in the silence of commentators on John Wesley's bloodletting, examined in chapter five. In Thomlinson's case his juvenile and obscene diary entries were thought to be too vulgar for the scholarly community in 1910 and in the case of Wesley the hagiographic industry that Methodism spawned could not cope with anything other than an idealised leader.

Another major reason to consider the relationship between attitudes towards sexuality and the Church is the need to carry forward the historiographical revision, and now broad consensus, begun in the 1980s, that the eighteenth-century Church was a powerfully influential political, social and cultural institution.¹⁵ This corrected view of the Church will only be partial if its role in important aspects of social and cultural life is unexamined. This book, therefore, stands in that historiographical tradition and charts the influence of the eighteenth-century Church on understandings of sexuality. It is located in a more recent consensus within the history of sexuality, represented by Lesley Hall, that even in the twentieth century: 'it is undoubtedly the case that spiritual beliefs continued to play a significant role for much longer than simplistic stories of modernity and secularisation might suggest'.¹⁶

Politics, Theology, and the Enlightenment

This book therefore has two broad objectives: to restore religion to a central place in understanding sexuality in the long eighteenth century and to recognise that the Church, as a pervasive and dominant influence on society, was deeply connected to matters of sex. It does not, however, suggest that the eighteenth century was simply an extension of the sexual *ancien régime*, or perhaps *régimes*, of earlier periods. There were distinct, though uneven and not consistently 'progressive', changes in attitudes to sex in the period. This unevenness, and the frequent reversals in sexual attitudes, are an important feature of the period and firmly resist the Whiggish account of the period as an onward march to the Enlightenment, 'modernity,' and personal liberty. Historians have often ascribed changes in sexual attitudes and behaviour to the universal, though rarely anatomised, solvent of the Enlightenment. What historians of religion have seldom considered is that religion and theology were not simply passive, ambient influences on sexual behaviour but were engines of some of the changes that appeared in sexual attitudes and behaviour. This is not to argue for a repressive as opposed to permissive history of sexual change. In intellectual and religious shifts with regard to sex, the classification of sex acts into good or bad, acceptable or illicit, was a product of social power.¹⁷

The idea of religion and theology as motors of changes in sexual behaviour challenges the secularisation and Enlightenment narratives. It might appear plausible that the Toleration Act of 1689 loosened strictures on religious consciences, and therefore also on sexual culture. In fact, as chapter one shows, the powerful influence of Latitudinarian theology, and in particular of Pelagianism, was the forerunner of *both* the growth of politeness and sociability which so strongly features in historical scholarship *and* developments in sexual attitudes. The angry God, who punished all men and women for the sins of Adam and Eve, became less familiar than a God who wanted people to achieve their political, social, economic, and also their sexual, potential. Consequently the role of the Church was not diminished, rather it had a new function: teaching the proper regulation and restraint of sexual desire and pleasure and its lawful and moral expressions. Indeed changes in attitudes to sex in this period do not reflect a waning but a waxing of religious principles.

Historians have debated the nature of the Enlightenment. Some, like Jonathan Israel, champion a comprehensive, progressive and determinist interpretation while others, like Jonathan Clark, disagree.¹⁸ Perhaps the most significant challenge came from Michel Foucault who argued that the Enlightenment did not open up liberal values and end oppressive external discipline, but was, rather, a cultural phenomenon which imposed new forms of self-discipline on the individual. Indeed, while the Enlightenment apparently introduced reason to Europe, secular and religious institutions were exerting greater control over populations in all sorts of ways including the regulation of sex. Consequently, Foucault argued for a 'darker' Enlightenment in which sex was not liberalised and made subject to reason but was the subject of repression and coercion.¹⁹ Clearly, the generalised view of the Enlightenment and sexuality cannot be sustained without close attention to the particular.²⁰

So while there were profound changes in religious attitudes to sex in the eighteenth century, they cannot satisfactorily be ascribed to the cure-all of an anti-religious Enlightenment. Sexual behaviour changed, but this change was often led by churchmen rather than in opposition to them. Moreover, it is untenable to construct sexual behaviour in the eighteenth century as a secular or secularising paradigm. Anglican theology was not marginalised by changes in attitudes to sex, it was the cause and motivator of some of the changes. So to place religion and sex in the eighteenth century in separate categories of thought and behaviour is a mistake; they were for most people inseparable.

One of the themes in this book is the persistent relationship between theology, politics, and sex. To the twenty-first century ear this sounds odd. But this was an era in which theology and politics were intimately connected, and, at times, one and the same. Indeed, 'heterodoxy' and 'dissent' were often defined both politically and theologically. The same is true of sex. As this book demonstrates, people often aligned unorthodox sexual behaviour with unorthodox religion and politics. Consequently, Catholic Jacobites were regarded as sexually, as well as politically and religiously, dangerous; Methodism was attacked as popish and sexually transgressive, and early eighteenth-century women grappled with the idea that non-resistance to the state might be analogous to obedience to a husband. By the early nineteenth century the politico-theology of sex was strongly influenced by events. During the French Revolution and Napoleonic wars sexual

freedom came to be regarded as a dangerous portent of anti-clericalism and antagonism toward aristocracy and monarchy, and conversely France represented the place to which homosexuals fled and from which corrupting pornography entered Britain.²¹

The later part of the eighteenth century is sometimes seen as an age of reform, which embraced morality. For eighteenth-century historians such ideas call to mind the problem of a Whig interpretation of history in which society progresses towards modernity. This book recognises that changes in attitudes occurred during the final quarter of the eighteenth-century; but contends that these changes often materialized under the influences of new ideas and economic transformation. Yet we would want to avoid crude suggestions that in religious matters there was an 'unreformed' and a 'reformed' period. The structural reforms of the Church of England in the 1840s were not a stark break with the past, they were the continuation of a number of processes, some of which included ideas of sex.

The Ambiguities of Sex and Faith

One of the difficulties of writing about sex and the Church in the eighteenth century is the tendency to assume that belief, or absence of belief, and morality or immorality were hard and fast, impermeable and permanent categories. In fact, of course, this was not so. In the first place there is little evidence for the exclusive categories of faith and sex. Eighteenth-century institutions certainly integrated the two. For example Jonas Hanway's 1758 scheme for a Magdalen Hospital was not only a refuge for the large numbers of prostitutes who plied their trade in mid-Georgian London. In fact, Hanway was motivated by both a desire to clear the streets of the open plying of the sex 'trade' and a desire to save the souls of those women who would grasp the opportunity to abandon their sinful ways. Hogarth's huge canvasses for the entrance hall of St Bartholomew's Hospital, one of which showed Jesus healing at the *Pool of Bethesda*, and probably depicts at least some of the afflicted suffering from venereal disease, indicated the biblical basis for the foundation and a similarly providential hope for healing. The Lock Hospital for venereal diseases was equally religious in origin and intention. The first meeting of the hospital governors began with a reading of St John's account of Jesus' response to the stoning of the

adulteress: 'he that is without sin among you, let him cast the first stone,' which captures the religious character of the philanthropy on which the hospital was built. Despite the deeply unfashionable nature of the patients' afflictions, and its perpetual need for funds, in 1762 the hospital built a large chapel. Moreover, its first chaplain, Martin Madan, was a celebrity preacher who attracted huge audiences; and pew rents and sales of sermon tickets probably accounted for half the Lock Hospital's income.²²

Thomas Coram's Foundling Hospital and the Magdalen and Lock Hospitals were all motivated by a religiously-inspired change in the ways women were perceived.²³ During the sexual vigilantism of the early eighteenth century and of the societies for the reformation of manners, prostitutes were seen as brazen, sinful whores who drew men to temptation and damnation; but by the middle of the eighteenth century prostitutes were regarded as victims of men's sinful predation and self-indulgence.²⁴ Such views lay behind Martin Madan's proposals for legalised polygamy examined in chapter eight.

Eighteenth-century individuals also encountered considerable moral ambiguity and complexity in matters of sex and faith, which hardly points to an advancing modernisation and liberalisation. For instance, people experienced periods of uncertainty and doubt in their faith, and may also have experienced fluctuations in their personal morality. The uncertainty and malleability of both is captured in some eighteenth- and nineteenth-century conversion narratives, whose authors resisted sexual temptation and frequently failed to arrive at a new level of faith. For every indicator of sexual liberty or secularisation there was another of struggle in reconciling sexual acts with religion. For example, should it be concluded that the fairly common use of St Paul's Cathedral's precinct for clandestine homosexual liaisons represented a conscious and flagrant flouting of religious teaching, or simply a search for a quiet, dark place for illicit sex?²⁵ Equally, when John Painter and John Green were arrested in September 1727 for conducting 'Sodomitical Practices in Stepney Church-Porch' was this a case of deliberate desecration?²⁶ Certainly 'Molly Christenings,' in which homosexuals adopted new female-nicknames, implies a parody of baptism and exposes the intricate associations between sex and religion.²⁷

This religious ambivalence can be seen in individual lives and choices: in 1762 James Boswell solicited a prostitute in the Strand and planned

to have sex with her. He recalled toying with her, but in the end confessed: 'I gave her a shilling, and had command enough of myself to go without touching her. I afterwards trembled at the danger I had escaped.'²⁸ What is to be made of this? Boswell was certainly fearful of catching venereal disease and 'armoured' himself with a sheep gut condom. But did his trembling also arise from his guilt over his flouting Christian rules? Dudley Ryder, an earnest and serious minded young dissenter who attended Anglican services and read large numbers of sermons and religious tracts, nevertheless experienced the urge to 'fill a whore's commodity' in April 1716, though he was too shy to do so.²⁹ In Maria Edgeworth's novel *Belinda* of 1801, Lady Delacour marked passages in John Wesley's *Admonitions*; when this was discovered she suggested that she did so in mockery rather than admiration, though her maid suspected otherwise.³⁰ Evasion was a human trait in both religion and sexuality.

What should be made of the mob's treatment of John Waller, an 'affidavit man' who gave false evidence against prostitutes, homosexuals and other criminals, and on whose evidence some were sentenced to death. When Waller was revealed as a perjurer, whose evidence had condemned prostitutes and homosexuals to execution, he was punished by the pillory. The mob savagely attacked Waller and killed him while he stood in the pillory, some shouting that they were sending his soul to hell.³¹ Although he had attacked sexual transgressors, Waller's behaviour was in violation of popular morality. It seems that faith and sex always operated in a highly complex and ambiguous relationship.

There were no hard and fast categories of sex and religion even in perceptions of prostitution in the long eighteenth century. For example, prostitutes took sides in religious controversies. In 1710 the Sacheverell trial led to riots in London on the issue of whether Protestant dissenters were dangerous to the Church of England. The trial brought to the surface of London society the deeply-felt divisions between High and Low churchmen. One of the sections of the population which mobilised for Sacheverell's High Church Tory opinions were the London prostitutes. They importuned their clients with the phrase 'are you for the Doctor, sir?' – asking the client if he supported Dr Sacheverell.³² As late as 1731 Hogarth depicted the harlot Moll in her boudoir with a picture of Dr Sacheverell on the wall.³³ In this way, even the most fallen section of society engaged with

religious politics and saw their identities as strongly affected by matters of faith. In fact one of the neglected aspects of the Sacheverell unrest between Tories and Dissenters was whether the recruitment of women to their causes was a source of division.³⁴

It is likely that prostitutes did not all regard themselves as irredeemably sinful, just as people experienced periods of doubt in their religious belief. After all, some of the lurid contemporary accounts of prostitution in London suggested that tens of thousands of women were involved in the sex trade, many of whom were 'demi-reps,' that is, married women or servants who fell back on prostitution from time to time as their financial needs dictated.³⁵ Moreover prostitutes often deployed signs of faith alongside their immoral activities. One of the notorious London brothel keepers, Mother Wisebourne, was said to carry a Bible with her when she walked the streets, partly as a feint to deter people from assuming she was a prostitute; and she left a Bible open in the hallway of her house to throw off her naiver neighbours.³⁶ Of course, the question arises, was Mother Wisebourne therefore considered hypocritical, a doubter or woman of faith? Fears of hypocrisy in matters of sex and faith abounded after all. In the *History of the Human Heart* (1749), the author noted that Camillo, the young hero of the novel, did not just attend church on Sundays but also on weekdays and 'behaved on these occasions with all the outward marks of the most sincere devotion.' Nevertheless he was soon to corrupt a 'posture girl'. The author took Camillo's religious observance to be hypocrisy and a feint to throw off his observers.³⁷

Faith, superstition, and stratagems of expedient morality coincided in other fictional accounts of prostitution. The author of *The Whore's Rhetorick*, claimed that the fictional 'Mother Creswell,' told her girls that they would be provided with a copy of *The Whole Duty of Man* and *The Practice of Piety* partly because it helped to impress their clients. However, she also claimed they were 'helps to devotion'.³⁸ So she expected her prostitutes to be devout. The claim that madams and prostitutes attended St Anne's Soho to 'pray in their paint' and to solicit clients from the congregation, captures the moral ambivalence of the age.³⁹ Certainly it is possible to be cynical about such ploys. But erotic books, such as *The London Bawd* of 1705, suggested that prostitutes went to church and saw their trade as operating alongside their worship and faith.⁴⁰ The author of the *London Bawd* showed how a devious

demi-rep gulled her husband in religious vein. When he returned home unexpectedly she was entertaining a client, she recalled:

springing from the Arms of my affrighted Gallant, I took a Sheet out of the Chest of Drawers in the Chamber, and tying it with a Copped Crown upon his Head, I made him look methought just like some Fornicator, a going to do Pennance in a Parish Church, and then turning him into the next Room, I bid him, if my Husband came in thither (who was a very timorous Man, and almost trembled at the Talk of Spirits) to Counterfeit a Ghost, by which means I wou'd quickly use a Stratagem which shou'd Relieve him without Danger.⁴¹

As chapter eight shows, clergymen also embodied the tensions between sex and faith. The *Cuckold's Chronicle* in 1793 considered the serial adultery of Mrs Errington. Among the men with whom Mrs Errington was reported by her maid to have spent time alone was the curate of Battersea, Mr Walker. In sarcastic tone the author asked whether Mrs Errington and the curate spent their time together in religious exercises, or reading *Pilgrim's Progress* or *The Whole Duty of Man*. In the end the author conceded that 'a transaction will bear two constructions.'⁴²

The Unrecoverable Past

Ideas about sex have changed over time. Scholars of sexuality demonstrate that while 'there is a biological basis for human impulses, drives, and desires . . . it is social forces that fashion a biological reality into a "sexuality."'⁴³ In the broadest sense, sexuality and sexual identities are modern constructs. As Kim Phillips and Barry Reay point out, before 1800 it is more constructive to explore the universe of meanings that people placed on sex acts, rather than attempt to identify the acts themselves.⁴⁴ This book takes such an approach since it is more fruitful to explore individuals' experience of sexual acts and attitudes.

Sex inevitably raises evasive issues of attraction and the interior life. For historians this can be problematic and represents an element of the past that can only be glimpsed since few people discussed their sexual desires and acts in the past. Scholars of sexuality and the Church are faced with a number of questions. To what degree was there an interplay

between faith, the Church, and people's sexual acts, thoughts, and feelings? Did sex play any part in clerical career advancement and patronage? Was sexual attractiveness an ingredient in the application of spiritual and civil jurisdiction? Did sexual proclivities and feelings influence theologians and churchmen towards certain religious ideas and principles? Did denial or sublimation of such feelings play a part in church teaching? Did people align beauty and goodness, desire and desirability, with one another in the way they often do today? If not all these questions can be answered, the centrality of sex to the 'workings of society,' as Sarah Toulalan and Kate Fisher observe in their introduction to a history of sex and the body since 1500, 'ensures that a variety of relevant documents that provide insights into various sexual cultures, customs, thoughts, rules and regulations, experiences and emotions can be mined by scholars'.⁴⁵ This book therefore uses a wide variety of sources to uncover the centrality of the Church to understandings of sex and vice versa in the eighteenth century.

Route Map

This book is organised thematically. The first chapter examines the Church's teaching on sex. Although the Church's teaching on sex has been normative, and has varied according to its context, after the Restoration there was a degree of consensus on what constituted sexual infringement of religious teaching. That consensus was sufficient for there to be popular support for spiritual discipline and for the need for church-enforced penance. Nevertheless there were some important changes in the Church's teaching on sex. While biblical injunctions regarding sexual behaviour remained strong, the notion of collective guilt as a result of sexual sin was fading. Sin became increasingly perceived as an individual responsibility, as did redemption, and moral behaviour. Moreover theological arguments against sexual misbehaviour were joined by economic and social arguments, including those of property rights and of the need for social order. Some sexual behaviour, such as masturbation, was more likely to be conceptualised as a medical as well as a spiritual problem. Ideas of relativism also grew, in which behaviour such as masturbation was perceived as less dangerous morally and socially than adultery or fornication. New theological ideas also developed, largely under the influence of Latitudinarians. In the

eighteenth century God was seen as more reasonable in his expectations of mankind and therefore more tolerant of sin. Moreover the theological suspicion of pleasure declined, so that it became a natural behaviour not necessarily associated with sin. God was perceived as wanting men and women to achieve their full potential. In such a universe, sex was natural and to be enjoyed; and blanket proscription gave way to nuanced regulation. However, it would be mistaken to overstate these changes. They were gradual and evolutionary. The period remained one in which there were different sexual standards of behaviour for men and women, and for aristocrats and the poor. Enlightenment ideas of individualism and of the naturalness of mankind were emerging but they were not dominant. And earlier ideas of the nature of sin and the need for firm sexual regulation remained strong among many social groups.

Chapter two considers the Church's role in the public sphere. The Church of England endorsed public activism against sexual misbehaviour and regarded rebuking and shaming those deemed immoral as important weapons for this end. Sexual morality was linked in the public mind with other social transgressions, criminality and failure to conform to sexual norms was associated with religious and political heterodoxy. This morality dominated public life for the first half of the eighteenth century. But the sexual vigilantes of the societies for the reformation of manners over-reached themselves and the moral consensus they reflected was in decline from the mid-century. Thereafter public moral campaigns focused on 'vice' with less emphasis on sexuality. Public morality had an ambivalent attitude to the sex lives of monarchs, who were in the long eighteenth century also religious figures. For political and religious reasons William III, Mary II, Anne and George I were all deemed to be beyond the public censure for sexual misbehaviour. But, by the mid-century, public rebukes of George II for adultery emerged. By the reign of George III royal sexual misbehaviour became both politicised and symptomatic of emerging anti-clericalism.

Chapter three addresses the role of the spiritual regulation of sex. The Church regulated lay and clerical sexual behaviour through its courts throughout the long eighteenth century. The Church prosecuted people who were considered sexually immoral, typically those who had sex outside marriage, and punished offenders found guilty through public confession and humiliation. People also used the church courts to deal with illicit sexuality in other forms, including spouses who sued

each other for adultery, and those who tried to defend themselves against accusations of sexual misbehaviour and restore their public reputation. Though the system of ecclesiastical courts is sometimes characterised as being in terminal decline in the long eighteenth century and thus a manifestation of the Church's loss of control of sex and society, it is more accurate to see it as in a state of flux. The courts' role in punishing sexual offences varied according to region: earlier decline in regulation occurred in areas which underwent more rapid economic or urban transformation while they continued to present offenders in rural, less industrialised areas up to the final quarter of the eighteenth century. It is misguided to see the decline, whether rapid or slow, as indicating society's rejection of the Church's teachings on extra-marital sex. Other factors played a part in the changing role of the church courts. The volume of litigation overall declined in the period. Like other arenas of civil litigation, the church courts became more socially exclusive and professionalised, used predominantly by higher-ranking married couples to resolve marital difficulties. Crucially, the church courts also responded to intellectual and social change, adopting the shift in ideas about discipline and inculcating morals which saw more success in their indoctrination through education and internal conscience rather than through external regulation.

The fourth chapter considers the Church and marriage in the eighteenth century. The Church played a powerful and ongoing role in the making of marriage, as well as defining its parameters and seeking to ensure its success both at the level of institution and as a personal relationship. Those who wrote about marriage, frequently used scripture as the foundation of their discussion and advice and it was canon law which dictated how people entered and left matrimony. The church courts, as already shown, policed marital conformity and punished those who weakened the institution of marriage by fornication, bastardy, and adultery. In many ways, it was the Church's views on marital sex that shaped much of its activities in the arena of matrimony, a factor which has been overlooked by historians to date. The Church taught that sex, procreation, and mutual comfort were the fundamental reasons for marriage. In its courts, marital sex helped prove the existence of a union and clerics who published guidance for married couples, often used marital sex as a measure of the health and state of an individual marriage. Indeed, society accepted the Church's contention that marriage was the

only legitimate site for sex and individual and familial faith was critical in finding a suitable partner and sustaining a successful marriage. Spouses whose partners broke their marriage vows by committing adultery were also offered the Church's assistance through separation and while understandings of extra-marital sex became more nuanced, its definition as a sin did not disappear by the end of the Georgian period. In fact, breaking the marital vows of fidelity had considerable ramifications for those who held political authority, a feature of political life which retained a grip throughout the long eighteenth century as the prevalence of adultery (and clerics) in sexual scandals reveals.

Although evangelicalism is often associated with temperance and prudery in the nineteenth century, chapter five demonstrates that in the eighteenth century its association with sexuality was profound and widespread. This chapter spans the two major waves of evangelicalism in the long eighteenth century. The first, from the 1730s when John Wesley and George Whitefield spearheaded a period of conversion and 'vital' religion, saw Methodism identified by contemporaries as a highly gendered movement and one which used the language and imagery of sex. The intimacy developed by Methodist organisations led to both imagined sexual behaviour and scandals and rumours that dogged the movement. One of the problems for Methodism was that both its principal leaders, John Wesley and George Whitefield, had troubled relationships with women and wrestled with their sexuality. Wesley also placed greater emphasis on the advantages of the single life, which appeared to undermine the value of marriage among his followers. As an itinerant preaching society, Methodism also suffered from the ability of preachers to move on from relationships and a number of its preachers were the subject of scandal. In its second wave from the 1770s, Anglican evangelicalism was more institutionalised. The period of acute national crisis in the 1780–90s ushered in an active evangelical movement headed by men and women like William Wilberforce and Hannah More. Although Nonconformists were also swept up in the evangelical tides, this chapter focuses on those who remained within the established Church. It specifically proposes a shift over the period in the relationship between society, evangelicalism, and sex and gender. In the earlier period, evangelicals such as Wesley and Whitefield were conceptualised as a threat both to social and familial order, with widespread allegations of illicit sexuality, the destruction of family life, and disruption of

gender conventions. By the later period, however, evangelicals espoused a rhetoric which placed them at the centre of familial, gender, and therefore social order. Indeed arguably in the period 1780s to 1840s the relationship between evangelicalism, morals, and respectability came to define and distinguish middle-class culture.

Chapter six tackles celibacy, and the related issues of conjugal chastity and moral restraint, to challenge further the view of the eighteenth century as one of sexual revolution in which a secularising process changed attitudes to sexual continence. The Church of England certainly promoted marriage as the primary institution of social order, and thus the unmarried state was often characterised as inferior, with the potential to pose a moral and economic risk to society and nation. Consequently, numerous religious writings tackled the issue of celibacy, particularly in the early eighteenth century. This chapter demonstrates, however, that in attacking the celibate state or promoting a modified version, the Church did not present sex as either intrinsically sinful or problematic. The clergymen who offered their views typically celebrated sex and its pleasures as long as it was the right type: marital. Moreover, although the Church's ability to discipline illicit sexuality through its courts diminished, and a discourse of sexual liberty circulated among some highly educated, wealthy men, celibacy was not side lined, nor did it lose its political, rhetorical, and ideological force over the century. Celibacy was indeed disparaged, not least because Anglicans identified it as Roman Catholic and therefore reprehensible and the concerns around celibacy shifted, tied to political, economic, and cultural concerns. Yet, the debate remained rooted in a religious framework, which in some respects encouraged a degree of ambiguity about the celibate state across the period from outright denigration in the later seventeenth century to cautious approval in the early nineteenth. Definitions of celibacy were not fixed, with a variety of different terms in use, a range of views about the merits of abstinence in general, and, critically, the possibility of temporary celibacy. Discussions of sexual continence served several political purposes at different times from denigrating Roman Catholicism legitimately to evading patriarchal authority, to avoiding the distractions of family life with the goal of greater spiritual conviction, or from professional necessity.

Chapter seven analyses the Church and same-sex relationships. In the eighteenth century popular and religious responses to same-sex

behaviour and desire were perhaps among the most unstable and inconsistent of opinions. There was fierce vilification, condemnation, and prosecution by Church authorities, such as that aimed at molly culture. At the same time some churchmen appeared to have taken a more tolerant attitude to it, sometimes unwilling to prosecute or condemn sodomy, with others even willing to collude in the evasion of punishment in certain homosocial environments in which tolerance was more prevalent. The covering up of homosexual scandals and the willingness to permit those clergy caught in compromising situations to evade punishments did not necessarily imply any acceptance of same-sex behaviour; it is more likely to have been an institutional defence mechanism and later one which saw political defence of the status quo as important for the stability of wider society. So if there is a field of religion and human sexuality in this period which most exemplifies the need to avoid a Whiggish interpretation of an upward path from darkness to sunlit uplands it is that of same-sex activity. This is reflected in wider discussions of the nature of homosexuality in the eighteenth century and the historical divergence of interpretations between those who emphasise the repression and punishment of sodomy and those who lay stress on gradual tolerance of it. These divergent opinions should not be viewed as exclusive categories since both repression and tolerance were evident in the period.⁴⁶

The final chapters turn to representations of the Church and its personnel in print culture. Chapter eight examines sexual scandals and the Church. Throughout the eighteenth century scandals dogged the Church, as they did in earlier and later ages. Sexual scandals in the Church, like those of the monarchy, could challenge institutional authority and the ideas of moral absolutes on which ecclesiastical influence rested. An aspect of their significance is in the emergent ideas of what was public and private, and of what was legitimately a matter for public comment. In many cases those scandals that reached the public did so because there was some animus or motive for revealing them. But there was also a randomness in whether scandals were made public. The nature of scandal was rooted in the expectation that clergy should lead exemplary lives, and in the issues of hypocrisy and double standards that occurred when they did not. The Council of Trent held that the character of the priest did not affect the sacraments he conveyed, but in the popular mind a parson who was immoral was unlikely to be effective.

Some of the scandals in this chapter arose from sincerely held views, in other cases scandal arose from clergy affected by mental illness; by the later period all of these scandalous cases took advantage of a new form of literature, the cheaply produced sensational account of a trial or other event. It was in the early nineteenth century that these writers and publishers took advantage of the growth of radical anti-clericalism in publishing lurid accounts of clerical crimes to further their own political and ideological positions.

The final chapter explores the ways in which writers combined sex and religion in erotic narratives to contribute to political, social, and cultural debates throughout the long eighteenth century. These erotic narratives encapsulate the complex relationship between the Church and sex. While defenders of Christian morals campaigned against obscene literature and its circulation, the Church and its personnel found themselves protagonists in this material, which developed eventually into the genre of pornography. This chapter explores how writers used sex to condemn different denominations, featured fictional clergymen as characters in erotica, and exposed real clergymen's sexual proclivities in order to advance political views. The resulting sexual narratives do not therefore conform to any thesis of modernity in which a stable category of pornography emerged designed solely to sexually stimulate readers. This chapter confirms that authors continued to write about sex in order to attack institutions. Since erotic writing retained anti-religious and satirical facets, perhaps it suggests that sexual liberty was not yet in place by the turn of the eighteenth century.

CHAPTER 1

THE CHURCH'S TEACHING ON SEX

Some histories of sexuality give the impression that changes in attitudes to sex in this period were smooth and uncontested. By associating sex with modernity and the Enlightenment, they suggest that attitudes to sex developed in the same way as economic advances, or the growth of ideas such as liberty.¹ The theological ideas that underpinned eighteenth-century attitudes to sex, as this chapter shows, underwent significant changes, but they did not follow a uniform Enlightenment trajectory. In the Church of England theological teachings on sex were often rooted in the past and the changes in attitudes it stimulated were a complex combination of progressive and conservative ideas.

Historically, the Church's teaching on sex has not been constant, it has varied over time and was socially constructed by the context in which the teaching developed. For example, though St Augustine and Thomas Aquinas both appeared to sanction prostitution as a release of sexual tensions, at other times the Church regarded prostitution as a serious social evil to be fiercely condemned. Theologians themselves acknowledged the relativist attitudes towards sex. In *Archaeologiae Graeca*, 1697, John Potter, later Archbishop of Canterbury, explained that in pagan society prostitution was not condemned for a number of reasons. First, it was not publicly seen, prostitutes went to the homes of their clients rather than importuning in the streets; secondly it was an indulgence to young men; and thirdly it prevented such men from making 'attempts' on the virtue of respectable women.² Potter did not condone such

behaviour, though he acknowledged that Western culture sprang from ancient society. Like others, in the eighteenth century he recognised that much of the Church's teaching on sex was derived from an earlier time.

An example of such a regressive regime was that exercised by Bishop Thomas Wilson of Sodor and Man. Wilson's was one of the longest episcopates of the period: he was consecrated bishop in 1697 and remained at Sodor and Man until his death in 1755. Wilson's approach to morality and the Church's discipline was derived from earlier times. In 1714 he arranged for a bridle to be made with which he punished cases of defamation and in 1720 he imprisoned one islander for fornication in addition to his public penance.³ Wilson even ordered a prostitute to be sentenced to be dragged across Douglas harbour behind a boat, in effect a judicial execution by drowning.⁴ Such was Wilson's inflexibility that in 1722 the governor, with whom he was in a political conflict, imprisoned him for nine weeks for appearing to defame his wife.⁵ Wilson's moral government of the diocese of Sodor and Man though representative of an older, sterner, and inflexible system of ecclesiastical oversight of moral discipline, overlapped with less repressive attitudes to morality. Yet Wilson remained a celebrated bishop, noted for piety and devotion to his diocese, and his publications remained in print and widely recommended well into the nineteenth century.⁶

Theological views on sex were not homogenous in this period because they reflected different doctrinal positions and principles. An example is the advice given to married couples on having sex the night before, or on the day of, taking Holy Communion. The discussion of this issue followed the advice given by the Catholic saint, Francis La Salle (Bishop of Geneva until his death in 1622) in his *Introduction à la vie devote*, published in 1609. La Salle commented that what he called 'the marriage debt' could be paid on the night before and even the day on which someone had communicated, for, 'it is no indecency, but rather a meritorious thing to pay it. Wherefore no one ought to be debarred from communion for paying this debt.'⁷ His advice was reiterated by Richard Challoner (later Catholic vicar-apostolic for London) in his 1724 translation of the work for an English Catholic readership. When, however, the Anglican Henry Dodwell translated the work, 'fitted for the use of Protestants', in 1673, he omitted this section, simply noting that as far as sex on the night before communion 'in ancient law,

God would not have the creditors exact that which was owing to them, upon feast days and holy-dayes.'⁸ So sex immediately before Holy Communion was acceptable for Catholics but not for Protestants.

The Church's teachings on sex were derived from a number of sources, principally from the Bible. Paul-Gabriel Bouce suggested that eighteenth-century society was so strongly influenced by the Bible that it was hardly surprising that most attitudes to sexuality were based on Leviticus and Deuteronomy.⁹ But there were other sources for Church teaching. Homosexuality was regarded as sinful as a result of biblical injunctions and was punished by the spiritual courts; but in 1534 the 'Acte for the punysshement of the vice of Buggerie' also condemned it as a criminal offence which could be punished by the death penalty. During the Commonwealth other forms of sexual behaviour were criminalised and severe punishments were imposed: in 1650 a law even imposed the death penalty for incest, adultery and fornication. The Restoration of 1660 reversed Commonwealth legislation and restored the church courts for spiritual offences. By 1676 Lord Chief Justice Matthew Hale asserted that Christianity and biblical injunctions were 'a parcel of the laws of England' and any attack on the Church's teaching was 'a subversion of the law.'¹⁰ Thereafter, in the period covered by this book, the Church's teachings were of two types. First, the offences punished in the church courts and in other legal actions and secondly the public teachings of leading churchmen. As the activity of church courts is considered in chapter three, this chapter will address the ways in which the Church's beliefs about sex were constructed in canon law, theology, and public teaching.

The Church and Sex in Canon Law

The eighteenth century saw the most comprehensive codifying of English canon law since the Reformation, which aimed to provide a clear and coherent rationale for the Church's claim to both moral authority and jurisdiction. Edmund Gibson's monumental two volume *Codex Juris Anglicani* of 1713 made the case for the spiritual jurisdiction of the Church of England. Gibson took the authority back to 28 Henry VIII, c. 12 which sanctioned spiritual courts in England following the split from Rome. He also cited the Act of 1662 (13 Charles II, c. 2) which permitted clergy to exercise temporal authority.¹¹ The Church's claims

C O D E X
 JURIS ECCLESIASTICI
 A N G L I C A N I:
 OR, THE
 STATUTES, CONSTITUTIONS,
 CANONS, RUBRICKS and
 ARTICLES,
 OF THE
 Church of England,
 Methodically DIGESTED under their Proper *Heads*.
 WITH A
 C O M M E N T A R Y,
Historical and Juridical.

BEFORE it, is

An Introductory Discourse, concerning the *Present State* of the
Power, Discipline and Laws, of the Church of England:

And AFTER it,

An APPENDIX of INSTRUMENTS, Ancient and Modern.

By EDMUND GIBSON, D. D.

Archdeacon of *Surrey*, Rector of *Lambeth*, and Chaplain to his Grace
 the Lord Archbishop of *Canterbury*.

L O N D O N:

Printed by *J. Baskett*, Printer to the Queen's Most Excellent Majesty; and
 by the Assigns of *Thomas Newcomb*, and *Henry Hills*, deceas'd. And are to be Sold
 by *R. Whitledge*, at the Bible and Ball in *Ave-Mary-lane*. 1713.

Figure 1 Title page of Edmund Gibson's *Codex Juris Ecclesiastici Anglicani* (1713), the formal position of the Church's authority over spiritual and moral behaviour.

to spiritual authority over sexual matters rested on these statutes. Gibson made clear that, according to the Canons of 1603, 'notorious and evil livers' could not be admitted to Holy Communion. He also provided an account of the 'spiritual crimes and vices restrained by temporal punishment'.¹² There were four principal categories of sexual crimes: buggery and sodomy; rape and ravishment; fornication, adultery and incest; and bastardy.¹³ Gibson stated that though buggery and sodomy remained sins, the spiritual courts could hand offenders over to the temporal courts because they were criminalised by the act of 1534 as crimes. The same was true for rape: it had been a crime in England since 1275 and statutes concerning forcible sex with women had been passed under Richard II and Elizabeth I. Gibson showed that while the law had been repealed under Mary, it had been restored by Elizabeth I in 1562, and thereafter those convicted of rape had been exempted from general pardons in 1609, 1661, 1674, 1695, 1696, and 1708. The penalties for conviction of rape were severe, including life imprisonment and heavy fines, and under the law of Elizabeth I the death penalty was added. Moreover rape of a child under the age of ten was a crime which could not attract benefit of clergy.¹⁴ Gibson's third category, fornication, adultery, and incest, included offences reserved for the spiritual courts alone since 1285 and there had been no change in that provision (other than in the case of courts martial for such instances in the army and navy). Similarly bastardy was principally a spiritual offence, although there were important civil consequences, not least those concerning inheritance, maintenance of the child, and poverty.¹⁵

Gibson's *Codex* was the most significant work on the Church's spiritual jurisdiction of the eighteenth century. It was granted official status by formal receipt by the archbishops of Canterbury and York and also by acknowledgement and thanks to Gibson from the Convocation of the Province of Canterbury in 1713. Thereafter it was the standard work, with bishops, ecclesiastical lawyers, and laity using it as a guide to ecclesiastical law. A copy was bought by Convocation for Westminster Abbey which was available to be consulted by the public.¹⁶ The *Codex* demonstrates the strength of the Church's spiritual jurisdiction over matters of sex and indicates that leading churchmen regarded it as an important element in the relationship between Church, state, and society throughout the eighteenth century.

Gibson's work suggested that just as the state was responsible for the economy, foreign policy and other temporal aspects of society, the Church was responsible for its moral and sexual regulation. Civil and criminal offences were to be pursued in the king's courts; moral and sexual crimes in the Church's. The restoration of the jurisdiction of church courts after 1660 was undoubtedly more successful than some scholars have recognised, a theme explored in more detail in chapter three. Indeed, concerns at the vigour with which the Church pursued offenders led to petitions to the House of Commons in 1732 to prevent ecclesiastical courts from over-reaching their bounds. Robert Whatley argued, both to Bishop Edmund Gibson and to the committee of the House of Commons examining church courts, that they were too active and the deployment of penance had the effect of punishing men and women for a sinfulness that was integral to the human condition.¹⁷ Consequently, the House passed a resolution that no suits for criminal cases should be initiated in ecclesiastical courts. The Commons committee also resolved that the church courts should not add excommunication, a penalty following a spiritual conviction, to criminal punishments. In the 1670s and 1680s an attempt had been made to disqualify from voting those who had been sentenced to excommunication, but this was eventually regarded as illegal.¹⁸ A further resolution laid down that fines paid instead of a sentence of penance should be devoted to the poor law of the parish.¹⁹

In order to implement its spiritual jurisdiction over sex, the Church needed a means of discovering and prosecuting such offences. The mechanism used was that of churchwardens' reports to the archdeacon's annual visitation of the parishes in his archdeaconry. Gibson, for instance, included direct questions about sexual matters in his articles of enquiry, issued prior to his visitations as archdeacon of Surrey. He asked: 'are there any in your parish who lie under a common fame, or vehement suspicion, of adultery, fornication or incest?' Offenders identified in this way were presented by the churchwardens for punishment at the archdeacon's court. Gibson's visitation practices were so admired and copied that in 1717 he published his account of how to organise them, including the questions to be asked. It is not clear how many archdeacons took up Gibson's questions about sex, but it seems likely that most did so.²⁰

The character of religious punishment of sexual offences was different from that of criminal penalties. The latter included elements of deterrence and exemplary punishment as a means of instilling norms into society and to persuade offenders not to repeat their behaviour and the community used the pillory to exact revenge and retribution. But spiritual punishments also sought, uniquely in this period, to achieve an inner transformation by seeking offenders' genuine remorse and regret, symbolised by the penitents' white wand and wearing of white raiment. Churchmen emphasised that punishment of sexual crimes was also an act of charity and compassion since it was aimed at defending the transgressor's salvation and chance of entry to heaven.²¹

The Church and Fornication

The Church's position on fornication, which was defined as sex outside marriage, was clear and rooted in its condemnation in biblical teaching. In sexual matters ideas of communal guilt were gradually declining but as belief in individual responsibility for sin grew collective responsibility did not disappear completely. In 1690 William Barlow declared that adultery and fornication were 'distinct sins', the latter being 'the lower sort of uncleanness.'²² Barlow urged his congregation to watch out for fornication and to challenge it in others. This communal responsibility for fornication was demonstrated in the financial consequences of the sin: a congregation might have responsibility for the children born from fornication, especially when 'so many base-got children are either murder'd as soon as born, or neglected or starv'd not long after their birth.' Barlow also argued that fornication struck at the heart of Trinitarian belief: it was a sin against God's creation, a sin against marriage instituted by Christ, and a sin against the Holy Spirit by defiling the body.²³ Such explicitly theological constructions of the nature of fornication exerted a strong force on the clergy who viewed such arguments as part of the Church's battle against Socinianism and Dissent.

Barlow also claimed that fornication was so widely known to be a sin that none could claim ignorance of it and therefore transgressors were wilfully separating themselves from God and the Church. He observed that fornication enslaved men and women to lust, and 'the slave to that tyrant is never at rest, no not so much as in the night when other slaves, tired with the toil of the forepassed day, take their ease.' Such a 'slave'

was robbed of peace. The mind which was focused on lust also turned to stratagems and tricks to indulge itself. Like others, Barlow saw a link between fornication and the theatre: 'one seeing a harlot going in her gaiety to the theatre wept to think of the pains the wicked took to go to Hell.' Finally a man robbed his family if he used their money to indulge his desire for fornication with prostitutes, and destroyed his body since lust 'impairs his health, shortens his life and hastens his death.'²⁴

Barlow also emphasised that fornication robbed women of both virginity and reputation. He argued that the only solution was to shun fornicators and to have no commerce or conversation with them; and to avoid the idleness which often gave rise to lust. Drunkenness and gluttony led to fornication and he therefore advocated regular fasting to cleanse the body. Finally, he reminded his congregation that 'the eye of God is upon you.'²⁵

Some saw a need to condemn fornication because they feared that adultery and fornication, and even polygamy, might be seen as lawful. It was assumed that, as access to the Bible increased, instances in the Old Testament of divorce, polygamy, and bigamy would come to the public's attention. As will be seen in chapter eight, polygamy was a topic which preoccupied eighteenth-century churchmen. This concern was the motive of the *Letter of Advice to a Friend Upon the Modern Argument of the Lawfulness of Simple Fornication, Half-Adultery and Polygamy* published in 1696. The author made clear that there was no doubt in people's minds that these activities were sins and unlawful, but that there was a tendency for men 'having their appetites unbridled' to find ways to justify their behaviour. The author reiterated that the Gospels condemned fornication, adultery and polygamy and that these sins affected people beyond the fornicators as well as damning them. He emphasised that there was no such thing as a 'tolerable' sin, and cited a consequence of adultery that was evident for all to see in royal and aristocratic houses:

King Charles II had no lawful issue: and his un-lawful was a Grief . . . to him, joining with the Seditious Party against him.²⁶
How many Noble Families in England might be brought as instances, to confirm this observation, whose Honours are fallen, or gone into Collateral Families, for want of lawful Heirs, from the most remarkable Corrupters of the Marriage Bed?²⁷

In a sermon in 1712, John Ovington, rector of Lee in Kent and a chaplain to Queen Anne, was keen to emphasise cases of fornication in the Old Testament were replaced by Jesus' teaching on sex. He conceded that in the New Testament fornication was held to be a valid justification for divorce, but that this was not a reason to avoid marriage. Ovington claimed that the best way to deal with 'vagrant lust,' which led to fornication, was to marry. Marriage was especially designed for those who 'have not the gift of continence' since 'lustful heats, libidinous thoughts and restless carnal inclinations' were calmed by marriage; a view shared by John Wesley and explored in chapter four. Like the Non-juror Jeremy Collier, Ovington feared that public theatre encouraged fornication, but argued that marriage would settle men and deter them from indulging their desires. Furthermore, he condemned Catholicism for stipulating clerical celibacy, which he said was 'one of the doctrines of the devil,' a view several shared as chapter six considers.²⁸

The status of fornication, and ways in which it should be prosecuted, were debated in the early eighteenth century. Some commentators proposed that fornication was not especially threatening because it was natural. An example is Matthew Tindal's *Christianity as Old as the Creation*, published in 1730, a book adopted as the 'bible' of Deists. Tindal constructed human experience regarding sex in this way:

enjoying a woman, or lusting after her, cannot be said, without considering the circumstances, to be either good or evil: that warm desire, which is implanted in human nature, cannot be criminal, when pursued after such a manner, as tends most to promote the happiness of the parties, and to propagate . . . the species.²⁹

The principal response to Tindal's view was from Anthony Holbrook, rector of Waltham Parva in Essex. Holbrook claimed that Tindal's view was a 'dangerous opinion, ruinous practice!' and a 'dirty suggestion'. Holbrook argued that by Tindal's own measure: the happiness of the parties, fornication was both immoral and sinful. He claimed that the ways in which fornication damaged society were obvious and led to injustice and unhappiness. Friends, neighbours and relatives had a 'social interest' in fornicators, who had 'a natural obligation to do no injury to his brethren and companions'. Holbrook also argued that chastity was a Christian virtue.³⁰

Secondly, the insistence on the status of fornication as a spiritual offence, and of the church courts as the appropriate forum for its punishment, was questioned in the Committee of the House of Commons in 1732, mentioned above. In reply, Robert Whatley recalled how he had treated a convicted fornicator, known as 'T. H.'. Whatley was rector of Toft in Lincolnshire so it is likely that he was referring to the penitence of a fornicator in his own parish. Whatley described the punishment meted out to fornicators (and other moral transgressors) by the church courts: standing on a stool, wearing a white sheet and holding a white wand in the middle of the parish church the offender publicly recited the words of penitence. He emphasised that the public nature of the penitence was to ensure genuine repentance and resolution not to repeat the offence. After all, men had animal lusts and desires but also minds with which to choose good or evil, and he urged the penitent to use the latter to avoid sin. As will be seen, this view was a growing feature of eighteenth-century theology and eroded ideas of Original Sin. Whatley also urged the penitent to rise above the level of the beasts of the fields which simply ate and procreated. From a decision to turn away from sin, he observed, would rise 'order and beauty in the natural world and happiness in the intellectual world.'³¹

Whatley also considered that fornication was a collective danger to Christians and had to be prosecuted. Its secret nature meant that its punishment had to be public as a deterrent to others, a widely-held view, and he pointed out that the laws did not guarantee the peace of society but the execution of them did, which was why the ecclesiastical courts were so vital for society. Indeed, at a time when the Anglo-French alliance had collapsed, he made the comparison with foreign policy:

Our temporal valour ... has defended us from being Frenchmen; and I question not but by the Blessings of God, our spiritual valour, under the goodness of our cause ... will continue us Christians.³²

Such comparisons indicate that people viewed religious and moral concerns as having the same immediacy as matters of defence and succession to the throne as foreign policy; for Whatley the peace of society required some punishment of spiritual as well as temporal crimes.

Certainly, fornication continued to be regarded as a public danger, partly because it was linked to prostitution. In 1749 the author of *Satan's*

Harvest Home bemoaned the low state to which fornication had brought London. The work was a revised version of a strongly Catholic and Anglophobic work, first issued in France in 1734 under the title *Pretty Doings in a Protestant Nation* by the pseudonymous 'Father Poussin', so it was hardly unbiased. The author said that the age of the girls who prostituted themselves was a scandal: 'some of them whose heads will hardly reach above the waistband of a man's breeches found to be quick with child.' 'Poussin' claimed that 'Where the Devil do all these b – ches come from?' was a common Fleet Street phrase. And this took place in a 'great Protestant city.' Such women, he feared, when taken to the Bridewell and imprisoned with other prostitutes, became 'hardened in [their] indelible shame'.

'Poussin' believed that the supply of the women for prostitution was from domestic servants coming to London from all corners of the kingdom, who were assaulted by their masters and men of all sorts. 'Poussin' blamed their gullible parents and employers for their ruin. He wrote,

I have often been astonished, how any men or women could be so great a stranger to the knowledge of life, as to trust a young daughter or niece, in a little bawdy vehicle, along with a rampant rake, able and ready to ravish a whole boarding school, to take a country Jaunt ten or twelve miles distant, when every jolt on the road, not only gives a kind of titillation, but even the situation itself affords the most favourable opportunity, for a fellow to rob a girl of all that's dear to her.³³

He suggested that it was the duty of virtuous older women to guard such girls from sex 'before she is betrothed' and recommended sending footmen to guard them. Lack of virtue affected all classes of women.

'Poussin' was more broadly concerned about illicit sexuality. He stated that,

A stay-maker at St. James assures me that he never waits upon a certain peeress, to make proof of his art, but that she puts him as much out of countenance, as a young lady who has had the misfortune to break wind before her admirer.³⁴

'Father Poussin' also alleged that the parishioners of a London church had been offended when they were attacked from the pulpit by their parson who railed against prostitution and even claimed that those who attended church had frequented 'abominable whoredoms'. After their parson died, the parishioners, who had the right to choose their incumbent, therefore took 'a notable expedient for extricating their ears out of this difficulty' by selecting a clergyman who had been sufficiently relaxed in his attitudes to sexual matters to have conducted the marriage of a nobleman's illegitimate daughter. Moreover, he fumed:

I have e'er now seen a whole congregation put to the Blush, when a Reverend Gentleman has been pleas'd to prostitute the prayers of the Church, by way of a Compliment to his Right Honourable Master, whom almost every one in the place had reason to believe, to have been at that very instant in bed between a brace of harlots.³⁵

While 'Poussin' had no remedy for the situation he had no doubt that the circumstances were entirely religious in interpretation, commenting that such scenes were 'planted here by the Devil for the mischief of mankind.'³⁶

More generally, the Church's teachings on sex were prominent in various books of advice to young gentlemen. In *Antenuptial Fornication Considered in a Letter to a Young Gentleman* of 1766, regarded by a writer in the *Critical Review* for that year as 'rational and important',³⁷ the author appealed to churchmen as his principal weapon against fornication. Bishop Warburton's *Sermon on Marriage* and Henry Stebbing's *Dissertation on the Power of States*, as well as Scripture, were used to argue that antenuptial fornication was unnatural and dangerous.³⁸ Far from advocating secular reasons to avoid fornication the author rejoiced that the reasons were scriptural and buttressed by Parliament.

Some churchmen made a direct comparison between 'spiritual fornication', by which they meant a form of religious promiscuity, in particular leaving the Church for Dissent, and sexual fornication.³⁹ In the Old Testament spiritual promiscuity led to the worship of false gods and idols and in the modern age it led to the vanity of assuming greater knowledge than the Church's. Spiritual fornication led to

separation from the Church and ultimately from salvation, according to *Antenuptial Fornication* this was why establishment of the Church was so important:

... to have such dictates of reason and scripture established by the authority of parliament, must certainly increase our obligation to a conscientious compliance. Indeed, it affords us a distinct illustration of the high importance of civil government to society, and of the real excellence of civil governors, in taking care that reason and scripture should be the firm and unshaken base of the laws which they enact.⁴⁰

The charge of fornication could be damaging for public figures in the later eighteenth century despite the circulation of ideas about the naturalness of sex. In 1788 a satirical attack on Lord Thurlow, the Lord Chancellor, known for a series of relationships with unmarried women, was published in the preface of a letter to the Bishop of London.⁴¹ The letter alleged that the Bishop had turned a blind eye to Thurlow's fornication, which was 'a libel on the Protestant Religion ...' The tract went on for fifty pages raising all manner of political issues, but its significance lay in its religious basis for the attack on Thurlow for fornication. The tract offered the Bishop the 'opportunity of manifesting your indignation at a sin, which you are profanely suspected of countenancing.' The author imagined that when convicted of the charge of fornication 'our noble transgressor must submit to the censures of the Church, and it is no small consolation, that the virtues of the Sovereign will resist every application for a pardon.'⁴² In a mock defence of the charge, Thurlow was imagined saying that sex was a matter of the laws of nature not of civil law. He denied that he believed that love was 'free as air' but refused to accept that there was any biblical basis for the charge against him. Having put these words into Thurlow's mouth, the author then despatched them in 'Animadversions on the Defence', which cited a plethora of authorities from the Bible (Ecclesiastes and Romans), Church Fathers (Augustine) and all the 'suffrages of antiquity' that Thurlow was wrong and fornication was unlawful. The author told the Lord Chancellor that a form of words did not create love, arguing that absence of marriage scandalised society.

The Church and Adultery

The Church's teaching on adultery was a regular part of preaching in the period. Occasionally, however, such teaching was reinforced to make a specific point to an individual or group of individuals. In 1703 a Manchester stationer, Mordecai Moxon, published *The Manchester Dæmoniack, Or, The White She Devil Ejected: in a Sermon Against Adultery*.⁴³ It was addressed to a Manchester woollen draper and occasioned by his 'playing water-wag-taile' with a shoemaker's wife.⁴⁴ The sermon was anonymous, but was addressed to the draper because it was known that he had an 'inordinate affection for the female sex' and was given to whoring and adulteries. The draper's wife was described as unvirtuous and Moxon commented that it was a 'great folly' to 'dabble your Man-Anthony into a common and filthy sink.' Significantly Moxon also related sex to politics, since he observed that, though he was a Non-juror and a Jacobite, the draper did not object to whoring with the King's subjects. As explored further in chapters eight and nine, the association between political and religious heterodoxy and sexual deviance was powerful.

Moxon's sermon was a fairly standard account of the sinfulness of adultery, derived from Matthew chapter 5, verse 28.⁴⁵ He asserted that adultery was a breach of a sacred vow and a defiance of God, even if it was only committed in the heart. Lustfulness, and especially looking at women, was a step towards greater sin and to be avoided. The sermon condemned men and women who consented to adultery and the 'serpent' which had drawn the pair to sin. Adulterers could not evade the omniscience of God and would be judged and burnt on judgement day. Even Moxon found the topic distasteful, saying: 'I am weary of this dunghill, I have dwelt too long in the stench of it' and concluded by warning his hearers not to confuse lust and love or to be exhorted to abandon their ways.⁴⁶

The Church viewed the youth of the nation as especially in need of warning of the dangers of adultery. For instance, Alexander Jephson, rector of Craike, County Durham addressed his sermon, *The Heinous Sins of Adultery and Fornication Considered* (1754), to 'the youth of Great Britain,' with the reservation that the topic was not one that could be treated with the 'niceness and delicacy that it requires and without giving offence and distaste.' Jephson referred to the poor example set by

the great and powerful giving themselves up to 'horrid vices.' Emphasising that Archbishop Herring had preached against vice and adultery in the same vein, he also drew on changing ideas that adultery and fornication were private matters which did not concern other people.⁴⁷ Nonetheless, he said that 'the judgements of God are hanging over our heads' and referred to providential arguments.⁴⁸ Deploying the old idea of communal punishment for sin, Jephson suggested that the raging cattle fever of the time was caused by such sinfulness. The main body of the sermon was devoted to emphasising that God judged adulterers and no one could evade punishment for their sin.

There were other attitudes towards adultery. The Church reflected and reinforced social attitudes of the inferior position of women by supporting the sexual double-standard, in which women's adultery was regarded as more serious than that of men's, partly because a woman could pass off another man's child on her husband.⁴⁹ Furthermore, an unfaithful wife was considered to break the gender hierarchy within marriage by displaying husbands' sexual incapacity and wives' disorderliness. In terms of masculine identity, chastity among men was regarded as a lesser virtue.⁵⁰ Even so, the sexual double-standard was not as severe or one-sided as is sometimes expected. For example, when the devout and pious Samuel Wright died in 1736, leaving the huge sum of £36,000 in legacies, he wrote into his will to prevent any challenge from supposed heirs that 'I never carnally knew any woman whatsoever, as a man does his wife, nor ever was under any contract or engagement with any woman.'⁵¹ This may have prevented false claims on his property, but it also reflected that sexual chastity was acceptable for some men too.

Attitudes to adultery varied across the century, linked to wider political and social concerns. Thomas Pollen's *Fatal Consequences of Adultery* of 1771 listed the various historical punishments for women caught in adultery, including stoning, beheading, burning, hanging, disfiguring, blinding, banishment and even 'tearing asunder'.⁵² Pollen's purpose was to advocate support for a bill which passed in the House of Lords, but failed in the Commons, which would outlaw the marriage of adulterers, criminalise any future marriage by an adulterous woman, and debar any children of such a marriage from inheritance. Pollen's objective was to stigmatise adultery in general and women adulterers in particular. The same anti-adultery bill was reintroduced by Bishop Shute

Barrington of Llandaff in 1779 and failed in the Commons by a single vote.⁵³ Unlike Pollen, Barrington's objective was to reduce the numbers of divorces, since he regarded this as an equal problem to adultery. The bill was ridiculed by one author because 'prohibit[ing] marriage between the offending parties is not to apply the remedy to the disease. Marriage is an event which we cannot suppose to have been in their contemplation.' The tract identified a more serious concern which was that the children of such adultery would be permanently illegitimised by the provision which prevented women adulterers from remarriage.⁵⁴

A fictional female response to Barrington's bill was published in *The House of Peeresses*, in which a group of aristocratic women were imagined to hold an assembly in order to respond to House of Lords debates. The satire asserted that their male relatives were 'ineffectual obstacles' to the women. Some, like the 'C---ss Dow. of Hu---n' (Selina Countess of Huntingdon, the evangelical leader) were shown to support the Bishop's bill, while other peeresses suggested that women were being made scapegoats for men's waywardness. The final motion put to the peeresses was that 'conjugal fidelity is one great means for the preservation of domestic tranquillity, and for the promotion of general felicity' to which some peeresses dissented.⁵⁵

The anti-adultery bill was renewed by Lord Auckland, with the backing of Bishops Barrington, Porteus, and Horsley, in 1800, though it failed again, perhaps because it was predicated on the claim that marriage was being undermined by foreign influences.⁵⁶ In all three bills, the Church was especially concerned that aristocratic morals were becoming separate from, and a threat to, the general population.⁵⁷

The Church and Masturbation

In the wake of the anti-Catholic feeling strengthened by the Glorious Revolution, masturbation was often popularly associated with celibacy and Catholicism and, like other sexual transgressions, was viewed through a political as well as a religious lens. However there were standard Anglican condemnations of masturbation early in the eighteenth century that regarded it as 'uncleanness' and subject to an absolute biblical injunction that could not be mitigated. Indeed, such writers tended to bundle masturbation with such sins as prostitution and with crimes such as duelling.⁵⁸ For example, a widely read work on

masturbation was Josiah Woodward's *A Rebuke to the Sin of Uncleaness*; having first been published in 1701 it saw subsequent editions in 1704, 1717, 1720, 1721, and 1740. Woodward, one of the leaders of the religious society for the reformation of manners, who regarded masturbation as from the same branch of 'hateful filth and nastiness' as adultery and fornication. Masturbation, wrote Woodward, was encouraged by those who,

write or print filthy language; or cast, paint, carve or draw filthy Pictures or Figures in Books, or otherwise, or upon Walls, or other open Places in the Streets, to be seen by every one, to the great Offence of all good Men.

Clearly, as chapter seven indicates, masturbation was connected to the growth of print culture and of erotica. Woodward also argued that masturbation 'preys upon a man's body, soul, estate and salvation,' since it turned a 'clear cystem' into a 'nasty puddle'. Masturbation was seen as a gateway to other sins, once the 'unclean spirit has made such a beach of the guilty soul' it broke down resistance to all sins. It was, for Woodward, an exclusively male sin which damaged families because men who practised it turned away from women, and adopted a spirit that would 'bear no government, decency nor restraint'. Woodward also regarded masturbators as incorrigible: 'the extreme difficulty of getting any one out of this pit' was a good reason to avoid it and as a remedy he advocated simple bread and water to 'keep down the heat of your inclinations'.⁵⁹

Despite Woodward's views, it was not a male-only concern. Mary Astell sought to minimise the sexual stimulation she experienced so that she could preserve her self-control. She did this in part by meditation and careful observance of fast days which gave her a sense of self-control over her body. She also meticulously followed the devotions of the Church as a means to eradicate sexual thoughts.⁶⁰ Woodward's concern about masturbation led him to write two other such works: *The Young Man's Monitor* 'shewing the dreadful consequences of indulging youthful lusts' and *The Seaman's Monitor*. Woodward was not alone in warning against the dangers of masturbation, as is seen in chapter six, more than half a century later, John Wesley's tract on the topic was a best-selling work in the period.

Scholars have associated changing ideas about masturbation with sexual modernity and secularisation. As noted in the introduction, Thomas Laqueur suggests that 'modern masturbation can be dated with a precision rare in cultural history' to the first decade of the eighteenth century, with the 1712 publication of *Onania, or the Heinous Sin of Self-Pollution*. Laqueur of course does not mean that masturbation did not happen before 1712, but that it did not hold its place in modern sexuality before that date. After the publication of *Onania*, Laqueur claims, masturbation reflected 'Enlightenment' notions of imagination, selfhood, secrecy and indulgence; associations which he argues did not exist before the eighteenth century. He regards the moral panic about masturbation in the eighteenth century as analogous to the regular outbreaks of anti-homosexual attacks. He also sees these ideas about masturbation as operating in an era in which birth, marriage and death were being transferred from the religious sphere to that of medicine so that masturbation was increasingly regarded as a scientific rather than a moral matter. As Laqueur makes clear, masturbation was one of those areas of the Church's teaching which was not absolute; in medieval monastic communities, for instance, it was regarded as a lesser sin than fornication or adultery. It was, moreover, a practice that was as widely used by women as men.⁶¹ The problem was in part that it was unclear what the biblical injunction in Genesis actually meant. Onan was killed by Yahweh apparently for not consummating his marriage to his brother's widow, choosing instead to masturbate. But there were other interpretations, including that of Simon Patrick, Bishop of Ely, that Onan's sin was wilfulness and his failure to expand the tribe of Judah rather than masturbation.⁶² Another clergyman, writing in 1697 claimed that Onan's sin was in practising *coitus interruptus* rather than masturbation.⁶³

Onania or the Heinous Sin of Self-Pollution and All Its Frightfull Consequences,⁶⁴ was an immediate best-seller and ran through a dozen editions in a decade, reaching its fifteenth edition in 1730. The author of *Onania* was obliged, by the time of the tenth edition, to produce a supplement which responded to his critics and correspondents. Laqueur claims that *Onania* brought the horizon of masturbation closer to people because it medicalised masturbation and its supposed consequences and also because it raised disturbing issues of pleasure and in particular of self-pleasure. Laqueur's argument is persuasive, but his assumption that

O N A N I A;
OR, THE
HEINOUS SIN
OF
Self-Pollution,
AND

All its Frightful Consequen-
ces, in both Sexes, Considered,

WITH
Spiritual and Phyfical A D V I C E
to Thofe who have already Injur'd themfelves
by this Abominable Practice.

To which is Subjoin'd,

A Letter from a Lady to the Author, [very curious]
concerning the Ufe and Abuse of the Marriage-Bed,
with the Author's Answer.

*There fhall in no wife enter into the Heavenly Jerufalem
any Thing that defileth, or worketh Abomination. Rev.
xxi. v. 27*

The Fourth Edition.

L O N D O N, Printed for the Author, and Sold by N. Crouch,
at the Bell in the Poftory; P. Varenne; at Seneca's Head near
Somerfet-Houfe in the Strand; and J. Ifted, at the Golden
Ball againft St. Dunfton's Church, Fleet-ftreet Bookfellers.
Price 1s. Stitch'd.

Figure 2 Title page of *Onania, or the Heinous Sin of Self-Pollution* (4th edition, 1716), one of sixty editions during the century suggesting the popularity of the work.

the book and the responses to it 'had almost no interest in the Christian taxonomy of sexual sin' misunderstands the era.⁶⁵

It is the case that some texts on masturbation appear to be morally relative. The pseudonymous writer, 'Math. Rothos.', for example, challenged the idea in *Onania* that masturbation for married men could be proscribed; he asked why, when a woman might be in childbirth or post-menopausal, non-conceptual sex was acceptable, but masturbation was not.⁶⁶ This might appear to undermine the Church's absolute injunctions. After all, though the Bible might be the source of teaching on masturbation, it could not accommodate more recent ideas of science and medicine or the common-sense of people who realised that the scriptures did not address all the cases of human experience. Nevertheless, the view that during the eighteenth century most people had medicalised masturbation and had abandoned its moral and religious proscription is erroneous.

Onania was dismissed as pornography by some, even though its author claimed that, 'not one sentence is capable of sullyng the mind' and none of it 'might not be spoken in a pulpit.' The author also claimed that *Onania* was principally 'a book of morality.' In addressing one of the main questions about whether masturbation was natural, the author suggested that there was plenty of evidence that 'the patriarchs and other holy men' were chaste, did not masturbate, and remained perfectly healthy. This contradicted the theory that semen, if unused, returned to and polluted the blood, a view that John Wesley seems to have been worried about, and is discussed in chapter six. The second half of the *Supplement to Onania* was a series of testimonials from people who wrote to Crouch, its publisher, giving accounts of their battles with lust and masturbation. Almost without exception these were framed in strongly religious terms of a struggle against biblical injunctions and against sin. One of these contributors declared that his effort to control his masturbation was a contest with the devil, who 'had got such power over me that I could not withstand his assaults.' Whenever he masturbated his heart was 'heavy and sorrowful'.⁶⁷

One of the most controversial aspects of *Onania* was the claim that women were as prone to masturbation as men, which was a major reason for the attacks on it, and that masturbation in marriage was sinful. A response by the pseudonymous 'Philo-Castitatis' in 1724 addressed these issues. 'Philo-Castitatis' was scandalised by the claim in *Onania*

that 'to imagine that women are naturally more modest than men is a mistake'. He asserted that women who gave themselves over to masturbation were 'few' and that *Onania* tended to undermine,

that just esteem and regard we ought to keep, both in thought, word and carriage toward not only our fellow creature but that only meet and fit help and companion for us in the whole creation: how much do we owe to them, ev'n our very bodies?

In this way, even the opponents of *Onania* tended to adopt a strongly biblical view of the world. Indeed 'Philo-Castitatis' claimed:

does not filthy dreams flow from impure imaginations? Does not the Devil inflame the minds of men to lust, whereby the bodies as well as minds of men are frequently defiled in their sleep by impure dreams? Hence Holy St Augustin bewails his sinful filthy dreams.

He also declared that it could not be sinful for married couples to masturbate, telling the author of *Onania*: 'you destroy the sense of your own argument by telling us married men are guilty as well as single men and boys.' 'Philo-Castitatis' suggested that since *Onania* claimed that masturbation was universal Adam must have committed it, so was he guilty before the biblical injunction? He challenged *Onania's* hierarchy of sexual misbehaviour, where 'fornication [is] a greater sin than self-pollution . . . [and] adultery is a greater sin than fornication.' 'Philo-Castitatis' claimed that by adopting such relative standards the author of *Onania* was 'a poor shallow divine', assuming the views he advanced to be those of a clergyman.⁶⁸

Popular Church Teaching on Sex

The most widely used ecclesiastical manual of behaviour in this period was Gilbert Burnet's *Discourse of the Pastoral Care*, written as a guide to clergy on their parochial duties. First published in 1692, and dedicated to Queen Mary II, it was astonishingly popular and influential. It remained recommended reading for clergy in training well into the nineteenth century. Burnet was a Whig Low Church controversialist and

his *Discourse* showed that Latitudinarians were as demanding in their attitudes to sex and morality as High Churchmen. He set rigorous standards for clerical behaviour, arguing that they should not attend theatres or entertainments which smacked of immorality. Clergy, held Burnet, 'must not only abstain from acts of lewdness, but from all indecent behaviour and unbecoming raillery.' The purpose of such injunctions was not merely to safeguard the parson's own soul but also to enable him to reprove the actions of others. Burnet advocated that it was sometimes better for clergy to offer a private reproof to 'men of rank', since an indiscreet or public admonishment might lead them to reject the advice. Public reproof was best handled in generalities in sermons, claimed Burnet, and in their preaching the clergy should speak against 'particular sins, swearing, drunkenness or lewdness, as abound in any place.' And the clergy should do so in such words as men of all abilities and education could understand them.⁶⁹ This combination of private admonishment and public teaching became the standard position of the Church of England during the eighteenth century.

The most widely-read work of popular piety in the eighteenth century was Richard Allestree's *Whole Duty of Man*, a work first published in the mid-seventeenth century but taken up after the Revolution of 1688 as a manual for the ordinary Christian.⁷⁰ Its popularity was extraordinary. It was a goal established in 1696 that every household should own a copy of the Bible, a Book of Common Prayer, and the *Whole Duty of Man*.⁷¹ By 1714 about 10 per cent of households in England possessed a copy, and many more individuals read it, or heard it read aloud. It comprised seventeen chapters on the duties of pious men and women, and despite targeting ordinary people, found public acceptance among the social elite also.⁷² So popular was the work that it was chosen for free distribution by the Society for the Propagation of Christian Knowledge (the SPCK) in 1708 and was widely used as a manual for a godly life; even workhouses gave copies to the apprentices and the poor they housed and released.⁷³ By the 1740s copies were published with royal approval and endorsed by the king as 'essentially necessary for salvation' and 'of public use and benefit.'⁷⁴

The *Whole Duty of Man* was a cycle of weekly readings on topics essential for a Christian, the tenth of which was on duties to neighbours. One of these was a dissuasive to adultery, an offence which, the author claimed, robbed both a wife and her husband. Allestree wrote that a wife

was the 'chief' possession of a man and therefore adultery was as much a property crime as a moral one, likely to disrupt neighbours and peaceful relations in society. The children of adultery were also problematic: 'should the injured husband be burthened with the providing for a spurious offspring of his wife's adulterous practices?' But fundamentally adultery was a spiritual sin and the *Whole Duty of Man* taught that God whose 'knowledge penetrates the most secret parts' would punish unrepentant adulterers with damnation. In the weekly readings for the following month the *Whole Duty of Man* addressed the theme of 'contentedness', to which chastity and the avoidance of uncleanness were essential.

For Allestree, chastity was a means to avoid the sins of fornication and adultery. The fornicator and adulterer 'sinneth against his own body' and by indulging in non-procreative sex, violated the teaching that sexuality was an appetite,

which God has planted in us for the increase of mankind, which must be confined within the bounds of lawful matrimony; since any other method of gratifying [it] is contrary to that purity which the gospel enjoins.

The *Whole Duty of Man* emphasised that chastity was a form of self-government and suppression of appetites since lewdness could engage any of the senses and was damaging to a Christian's body and soul. Above all, the manual asserted that there was no avoiding God's gaze, 'every minute we must tremble for fear of being discovered in our vicious habit.' The book recognised that 'they who are under the power of these evil habits, know the force of them' and this was why God imposed the punishment of eternal damnation for the unrepentant fornicator and adulterer.⁷⁵

Marriage was a vital bulwark against such sins. The other 'helps to chastity' in the *Whole Duty of Man* included employing the mind 'vigorously upon other objects' and the abandonment of both fantasies and memories of sex. 'Filthy and unclean discourse' were also to be avoided, and fasting and moderation in other appetites was recommended since they disposed people to restraint. Above all, work was a means to avoid lust: 'we must do our duty in our proper callings, for when we are prosecuting any art or science, when we are employed in

any innocent business ... we are not at leisure to entertain thoughts of pleasure ...' The manual warned against a presumption of moral strength, that people often made, since 'confidence is the portion of fools'; the only preservative against temptation was prayer and thoughts of God and thus the book included 'a prayer for chastity.'⁷⁶

A New Theology of Sex

The eighteenth-century Church inherited a clear and well-developed theology of sex. Sex remained God's punishment imposed on men and women for disobedience in Paradise; and Milton's biblical view of the sinful nature of sex was strongly influential throughout the seventeenth century. Consequently, sex was associated with uncleanness and much of the Church's teaching focused on non-procreative sex which violated biblical teaching; marriage and reproduction were the only circumstances in which sex might be sanctioned, consequently all other forms of sexual behaviour were intrinsically sinful. Menstruation, while it became increasingly viewed from a more medical and scientific perspective, also remained theologically constructed as 'the curse' of the Fall from Eden.⁷⁷ There were ancient and continuing prohibitions against sex during menstruation and, because pregnancy was a consequence of sex, women had to undergo 'churching,' a rite of cleansing and thanksgiving after childbirth to be readmitted to the congregation. The taint of pollution of childbirth was such that in the Middle Ages women who died while pregnant or in childbirth were sometimes refused burial in consecrated ground.⁷⁸ Churching continued to be widely practised during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.⁷⁹ In 1818 Benjamin Newton, rector of Wath, recorded that he had refused to church a woman who had given birth to an illegitimate child.⁸⁰

In the eighteenth century there were challenges to this theology, some of which came from unexpected quarters. In 1718, Charles Ancillon, a French lawyer and diplomat, questioned how far procreation was essential to marriage in *Eunuchism Displayed*, first published ten years earlier in French. Ancillon addressed the case of a young woman who wanted to marry an Italian *castrato*, but was refused because the *castrato* could not consummate the marriage. Ancillon provided an historical account of the status of eunuchs and explored Catholic and Lutheran injunctions against the validity of their marriages. He concluded that

some eunuchs could 'satisfy the desires of a woman', and since marriage was a civil, as much as a religious, contract it was 'therefore lawful for every body to engage in'. He also pointed out that many marriages were non-sexual, comparable to the relationships of brother and sister, and that the Church's injunction against non-procreative marriages might often apply to old people, who were no longer sexually active. His conclusion, that in marriage 'there is no injury to those that are willing', struck at the roots of the claims of the Church that marriage was exclusively a procreative relationship.⁸¹

Another case at the extreme of contemporary experience was that of the Revd John Butler, an Anglican parson whose wife, Martha, refused to sleep with him after the birth of their fourth child in 1696. Butler patiently made many attempts to persuade his wife that it was her duty to sleep with him. In the end Butler took the view that Martha had deserted him and that his marriage was therefore nullified. Consequently, he took what he held to be a lawful concubine in the form of his maidservant, Mary Tomkins, with whom he had sex and had a number of children.⁸² The church courts prosecuted Butler who adamantly defended his view that in cases of desertion it was reasonable and lawful for a man to regard his marriage as dissolved. Butler was able to make a good case that the Old Testament sanctioned divorce in cases of desertion by a wife, and that even in Scottish and English royal houses there had been such instances.⁸³ He argued that his sexual relations with Mary Tomkins were not a matter of 'lust, wantonness or uncleanness' but of 'a pure desire of an holy seed with her.'⁸⁴ Even when convicted and attacked by fellow clergy, Butler was unrepentant and insisted that he was not keeping a mistress because concubinage was lawful.⁸⁵ Butler's case was kept in the mind of the public by the fact that his sons by his wife Martha converted to Catholicism and he disinherited them, leaving his estate of more than £200 a year to his natural children by Mary Tomkins, who called herself Mary Butler. Moreover in 1750, Butler's will was made public because it was, wrongly, assumed that he was the father of John Butler, bishop of Oxford. Consequently the public was able to read in his will that Butler asserted:

I doubt not but God will accept of me and my Children, in as much as he did of Abraham, in the Matter of Ketura his additional Wife, and that without any Thing of Adultery or Fornication in the Case.⁸⁶

What Ancillon and Butler had in common was an assumption that men and women had a 'right' to a fulfilling sex life. It seems that both regarded a satisfying sex life as integral to marriage. So seeds of self-actualisation in religious ideas of sex can be identified before the development of the Enlightenment. Ancillon and Butler made judgements of what was their duty and right which conflicted with that determined by the Church; in both cases obedience to the Church took second place to an ethical decision. However, it would be unwise to assume that the notion of sexual rights was evidence of greater liberality in ideas about sex, or that this stance was secular in orientation. The situation was far more complex and nuanced.

Extreme cases such as those of Ancillon and Butler were rare, but raised in the public mind questions about the validity of the Church's absolutist teaching on the sinfulness of adultery and fornication. The growth of relativist attitudes to morality, however, appeared to some churchmen to be dangerous and linked to heterodox theology. In 1698, in the wake of the passage of the Blasphemy Act, Bishop Gilbert Burnet wrote to the Dutch theologian Philipp van Limborch that:

the Socinians, in addition to undermining Christian doctrine, openly argue in favour of free love, even without the formality of divorce. Such doctrines, propagated among the crowd, and almost universally discussed, have produced such a dissolution of manners as gives us the most melancholy prospect.⁸⁷

Burnet thus aligned heterodox sexuality with heterodox theology. Moreover older Puritan views prevailed and emphasised that any sexual pleasure was a source of irredeemable damnation.⁸⁸

As has been seen, the young were especially the object of warnings against lenient attitudes to sex and sin, often clothed in the hyperbole of damnation. In 1728 Samuel Wigglesworth preached to a group of young men:

Walk in the light of your fire, and in the sparks ye have kindled; but remember you shall lie down in sorrow. For your vanishing joys and unsatisfying pleasures, you shall receive unutterable Torments in the everlasting fire which is prepared for the devil ...⁸⁹

Similarly, in a sermon before the University of Oxford in 1747, John Tottie, Canon of Christ Church, warned students of 'the fatal mischief of sensuality' and against 'delusive but unmanly pernicious pleasures.' He warned that people lived in 'this degenerate condition of humanity'.⁹⁰

Nonetheless, a more optimistic view of human senses and pleasure developed during the eighteenth century and drew on earlier church teachings. Pelagius's teaching that Original Sin did not irredeemably taint humanity, led eighteenth-century theologians to regard pleasure and enjoyment as morally neutral, to be turned to good or evil ends. The Early Church may have regarded Pelagius as a heretic, but his teaching strongly influenced religious movements in the eighteenth century, and the adoption of his teaching was in some ways an intellectual precursor of the Arminian evangelical movement.⁹¹ Pelagianism was also an intellectual forerunner of eighteenth-century ideas of politeness and sociability, because religious toleration coincided with, and was inextricably linked to, social toleration.⁹² Moreover the Puritan idea of the 'Godly community', in which sin had a communal character, and could infect those who did not rebuke or shun it, was steadily declining at the end of the seventeenth century.⁹³ Indeed this decline might be a taproot of the eighteenth-century Enlightenment. Such ideas of the legitimacy of pleasure, the social value of toleration, and the decline of ideas of communal moral punishment (though not their eradication as has been seen) loosened the mental shackles on biblical ideas of sexuality. Sex could be pleasurable, neighbours' sexual behaviour might be disapproved of, but tolerated, and certainly the sexual transgressions of other people did not seem to imperil an individual's salvation.

The angry God, who punished all men and women for the sins of Adam and Eve, became less familiar than a God who wanted people to achieve their political, social, economic, and also their sexual, potential. Even Samuel Wigglesworth advocated 'natural pleasures [...], pleasures respecting outward and common things.' Sensuality and appetites were condemned in excess. Pleasure in 'debaucheries' was short-lived but spiritual pleasures and those derived from marriage were entirely legitimate.⁹⁴ John Tottie advanced the case for the natural character of sexual impulses to Oxford students though he still placed this in a religious framework. He said:

Let it be further remarked, that when Concupiscence itself is said to have the Nature of Sin, it is because it is an irregular Tendency of the Appetites, either desiring that which is not lawful, or pursuing that which is so, beyond the limits of Reason and Duty. Otherwise, the Desires are Natural and therefore not Criminal, and the Gratification of them must be Innocent because it is Necessary. We are placed by Providence in this world not only under a Necessity of satisfying them for the support of Life, but with a gracious Permission to gratify them with force degree of Indulgence beyond strict Necessity, for the comfort and well being of it ... They are not therefore absolutely and in their own Nature Sinful; but they are too apt to be the Occasions and Incitements to Sin.⁹⁵

Consequently the role of religion and of the Church was to teach the proper regulation and restraint of sexual desire and pleasure and its lawful and moral expressions. Tottie warned against sex when it became the source of 'incontinence riot and luxury' but praised it when it was the source of 'order, harmony and the peace of regular self-government.' The University of Oxford was, claimed Tottie a place where:

Young Persons are ... designed to be put out of the Way of Temptations, to which others from a less happy Situation are too frequently exposed; and from an early Habit of Temperance and Self-command they may learn either to prevent all irregular Solicitations, or with ease to controul them. Happy are they, who by a thankful enjoyment of these Advantages, and a willing Compliance with these Rules, lay up in store for the rest of their Life Vertue, Health and Peace!⁹⁶

Gilbert Burnet had taken a similar view but had identified the origin of restraint in Christ's teaching for mankind. Writing of the restrictions imposed on men's sexual behaviour, and especially of the control required so that men did not defile the wives or daughters of others in whom they possessed a 'property', Burnet wrote:

Our Saviour, knowing that nothing could so effectually deliver the world from the mischief of unrestrained appetite, as a confinement of it, might very seasonably enjoin it.⁹⁷

It was a view also endorsed in the correspondence of the Revd Lewis Stephens, a Hampshire parson. Writing to his friend the MP Francis Gregor in July 1745, in the wake of homosexual scandals in Oxford, Stephens argued that excessive alcohol consumption had caused the sexual misconduct: 'bridles govern the violent heats of the horse; and Temperance is the only bridle that restrains the violent passions of men; and leads them on, in a gentle & stately pace, to ye pleasant fields of Virtue.'⁹⁸

A different view, directed at a young aristocrat, was advanced by the Revd Charles de Guiffardiere, later prebendary of Salisbury and rector of St James's Piccadilly, in December 1764. He advised James Boswell on the source of sexual morality, claiming that 'our hearts' morality is the only morality we have to lead us'. He argued that there was a difference between 'those gross and clumsy souls' for whom the church's 'absurd principles' had been framed and those who could obtain 'the delicacy of taste which enables a well-born soul to feel all that is lovable in virtue and hateful in vice, independently of the ridiculous reasons advanced by our sages.' This class-based morality enabled de Guiffardiere to advise Boswell:

Above all, devote yourself to women. You realize of course that I am not speaking of that class of women to whom young men go to purchase disgust at real pleasures, but of those women who are distinguished for their feelings, their delicacy, for that taste for the voluptuous which so well characterizes sensitive souls; for a healthy judgment, an exquisite finesse. That is the world in which you belong. Let books and study have their turn, but let them never serve save as pastimes.⁹⁹

Perhaps it was to be expected that a young aristocrat would receive such advice from a liberally-minded clergyman, who made a distinction between biblical teachings for the poor and emotional morality for the rich; and that women might be divided into those who provided disgust or delicacy.

In travelling through Europe, and in many cases to the Mediterranean and the Near East, eighteenth-century grand tourists often saw sexual behaviour that was in contrast to the teaching of the Church of England. Expanding the mind often meant expanding morality too. Though de

Guiffardiere's advice was the private teaching of a clergyman, not for the consumption of the public, the literate public increasingly read of explorations to distant parts of the world where native peoples did not conform to the Church of England's teaching on marriage. John Wesley was especially shocked by accounts from Captain Cook's voyages of men and women freely having sex 'without any sense of shame'.¹⁰⁰

The adoption of less restrictive religious ideas took time to permeate society. There remained many who could not conceive of sex as other than a source of shame and biblical condemnation; but theology increasingly endorsed a rational and moderate view of sexual behaviour. Indeed, public preaching increasingly taught the reasonableness of God and of the demands he made on Christians for a good life. Pleasure was no longer automatically seen as dangerous and a door-way to self-indulgence and vice. Pleasure when it was restrained and reasonable, and did not lead to vice, indecency, or licentiousness, played a natural part in the world.¹⁰¹ Music, for example, was a virtuous pleasure and endorsed by church ventures such as the Three Choirs Festival.¹⁰² Laurence Sterne's sermon on the 'temporal advantages of religion' also addressed this theme. Sterne took the view that it was not the case the sinful life is one of 'pleasure and happy advantage' and the virtuous life 'a most servile and uncomfortable state.' Indeed he argued that the devil led men to commit sins because of the mistaken assumption that it was pleasurable. He challenged whether:

... not to prosecute our passions is to be cowards – and to forgoe every thing for the tedious distance of a future life ... I own we are by nature so goaded on by the desire of present happiness that was that the case, thousands would faint under the discouragement of so remote an expectation ...'

Sterne argued that pleasure came from everyday acts of kindness and from sensations and emotions.¹⁰³

Faramerz Dabhoiwala has argued that the gradual change in attitudes to sex was derived from religious toleration: 'sexual toleration grew out of religious toleration'.¹⁰⁴ For Dabhoiwala, sexual tolerance was rooted in the intellectual changes of the early English Enlightenment. Not all eighteenth-century observers would have agreed. John Shower, a Dissenter, preaching before the societies for the reformation of manners

in 1698, contended that religious toleration did *not* lead to moral toleration.¹⁰⁵ There is evidence that Shower's view was widely held: in the wake of the Toleration Act there had been some tightening of legislation on other moral issues, the best example of which was the Blasphemy Act of 1697. Still, in the long run, John Locke's arguments prevailed, that private principles and beliefs could not be forcibly changed or shackled, and that the state had no role in matters which were entirely private and did not affect the wellbeing of society.¹⁰⁶ Locke held that the logic of the prevailing system of ecclesiastical establishment was that:

Whosoever . . . is sincerely solicitous about the kingdom of God and thinks it his duty to endeavour the enlargement of it amongst men, ought to apply himself with no less care and industry to the rooting out of . . . immoralities than to the extirpation of sects.¹⁰⁷

This was the basis of the work of the societies for the reformation of manners. But Locke went on:

no opinions contrary to human society, or to those moral rules which are necessary to the preservation of civil society, are to be tolerated by the magistrate. But of these, indeed, examples in any Church are rare.¹⁰⁸

Locke held that conscience, not the law, was the prime means of policing private morality. Dabhiowala's view is that Locke's prescription was 'a tricky balancing act to sustain.'¹⁰⁹ Certainly Locke has to be treated carefully, as Mark Goldie has pointed out:

His arguments are not as radical as those of Spinoza or Bayle, who were more inclusive and more skeptical. Crudely, Locke is not John Stuart Mill, for it is to *On Liberty* (1859) that we turn to find a celebration of pluralism and arguments for moral diversity. "Tolerance," after all, denotes forbearance, not approval, and Locke defends rather than applauds religious diversity. Moreover, he does not offer toleration in the ethical sphere; quite the contrary, he upholds godly living as a better aspiration for civil societies than the disciplining of doctrine and worship.¹¹⁰

So it is important not to assume that Locke advocated sexual liberalism or complete moral freedom.

In fact Locke indicated that there was a distinction to be made between spiritual and moral issues, the former threatened the stability of society whereas the latter did not.¹¹¹ In fact it is clear from contemporaries that both were regarded as dangerous: religious heterodoxy and sexual heterodoxy were closely associated in the eighteenth-century mind with political dissent and certainly as equally destabilising forces.¹¹² It is also clear that Locke's goal was not to weaken moral restraint, it was to strengthen it; whereas he certainly advocated loosening strictures on religious opinion.

Nevertheless, the intellectual implications of the Toleration Act were wide-reaching: if individuals were permitted to worship in their own way, and not required to pay public allegiance to the Church of England, why should their sexual lives be regulated? Some of the opponents of religious toleration argued exactly this case, observing that religious toleration would lead to immorality because it loosened the discipline of the Church over society and unfettered people's behaviour and scruples.¹¹³ By 1750 Samuel Johnson wrote in the *Rambler*:

That every man should regulate his actions by his own conscience, without any regard to the opinions of the rest of the world, is one of the first precepts of moral prudence; justified not only by the suffrage of reason, which declares that none of the gifts of heaven are to lie useless, but by the voice likewise of experience, which will soon inform us that, if we make the praise or blame of others the rule of our conduct, we shall be distracted by a boundless variety of irreconcilable judgments, be held in perpetual suspense between contrary impulses, and consult for ever without determination.¹¹⁴

In this way the judgement of the Church on sexual conduct became just another voice of 'praise or blame' which could be followed or ignored. As Mark Goldie has claimed, the Toleration Act made religion a voluntary activity and the same applied to its sexual precepts.¹¹⁵ Nevertheless such ideas took a long time to percolate widely through society.

At the same time as ideas of religious toleration were growing, Anglican Latitudinarians were advocating religious toleration of Dissenters and the adoption of conscience and sincerity of judgement over Church discipline in securing moral lives. Benjamin Hoadly repeatedly advocated this view in his debate with Dissenters on conforming to the Church, and in opposition to Non-jurors.¹¹⁶ Hoadly wanted the Church to broaden its bounds to enable the return of Dissenters to its fold. This required the Church to give up its power to censure and proscribe Christians who were not strictly orthodox. So Hoadly attacked the Convocation of Canterbury for its claim to be able to discipline those who did not conform to all its principles. In his Bangorian sermon he argued that Christ left no human authority to discipline Christians:

[Christ] is himself the sole law-giver to his subjects, and himself the sole Judge of their behaviour in the affairs of conscience and eternal salvation. And . . . hath, in those points, left behind him no visible, human authority; no vicegerents who can be said properly to supply his place; no interpreters upon whom his subjects are absolutely to depend.¹¹⁷

In such circumstances how could the Church claim to judge and condemn differences of conscience or of personal morality?

Moreover Hoadly and other Latitudinarians, who were also often Pelagian in their views of God, regarded God as rational and reasonable. Hoadly taught that God's expectation of human behaviour was proportionate to Christians' capacities.¹¹⁸ It followed that God would not have given mankind sexual desires without a proportionate ability to enjoy them or restrain them. Furthermore God did not expect perfection of men and women; Hoadly preached that on earth: 'The perfection required of man in a state of trial and probation cannot be a state incapable of improvement . . .'¹¹⁹ So God himself was regarded as more tolerant of human weakness and frailty, and this applied as much to sex as to other forms of moral behaviour. Hoadly's work was enormously popular and certainly gained wide readership; his suite of sermons on 'the terms of acceptance with God' which propounded his ideas of a reasonable God, went through four editions between 1719 and 1734. Hoadly and the Latitudinarians promoted a new confidence in God's

leniency and mercy, especially in what might be seen as lesser moral transgressions.

The teaching of the Latitudinarians regarding morality took time to achieve acceptance in the Church. It did not achieve currency without challenge. In 1720 the Tory parson Richard Fiddes wrote that:

Many take refuge in the divine mercy and goodness, tho' they live in a known state of sin, presuming that God, who knows whereof they are made, will not in consequence of any abuse of their liberty, render them more miserable than if they had never been. Others flatter themselves, that tho' God has threatened eternal punishment to sinners, yet he reserves the power of executing his threats in his own hands, and possibly after all may not execute them.¹²⁰

Fiddes argued that this view was an error on the part of Christians; but he represented a declining opinion. A rational and reasonable God, who knew men and women's weaknesses and flaws, would not punish them for acting on their appetites or for not being in a state of perfection. Such ideas were in tune with the rise of ideas of 'natural religion' in which sex was regarded as a natural element in the order of creation and stripped of ideas of sin and pollution. Natural religion seemed to occupy a middle ground between traditional High Church Anglicanism and the apparent atheism of David Hume. Taken to its logical conclusion, natural religion led to views like those of the radical politician Richard Carlile who in 1824 suggested that sex had as little to do with morality as other bodily functions like eating and drinking'.¹²¹

The growth of natural theology went hand in hand with a Pelagian-led decline in the idea of Original Sin. Theologians like William Paley emphasised the innocence and sinlessness of humankind in its natural state and regarded sin as an aberration rather than an integral part of human nature. As the notion of Original Sin declined, so too did the absolute injunctions regarding sex that attended it. If men and women were not irredeemably sinful, and could choose to be good or evil, it followed that sexual transgressions were matters of choice and judgement. In this way individuals chose personal morality over absolute ecclesiastical proscriptions.

Jonathan Swift is an example of a clergyman who adopted something of a middle path in his attitude to fornication and adultery. Swift preached against fornication, and denounced it both as a moral sin and as a cause of social evils including the spread of venereal disease. In this he possessed the seriousness of a conscientious clergyman.¹²² He was also capable of denouncing adultery in public figures, as he did with Lord Wharton.¹²³ Yet Swift himself engaged in complex sexual relationships outside marriage with women, though allegations that he contracted a secret marriage to Esther Johnson have been contested by scholars.¹²⁴ In satirical mood, Swift spoke of preaching 'against foppery and fornication' as '... a ball bandied to and fro and every man carries a racket about him to strike it from himself among the rest of the company.'¹²⁵ In more serious tone in 1712, Swift responded to Gilbert Burnet's attack on sacrilege in his *History of the Reformation*:

Our Litany calls fornication a deadly sin and I would appeal to his Lordship for fifty years past whether he thought that or sacrilege the deadliest? To make light of such a sin at the same moment that he is frightening us from an idolatrous religion should seem not very consistent.¹²⁶

But Swift was a subtle thinker who understood and relished the nature of paradox. Adultery was a source of Swift's condemnation, yet he saw the nature of relativism in sin. This was one of the emergent elements in eighteenth-century thought that changed the nature of attitudes to sexuality. The next two chapters demonstrate that the Church's attitudes to, and disciplining of, illicit sex was also complex and multi-layered.

CHAPTER 2

THE CHURCH, SEX, AND THE PUBLIC SPHERE

The Church's position on public sexual morality in the eighteenth century was the result of the complex and ambiguous relationship between the Church, politics, and sex. Its values dominated public life, even after the Toleration Act, since it was the only legally established moral guardian of the nation. Public morality was, however, differentiated because the Church's expression and enforcement of these values operated differently in its relationships with the poor, the middling-sort, and with the aristocracy and monarchy. By the later eighteenth century this differentiation had become an aspect of social conflict given the established Church's identification with the middle- and upper-classes. In this way the Church's interaction with sexual matters in the public sphere did not produce a universal language of moral values. Its role cannot therefore be fully accommodated within the Habermasian notion of the public sphere as creating an inclusive forum for debate, nor was the Church's engagement with sexuality in the public sphere always progressive. On the other hand the Church's involvement with sex supports Habermas's thesis that a national discourse emerged in this period which was separate from the state and public authority. This chapter explores the ways in which this public sphere of sexual morals related to the state and was formulated around sexual vigilantes' appropriation of moral authority, and the questioning and discussion of the royal family's and aristocracy's moral behaviour.¹

The Sexual Glorious Revolution

Dudley Bahlman argued that the Glorious Revolution of 1688 ushered in a moral as well as a political and constitutional revolution.² Bahlman's case was that in the wake of the avowedly Protestant Revolution came a vigorous moral reform movement in the guise of the societies for the reformation of manners. For many pious Christians, the Restoration of Charles II in 1660 had brought decadence and moral decay to the nation. Even Lord Rochester, a rake who died in 1680 of syphilis after years of scandalous behaviour at court, was said to have been an innocent young man when he came to court in 1664. Yet within a few years he was infected by the libertine ethos of court life and penned poems about 'who fucked who, and who does worse.'³ The decadence of the pre-Revolution court, its moral critics thought, owed a good deal to Charles II's and James II's foreign travels and Catholic sympathies. Moreover, critics believed the masquerades and sexual promiscuity that were openly indulged at court and in the theatre created a precedent for sexual immorality that spread through the rest of the nation. For zealous Protestants, this growth of vice was regarded as part of a conspiracy by Catholics to debauch the nation so that it was morally weakened and could not resist the attempts by Charles II, and especially James II, to convert England back to Rome.⁴

Other examples of sexual decadence survived from the extreme Protestant sects of the earlier seventeenth century, which had adopted Antinomian principles organised around the idea that their faith and elect status freed them from the obligation of human and even biblical laws. Antinomians believed that the elect were able to transgress moral tenets without sinning, so demonstrating their elect status. Thus they were alleged to have behaved as shockingly as some courtiers. Antinomianism, for example, was one of the explanations advanced to explain the case of a small group of middling Protestants in Norwich who engaged in voyeurism, group-sex, wife-swapping, and flagellation and claimed it was holy behaviour. When the group was prosecuted in 1706–7 the case shocked both the court and the city of Norwich.⁵

Given the associations of the Restoration court with illicit sex, after the Glorious Revolution sexual immorality and vice could be portrayed as foreign, and as dangerous politically as it was spiritually. Bishop Gilbert Burnet aligned sexual licence with extravagance and

self-indulgence, alleging that both drew people to vice.⁶ This was also a period in which there remained a widespread religious fear of the immediate consequences of sexual immorality and blasphemy. A nation whose sin and guilt was flagrant might be punished as a whole, with the innocent struck down as well as the guilty.

Fear of national immorality was the official position of the government: William III issued two warnings that God might visit his wrath and vengeance on a sinful nation if vice was not reduced.⁷ His 1699 proclamation asserted that 'vices were sins and insurrections against God' and that the nation was in danger because 'the open and avowed Practice of Vice ... provoke God to withdraw his Mercy and Blessings from Us and instead thereof to inflict heavy and severe Judgements.'⁸ There was plenty of evidence for such providential punishments, from the plagues that afflicted England in the 1660s, to the Great Fire of London in 1666, mild earthquakes in 1692, the deaths of Queen Mary II and Archbishop Tillotson in 1694, and the Great Storm of 1703. Each event was attended by warnings that it was the consequence of divine fury at immoral behaviour and national sinfulness. In 1699 Archbishop Tenison's letter to the bishops of his province claimed that unless there was an improvement in the battle against vice the nation risked bringing down 'the heaviest judgement of God upon us.'⁹ James Harris's sermon on 4 April 1701 at St Mary Magdalen, Old Fish Street in London used the text 'wash you, keep you clean' as the starting point for an account of how sin and immorality would bring down a punishment of blood on the nation. As a fellow of the Royal Society as well as a parson, Harris spoke with the voice of science as well as religion.¹⁰

These fears of public sinfulness covered all manner of offences besides sexual misbehaviour, including drunkenness, swearing, blasphemy, and not observing Sundays with due reverence. Theologically these were not distinguished from sexual offences such as fornication, adultery, sodomy, and prostitution. For the state and the Church, all of them transgressed biblical injunctions and had the potential to lead from minor to major sins. Thus in February 1689 William III issued instructions to the Bishop of London, almost the first declaration of his reign, that parish clergy should be urged to present to the church courts for punishment those guilty of fornication and adultery, as well as preaching against these sins.¹¹ Such proclamations became a standard feature of public life

and were repeatedly issued by William and Mary, Queen Anne and George I and II. Queen Mary, for example, wrote to the Middlesex magistrates in 1691 urging them on to great efforts to prosecute and punish immorality.¹² William III asked the Convocation of Canterbury to consider 'the reformation of manners both in ministers and people' at its first meeting of his reign.¹³ It was an initiative that was welcomed by widespread support for the suppression of vice. Moreover, bishops were quick to adopt such injunctions in their visitation sermons and charges: Bishops Stillingfleet of Worcester and Patrick of Ely were among those whose first sermons after the Revolution addressed the improvement of morality.

There is however a paradox in the moral revolution of 1688. At the centre of the events of 1688–9 was a process of national disavowal of James II as king. All manner of officials, magistrates, lord lieutenants, clergy, and ministers, abandoned their oaths of allegiance since the public ideological narrative was that the king had broken his coronation oath and had abdicated the throne, freeing those who had sworn oaths from their commitments. Though Non-jurors felt that they could not be released from their oaths, most people believed that an oath, even when given in good faith, could not bind men and women unconditionally. This was a small crack in the edifice of the cement that bound together England which was a 'polity defined by oaths.'¹⁴ Such fissures extended into the domain of personal sexual relationships with some aristocrats' attempts to terminate their marriage contracts through parliamentary divorce.

Like the oaths of allegiance to James II, marriage vows were increasingly regarded as given in good faith but not unconditionally binding on spouses. In the 1690s the House of Lords was confronted with the Duke of Norfolk's private divorce bills.¹⁵ Three bills between 1692 and 1700 pressed the Duke's case that he could not be held to his vows because of his wife's adultery. Contemporaries made a connection with the oaths taken to James II.¹⁶ After Norfolk instigated proceedings, the Earl of Macclesfield followed, achieving a parliamentary divorce before the Duke in 1697, the first act of Parliament dissolving a marriage.¹⁷ Both cases were protracted and played out in the public eye with tracts and broadside sheets commenting on them.¹⁸ They also suggested that the slackening of strictures of oaths and unconditional commitments was growing. Moreover, the Duke's success at the third

attempt in 1700 was largely due to an alignment of religion and politics. His bill stated that granting the divorce was a means for Parliament to 'preserve the inheritance of so great an office and honours to persons of the true religion.' The ducal couple had no issue and a divorce would thus avoid the Protestant duke's estates being inherited by the adulterous Duchess of Norfolk who was a Catholic.¹⁹ The Revolution of 1688 may have strengthened the Church but it weakened the concept of absolute and indissoluble vows.

Sexual Vigilantes and the Reformation of Manners

In his 1699 letter to his bishops Archbishop Tenison suggested the most effective mechanism to address royal and episcopal concern about loosening sexual behaviour in the first decades of the eighteenth century. He proposed that clergy should join together to take action against immorality and share their best ideas of how to do so. Tenison's letter was inspired by the societies for the reformation of manners which had emerged in London. The earliest society dated back to 1678 when a group of young London clergy, including Tenison and Anthony Horneck, a German convert to Anglicanism, met to discuss their concerns over the sexual excesses of Charles II's court. The movement did not gather pace until the creation of more societies after 1691 under William and Mary's impetus.

The societies were formed of pious laymen and clergy who set out to enforce the existing laws against immoral behaviour. The societies drew together a diverse membership. Socially they included members of parliament, lawyers, magistrates, and the wealthy, as well as tradesmen and working men; religiously they brought together Anglicans and Protestant Dissenters. Cooperation only went so far in certain cases. Some societies, such as that in Hull, were led by dissenters and in such instances bishops were very wary of endorsing their work, for fear of giving official sanction to what they saw as schismatic congregations.²⁰ Elsewhere collaboration was common. Societies often held their annual sermons in dissenters' meeting houses, as when Moses Lowman preached at Salter's Hall, a Presbyterian meeting house, in 1720. Indeed, Lowman asserted that civil and religious powers should unite in moral reformation.²¹ Among Anglicans, the societies attracted both Latitudinarians, like Gilbert Burnet, who saw their business as



Figure 3 R. White, *Engraving of King William III and his wife Queen Mary*, c. 1689. Despite ushering in a period of moral reform in the country, both William and Mary experienced controversial personal relationships.
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'charitable reproof' of sinners, and High Churchmen, who regarded punishment of sin as the exercise of the disciplinary and sacerdotal authority of the Church.²² As an institution the Church strongly supported the societies, with the Archbishop of Canterbury and all the bishops of his province writing a circular letter to endorse the societies' activities,²³ although the Tory High Church Archbishop Sharp of York was much more equivocal in his support.²⁴ As early as 1699 an account of the societies identified the approval of the bishops and the work of Anglican clergy as vital to the success of the enterprise.²⁵

The movement for the reformation of manners gradually spread across England and Wales and many towns established their own local societies. Members of these societies regarded sin and immorality as encompassing a wide range of public behaviour which could have specific local concerns. In Lincolnshire, horse-racing on Sundays was a particular anxiety, while elsewhere swearing and public profanity were more serious worries. Nonetheless all the societies had worries about the corruption of youth, Sunday observance, and the public visibility of prostitution and fornication. It was thought that God was especially troubled by the brazenness of public displays of sin, whose notoriety was likely to normalise it in the eyes of the young. The societies also linked sexual immorality to criminality. Josiah Woodward, one of the societies' leaders, thought 'shameful lewdness' and lust were naturally associated with idleness and led people into more serious property crimes such as burglary, lock- and pocket-picking.²⁶

The societies joined the long-established religious attack on the stage and theatres. Under the Commonwealth, plays and acting had been banned and many theatres were pulled down. Charles II had permitted the return of theatres and during his reign their number grew. Nevertheless clergymen remained wary and worried by acting and theatre. The most vocal opponent of the stage in the early eighteenth century was the Non-juror Jeremy Collier. His *A Short View of the Immorality and Profaneness of the English Stage*, published in 1698, was a stern attack on the vulgarity and sexual immorality depicted in Restoration comedies.²⁷ Collier regarded plays, and especially the comedies, as smutty, obscene, and coarse and claimed they impugned women's reputation by depicting them as promiscuous.²⁸ Moreover, depictions of effeminacy and homosexuality were common in Restoration dramas.²⁹ Collier especially objected to the way in which religion was

treated with levity, and clergy were depicted as figures of fun, and saw the depiction of prostitution and debauchery on the stage as sinful. To Collier the theatre was both morally wrong and normalised vice so that it encouraged people to indulge themselves. He appealed to the early church authorities who opposed the theatre, such as Tertullian, St Cyprian, St Chrysostom, and St Augustine.

While Collier expressed himself in scriptural and theological terms, he captured a popular sentiment that had turned against the increasing coarseness of Restoration comedy.³⁰ In 1704, in response to an address, Queen Anne commissioned Sir John Vanbrugh and William Congreve to ensure that 'the immoralities of the stage' were corrected and that new comedies omitted the vulgarities of the past.³¹ The attack on the stage was not successful in the long run, but Collier's and other campaigns ensured that excessive vulgarity and public displays of sexual innuendo were restrained. Macaulay even claimed that, as a result, there was a dramatic change in the tone of plays between 1660 and 1710.³²

The societies for the reformation of manners justified their work through biblical teaching, such as St Paul's letter to the Thessalonians in which he urged them to 'exhort yourselves together, edify one another, even as also you do. Let the word of Christ dwell richly in you, teaching and admonishing one another. We beseech you, warn them that are unruly.'³³ Other Pauline scriptures advised Christians to reprove sinners and to shun them.³⁴ Vigilantism was a new departure, however. Earlier such direct action had been subject to disapproval, Lord Chief Justice Sir John Keeling had accused London apprentices of acting against the king's peace when they pulled down a bawdy house in 1668.³⁵ Though the societies' meetings were partly opportunities for members to worship and pray, they were also to plan and organise vigilante action against immorality. This action included the use of informants, private prosecutions, the encouragement of magistrates to investigate, and even payment of bribes and bounties for the capture of, or information against, sinners. In some cases the societies used *agents provocateur* to lead people to commit an offence which was then prosecuted.

At the core of the work of the societies in reforming public manners was the open shaming and rebuking of those accused of sexual offences. In a sermon to the societies for the reformation of manners in 1702, George Stanhope, a leading churchman and chaplain to Queen Anne, argued that rebuking sin was a Christian duty, since it encouraged

offenders to amend their behaviour. He stated that Christians had an obligation to challenge the 'brutish obstinacy' of sinners who threatened the 'common safety' though he counselled the congregation not to rebuke people at the moment when they were 'inflamed by lust' and to avoid adopting a vengeful or grudging tone.³⁶ For Stanhope, sins such as adultery and fornication were aspects of broader immoral conduct which included a range of 'unnatural' behaviour, all of which contributed both to the disorderly nature of society and the imperilling of the sinner's soul. An adulterer stood alongside an undutiful child since both broke the Ten Commandments. He reminded his audience that:

it is impossible for an Adulterer, a Fornicator, a Drunkard, a Swearer, a Profane Person, or the like; so is it for an unkind Husband, a cruel Master, an unnatural Father, an undutiful Child, an unfair Dealer, a negligent or malepert Servant, or a contentious Neighbour, to be a good Christian.³⁷

Shame and public embarrassment were integral to the biblical campaign against immorality; the societies thus deployed shaming in their work. In the words of Bishop Edward Chandler, shame was a sense 'interwoven with the constitution of men' to anticipate the judgement of God and convey the 'reproach of other men' against 'things immodest, indecent or dishonest.'³⁸ Most striking was the practice of issuing printed lists of offenders, in the hope that by naming 'lewd persons' they would be shamed into ceasing their activities. One of the most vocal of the societies' supporters, the Revd John Disney, demonstrated in his publications how deeply rooted in biblical teaching the shaming publicity campaigns of the societies were.³⁹

Recent scholarship on shame has suggested that manners and politeness were a method for controlling appetites that developed in the eighteenth century, though they did not replace 'the need for more direct controls on errant individuals.'⁴⁰ Informal action by communities, such as 'rough music', remained strong through this period, but the societies for the reformation of manners used public formal methods of shaming. These included prosecutions and the naming of those convicted, which relied on an audience that held the same values and principles of those who accused the transgressors, and in this respect the societies assumed that society at large shared their disapproval of swearing, prostitution,

homosexuality, and promiscuity. There is evidence that even the most committed rake felt guilt at his own misbehaviour. James Boswell in 1776 devoted a night to sex in a brothel, but wrote later, 'I could not rest ... and went home cold and disturbed and dreary and vexed, with remorse rising like a black cloud without any distinct form.'⁴¹

Shame and guilt were bedfellows that drew on the ambient religious teachings of what was right and wrong, and even Boswell could not insulate himself from it. Shaming raises the issue of the degree to which public vice was objectionable because it was open and therefore seemed more brazen. Disney, a magistrate as well as a parson, commented that 'vice when it is private and retired is not attended with those provoking circumstances as when it revels in your street and in your markets and bids defiance to God and Religion in the open face of day.'⁴² This might appear to be hypocrisy, but Disney focused on how the dangers of open vice encouraged others to engage in it.

The main strategy of the societies for the reformation of manners was to prosecute offenders in church courts or use laws which obliged magistrates to take action. Indeed members soon grew into an informal militia of reformers. In addition to prosecutions, the societies published and circulated tracts, especially sermons, which warned against the dangers of sin and vice. They also issued guides to how to compel magistrates to pursue prosecutions, including the specific laws and penalties against constables and magistrates who were negligent in prosecuting vice. These guides were accompanied by blank warrant forms that constables and magistrates had simply to fill out in order to prosecute an offender.⁴³ Some magistrates enthusiastically joined in the campaign. Sir John Gonson (1677–1765) came to specialise in raiding brothels in the 1720s and 1730s. His notoriety for searches of brothels was so widespread that he was depicted on a raid in the third scene of Hogarth's *A Harlot's Progress*, published in 1731.

Contemporaries made significant claims for the achievements of the societies for the reformation of manners. In 1722, Bishop Joseph Wilcocks of Gloucester, preaching before the societies in London and Westminster, claimed that there were some grounds for optimism, and that the work of 'the virtuous informer' was achieving its objective. He asserted that 'there have been times more profligate' than their own; and 'it may, I believe, be truly said, that within our own memory there has been an alteration for the better and some progress made in the cure

of evil ...'⁴⁴ Wilcocks congratulated those whose 'eminent services and successful endeavours' had opposed the 'agents and commissaries of the Devil' who ran 'seminaries of vice and marts of immorality'.⁴⁵ This sort of contemporary expression of satisfaction at the work of the societies for the reformation of manners has been largely ignored by scholars. The tendency to treat the societies as a hopeless attempt to uphold out-dated standards is perhaps one which is in need of revision. It is only on the flimsy evidence of Hogarth's satire *A Harlot's Progress* that Cruickshank implausibly claims, 'classically educated and bookish eighteenth century clergymen did little to prevent young women from falling into the snare of prostitution.'⁴⁶ Indeed some historians and theologians have therefore tended to consider the societies for the reformation of manners as a high point of moral teaching in the first half of the eighteenth century and as a regressive expression of older morality.

Other scholars have made different claims for the movement. For example, G. J. Barker-Benfield suggested that the societies were part of a broader reformation of masculinity in the eighteenth century. In this model of masculine identity, honour, and decency were elevated over immediate sexual gratification. The work of the societies may also have contributed to the growing politeness of English society because it challenged and aimed to eradicate vulgarity, coarseness, and open sexual promiscuity. Barker-Benfield even claimed that the movement contributed to growing literacy in the eighteenth century.⁴⁷

Of course reform and progress were not inimical to religious principles. For example, the philosopher Bernard Mandeville developed a critical response to the campaign of the societies for the reformation of manners against prostitution, which was part of his critique of moral virtues as the key to economic and social success. But Mandeville did not reject religious values. He addressed his *A Modest Defence of Public Stews* directly to the societies' members.⁴⁸ It was a heavily satirical work with an emphasis on the futility of religiously-inspired vigilante action. Mandeville claimed that the societies had only 'prun'd instead of ... lopp'd' prostitution so that it had grown back more strongly; and by prosecuting prostitutes the societies had blocked 'those drains and sluices we had to let out lewdness.' While Mandeville's suggestion that there should be government-run brothels, licenced, inspected for pox, and confined to a specific district was a satirical one, it pointed out the flaws in the societies' approach to the problem. It was a self-conscious

inversion of traditional religious teaching by advocating rather than condemning prostitution, and accepting it as a public good. Mandeville claimed the societies assumed that all men were incorrigible and that matrimony could not affect men's behaviour; they had also found the wrong solution for the problem, Mandeville wrote ironically:

It is very possible, indeed, that leaving a poor girl penniless, may put her in a way of living honestly, tho' the want of money was the only reason of her living otherwise; and the stripping of her ... may, for aught I know, contribute to her modesty ...⁴⁹

He argued that legalising and regulating prostitution would control and restrict the vice, it would end infanticide, prevent the debauching of married women, limit disorder, and control disease. He claimed that men 'can't stop the circulation of his blood, or prevent the seminal secretions: for sleeping or waking the spermaticks will do their office, tho' a man's thoughts may be so much employ'd about other affairs ...' and consequently there would always be prostitution. It was in many ways preferable to men relieving their lust with 'manufriction' which weakened their natural vigour.⁵⁰ It is clear from his references to the House of Lords as the natural regulator of prostitution that Mandeville's tongue was in his cheek.

Nevertheless, Mandeville was concerned with religion; he agreed that actions were good or evil and 'cannot be alter'd or determin'd by any secular force.' He acknowledged that he would be accused of doing evil that good may come of it, but he countered this that there was biblical injunction to choose the lesser of two evils, and replacing private vice with public stews was the lesser. He argued:

One of the greatest perfections of the Christian religion [is] that its precepts are calculated to promote the happiness of mankind in this world as well as the next; if so, then it is a direct arraignment of the lawgivers infinite wisdom ... therefore we can with conscience affirm that no sinful laws can be beneficial, and that no beneficial laws can be sinful ...⁵¹

This may not have been good logic but it served Mandeville's purpose. Profoundly cynical as Mandeville's proposal was, it suggested that the

campaigns of the societies for the reformation of manners against prostitution declined in part because the argument against vices was no longer regarded as a public matter. But even advocates of social progress, like Mandeville, were not proposing to eradicate all moral and religious restraint, indeed quite the opposite, he wanted to buttress ideas of honour and public virtue.

The societies had a significant impact identifying and prosecuting vice initially. Between 1695 and 1700 the societies prosecuted an average of 792 people a year.⁵² In 1720 they were prosecuting 2,000 cases a year in London, and in total since 1691 they had brought 75,270 cases to the courts.⁵³ When Bishop Edward Chandler of Lichfield and Coventry preached to the societies for the reformation of manners at St Mary le Bow, the work of the societies was a source of some satisfaction. In the year from December 1723 to December 1724 nearly three thousand people had been prosecuted for some form of immoral behaviour and in total 89,393 people since the start of the societies' work. The thirtieth annual account of the societies appended to the sermon noted that:

if impiety and debauchery had gone on spreading and increasing amongst us for the last thirty years, at the same prodigious rate as they did for many years before, we had assuredly been one of the most profligate nations in the Christian world ... but by the Blessing of God on the various endeavours of the societies ... a wonderful check hath been given to the prevalency of the most scandalous vices ...⁵⁴

By 1738 the societies claimed to have prosecuted over 100,000 offenders.⁵⁵ Their prosecution rate fell back under the administrations of 1710–14 because the Tories disliked the collaboration of Anglicans and Dissenters in the societies, but prosecutions rose again under George I and II. According to Defoe, by the mid-1720s Bankside and other areas of London had been cleared of their brothels due to the work of the societies; although other accounts suggest that prostitution was growing.⁵⁶

It has been argued that the reformers' activities against prostitution attracted public opposition and brought the societies into disrepute and, in time, disuse.⁵⁷ From a peak in 1724, when 1,951 individuals

committing 'lewd and disorderly practices' were prosecuted, the vigilante work of the societies fell away until by 1738 this number had fallen to 52.⁵⁸ Prosecutions and informants were less effective as the population of London grew, as constables and magistrates became more active, and as the Church preached more consistently against the dangers of immorality. Some vigilantes, such as Sampson Cooke, were also found to be using illegal general warrants against transgressors.⁵⁹ Even legal principles seemed to obstruct the societies: Lord Chief Justice Holt argued as early as 1709 that women could not be prosecuted as prostitutes simply because they were on the streets at night.⁶⁰ Some provincial societies were unable to sustain their activities for more than a few years; the Hull society lasted only from 1697 to 1705. Perhaps its emphasis on the prosecution of swearing contributed to its demise because the offences seemed so minor.⁶¹ A further factor was the rise of Methodism, another form of religious society that stood in direct succession to the societies for the reformation of manners. Moreover the societies had always existed in an ambiguous relationship to the Church's formal structures and some churchmen had been lukewarm about their efforts.⁶² So by the mid-eighteenth century vigilante sexual policing had largely been eclipsed. Many campaigners had turned their attention to worries about gin and public drunkenness.

Nonetheless royal interest in moral reform did not disappear after the decline in the number of prosecutions by the societies in the mid-eighteenth century. George I and II both issued regular proclamations against disorderly behaviour and immorality. In 1787 the evangelical William Wilberforce and Bishop Beilby Porteus petitioned George III to issue a proclamation 'For the Encouragement of Piety and Virtue, and for the Preventing and Punishing of Vice, Profaneness and Immorality', which the King agreed to. The proclamation was required to be read four times a year in churches; it urged the need to prosecute those who engaged in 'excessive drinking, blasphemy, profane swearing and cursing, lewdness, profanation of the Lord's Day, and other dissolute, immoral, or disorderly practices.' In the wake of the proclamation, Wilberforce established the Proclamation Society which became the Society for the Suppression of Vice, and was a successor of the societies for the reformation of manners. The Society for the Suppression of Vice also continued the emphasis of the societies for the reformation of manners on shaming those who broke the law.⁶³ Among the matters

denounced by the Society for the Suppression of Vice were obscene books and prostitution, which is discussed in detail in chapters five and nine.

The more diffuse interests of the Society for the Suppression of Vice, which even included the prosecution of the use of false weights and measures and of politically seditious books, meant that it could never pay the same attention to matters of sexual immorality that the earlier societies had. Moreover the willingness of both informers and jurors to cooperate with vigilantism was declining.⁶⁴ The Society for the Suppression of Vice was a distinctly aristocratic organisation, led by bishops, MPs, peers and the landed classes, unlike the wider membership of the societies for the reformation of manners. And the Vice Society was distinctly evangelical in tone, driven by the preoccupations of Wilberforce and More, rather than more broadly conceived. Its prosecutions included fairs, gaming establishments, public houses as well as lotteries, fortune-telling and Sabbath-breaking. In 1814 the Society endorsed the Thames Police Act which outlawed nude bathing in the river. Nevertheless the Society for the Suppression of Vice shared the belief of the societies for the reformation of manners of a growing sense of moral crisis at sexually dissolute behaviour. Another feature of the Society's campaigns was the developing view that sexual behaviour could be defined as much in medical and social terms as in theological.⁶⁵

By 1809 Sydney Smith wrote stern attacks on the Society for the Suppression of Vice in the *Edinburgh Review* claiming that it was the repository of evangelical claptrap. He suggested that it should be renamed the Society for Suppressing the Vice of Persons whose Income does not exceed £500 a year, since it seemed to prosecute the poor and overlook the vices of the rich. This sort of 'cant and hypocrisy' in Smith's view damaged the Society's reputation. The poor were condemned to 'decorous gloom' while gaming clubs in St James's flourished. Like the societies for the reformation of manners, Smith asserted that it was a foolish goal to try to prosecute men into piety, and force them to develop inward feelings of godliness.⁶⁶

The Church, Masquerades, and Casual Sex

The Church was also part of a campaign against the public fairs and aristocratic masquerades that were held, principally in London, in the period. Both were seen as occasions of unrestrained disorder. At public

fairs there were displays of women dancing, especially rope-dancing which required the women to reveal more of their bodies than was thought decent. Women also served food to fairgoers, which seemed to upset the usual monopoly of male entrepreneurship, and brought young women into a world with opportunities for prostitution and anonymous sex.⁶⁷ One writer compared the disorder of the huge crowds at the St Bartholomew's fair to the behaviour at indecent gatherings of Catholics, Quakers and Dissenters.⁶⁸ The societies for the reformation of manners were active in opposing the fairs that were held in London and other cities, principally because they were often accompanied by prostitution. In 1709 the society managed to close the annual St Bartholomew's Fair in London and in 1711 proposed to limit it to three days in order to control the scenes of drunkenness and lewdness in the streets.⁶⁹ They were also concerned that fairs encouraged Sabbath-breaking. Thomas Bray was in the forefront of those who preached against fairs, claiming the lewd behaviour at them threatened to bring down God's punishment on the city of London. Certainly Anglican clergy regarded such fairs as the source of civic shame rather than pride.⁷⁰ Such attacks on fairs were not new but took on a greater intensity in this period.

The attack on fairs brought together Christians from across denominational divides: Charles Leslie, the Jacobite Non-juror, and John Tutchin, the Dissenter, were as strong in their denunciation of the moral dangers presented by the fairs as Anglican clergy. By 1721 George I and the Lord Chancellor urged the Middlesex justices to act against misbehaviour at the fairs, because they seemed to present a religious threat to the nation.⁷¹ Those who defended fairs claimed that they often included booths which presented pious tableaux of biblical scenes.⁷²

In other cases measures were taken to ensure that public entertainment which aimed to attract the 'middling sort' was morally acceptable. Later in the century, the pleasure gardens of Vauxhall and Ranelagh in London obtained a reputation for places in which it was possible to indulge in illicit sex. The proprietors' solution at Vauxhall was to employ two clergymen to patrol the grounds whose 'holy looks' it was hoped would keep decorum and deter sexual misbehaviour. As a result Vauxhall was able to attract a more respectable class of attenders.⁷³ Although this was not a venture promoted by the society for the reformation of manners, it reflected the same concerns about public sexual behaviour.

While fairs were opportunities for sexual misconduct by the lower classes in society, aristocratic vice was equally worrying to churchmen. Masquerades became especially troubling in the 1720s. The Church censured these court entertainments principally because they became occasions for drunkenness and semi-public casual sex. William III, influenced by Dutch Calvinist principles, had forbidden them, but under George I they were resumed. Bishop Gibson opposed George I's revival of masquerades in 1723–4 as a result of aristocratic pressure, so had the magistrate Whitlocke Bulstrode in his charge to the Grand Jury of Middlesex in 1722.⁷⁴ Gibson preached a sermon to the societies for the reformation of manners denouncing them as leading to the corruption of people at court since they were a foreign import which led to 'licentiousness and effeminacy'.⁷⁵ Above all, the horror for Gibson was the shameful opportunities for adultery and clandestine sex. Masquerade attenders were disguised and often intoxicated, and it was common for men and women to retire to nearby rooms for anonymous sex, or as Bishop Gibson coyly remarked, 'fall into any profane discourse or lascivious behaviour to which their inclinations should lead them.'⁷⁶

In his exhortations to the King in 1724, Gibson claimed that such furtive sex destroyed any sense of shame. As has been seen, shame was an integral element in the campaigns of the societies for the reformation of manners. Like the societies, Gibson regarded shame positively. It was, he wrote:

the great guard of the virtue of mankind and the chief preservative from vice, especially in youth . . . which has been planted in our nature to be a constant check to inordinate desires and vicious inclinations of all kinds. It is this restraint which preserves the innocence of mankind by keeping them out of the ways of temptation, out of scandalous company, and lewd places, and from all indecencies and irregularities which lead to vice. If shame were out of the way, it is easy to foresee how fast wickedness of all kinds would increase, and to what degrees of licentiousness mankind would quickly grow.⁷⁷

Gibson's worry was that if masquerades were adopted by the leaders of fashionable society, they would set a corrosive example for the lower classes.⁷⁸ He commented that 'some instances of their spreading have

already happened and it is very probable that we shall hear of more.⁷⁹ The public awareness of the behaviour of the affluent at masquerades was evident from Hogarth's pornographic *Small 'Masquerade Ticket'* of 1727, which featured priapic figures and, in one version, even a lion and unicorn appearing to masturbate.⁸⁰

Gibson was sufficiently concerned about the revival of masquerades that he consulted other bishops before presenting his objections to the King. With the weight of the bench of bishops behind him, Gibson sent a petition to the Secretaries of State, Lords Townshend and Carteret, for the King. With such a public request, the King felt obliged to issue a proclamation suppressing further public masquerades, except those already subscribed to. The King may have been influenced to suppress masquerades because of rumours that he attended such events for the purpose of having sex with young women.⁸¹

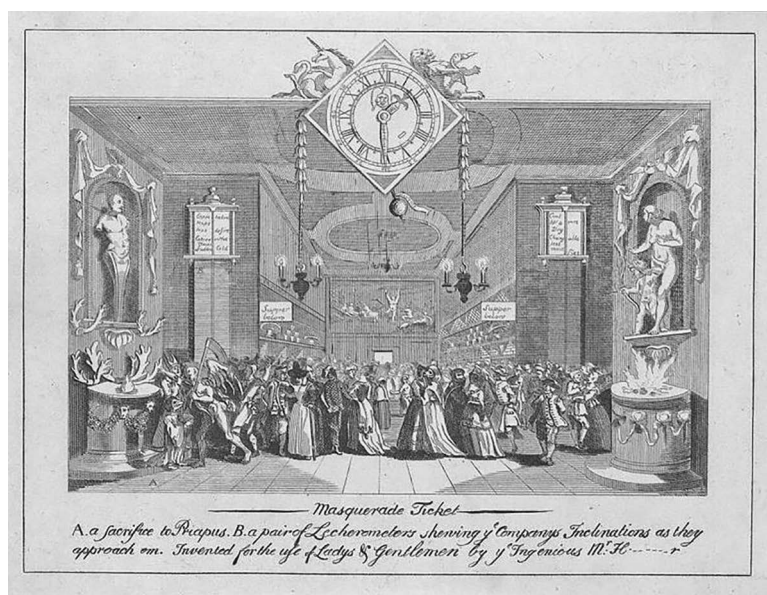


Figure 4 William Hogarth's pornographic *Small Masquerade Ticket* inscribed: 'A. a sacrifice to Priapus. B. a pair of Lecherometers, shewing ye company's inclinations as they approach 'em. Invented for the use of Ladys & Gentlemen by y^e Ingenious Mr. H—r' [Heidegger]'. Author's Collection.

To Gibson's horror, with public and court masquerades banned, private entertainments grew in number and were even more dissolute and debauched. In one case married and unmarried men and women openly attended a private masquerade for 'lewd and profligate purposes'. Prostitutes were also known to attend in disguise, seeking clients. Again the bishops met and wrote to the King, this time adding the warning that to countenance such entertainments led the 'sober and serious part of the nation' to 'coldness' and disaffection towards the King and his government.⁸² Gibson pointed out that such happenings in his own diocese especially offended him. However the King could not be prevailed upon to renew his proclamation – partly because there had been opposition to it from some of the nobility. There had also been some ribald humour at Gibson's expense, including from the impressario John Heidegger, whose masquerades had been the cause of the initial outrages in 1722.⁸³ Heidegger wrote a *Letter to the Bishop of London*, suggesting that Gibson was particularly offended by women wearing men's clothes at masquerades – against which there was a biblical injunction. In heavily satirical mood, Heidegger also argued that disguise was the order of the day: scribes passed as prime ministers and a juggler might pass for a parson, so why could not others go to masquerades in disguise?⁸⁴

Gibson did not give up the campaign against masquerades and wrote a public letter to the clergy of his diocese encouraging them to denounce and oppose the events. His letter made clear that he regarded unrestrained sex as a threat to the souls of the participants.⁸⁵ In January 1725/6 the parliamentary session coincided with an especially scandalous masquerade which was so debauched that even some of the organisers were shocked. Gibson was forced to concede that he had not succeeded in getting the court to suppress masquerades.⁸⁶ Three years later he wrote in a pastoral letter to the people of his diocese of his distress that brothels and 'stews' were openly used and appeared to be promoted by some.⁸⁷ Gibson's *Pastoral Letter* was widely circulated and read, and even depicted in parody in Hogarth's 'Harlot's Progress' in Moll's boudoir in which it is used to wrap some food.⁸⁸

Royal Sex

Leading churchmen at court were aware of the sexual behaviour of monarchs. Sexual infidelity was a public issue in the post-Revolution court.

When Catherine Sedley, Countess of Dorchester, a mistress of James II, was admitted to the court after the Revolution, she was received icily by Queen Mary. She brusquely told the Queen: 'Why so haughty madam? I have not sinned more notoriously in breaking the seventh commandment with your father, than you have done in breaking the fifth against him.'⁸⁹ The Countess's comparison of the commandment 'thou shalt not commit adultery' with 'honour thy father and thy mother' is an important insight into the moral equivalence of sexual infidelity and rebellion against natural authority.

Even after 1689, despite the Parliamentary settlement of the throne, monarchs were still consecrated and anointed and were termed sovereigns *Dei gratia*. And since, especially after the Act of Settlement of 1701, their Protestantism was integral to their sovereignty, it might have been expected that their moral character would have been important. Certainly monarchs' sexual lives were closely scrutinised. From 1689, despite his much vaunted Calvinism, there were persistent rumours of William III's homosexuality.⁹⁰ The author of a fictional meeting between William III and Titus Oates, the homosexual originator of the Popish Plot, put these words to William into Oates's mouth:

Since you and I both act the selfe same thing
W't difference twixt Sham Dr and Sham King.⁹¹

In both cases homosexuality was equated with inauthenticity and invalidity. Another satirical verse compared William's homosexuality with James II's Catholicism:

... to find old Popery
Turn'd out and replaced by Allmighty Sodomy
But here content with our own homely joys,
We had no relish of the fair fac'd Boys.
Till you came in and with your Reformation,
Turn'd all things Arsy Versy in the nation.⁹²

This suggested that the attack on William III was as much a religious and political as a sexual one. It was an allegation that the Jacobites were keen to keep up, and as William became less popular with the Tories, they also fanned the flames of the rumour. In a

manuscript satire compiled for the Earl of Bridgewater, William was shown with Bentinck 'at the old game of Gomorrah' whereas Queen Mary was 'more pious of life.'⁹³ In a later verse, Bentinck was referred to as 'topping' and compared with other Dutchmen: 'they've huge pricks, much money and no witt.'⁹⁴ In 'A Description of Hampton Court Life' William was portrayed as trying to slim down his wife, whereas Mary sought to fatten her husband, but neither prevailed since:

Mr Dean says Grace
 With a reverend face
 Make room crys Sir Thomas Duppa
 Then Bent—g⁹⁵ uplocks
 His King in a box
 And you see him no more till supper.⁹⁶

And in a satire called 'The Sash' a courtier saved William from accidental decapitation when he was looking out of a window at an attractive young man:

Twass enough to set Bent—g on Thorns
 And make the He-Bedfellow Jealous.⁹⁷

Some satirists compared William's homosexual relationships with those of his great great uncle, James I, one wrote:

The world is changed I know not how
 For men kiss men not women now
 Of smuggling Jack and Tom complain
 A most unmanly nasty trick
 One man to lick the other's cheek
 And only what renews the shame
 Of J[ames] the first and Buckingham ...⁹⁸

Such gossip leaked into the public sphere, with *The Relapse: Or Virtue in Danger*, a play put on by Vanbrugh at the Theatre Royal hinting at homosexuality in court circles. Historians have claimed that William and Mary's court was a hotbed of homosexuality, one claiming that Lord

Portland, the Duke of Shrewsbury, Lord Albemarle and six other office holders were part of a 'gay court circle.'⁹⁹

Despite widespread suspicion of William's homosexuality, there was no public censure of him. Gilbert Burnet, William's chaplain and supporter, reported the King's closeness to both William Bentinck and Arnold van Keppel, including that, on his deathbed William held Bentinck's hand against his breast. But Burnet did not condemn it or describe it as more significant than the favouritism of a king.¹⁰⁰ Burnet rather guardedly noted that William 'had no vice, but of one sort, in which he was very *cautious* and *secret*.' Swift corrected this view in his remarks on Burnet's memoirs that the King's vice 'was of two sorts – *male* and *female* – in the *former* he was neither cautious nor secret.'¹⁰¹ The observations of Burnet and Swift should not suggest that they did not disapprove of the King's same-sex desires; rather that they saw them as a sin in someone above them in the hierarchy who was answerable to a divine authority.¹⁰²

It was not just William's conduct that was scrutinised for sexually illicit behaviour. Mary herself was not entirely free of rumours of homosexual affections.¹⁰³ Her letters to Frances Apsley, her childhood friend, were passionate and intense; in them Mary referred to Frances as her wife and after her wedding night suggested William had cuckolded Frances and that 'though I have played the whore a little, I love you of all things in the world.'¹⁰⁴ McClain takes the view that their relationship was sexual, at least in terms of desire, though it cooled in time, and was over when Mary became Queen. McClain's conclusion is that 'it appears that same-sex relationships between young women were tolerated so long as they remained private matters within elite social circles.'¹⁰⁵ Certainly one satire refers to suggestions of homosexual lusts attaching themselves to the Queen:

Since fasts and Lenten sermons do no good
To cure the raging itch of courtiers' blood
Since deans and doctors with their grave directions
Cant curb young lustfull ladies' lewd affections ...
Fair madam B--'s unruly appetite
The fair, the foul, the lusty and the lean
Confess a passion for the goatish Q-- ...¹⁰⁶

William was also denounced for preferring his female mistresses over his wife.¹⁰⁷ Thus when Queen Mary died in 1694, he put aside his long-standing mistress, Elizabeth Villiers, because Archbishop Tenison convinced him that the Queen's death was partly a result of his sinfulness. Mary II's forbearance in remaining loyal to her husband was regarded as a model of obedient womanly and regal virtues. One satire referred to her,

As youthful Tullia¹⁰⁸ unregarded lay
By a dull lump of Netherlandish clay
Whose frozen veins not all her charms could move
The Hero is incapable of love ...¹⁰⁹

Mary saw herself as 'long-suffering, duty-bound, tragic' and one element in this was that she endured a loveless marriage, and surrendered her chance of happiness because she adhered to the Church's teaching as well as to national duty. Certainly, scholars have emphasised Mary's dutiful Anglicanism and her receptiveness to a series of influential Anglican chaplains including Henry Compton, William Lloyd, and Thomas Ken all of whom were later to become bishops. From them she absorbed the Church's teachings on marriage as well as on the political importance of the Protestant succession. It happened that her duty to her religion coincided with her duty to her country, so the latter obscures the former.¹¹⁰ Nevertheless while it may be that William was a monarch who ignored and was not challenged by teaching on sexuality, Mary may have internalised such teaching. Certainly her early death, and the extraordinary outpouring of emotion it stimulated, obscured any misgivings churchmen had of her moral character.¹¹¹ Perhaps the bishops were silent on the issue of Mary's sexuality because of her status and that it was not proper for them to comment on the monarch; more plausible is that the hold she had over many leading bishops and churchmen, who Zook claims 'adored' her, earned their silence. Certainly her stewardship of the Church and sponsorship of proclamations against profanity earned her the admiration of the bishops.¹¹²

Queen Anne was also rumoured to have a lesbian relationship with Abigail Hill (later Lady Masham). The origin of the claim in the jealous mind of Sarah, Duchess of Marlborough and dissemination by her clients, does not suggest that they were entirely credible and they were

not treated as such by churchmen at the time. Both Archbishop Sharp of York and Bishop Burnet knew of Queen Anne's friendship with Masham and regarded it as innocent.¹¹³ Moreover Anne attracted the same admiration as her sister, many bishops and churchmen regarding her as especially dedicated to the Church, and therefore perhaps deserving of its support. Even the most blatant public allegation of lesbianism, printed as a *roman a clef* in *The Rival Dutchess or Court Indecency* was the work of Arthur Maynwaring, one of Sarah's election agents. In it, Masham's character said 'I was taken for a more modish Lady, was rather addicted to another Sort of passion, of having too great a Regard for my own Sex.'¹¹⁴ Such accusations served a political purpose. The rest of the pamphlet, though it smeared Anne, was without doubt a political tract, discussing domestic and foreign policy. The rumours of Anne's sexuality did not gain a greater purchase probably because of her famously affectionate marriage to George of Denmark and her numerous pregnancies. But the political circumstances in which Anne felt herself caught between two opposing factious parties in Church and state, added an element of ambivalence to the Queen's position.

Moral judgements about monarchs' sex lives were undoubtedly subordinated to eighteenth-century churchmen's political views. Perhaps the best example of this was John Wesley, who was extraordinarily censorious about the chastity and adultery of various monarchs. His *Concise History of England* (1775–6) was littered with condemnation of adulterous monarchs, and praise for the chaste and those faithful to their spouses. He singled out Edward IV and Charles II for severe rebukes for their adulteries – Charles II in the following terms:

He was in every respect a consummate hypocrite, equally devoid of piety, mercy, honesty and gratitude. Under a cover of gentleness he was cruel and revengeful to a high degree. He was abandoned to all vices. A worse man never sat on the English throne, and few worse princes.¹¹⁵

Wesley had a very different view of George I and George II, he ignored their questionable private lives. George I was the second English king (after Henry VIII) to have been divorced, his former wife, Sophia Dorothea of Celle, having been imprisoned for adultery in 1694. Thereafter he lived with his mistress, Melusine von der Schulenburg, by

whom he had three illegitimate children who were often called the King's nieces to prevent direct accusations of adultery. Von der Schulenburg seems to have been almost a morganatic wife. The King's relationship with his mistress was largely ignored by churchmen, who, as was the case with his predecessors, regarded the monarch as beyond sexual reproach. While churchmen were largely silent, the caricaturists enjoyed a field day portraying the King and his mistress.¹¹⁶ Nevertheless, since there was a direct alternative to George in the form of the Old Pretender, James Edward, son of James II, it seemed preferable to many to accept a Protestant king, despite his adultery, rather than the Catholic son of a tyrant. Certainly as a staunch Hanoverian Wesley ignored George I's behaviour and went to extraordinary lengths to assert that the Hanoverian succession of 1714 was legitimate and lawful.¹¹⁷

As the century progressed, however, the Church regarded the Protestant succession as secure enough to enable it to challenge royal adultery.¹¹⁸ In 1737 the Oxford academic Joseph Trapp published *The Royal Sin: or Adultery Rebuk'd in a Great King*. It was based on a sermon delivered at St Martin in the Fields and sold well, within a year running to four editions. It used the biblical case of King David's adultery with Bathsheba, the wife of Uriah, as the example from which Trapp drew his conclusions. At the outset, Trapp laid out that he intended that his words should thunder into the ears of rulers and bemoaned that so many kings had looked upon adultery as 'a considerable branch of their prerogative.' He outlined the case of King David and how 'what the King had done displeased the Lord.' At least David had the grace to know that he had sinned, even if he had not sufficient resolve to stop sinning.

Trapp's message was for contemporary rulers who were under obligation to keep themselves free from adultery. This was in part because Trapp claimed kings and princes were 'ministers of God' and under a trust to promote religion and virtue among their subjects. He argued that kings had a duty to maintain the bounds of the law and their own failure to do so brought their authority and religion itself into contempt: 'in vain shall virtue and religion be authoritatively taught and enjoined when the authority destroys itself by the immoral and impious practices of those who exercise it.' Such sin in a king was especially damaging also because it gave great power and influence to the

adulteress which led to public discord. It was a strong attack on George II in the year after his wife's death and when it was known that he had a series of mistresses.¹¹⁹

Trapp was censuring the supreme governor of the Church for not adhering to its teaching, which was a bold act. In 1741 an anonymous sermon claimed that 'a sin . . . when it receives the sanction of the Great, diffuses itself into the body-politic, and is destructive to a Commonwealth.' The great man seems likely to have been George II. He was described as

the Person, who upon seeing a Woman (and knowing her to be the Property of another) invites her to his Bed; lets her live with him, even under the same Roof with his Children and Family; squanders away the Money upon her, which would make many of his Dependants happy; is surly and haughty to all about him, to shew her that she only has his Esteem; is not ashamed to appear with her on any publick Occasion; keeps a Child at a Distance, and hugs her in his Bosom; when Affairs call him from Home, she must go with him, and no Expençe is spar'd to make the Grandeur of her Retinue equal with his own; and last of all, confers favours upon her, which belong only to the Virtuous! Such a Man as this certainly must lack Understanding.¹²⁰

The absence of mention of the great man's wife suggests the King was the target, since Queen Caroline had died in 1736, and George certainly kept his son Frederick, Prince of Wales, at a distance as they had not spoken for some years. The mistress to which the sermon referred was probably Amalie Sophie de Wallmoden, later Countess of Yarmouth, who had abandoned her husband and son to live with the King, and who the King travelled to Hanover to visit until she moved to London.¹²¹

It was a serious matter for a clergyman of the Church of England to denounce his sovereign, and the supreme governor of the Church, which probably explains why the sermon was published anonymously. Nevertheless the sermon was sold by Webb for sixpence and went through a number of reprints. It emphasised that since providence had placed the great man in his station, he was an example to others and reminded readers that chastity in marriage was a duty and adultery was a sin. Since adultery was a sin against a neighbour, and society relied on

bonds of trust, then the King's adultery damaged his own nation. The preacher asked whether the great man wanted to make it dangerous to be virtuous and profitable to indulge in vice?¹²²

At least Archdeacon Edward Cobden did not directly accuse the King of adultery when he obliquely preached on 'a persuasive to chastity' before George II in December 1748. Cobden said that there were 'few sins which people condemn more in their own breast' than adultery. Aware of George II's troubled relationships with his father and son, Cobden asserted that parents were distressed by 'the indelible stain of infamy' that adultery represented. Pointedly, he argued that if men could not govern their own desires they would not govern other impulses well. He included in the printed version of the sermon two paragraphs which he did not preach before the King, which asked 'whether the judgments we of this Nation have lately suffered, have not in some Measure been owing to the Increase of the Sins of Uncleaness, together with those of every other Kind, among us?' He also recommended that his hearers:

avoid all filthy Communication, and the reading of filthy Books as are filled with Stories of infamous Gallantry and to abstain from such Dramatic Entertainments, as are an Offence to good Manners, and inflame the impurer Passions: But more especially, to fly from those fashionable Assemblies, Which seem calculated for no other End, but to promote the Purposes of Lewdness.¹²³

George III's faithful and fruitful marriage to Charlotte of Mecklenburg-Strelitz marked a sharp change in the morality of the court. Archbishop Secker was deeply affected by the pious behaviour of George and Charlotte at their wedding and their decision to take Holy Communion after the ceremony. Charlotte delighted him further by saying that she had been taught that the Church of England was 'the best in the world.'¹²⁴ For the next two decades, Charlotte was almost permanently pregnant with the fifteen children who were born between 1762 and 1783, which George regarded as a divine blessing. Such was his affection for his wife that in 1773 returning from Portsmouth observers saw that as he got back to Kew he leapt from the carriage and carried Charlotte in his arms into their private apartments.¹²⁵

It was therefore all the more troubling that during his periods of illness, George thought that he was married to the Countess of

Pembroke and he pestered her with love letters. In this reign, royal adultery, if such it was, reflected the King's disordered state rather than his usual outlook. When well, George was a devout Anglican, to the satisfaction of the bishops and clergy, and was often shocked by irreligion and vice and even tended to sabbatarianism by disliking government business on Sundays. He gladly issued the Proclamations to Suppress Vice and supported the campaigns.

George III's reign nevertheless witnessed further periods of royal sexual misbehaviour. The first instances were the marriages of George's two brothers, William Duke of Gloucester who in 1766 secretly married Maria Walpole, a widow who was illegitimate, and Henry Frederick, Duke of Cumberland who in 1771 married another commoner, Anne Houghton, widely regarded as unsuitable having been the mistress of a number of men. George III's fury at his brothers' unsuitable marriages resulted in the Royal Marriages Act of 1772 which required all marriages to have the monarch's permission before they were legal. It was under the terms of this act that the marriage of George III's son, George, Prince of Wales, to the Catholic Maria Fitzherbert in 1785 was unlawful, despite having been solemnised by an Anglican parson and in all other respects legitimately witnessed and contracted.¹²⁶ To the horror of the King, Pope Pius VII proclaimed the marriage valid.¹²⁷ The public print, *His Highness in Fitz* of 1786 showed George and Maria in bed, with the Prince of Wales's feathers and a cross behind them to indicate the religious problem with the marriage.¹²⁸

This royal misbehaviour led to a growing public concern about adultery in the latter decades of the century. From the 1770s onwards there was both greater debate about adultery and matrimonial breakdown and also more litigation of cases of adultery. Historians have traced both to the behaviour of George III's brothers and sons.¹²⁹ Even if social inferiors did not emulate royalty and the aristocracy in viewing marriage as a state that could be abandoned, between 1770 and 1840 adultery came to predominate in marital cases which came to court and petitions for divorce to Parliament rose similarly.¹³⁰ In this, the Church was less powerful in the public mind than the social example of princes and aristocrats. It explains why churchmen were so keen for royalty and nobles to set an example in matters of morality.

In 1795, at his father's insistence, George, Prince of Wales, married Princess Caroline of Brunswick. Archbishop John Moore, who

conducted the ceremony, observed that the Prince's mind was not affected 'in that part of the service from which one might be led to fear he had upon his mind a feeling that he had bound himself by solemn engagement'.¹³¹ It was a famously unsuccessful marriage. After the birth of their daughter, Princess Charlotte, in 1796, the couple separated, each living dissolute lives, Caroline principally on the continent. Caroline returned to England in 1820 when she was technically queen consort on the death of George III. George IV had long sought a divorce from his wife, but his own infidelities meant that any action would be a perilous venture, opening the prospect of public exposure. He prevailed on his friend, Archbishop Charles Manners-Sutton of Canterbury, to exclude Caroline from prayers for the royal family and sought a permanent solution in a bill of pains and penalties, in effect an act which would dissolve the marriage without need for a formal divorce process. Briefly, Caroline was the standard-bearer of radical, and, in the light of episcopal support for the King, anti-clerical agitation.¹³² In fact, Manners-Sutton led all but eight of his fellow bishops into the lobby to vote for the bill of pains and penalties. Caroline's death in August 1821 relieved the Church and king of the uncomfortable burden of dealing with such a public expression of royal marital dysfunction.¹³³

Conclusion

This chapter has indicated the degree to which the emerging public sphere in England after 1688 was preoccupied with religious concerns about sex and sexuality. Far from being an arena in which secularism was growing, and the Church's role was diminishing, public opinion was deeply influenced by religious attitudes to sex. In the wake of the Glorious Revolution, the sexual behaviour of the monarch might have been beyond comment, but this was only a temporary political expedient. The sexual vigilantism of the societies for the reformation of manners did not endure beyond the 1740s, but the moral concerns that motivated them did not disappear. Public anxiety about casual sex and public expressions of sexual behaviour remained intractable and present beyond the end of the eighteenth century. The next chapter explores the ways in which the Church's formal means for controlling illicit sex and immoral behaviour developed over the long eighteenth century.

CHAPTER 3

ILLICIT SEX AND THE CHURCH COURTS

The Church used its system of ecclesiastical courts to regulate illicit sex in the long eighteenth century, although, as has been seen in chapter one, secular courts also played a part in disciplining some forms of sexual offence.¹ Church courts heard two forms of case. The first were office, or corrective, cases, which the church courts initiated through the process of visitations. Individuals could also promote such cases through the office of the judge when there was 'common fame' about individuals' behaviour.² These cases imposed spiritual discipline on clergy and parishioners found to have been sexually immoral. In addition they corrected those who married clandestinely (ceremonies which did not conform to the Canons) until the 1753 Marriage Act, as well as unions within prohibited degrees (sometimes known as incest, though the term referred to unions made within specifically prohibited degrees of kinship). The second type, instance cases, were initiated by disputes between litigants, and were decided by a judge. Typically, they were brought by an injured party and were motivated by ideas about appropriate sexual behaviour within marriage, including marital separation on the grounds of cruelty and adultery, restitution of marital rites, annulment of unions, jactitation (the attempt to prevent an individual from claiming to be married), prohibited degrees of marriage, as well as annulment and failed contracted marriages. Instance cases also included defamation, which came under the jurisdiction of the church courts because the slanderous words attacked the plaintiff's moral and sexual reputation.

The experience of being presented to the church courts was likely to have been somewhat daunting. Consistory courts met in cathedrals, after all, and facing accusations of immoral behaviour within such awe-inspiring spaces was surely calculated to intimidate offenders. The courts punished those found guilty through penance and humiliation where the offender confessed his or her sins before the parish church congregation. The legal and confessional language used to identify and punish sexual incontinence indicates how seriously the Church took these matters. A schedule of penance, performed in Gloucestershire in 1785, for example, required the offender to 'confess and acknowledge with shame and Confusion of Face that not having the Fear of God before mine Eyes and being seduced by the Temptation of the Devil and mine own filthy Lusts I have been guilty of the foul Sin of Fornication'.³ Collectively, these office and instance cases provide a valuable insight into ecclesiastical and lay attitudes to sexual misconduct.

Historians have argued that eighteenth-century society moved from perceiving extra-marital sexual activities as a sin to seeing them as moral offences against society. The church courts are therefore sometimes seen as losing their role in controlling and punishing clerical and lay sexual transgression. The courts collapsed during the Civil Wars and Commonwealth period, but experienced a significant influx when they were reinstituted at the Restoration clearing the backlog of offences.⁴ Thereafter, the courts entered a period of slow decline in dealing with moral and sexual offences. In the archdeaconry of Leicester, for example, the ecclesiastical courts heard 69 causes in the year 1713–14, whereas in 1774–5 the archdeaconry heard 36 causes, and from 1786 to 1803 only dealt with around 10 or 11 per year.⁵ From the 1830s the church courts were changed by legislation and lost several areas of their jurisdiction including those over defamation and marriage breakdown by 1855 and 1857 respectively.⁶ Moreover, it is possible that the minority of the population who dissented from the Anglican Church may have been less concerned about the church courts' authority. The evidence from patterns of presentment, however, does not point to a clear linear account of decline. This chapter therefore explores the extent to which church court activity reveals a rapid or steady decline in sexual regulation and how far this was indicative of a decline in the Church's intention or ability to discipline sexual offences.

While the courts never regained the vigour of their pre-Civil War years, it is a mistake to see them as a moribund legal structure in the eighteenth century. In the first place, there was considerable regional diversity since the diocesan structure that delivered ecclesiastical justice was subject to as much regional differentiation as other 'revolutions' of the period. The courts were arranged in a hierarchy with lower courts that heard cases from the archdeaconries, above which were superior diocesan or bishops' courts, the main consistory court heard in the cathedral; at the top were the two archbishops' provincial courts of Canterbury and York, with the Court of Delegates at the pinnacle.⁷ Local studies show that the courts that saw a fairly rapid and early fall in office and instance cases correcting sexual offences were typically those in areas which underwent more rapid economic or urban transformation. More rural, less industrialised, areas had higher volumes of such cases up to the final quarter of the eighteenth century. A second important factor is that all civil courts underwent a dramatic decline in litigation during this period, which means that attempts to single out the performance of the Church or its courts as failing or successful are somewhat illusory.⁸ Moreover, something of a judicial marketplace developed where justices of the peace could actively exercise summary jurisdiction over minor offenders and in which litigants had more choice in the courts that they used to defend their reputations. As such, the church courts did not disappear as arbiters of lay sexual behaviour and retained authority over clerical behaviour. Like other arenas of civil litigation, they became more socially exclusive and professionalised, with most litigation concerning sexual behaviour separation cases brought by more elite spouses.

Sexual Offences and the Church Courts

Both office and instance cases show how the church courts administered a system which sought to instil standards of sexual probity and identify, correct, and reintegrate sexual offenders into their communities. This chapter focuses on fornication and defamation cases and only considers bastardy where it arose in office adultery and fornication cases, rather than as a separate offence, because its pursuit was increasingly left to the secular courts due to its economic repercussions as the rise of poor relief, meant that overseers needed to recover the cost of supporting the mother and baby in new ways.⁹ The shift of the regulation of bastardy towards

the quarter sessions and the justices of the peace may well partly explain some of the decline of the role of the church courts. Marriage within prohibited degrees will be discussed in chapter four on marital sex.

One of the church courts' primary functions was 'spiritual discipline' and therefore they targeted and heard offences which threatened the health of the soul of an offender. Canon law required churchwardens to present anyone in their parish who 'offend their brethren, either by Adultery, Whoredom, Incest, or Drunkenness, or by Swearing, Ribaldry, Usury or other Uncleaness, and Wickedness of Life'.¹⁰ Such offences were brought to the courts' attention either by local complaints made to churchwardens or the process of visitations. According to the Canons, archidiaconal visitations were to be held annually and episcopal visitations triennially. Concerns about sexual misbehaviour centred on reporting incidents of clerical and lay extra-marital sex in the form of fornication (before marriage) and adultery (within marriage).¹¹ One 1686 Lichfield archidiaconal visitation inhibition sought the churchwardens 'to cyte all persons for fornication [and] for Clandestine Marriage' along with other 'crimes'.¹² The church courts' function was to punish offenders and, through their public penance, act as a deterrent to others. As Outhwaite observes, the courts also sought to 'bring the sinful to repentance and the community to forgiveness' and 'to settle personal disputes by reconciling warring parties rather than insisting on cases coming to sentence'.¹³ The courts are best viewed in this broader capacity of working with communities and individuals, rather than purely as a disciplinary forum.

Fornication office cases reveal that authorities, individuals, and communities saw sex as part of the process of marriage, so it is necessary to exercise caution in seeing instances of pre-marital sex as indicative of a culture of sexual liberty. Detailed office cases show that people had sex when marriage was contemplated, often once the union was agreed. John Corles, for example, was presented in the County Palatine of Lancaster for fornication with Alice Turner. He was an attorney-at-law in Preston and boarded with the family where Alice worked as a servant. Alice said that she had sex with him in April 1727 because he promised to marry her; a baby was born in January. Many such couples married once pregnancy was identified. Indeed in 1700, 20 per cent of brides were pregnant at the wedding, and 40 per cent were in 1800.¹⁴

It was when John Corles failed to fulfil his promise and refused to pay for his baby that Alice went to the justice of the peace. When the Blackburn quarter sessions justices ordered him to pay maintenance, John refused, and claimed he had not had sex with Alice, declaring in his allegations that 'ye Laws of our Land so far favouring Strumpetts [he] humbly hopes that will not be looked on and adjudged such Evidence against him . . . as to subject him to any Ecclesiasticall Censures'. Found guilty of incontinence, he appealed his case to York. Despite his defence, the tone of the letters he wrote to Alice after the birth of their baby, brought as evidence, certainly suggest that theirs was a long-term relationship in which sex was a component intended, at least in one partner's understanding, as the precursor to the wedding.¹⁵

Office cases also offer valuable insights into collective community endeavours to police sexual immorality and how they changed over time. William Burton, a married brewer of Colliergate, York, was presented to York Consistory Court in 1692 for consorting too familiarly with his thirty-eight-year-old servant, Agnes Hunter, during his wife's lying-in period in 1691. William did his best to hide his illicit behaviour by sending the pregnant Agnes to Kirkby Kendal to give birth. The complementary role of religious and secular discipline was evident. A petition, dated 14 July 1692, was offered as evidence, marked by five women who deposed that Agnes declared in their presence during the pain of childbirth on 19 March 1691/2 that William was her baby's father. Thereafter Agnes appeared before two justices of the peace at Kendal where she gave her oath that she had been delivered of a bastard got upon her by William Burton.¹⁶ For all William and Agnes may have sinned, religion remained absolutely central to their behaviour. Agnes deposed that she claimed to be married to William when she first arrived in Kendal, in order to prevent shame. But in childbirth she was very ill and when she was told she might not live she confessed to the midwives and gossips that she was not married in order to satisfy her own conscience.¹⁷

Midwives played a critical part in administering the canon law requirements for the proper regulation of child birth. Each bishop licensed the midwives who worked in his diocese in order to ensure that only women of 'good moral character' undertook this role, in part to exclude abortionists. It also ensured that midwives conformed to the Thirty Nine Articles of the Church of England and were therefore theologically orthodox. Such provisions were designed to ensure that

midwives did not propagate unbiblical ideas about sex and procreation and also that they acted as the Church's eyes and ears in reporting cases of bastardy or infanticide. Midwives also took an oath that they would detect the fathers of illegitimate children. An oath from Cropredy, Oxfordshire, 1726 specifies: 'you shall not deliver any privately or clandestinely to conceal the Birth of thee Child. If you help to deliver any whom you suspect to be unmarried you shall acquaint the Ecclesiasticall Court of this Jurisdiction therewith and before you yield your assistance or helpe you shall perswade and by all lawful means labour with them to declare who is the father of the said Child'.¹⁸ In 1705 some women in Preston recommended Hannah Savage to the archbishop of York for licensing as a midwife on the grounds that she was 'of good fame,' but also because she was a 'due frequenter of the Church' and had proven her ability in helping women in labour.¹⁹ Clearly skill in obstetrics was only one of the criteria sought in a proper midwife.

Though these cases show that the authorities sometimes severely treated mothers of illegitimate babies, and there is evidence of a sexual double-standard in prescriptive and legal attitudes, the Church of England was even-handed in presenting men and women accused of extra-marital sex, generally bringing both partners before the court.²⁰ Despite the existence of a sexual double-standard many men were anxious about their sexual reputation and activities. Although very wealthy men and youths may have taken, or been given, some leeway in sexual incontinence, most mature, married men's public reputations were tarnished by rumours of sex outside marriage.

Most likely to suffer from such accusations, of course, were clergymen. The Reverend James Robertson, vicar of Holy Island, was alleged to have despaired when his maid, Elizabeth Hudson, told him she was pregnant and that he was the father. After she rejected his offer to get her 'something in a bottle', clearly an abortifacient, he threw himself down on the bed, cried, wrung his hands, and said he would be ruined. He cried bitterly when she refused to claim that the father of the child was someone else for a bribe of eight or nine pounds.²¹ The bailiff of Holy Island, William Redhead, deposed that, after Elizabeth had visited him to confess her pregnancy, he warned Robertson of the allegations. Robertson promptly lay on the bed in the same room and though he denied the child was his, he said he and his family were ruined.²²

In time, Robertson was able to rebuild his reputation and return as incumbent of Holy Island.

Other 'middling-sort' men were acutely aware of their sexual reputation and were prepared to defend it. Peter Slainhead, a married yeoman with several children, was presented by the churchwardens of the parish of Warrington and Hollinfair, in Chester diocese, for getting a bastard upon Catherine Pearson in 1699. When the case went against Peter, who was at the time a constable and formerly overseer in the parish of Prescot, he appealed to York. In his defence he claimed that Catherine had been bribed forty shillings to 'father' her child upon him to avoid bringing disrepute on its real father. Thus he claimed Catherine lied when she confessed to the midwife and swore before the magistrates that he was the father. Peter fought the office case by making his reputation the central issue, and accusing Catherine of being of loose and lewd life.

What is clear from this type of evidence is that men did not deny adulterous affairs and fathering bastard children solely because of the economic repercussions of paying for the child's maintenance. Indeed it was frequently alleged that men bribed pregnant women and witnesses to swear that another man had fathered the illegitimate child. In Peter Slainhead's case, these alleged bribes ranged from eleven shillings up to five pounds. Even if these sizeable sums were preferable as a one-off payment, compared with ongoing maintenance, it would seem that the accusations of fathering a bastard had a high reputational risk too. Certainly Peter claimed he always behaved 'modestly and virtuously and has not been in the least suspected to be guilty of the Crime of Adultery or Fornication but is a p[er]son of good credit, fame, and reputation' thereby linking his sexual life and his public reputation.²³

A generation later, William Pexton of Huggate, Yorkshire, was equally determined to defend himself against an accusation of fornication with Frances Holmes in 1727–8. The court accused William of being 'a person of lewd and debauch life and conversacon [sic] and very much impudent much addicted to keep company with lewd and lascivious women and use wanton dalliances with them and frequently been with them in private places'.²⁴ William denied the charges, describing himself as 'modest, carefull and faithfull' and 'a man of good life and conversation'.²⁵

Prosecutions for pre-nuptial pregnancy are particularly revealing of different levels of concern about sexual incontinence over region and

time. Many were initiated during the difficult social, economic and demographic conditions of the seventeenth century. In these harsher circumstances even couples who had sex before marriage but went on to marry each other could be presented to the church courts for fornication. Such cases are usually considered to have disappeared in the less severe conditions of the long eighteenth century, though this is not true of all dioceses. In Lichfield and Coventry diocese, for example, courts prosecuted and enacted penance on both husband and wife throughout the century. In the archdeaconry of Nottingham, this was sufficiently common for pre-printed forms to be produced; acknowledging that the couple went on to marry, the penitents had to confess to fornication before marriage and plead forgiveness, but did not have to dress as penitents, unlike adulterers.²⁶ Extra-marital sex that ended in marriage was also punished. On Sunday 24 July 1726 Andrew Yarron and his wife Susannah did penance in the parish church of Islip, wearing sheets, holding long white rods, with bare face, legs and feet. They confessed to adultery, which pre-dated their union since Susannah was previously described as the wife of Christopher Johnson who had subsequently died. Their marriage did not ameliorate Andrew and Susannah's penance; perhaps this was part of the process by which they were reintegrated into their community.²⁷ By the mid-eighteenth century some penances were commuted to fines, though as Rebecca Probert finds, this is not evidence that the system designed to shame and warn people not to engage in illicit sex was becoming less of a deterrent. After all, many did not possess the money to pay a fine.²⁸

Another aspect of church court business which centred on sexual behaviour was defamation: cases in which a plaintiff sued a defendant for publicly defaming his or her moral reputation.²⁹ Large numbers pursued defamation cases even though the courts punished the offender through public penance rather than financial damages. For success, a plaintiff needed to prove that his or her character was previously good, and that the spoken words had damaged this reputation. The cases reveal the power words of sexual misconduct held for society. The typical defamatory words cited were whore, rogue, or whoremaster; all widely understood to damage the victim's reputation. Men sought to restore their reputation through the courts after attacks labelling them as whoremaster, seducers, adulterers, fornicators, and fathers of bastards. Women were the greater number of plaintiffs in defamation cases and

they tackled gossip about their sexual chastity which revolved around vivid, prurient, and imaginative variations of the insult whore.³⁰

Women were also defamed with specific accusations of immoral behaviour including fornication, adultery, keeping bad company, prostitution, and bearing bastards. For example, a London gentleman and his wife brought a case in Oxford diocesan court against Elizabeth Jack for calling the wife, Eleanor, 'a Common Strumpet and a London Gilt you went up to London to lay an Egg and are come down agen to keepest a three-half-penny shop for a cloak to thy wickedness'. Article 3 of the libel explained that Gilt was a 'person who by her lewd Gestures & unseemly Embraces do . . . provoke & encourage libidinous desires . . . & is lost to all manner of shame & good behaviour'.³¹ The role of Eleanor's husband was significant, for it is suggested that cases brought by married women were often driven by their husbands who objected to being humiliated as cuckolds.³²

Much of the scholarship on defamation cases focuses on its high point, in terms of volume rather than proportion of cases, in the seventeenth century. Yet studies of defamation do not suggest that attitudes towards sexual behaviour and reputation underwent a significant change over the long eighteenth century. Indeed, S. W. Waddam's investigation of defamation cases heard in ecclesiastical courts in England, Wales and the Isle of Man between 1815 and 1855 indicates very similar vocabularies of sexual insult used to damage individual reputations. In 1838, for instance, two surgeon-apothecaries, William Dix and Henry Scarse, met and quarrelled and in insulting the latter Dix accused him of being a cuckold and keeping a bawdy house.³³ Nineteenth-century expressions were similar to early modern ones, often evoking venereal disease, such as 'bloody clapped whore' and 'pox'd bitch'.³⁴

Where the evidence from defamation cases is sufficient, it is clear that existing hostilities informed the sexual insult which may not necessarily or solely have related to sexual offences. Even so, they also reveal shared notions of sexual probity, taught by and maintained through the Church and its legal institutions. As June Tarver suggests, the use of the courts in defamation cases 'may have provided an informal system of social control on sexual behaviour and reputation in a gossip-laden society' indicating, therefore, a shared sexual culture which the Church facilitated and supported.³⁵

Indeed, in many ways people instrumentally deployed the church courts because they offered a forum for the discussion of community attitudes towards sexual offences. There were several reasons for the use of church courts to restore reputations following slander. Reputation was essential to a successful family and business life in a society in which financial credit was often extended and where the capacity to trust someone to settle their debts was essential for financial buoyancy.³⁶ As Alexandra Shepard has demonstrated, credit and honesty meant both economic and sexual probity.³⁷ For victims it was essential therefore to restore a public reputation when it was rocked by accusations or gossip of sexual misdemeanour. Certainly, the defamed often emphasised that their business or trade had suffered through an accusation.³⁸ Accusations also threatened the gender as well as the social status of the victim. Although the period is generally seen as one of a harsh sexual double-standard in which men were permitted far more sexual freedom than women, for many adult men sexual probity was demanded since it demonstrated the requisite masculine self-control, honesty and virtue of the man. Thus the church courts offered a valuable service in the long eighteenth century, where successful plaintiffs could have their costs paid and publicly shamed the defamer who was forced to recant his or her words during divine service.³⁹ By the nineteenth century, Waddam suggests that, as more women became plaintiffs in defamation cases, defamation jurisdiction protected their interests and gave them some power directly into their own hands.⁴⁰

Differentiation in Disciplining Morality

There were differing practices and rates of change across England and Wales in the regulation of sexual offences by church courts. Over the long eighteenth century, the courts focused more on sexual offences because the range of offences pursued narrowed following the 1689 Toleration Act, which ended prosecutions for nonconformity and meant that sexual delinquency dominated office prosecutions thereafter. Thus of 1,116 presentments made between 1712–76 by the archdeacon's court relating to Whalley, 90.8 per cent were sexual offences.⁴¹ This was not growth in absolute terms, and in the light of substantial population growth from the mid eighteenth century indicates overall lower numbers than the seventeenth century. Yet there was no universal

pattern of decline in office cases against sexual incontinence, whose incidence was shaped by broad socio-economic variation.

Surveys of this litigation demonstrate that some areas saw rapid declines in presentments by the early eighteenth century, including courts in Oxfordshire, Wiltshire, Herefordshire, Derby, and London. Other courts in Yorkshire, Nottinghamshire, Hexhamshire, Norwich, Lichfield, and Carlisle, however, heard moral cases much further into the eighteenth century.⁴² Nottingham archdeaconry, for instance, continued to target bastardy, perhaps because there was more of it in the growing population or perhaps because of zealous clergy and churchwardens. From 1660 to 1795, 154 of 184 immorality prosecutions were for bastardy, cases falling away in the 1770s.⁴³ In one Nottinghamshire peculiar there were still 21 penances for fornication in the 1770s, while prenuptial fornication cases disappeared after 1765 in Nottingham.⁴⁴ Numbers could be quite high in some areas. Between 1731 and 1735, the diocese of Carlisle made 494 presentments for fornication, as well as citing 214 individuals for ante-nuptial fornication, and between 1736 and 1740 issued 409 fornication and 100 ante-nuptial fornication presentments.⁴⁵ Not all patterns of office cases were linear. In the parish of Whalley, Lancashire, presentments of fornication fluctuated from 119 between 1712 and 1720, to 206 from 1731–40, 236 for 1740–50, and 94 for 1761–70.⁴⁶ Ecclesiastical courts in the archdeaconry of Leicester, 1712–13, heard 19 cases of fornication, between 1740 and 1744 heard 64 cases of fornication, with only a handful from 1774–5.⁴⁷ In Leicester adultery and fornication were presented throughout the eighteenth century, but declined sharply in the 1740s when churchwardens seemed far less inclined to present offenders.⁴⁸

Fornication was the main offence presented and office cases against adultery continued in much reduced numbers. Jane Barnett carried out her penance for the 'foul crime of Adultery' on 1 July 1770 in the parish church of All Saints, Oxford; as did Ann Bowell, in Weston on Green in July 1789.⁴⁹ Admittedly by then rare, office adultery cases lingered on into the nineteenth century. William Slater, a gentleman of East Retford, Nottinghamshire, promoted an office case in March 1803 against Darker [sic] Parker, a coal dealer, for living in a state of adultery with Ann Rhodes. The citation demanded that Parker appear before York Chancery Court on 31 March 1803 to answer articles relating to his

soul's health and correction of manners; he may have done so, since the court book recorded 'satisfied' after the May 1803 entry.⁵⁰

Defamation cases over sexual reputation survived longer into the nineteenth century, though there was still a decline in numbers overall. York ecclesiastical courts, for example, heard 132 cases between 1692 and 1695 in the consistory court, though the volume never reached its pre-Commonwealth levels.⁵¹ By the 1730s and 1740s, the London consistory court was hearing an average of 24 cases a year. Again there was variation. Nottingham archdeaconry court saw 21 cases brought between 1780 and 1787.⁵² Snape's investigation of Whalley concludes that defamation was regularly brought before the courts throughout the eighteenth century and concludes that a litigious sense of honour survived for the parish middling sort.⁵³ The Royal Commission on Ecclesiastical Courts found that an annual average of 110 defamation causes was brought in all English and Welsh courts between 1827 and 1829.⁵⁴ It was in the first half of the nineteenth century that defamation cases dwindled more substantially. As Pemberton shows, however, right up to the 1830s Leicester archidiaconal court issued penances to defamers which were performed either in the chancel before the defamed or in the parsonage house if the defamatory words were not too offensive. Thus in defamation jurisdiction the Church held on to its corrective functions well into the nineteenth century.⁵⁵ This suggests that there was not a clear-cut shift from viewing immoral acts necessitating public sanctions to being matters for private conscience, since sexual reputation was considered to have a public component for longer into the century.

The reasons for different patterns of Church regulation of illicit sex are various. It is not the case that the Church gave up correction because it had lost its will or way. After all, as Outhwaite points out, the numbers of clergymen serving as justices of the peace climbed in the second half of the eighteenth century to 22 per cent by 1831.⁵⁶ There is also considerable evidence that ordinary clergy were keen to impose sexual discipline on their congregations.⁵⁷ Moreover, it is important not to forget that individual bishops were influential in the pursuit of discipline. The commitment of bishops and senior clergy to sexual discipline did not diminish during the century.⁵⁸ Some bishops, like Thomas Secker, gained a reputation for assiduous pursuit of legal cases.⁵⁹ Although Snape somewhat problematically agrees that a sexual

revolution in behaviour occurred, he does not see that alone as accounting for weakening of ecclesiastical discipline in relation to sexual matters in Whalley and regards the Church itself as remaining important. Indeed, the 1740s and 1750s were a peak period in presentments of sexual offences in Whalley because they were driven by the zealous Bishop of Chester, Samuel Peploe. In his primary visitation charge of 1728, Peploe told the churchwardens that they were to inspect the conversation of parishioners and notice through 'credible Fame and Report suspected to be real' all 'impudent Sinners' as this would be an advantage to religion and virtue, and 'Immorality and Prophaneness will not pass without some Shame and Punishment'.⁶⁰ Similarly, as shown in chapter one, ecclesiastical censure of sexual incontinence seems to have been far harsher on the Isle of Man, incorporating more severe secular punitive measures. In 1705, the punishment for William Kissack for committing adultery with his wife's niece was to be committed to St German's Prison for a month, and then to make a Sunday penance at the door of every parish church and at every town market cross. Moreover, he was to stand for two hours a day at the latter, with a note on his chest declaring his crimes.⁶¹

The state of the church courts has been identified as contributing to their collapse by the mid-nineteenth century.⁶² The closure of lesser church courts meant people had to travel further, which cost more money and put them off answering office cases or beginning instance suits. Furthermore, other secular agencies stepped in, such as magistrates who by the later eighteenth century were more accessible and offered mediation.⁶³ Influential, also, was the passage of a law in May 1787, which reformed some of the church courts' activities, specifically addressing 'frivolous and vexatious Suits in Ecclesiastical Courts;' whether it was a result of the shifts or a cause is less clear.⁶⁴ The law stipulated that a suit for fornication had to be initiated before eight months had elapsed from the offence being committed, and causes for defamation had to be pursued within six months of the utterance of defamatory words. It also abolished suits for pre-marital fornication after the two parties had married each other; effectively ending the discipline of pre-marital sex following the partners' wedding. The Royal Commission on the Ecclesiastical Courts of 1830 revealed that sexual discipline cases were largely non-existent by this date (not even fifty for all English and Welsh diocesan courts for the three years of 1827–9).⁶⁵

In some areas from the 1770s, local clerics and churchwardens became reluctant to present offenders due to the defendants' decision to ignore the church courts, which impugned the Church's spiritual discipline. The evidence of how far people simply rejected the imposition of the church courts into their sexual lives by the end of the century is complex, however. The wider explanation of collapsing discipline in larger, more anonymous, communities is clearly relevant. The correction of extra-marital sex continued longer in places with smaller communities, more predominantly rural or agricultural in nature, because face-to-face relationships still existed. Thus urban industrialising areas with immigration and anonymity were those likely to show the fastest reduction in cases. Outhwaite suggests the same factors affected the fall in defamation cases, with a shift away from face-to-face communities where sexual reputation may have been more highly prized than in the industrial areas of the early nineteenth century where many of the local populations were mobile incomers.⁶⁶

These factors accord with evidence of changing sexual habits in such industrialising areas. Emma Griffin argues that, over the course of the eighteenth century, sexual culture changed as a result of the environment and living conditions in areas with greater and earlier economic growth. The result was, she proposes, the waning of family and community demands that sexual activity was followed by a wedding. There is demographic support for this. At the start of the eighteenth century 2 per cent of children were born out of wedlock and 20 per cent of brides were pregnant at the wedding; a century years later those figures were respectively 6 per cent and 40 per cent. It would suggest, therefore, that in industrialising parishes, the church courts gradually lost authority, particularly after the 1787 statute stopping pre-marital fornication suits, and in a sexual culture in which individuals may have been less willing to respond to citations to appear for correction.

Yet, this was not a universal pattern. Griffin notes that there were differences in the sexual behaviour of particular groups. Snape attempted to test this by asking whether the least economically developed chapelries of the parish of Whalley had more rigorous standards of ecclesiastical discipline than the industrialising ones with larger populations. In the latter, he found that offenders were presented but did not appear. Nonetheless in the former, compliance was higher although presentments dropped after the 1750s. He ascribes the fall in

presentments to local church officers losing faith in the purpose and processes of visitation courts, although this does not explain why officers continued to make presentments in the industrialising parishes.⁶⁷ Moreover, for the most part, reproductive sex continued to happen within the process of making marriage, so there was no broad revolution in sexual behaviour which the Church fought and lost.

In her work on cohabitation, Rebecca Probert concludes that there were high levels of conformity to marriage, with, as she describes it, vanishingly rare numbers of couples cohabiting during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. It is possible to speculate that there was conformity in issues of sexual behaviour more broadly. Though the church courts did not actively pursue incontinence in several southern counties by the mid-eighteenth century and in the northern counties by the later century, this does not mean that deterrents against sex outside marriage disappeared. The lessons of moral discipline may well have been internalised by communities. As Probert observes, people did not cohabit once the Church stopped presenting couples who lived together without being married. This is because religion retained its hold, moral censure remained strong, and internal conscience took the place of external regulation.⁶⁸ Certainly, the harsh language of sexual incontinence as sin was retained, as examples above show. Although admittedly a legal formulation, separation cases on the grounds of adultery continued to state that the adulterous wife committed adultery because she was unmindful of her conjugal vow, did not have the fear of God before her eyes, and was moved by the devil.⁶⁹

Lay Attitudes towards Ecclesiastical Regulation of Illicit Sexual Activities

There are varying accounts of the ways in which lay people perceived the actions of the church courts; they fall into two broad categories. Some scholars viewed parishioners as resentful of the interference of ecclesiastical authorities in their moral and sexual behaviour. Others instead see communities working together with the courts to regulate disorderly sexual offenders for the good of local order. It is probably mistaken to locate these stances within a chronological framework where the regulation of moral offences was a joint effort between communities and the Church in the early modern period, while people resented

external intrusion into their sexual activities and simply refused to turn up to court if presented during the second half of the eighteenth century.⁷⁰ In fact it is possible to find both acceptance and resentment in statements from both periods. In general, even historians more likely to see the Church and its court system as inadequate, acknowledge the problems of an argument that people became increasingly secular over time. Snape, for instance, identifies inadequate parochial infrastructure and pastoral weakness in the large parish of Whalley, in the Hundred of Blackburn, which fell under the jurisdiction of the bishop of Chester. Yet he concludes that the laity was actively involved in Church life and that the Church enjoyed a high degree of popular conformity that only waned in the last quarter of the eighteenth century.⁷¹

There is also evidence of continued conformity to ideals of sexual probity. It was widely acknowledged that sex was acceptable if it was part of the stages taken towards marriage. When Thomas West, of Thame, Oxfordshire, was presented for fathering a bastard child on Mary Towsin, in 1718, he secured a certificate from twenty-five Thame parishioners, and the vicar, churchwardens, and overseers, who stated that he was 'never Suspected for any Unchastity of Dishonesty ... till this fact was discover'd by the said Mary Towset herselfe who was in hopes by that meanes to gaine him for her Husband hee being a Single Man'. It is not entirely clear whether Thomas fathered the child, but the petitioners' view of Thomas and description of Mary as 'a loose & Scandalous person' secured his dismissal.⁷²

As Paul Hair commented in his collection of cases from church courts, there was anxiety about unregulated sexuality and reproduction in a society which lacked effective fertility limitations and had expectations of sustained economic growth.⁷³ Church court cases involving extra marital sex show that couples' activities aroused suspicion if they did not conform to moral conventions, in the later part of the century as much as the earliest. In the mid-1770s the married Mary Fortnam, of Steeple Claydon, was noted walking in the fields with Thomas, her mother's shepherd, sitting next to him at meal times when she supervised her mother's household during her absence, and visiting him in pretence of seeing the lambs.⁷⁴ Thomas's seventeen-year-old fellow servant was being nursed by Mary after being kicked in the forehead by a horse and he offered the couple's 'frequently winking and laughing in each others [sic] faces' as evidence of them behaving

immodestly and amorously. He said this was familiarity 'as any young Fellow should not shew to a married woman'.⁷⁵ Similarly, a thirty-seven-year-old servant said she was thrown into 'a trembling' when she saw Thomas leaving a room in which the 'young mistress' could be glimpsed lying in bed in only a shirt.

Such a physical and emotional response indicates attitudes to illicit sexuality.⁷⁶ Deponents before the church courts often used a language of shame about illicit sexuality. In 1773, Thomas Bedding, a servant in Steeple Claydon, suspected his fellow servant, Thomas Palmer, of having sex with the married daughter of his mistress. Finding Palmer with the woman alone in a room, Bedding and another servant listened outside a chamber door for two hours until Palmer emerged wearing only his shirt and frock. Bedding took hold of Palmer on the stairs and told him 'that he did very wrong to be with another Man's wife'. William Stockford, their fellow servant, a carter who also lived in the household, recalled that Palmer cried when he was challenged, though whether this was due to shame or fear is not known. Bedding and Stockford portrayed Mary as shameless. The next morning, they said that she accused them of ill-using Thomas Palmer and she declared that if she'd asked them instead of Palmer, they would have done it. Stockford told her 'she might be ashamed of her actions' and that if she did not keep away from Palmer they would tell her husband. Bedding and Stockford were clearly keen to display their sound sense of morality.⁷⁷ Even if these deponents deployed conventional language, due to the forum in which they were being questioned, there is sufficient evidence that this language of shame and morality reflected social values, and some degree of conformity to social and religious demands for sexual chastity.

There is also evidence that individuals and communities themselves dealt fairly swiftly with the repercussions of sexual incontinence whether it was hidden or punished. In September 1715, Anne Reed gave birth to her brother-in-law's child. John Greiveson, a merchant in Sedgefield, County Durham, was married to Anne's sister. When Anne was about to give birth John carried her to a house in Greatham where she was delivered of his baby. Shortly after, John went to William Wordy, a weaver in Hartlepool, and demanded forty five pounds that William owed him. According to William the conversation then turned to John's 'friend' who had suffered a 'misfortune;' John continued that it would be a kindness to his 'friend' if William helped him nurse the child. William

was well aware that John was talking about himself, and perhaps to offset his debt agreed that his wife would nurse the baby. A few days later the child was carried to the midwife's house by Anne's mother, where William collected it. At the end of the month, the baby became sick and William visited Mrs Reed, the mother of Anne and John Greiveson's wife for advice. She asked him to baptise the baby and said she'd reimburse William for the costs. William next called on Walter Burne, curate of Hartlepool, and requested a private baptism for the ill baby. Burne asked who the father was and William said it was reported to be Greiveson's child. All these activities appear to be the Reeds' and Grievesons' attempt to restrict knowledge of the sexual immorality to the family. Margaret Grieveson, John's wife, was present at her sister's delivery; Mrs Reed, their mother, paid for the child's nursing, baptism, and burial. It was perhaps only the imminent death of the child that meant the adultery and fornication could no longer be hidden and the churchwardens of Sedgfield presented John and Anne at the visitation held in the parish church on 13 October 1715.⁷⁸

Parishioners were not simply the objects of the church courts' scrutiny and regulation; they used the courts instrumentally for their own ends too. Though David Lemmings does not dispute that there was an authentic suspicion of sexual incontinence, he suggests that since a sexual insult was actionable, women, who had few legal resources, actively mobilised this official authority in a wide range of their own disputes. Defamation cases in the church courts, as shown above, became a form of cultural exchange and negotiation. Indeed defamation cases 'reproduced the language and relations of a sub-culture of people who used sexual insult routinely in all sorts of economic, household and neighbourly disputes'.⁷⁹ It might seem that this litigation demonstrates disobedience to moral campaigns from above, but instead people were deploying elite legal discourses about respectability for their own ends. Over time, as the church courts became a venue for bringing cases against those who defamed the sexual reputation of the plaintiff, or undermined accepted marital behaviour, it may be that they were seen as simply another arena for resolving problematic relationships.

What is known about people's interaction with the church courts as civil courts? It was, after all, the higher officials who made judgements. At consistory courts, the bishop was represented by his chancellor of the diocese who held the role of official principal and vicar general. The legal

personnel were proctors, graduates in law, who were seen as the lawyers of the ecclesiastical courts.⁸⁰ This would suggest a more accepting attitude of the church courts as another legal service rather than an instrument of regulation. If courts were not uniformly seen as interventionist and harsh instruments of discipline, does this mean that the shift in the role of the church courts was not such a rejection of the premise of sexual regulation? As Snape concludes, the ecclesiastical courts saw themselves as 'guardians of personal honour and reputation' and in this sense, it is possible to conclude that there was enduring popular support for some of their services.⁸¹

Moreover, while the church courts may have been seen by their litigants as a faceless institution, ecclesiastical court administration was built on the relationship between parishioners, clergymen, and church officials, such as churchwardens. The clergyman in divine service, the clerical schoolmaster, and the parson-magistrate were perhaps the face of regulation of chastity and unchastity, which personalised it and made it more accessible. This could work in two ways. In some cases, clergymen were viewed as mediators between individuals and the Church authorities. There is evidence in matrimonial litigation, for example, that clergymen offered support and advice to wronged parties and warned people who were behaving inappropriately before their situation reached the courts.⁸² Couples who lived together as man and wife, but over whose marital status there was doubt, might be visited by their clergyman. In other cases, however, the clergyman's role in moral discipline shaped the relationship with parishioners in the correctional direction. Roberts claims that the clerical magistracy, which rose to greater prominence on the county benches in the later eighteenth century, gained a reputation 'for demanding a more uniform, reliable and strenuous discharge of public duty than most gentry JPs'.⁸³ Some clergymen were closely involved in presentations to the church courts, particularly in cases of fornication and marriage within prohibited degrees.⁸⁴

Individual clergy were occasionally accused of maliciously using the presentation process for their own ends. In 1709 the married William Newton, of the parish of Kirkby in Ashfield, in the archdeaconry of Nottingham, appealed against an office adultery case brought against him. His servant, Catherine Donnelly, had borne an illegitimate child in May 1705. In November of that year the churchwardens presented

John Billingsley for fornication with Catherine; however, they also presented William for adultery and fathering an illegitimate child. Witnesses said that William confessed to at least three people that his servant's child was his and he gave the midwife two guineas for its care. In his defence, however, he claimed that the report was raised by the curate of Kirkby, Matthew Brailsford, out of ill-will; the result of a quarrel over hay tithes which had reached the archdeacon's court. William appealed the case to York and in this stage of litigation, stated that the curate, Brailsford, had warned the midwife that he would 'destroy' her unless she swore that Catherine Donnelly had testified that her illegitimate child was fathered by her master. William also claimed the curate had threatened the churchwardens to force them to present him. Brailsford denied this and stated that he had sent for William six months after the baby was born to accuse him of adultery. William had confessed and promised Brailsford that he would deliver a bond to indemnify the parish from trouble on behalf of the child and would go to the ecclesiastical court and make his peace there.⁸⁵ This case not only reveals the importance of sexual probity to men's reputations, the nexus of tensions that might underlie sexual misbehaviour and its consequences, and the role of the church courts in both punishment and reconciliation; it suggests that it was not the curate's professional 'moral' actions that were rejected but his personal malice.

The parish church, as well as the church courts, was thus at the centre of people's perception of discipline.⁸⁶ Punishment had a considerable impact since it was enacted at the local level in office cases because penance was carried out under the clergyman's oversight. The shamed party had to carry out penance on Sunday during divine service in what was an experience that could stir profound feelings from guilt, to shame, to grief and anger. In one case from 1734, the penitent Margaret Sherratt was 'cloathed in a white Sheet in her Stocken feet, with her hair about her Ears, and having a white Wand in her hand'. In this case, the congregations of Biddulph, Leek, and Chedleton churches in Staffordshire heard her loudly confess that she had 'led by the Instigation of the Devil and my own carnal Concupiscence ... committed the grievous Sin of Fornication with Thomas Booth To the dishonour of Almighty God, the breach of his most sacred Laws, The Scandal and evil example of others, and the danger of my own Soul without unfeigned Repentance'.⁸⁷ The clergymen of the parish churches were required to certify that the penance had occurred.⁸⁸

Similarly the most extreme form of punishment, excommunication, ruptured the relationship between the offender and his community. The excommunicant was announced and denounced in Church during divine service and thereafter excluded from worship and sacrament, unable to make a will, have children baptised, or be buried in the churchyard.⁸⁹

The Changing Focus of Moral Correction

By the final quarter of the eighteenth century there were signs of a shift in the way that moral regulation was disseminated and inculcated. Snape sees a move towards a belief in 'popular education' as a 'more attractive means of eliminating vice.' This took the form of voluntary action in the setting up of catechetical charity schooling and at a national level was pursued by the SPCK. Another educational endeavour was the Sunday School movement, which began in Gloucestershire the 1780s, initially by Robert Raikes. It aimed at the moral improvement of the uneducated labouring ranks. When the interdenominational Sunday School Society was set up in London, in 1785, it declared it was 'united to prevent the corruption of morals and advance the peace and felicity of the country'.⁹⁰ Overall the movement sought to bring to order the supposedly lawless poor by teaching them to read the Bible, and drilling into them the virtues of being punctual, clean, honest, and hardworking. Virtue would result from these habits.⁹¹ These organisations are discussed in chapter five.

There is some evidence that the Church itself sought different means to achieve a morally sound society. For example, Beilby Porteus, bishop of Chester 1776–87, presided over a decline in visitation presentments of sexual immorality, yet he did not attempt to bolster them. This is less a sign of the Church capitulating under a sexual revolution, and more an indicator of a difference in the tools selected to tackle immorality. In Porteus's primary visitation charge of 1778, framed by the political turbulence of the 1770s, he warned his clergy that their fervent prayer and 'most earnest endeavours to produce that reformation of manners' would alone save the country from ruin. He had faith in the powers of the new Sunday Schools in which the right education would impress 'on the minds of youth principles and habits of piety and virtue'.⁹² Porteus also saw the state as the key to 'an effectual remedy to these gross enormities'. As Snape comments, he 'was prepared

to abandon the spiritual courts as a remedy for the moral ills of the nation in favour of Christian education backed by the coercive power of the secular arm' of law.⁹³ This was not simply one bishop's stance but was indicative of a much wider shift in attitudes towards the law.

As David Lemmings argues, there was a 'general decline of unmediated popular participation' in the law, and a shift to parliamentary statute in the long eighteenth century, rather than the culture of law, as the principal instrument of government.⁹⁴ Before this, people were accustomed to social discipline communicated, interpreted, and enforced through a variety of tribunals from the Kings' courts, to the church courts, to manorial and borough courts.⁹⁵ They accepted this regulation as part of their broader participation in judicial institutions. In the eighteenth century all forms of civil litigation fell, not only church court use, with a decline in broader access to Chancery, King's Bench, Common Pleas, and Exchequer, as well as the various local manorial and borough courts.⁹⁶ Lemmings observes that law went up-market through a process of rising costs, elaboration of proceedings, and the professionalisation and specialisation of legal services.

The role of 'politeness' was an important factor in leading secular as well as religious authorities to make legal services more exclusive because it was intolerant of popular culture and perceived it as disorderly and deviant. This had an impact on the use of the courts more generally. It led to reluctance to allow legal action over defamatory words, for example, as being too petty for attention. It also meant that quarter sessions, and church court proctors, advocates and judges found these sorts of cases embarrassing.⁹⁷ Perhaps, as Paul Hair observed over forty years ago, the decline in church courts should be seen 'as due in the main to the growth of a conviction among the clergy and learned laity that social and moral discipline could be increasingly entrusted, on the one hand, to a more efficient yet still Christian state, and on the other hand, to a host of voluntary bodies assisting and encouraging the state'.⁹⁸ The pressure, in other words, was both from within the established Church as from secularising forces without.

Conclusion

This chapter thus demonstrates that it is simplistic to blame the Church for a failure to control a society whose ideas about sexual behaviour were

changing, nor did the institution discard the desire to amend sexual incontinence. Numerous other factors played a part in the changing role of the church courts, not all of which offer evidence of popular rejection of their mores; and there is evidence of the established Church's continuing hold on sexual behaviour and attitudes. Indeed, the period saw a shift in ideas about discipline and the inculcation of morals from external regulation and punishment to indoctrination through education and internal conscience. As Michael Snape argues, we should be 'wary of being too dismissive of the power of the spiritual courts during the eighteenth century.'⁹⁹ Again this was probably part of a wider shift in the practice of law. Rebecca Probert points out that the approach of the secular law moved from personal punishment to deterrence.¹⁰⁰ So in this sense the Church was responding to intellectual and social change rather than failing to achieve its objectives. The next chapter explores the institution of marriage, one of the primary means by which the Church and state sought to inculcate moral and sexual probity.

CHAPTER 4

THE CHURCH, MARRIAGE, AND MARITAL SEX

The Church of England was the gatekeeper of marriage, regulating its making and breaking in various ways. From the medieval period Christian theologians had debated, defined, and determined its meaning, parameters, and terms. Scripture continued to be the source and inspiration of commentaries on matrimony throughout the long eighteenth century. Canon law directed how marriage should be administered and regulated and provided principles on dealing with its repercussions for family and property during spousals, or betrothals, conflict, separation, and widowhood. Moreover, the parish church was the location for most weddings and both the law and wider society recognised that its ministers were essential for a valid union. Clergymen frequently published books and sermons advising couples on standards of behaviour during matrimony and offered mediation to those spouses whose married life was problematic. The church courts policed marital conformity and punished those who weakened the institution of marriage by fornication, bastardy, and adultery, made decisions about what constituted a marriage when one partner rejected it, and mediated the disputes that arose when a spouse was unfaithful or cruel, and following its dissolution by death.¹ As Phillimore's edition of Richard Burn's *Ecclesiastical Law* explained only fifteen years before its jurisdiction was lost to the newly established matrimonial divorce courts in 1857: 'The Ecclesiastical Court has an undoubted jurisdiction upon the general law of marriage, so far as the legality of that contract is constituted by the law of this country.'²

As such, religion provided the framework for formal understandings of marriage, and the Church instituted them. It is of course possible to find examples where people did not conform to these conventions, particularly by marrying clandestinely, by committing bigamy, and cohabiting instead of marrying, but this was only carried out by a minority of the population who risked their legal position, their status, and, in some cases, prosecution, by acting thus.³ Although many of these features of marriage have been addressed extensively in the secondary scholarship, this chapter views them through the lens of the Church's views on marital sex.

The Church placed sex at the very centre of marriage through scripture, teachings, and regulation. It taught that all extra-marital sex was a sin and to be punished. Despite a decline in the Church's active presentment of illicit sex in the later eighteenth century, there is no doubt that society accepted its contention that marriage was the only legitimate site for sex. Moreover the Church's focus on the procreative function of marriage made family limitation problematic for couples, with considerable implications for demographic patterns. For individuals and society, however, matrimony was more than a means by which to legitimise sexual activity. The *Book of Common Prayer's* liturgy for 'The Form of Solemnization of Matrimony' began with the statement that marriage is:

honourable among all men: and therefore is not by any to be enterprised, nor taken in hand unadvisedly, lightly, or wantonly, to satisfy men's carnal lusts and appetites, like brute beasts that have no understanding; but reverently, discreetly, advisedly, soberly, and in the fear of God, duly considering the causes for which matrimony was ordained.

These causes were first, the procreation of children and to bring them up in the fear and nurture of the Lord; second as a remedy against sin and fornication for those people without the gift of continency; and thirdly for the mutual help, society, and comfort of the couple.⁴

Sex, procreation, and mutual comfort were the intertwined reasons for marriage and helped prove the existence of a union. The bedding ritual that survived into the eighteenth century in which the couple were 'put to bed' by the wedding guests, often with much laughter and bawdy

humour, was a public performance of this key moment.⁵ In the more formal circumstances of matrimonial litigation recording the date of marriage in church court cause papers was insufficient to prove marriage. The documents went on to state that the couple had consummated the relationship by 'carnal copulation' following the wedding ceremony, and cohabited with each other as lawful husband and wife. The litigants' allegations and defences also linked piety and marital behaviour. For instance, in 1701, Dorothy Cunliffe countered her husband's separation case against her on the grounds of adultery by declaring out that she was an honest Christian woman of honest and worthy parents, well educated, faithful and loving.⁶

The Church's elevation of the importance of marital sex also shaped the legal ages of consent of twelve for girls and fourteen for boys. Indeed canon law's definition of the legal age at which marriage could occur was mitigated by the ecclesiastical courts' insistence on parental consent for minors marrying under the age of twenty-one. It also influenced the ways in which marital sex was taken as a physical measure of the health and state of an individual marriage. After all, in strict terms, marriage was a means to the end of sex, reproduction, and affection, and thus the church courts offered annulments to spouses who had unwittingly married a partner who suffered some form of sexual impediment. Nonetheless, the Church had to find an appropriate balance in the institution of marriage between its procreative aspects and the repercussions of a union encountering sexual or reproductive problems. Hence, neither the development of an inability to have sex following marriage or lack of children were grounds for nullity or divorce.

Marital sex was also central to other forms of failed unions, as this chapter demonstrates. The church upheld scriptural prohibitions on marriage between people related by blood or through marriage, meaning it was a gatekeeper against 'close marriage', although it is possible that clerics in the localities may have tolerated unions that were made within the affinal prohibited degrees. The ecclesiastical courts also assisted spouses whose partner was unfaithful, since illicit sex was recognised as breaking a marital union, and offered separation from 'bed and board' on the grounds of adultery. Although the language of adultery changed over the period, the Church retained a powerful hold on its definitions. While sex was not generally included in cruelty separation cases, it may well have been a trigger of marital violence, and a husband's adultery could be

perceived as a form of abuse, particularly when it resulted in a husband infecting his wife with venereal disease. Finally, while the Church enforced marital regulations, individual and familial faith was critical in finding a suitable partner and sustaining a successful marriage.

Matrimonial Consent

What made a valid marriage in the first place? According to canon law, the answer was consent, sex, and a ceremony celebrated by an Anglican priest. The relative importance of consent and sex in making marriage was a matter of theological debate during the medieval period. Consent gained prominence in the debates of canonists in the twelfth century because diminishing its significance by insisting on sexual consummation as the indicator of a valid union risked undermining the status of the marriage of Mary and Joseph at Jesus' birth.⁷ Until Rebecca Probert's scholarship overturned the assumption, it was believed that before 1754 a valid marriage could be created by a couple merely exchanging consent. Although consent was critical, it was not alone sufficient to forge a regular marriage. An exchange of consent in the present tense only bound a couple to complete their contract to wed by a church ceremony, but was not seen by law or society as a valid union.⁸

For all that the place of sex in making a marriage was secondary, and its absence during wedlock would not invalidate a union or permit divorce, it was still vital. For instance, a promise to marry in the future would become binding once any conditions had been satisfied or the couple had sex, because the consummation 'was deemed to represent their present consent to marriage'.⁹ For most people and the Church of England, therefore, the factors essential to a regular marriage were a wedding ceremony performed by an ordained clergyman followed by consummation and cohabitation.¹⁰ The significance of cohabitation should not be underestimated. Indeed by the 1842 edition of Richard Burn's *Ecclesiastical Law*, in the section on marriage contracts, Phillimore saw it necessary to clarify that: 'A mere casual commerce, without the intention of cohabitation and bringing up children, would not constitute marriage under any supposition'. However, if two persons 'have that commerce for the procreation and bringing up of children' with lasting cohabitation, in the absence of civil and religious institutions, this could be called a 'marriage in the sight of God'. Though as Phillimore was careful to point

out, in anything other than a state of nature, a wedding ceremony performed by a clergyman was still essential.¹¹

The age at which an individual could enter marriage was determined by this definition of marriage formation, which emphasised both the capacity to consent to and have sex; in other words s/he to be mentally and physically mature. Canon law stipulated that children in infancy (defined as less than seven years) could not be married; they could only consent once they reached the age of discretion, which was twelve for girls and fourteen for boys. Thus a child could be espoused at seven, but the contract could not be completed until the parties consented to marry at twelve or fourteen, at which point they would be '*masculi quidem puberes; faeminae autem viri potentes*'.¹² The age of consent was consistent throughout the long eighteenth century. Nonetheless, both the Church and society saw the ages of twelve and fourteen as too young to enter marriage. Article 100 of the Canons 1604 required that people obtained their parents' consent to marry when under the age of twenty-one. The public calling of banns was intended to prevent secrecy and alert the public to such impediments, and marriage licences required parties to swear 'that they have obtained thereunto the express Consent of their Parents (if they be living) or otherwise of their Guardians or Governours'.¹³ After Hardwicke's Marriage Act of 1753, the unions of minors could be deemed void.¹⁴

Therefore, despite the legal age of consent, the Church administered marriage in a form that was consistent with social practice in which the majority of couples married in their mid-twenties, constrained by social and economic factors that required them to be able to financially support a household and dependents. By the end of the eighteenth century the age at which people married was decreasing and numbers of illegitimate children increasing. According to the latest research, this was due to family and community loss of control over young people's sex lives and industrialisation causing 'social change and dislocation.' Both 'weakened the social forces that for centuries had controlled access to marriage and irrevocably altered the cultural norms surrounding the passage from single to married life'.¹⁵ The Church is rarely assigned a role in this shift in practice, but it is perhaps relevant that the Church's methods of regulating sex and marriage also contracted at the turn of the eighteenth century and were a significant feature of the changing cultural norms that facilitated change.

Regulating Entry into Marriage: Prohibited Degrees

A lawful marriage was defined in *Ecclesiastical Law* as one 'consummate with bodily knowledge, or fruit of children, or child being had therein' and contracted between parties not prohibited by God's law to marry. The eighteenth chapter of the Book of Leviticus detailed the forbidden degrees of kindred and consanguinity, and degrees of affinity and alliance, which prevented marriage.¹⁶ Canon law deemed as incestuous marriages that resulted from unions within prohibited degrees. Essentially people were prohibited from marrying in the ascending and descending line their close relations by blood and by marriage to the fourth degree.¹⁷ Burn's *Ecclesiastical Law* explained that such unions were:

prohibited without limit; because they are the cause (immediate or mediate) of their being; and it is directly repugnant to the order of their nature, which hath assigned several duties and offices, essential to each, that would thereby be inverted and overthrown. A parent cannot obey a child, and therefore it is unnatural that a parent should be wife to a child; a parent as a parent, hath a natural right to command and correct a child; and that a child, as husband, should command and correct the same parent is unnatural. To which we may add, the inconsistency, absurdity and monstrousness of the relations to be begotten, if such prohibition were not absolute and unlimited.¹⁸

It was the fact that sexual relations between close kin could undermine hierarchical power relationships that was of concern, rather than the likelihood of it creating hereditary problems in offspring, which is only hinted in the final sentence with the word 'monstrous'.¹⁹ This was surely because canon law treated both affinal and consanguineal relationships as resulting in an incestuous marriage. There were also biblical injunctions against marriage with relatives which were especially potent for Protestants.

The church courts regulated such unions in three ways. Public officials could present the parties involved. As the eighteenth century progressed, interested third parties could bring cases, usually those who would gain benefit (generally property) from the dissolution of the marriage.

Finally spouses themselves could seek nullity after learning of their problematic marital status. Before Lord Lyndhurst's Act of 1835,²⁰ these marriages were 'merely susceptible to annulment' during the parties' lifetime. In other words they were valid until voided by the court. Marriages made after 1835 were defined as void.²¹ As well as dissolving these marriages, the courts gave penance to the couple. For example John Taylor and Alice Horley (his deceased wife's sister, whom he had married and had two children with) were ordered to the parish church of Wetwang, Yorkshire on Sunday 5 June 1720, to stand barefoot, bare-legged, and bareheaded, clad in white sheets with white rods in their hands. They remained thus throughout Morning Prayer and would then confess before the congregation, saying:

Whereas We good people forgetting our duty to Almighty God have committed the detestable sin of incest together and haveing thereby provoked the heavy wrath of God against us to the great danger of our own souls for the same desiring Almighty for the merits of Jesus Christ to forgive us this and all other our offences, and to assist us with his holy spirit that We never fall into the like Grievous Sin again.²²

The numbers of cases of marriage within prohibited degrees that were heard by the church courts were small. At Wells consistory court between 1736 and 1823, twenty-one were heard, most involving spouses who had married a deceased spouse's sibling (this kind of union probably occurred since it united couples who might be attracted to each other and meant that a step-parent was biologically related to offspring).²³ Between 1660 and 1800 York and Durham ecclesiastical courts heard 37 cases of marriage within prohibited degrees.²⁴ Only one of these was brought by a spouse in order to seek an annulment. Hannah Cutler married her deceased husband's nephew in 1795 in Thorne, Yorkshire, but waited six years before bringing a suit for nullity by reason of affinity to end their union. She successfully gained a sentence in her favour in 1803.²⁵ The profile of relationships echoed those in Somerset in being largely affinal; eighteen were to a deceased spouse's sibling, five men married their step-daughters, five men married their deceased uncle's wife, and three men married their deceased wife's niece.²⁶ Although few in number the cases offer insights into lay and clerical attitudes towards these relationships.

Though canon law provided a blanket proscription on marriage within prohibited degrees, society was far more likely to differentiate between types of 'incest'. For one thing, cousin marriage was not banned by canon law following the Reformation and at various times was very common, particularly from the early nineteenth century to mid-Victorian period. 'Close marriage' of this kind suited the prevailing demographic pattern of this period of large families with numerous siblings and offspring providing a wide pool of marriage partners, and it functioned to keep property within the family.²⁷ It was a particular boon for forging unity and strength in Nonconformist families who were on the margins of power in the long eighteenth century. Although a few worries about the health of offspring of cousin marriages existed, it was not until the twentieth century that this concern helped make cousin marriage appear far less acceptable, even revolting for some.²⁸ What is also clear is that people were more likely to tolerate relationships created by marriage (affinal) than those created by blood (consanguineal) which were considered to be incestuous.²⁹

Although accused couples responded in a variety of ways to the office cases in York, most responses suggest awareness that they had broken the Church's rules. Some denied cohabiting with the spouse. With the assumption that it was sex which forged the marriage, others claimed they had not consummated the union. In 1694 Susanna Barraclough alias Smith admitted marrying William Smith, her deceased husband's nephew, and living together as man and wife in the same house, but denied that William had carnal knowledge of her.³⁰ In 1695, Herbert and Susanna Lister of the parish of Riccall, Yorkshire, were prosecuted for wedding even though Susanna was Herbert's uncle's widow. They claimed they were misinformed that the union was valid by Mr John Preston, an ecclesiastical court proctor, who prepared the licence for them. The court dissolved their union and gave them penance for fornication and incest, as well as condemning them to pay expenses.³¹

Morris suggests that affinal unions were far more likely to be tolerated in the west of England, and the larger numbers of such cases in itself suggests this is plausible. Indeed, in the northern counties, where there is sufficient evidence, it seems some couples' families also accepted such unions. Susannah Railey's brother was present at his sister's marriage to their step-father in February 1715 in Kingston-upon-Hull. The Raileys

were presented to the church court for marriage within prohibited degrees the following April.³² Similarly, when John Taylor married his deceased wife's sister in 1717, his seventy-year-old father in law, a farmer, knew about the marriage and offered no objection according to his deposition in the ensuing case.³³ A few of these unions had existed for some years before they came to the court's attention, which implies a degree of acceptance. A further feature of couples presented for marriage within prohibited degrees is that they attempted to conform to regular marriage by being married in the parish church (though often not their own) by a minister.³⁴ This inevitably raises the question of clergymen's role in making and breaking these prohibited unions.

The motivation of clergymen who married such couples is elusive but, in the majority of cases, was likely to be ignorance. Many of the weddings took place outside the couple's home parish. In 1717 John and Alice Taylor, of the parish of Wetwang, Yorkshire, mentioned above, were married by a parson in St Mary's, Beverley, around fifteen miles away. Three years later they were presented to the York Dean & Chapter, which held peculiar jurisdiction over the parish, because Alice was the sister of John's deceased wife.³⁵ It would seem that such couples simply went where they were unknown. In 1741, Mr Morland, of Hartlepool wrote to William Pye in Durham, to initiate a case against Margaret and Ralph Davison, 'concerning reformation of manners for committing incest.' He explained:

Sir, Upon my refusing to marry a young fellow & his Brother's Widow they went immediately to Newcastle and were married there: the man's Name is Ralph, & the Woman's Margaret, Davison; he is a common sailor & she a Mantua-Maker, in this Town. I thought it necessary to give you this notice, that you may proceed ag[ains]t them as you shall think proper.³⁶

Other clergymen administering the law certainly defined affinal as well as consanguineal relationships as 'lewd' and therefore in need of regulation. In spring 1733 George Carr of Dalton-le-Dale, Seaham, was wed by a minister to his deceased wife's sister in the parish church of St Oswald, Durham City (around eleven miles away). Shortly after this, the curate of Dalton-le-Dale wrote to a Durham minister in order to present George and Mary for incest:

Rev Sir

I am heartily sorry that, as well in discharge of my duty, as upon account of the scandal and great offence the above unhappy marriage had given to this neighbourhood, I am constrained to make this presentment: and being confident of your ready concurrence and assistance in everything that may promote the reformation of manners, especially in Dalton parish; I've taken the liberty to send the above to you, begging you will deliver it to Mr Pye and prevail with him speedily to use what means he knows to be proper, either for dissolving that marriage or bringing the offenders to such punishment as may be a means to deter others from such lewd practices. Your compliance and endeavours as above desired, will much oblige every good Christian in this parish, and particularly Sir

Your most obedient humble servant.

J Burne.³⁷

In Dalton-le-Dale, a coastal village on the north-east coast, this union was seen as a matter of the reformation of manners, probably because, by falling within prohibited degrees, the union between George and Mary was recast as illicit sex.

Yet there are some instances of the local clergyman marrying the couple in their home parish. When Hannah Cutler, mentioned earlier, married her deceased husband's nephew in January 1795, they were living in Thorne, and were married in the parish church.³⁸ Polly Morris therefore asks whether this indicates clerical uncertainty about kinship and marriage ties, or a popular dismissal of canonical laws on prohibited degrees where the relationship was created through marriage. Morris discovered one rector who was wed to his own deceased wife's sister in 1736. Her study of cases of prohibited degrees from Somerset is inconclusive but she finds evidence for a range of behaviour. Some officiating clergymen, or those who failed to prosecute offending couples, were simply ineffective; others were possibly applying their own sense of justice, or acting expediently in facilitating a marriage between poor spouses rather than letting them fall onto the parish for relief when the union was dissolved.³⁹

Where more evidence is available, there are clues of official complicity in violating canon law in the later period under study. William Holland,

a Somerset parson, recorded a conversation in his diary in 1809 with a man who was living with his brother's wife and had children with her. They had not married, probably because the brother was alive though transported for life to Botany Bay. He asked Holland if he should marry the woman. Holland replied 'that she ran a risk if the Husband should come home, besides she was by law his sister'. So he essentially warned the man not to marry because he would commit bigamy, a felony. The man replied that surely 'it was more sinful in the Eye of God than living in the manner he did with her'. Holland avoided a direct answer, restating that he must do what the law dictated. He ended the diary account, however, observing that it 'was a difficult case to determine but certainly marriage of any kind is some sanction rather than to live together as they do without any sanction in a Moral Sense'. Clearly both men were grappling with reconciling religious teachings about morality with canon law that refused to differentiate between affinal and consanguineal relationships. Here the clergyman who represented the institution of the Church was more in sympathy with lay practice than with canon law; perhaps an easier stance to fall into at a time when the church courts were less likely to prosecute illicit sex.⁴⁰

Advice on Married Life

How did the Church sustain married couples after the ceremony? Scripture provided the basis for much guidance on what formed a good marriage and, from the Reformation onwards, clergymen frequently published advice on how to forge and maintain a successful relationship. Much of this entailed making sense of a theoretically unequal hierarchical relationship of dominant husband and subordinate wife in a lived reality that required similar levels of economic labour and contributions. This genre of print culture did not explicitly discuss marital sex in detail; but, its promotion of companionate, mutually satisfying marriages, did not shirk at making it clear that part of building such a relationship involved a couple's sex lives. Too much emphasis can be placed on a shift in the status of sexual relations within matrimony in pre- to post-Reformation England. The Catholic Church had elevated the status of celibacy as preferable to marriage, discussed in chapter six, but Erasmus and Christian humanists argued that marriage was a superior estate and this tradition informed post-Reformation views. While there

was some shift in emphasis regarding marriage in the post-Reformation Protestant world, the importance of marriage as the household's spiritual centre did not originate with Protestant thinkers.⁴¹ This is not surprising since, as Rosemary O'Day observes, Catholics and Protestants 'used the Bible as their conduct book' and scripture underpinned Christian teachings on marital sex. St Paul set out that a husband had authority over the body of his wife and she over his and both could demand the 'marital debt' even when the other partner was unwilling.⁴²

Anthony Fletcher's study of sixteenth- and seventeenth-century Protestant marriage advice, in the form of conduct books and sermons, shows that they stressed the regularity of marital sex to maintain physical health, to forge a happy relationship, and to make the onerous demands of patriarchy more palatable by making women's burden of obedience more tolerable.⁴³ The explosion of print culture in the early modern period led to wider dissemination of Protestant clerics' message that marital sex helped produce companionate and therefore successful unions, as well as procreating offspring.⁴⁴

The tone of marital conduct literature changed in the eighteenth century under the influence of emerging politeness and sensibility. Reacting to the political and commercial upheaval following the 1680s, it promoted sentimental love over functional motives for marriage. In general, it feigned and flattered when reminding wives of their subordination and husbands of their obligations. As Ingrid Tague observes of the literature, 'Love was essential in order to make women accept the natural order of marriage, which demanded their obedience to their husbands'.⁴⁵ If spades were no longer called spades, and eighteenth-century polite writers, including clergymen, were less direct in advocating the pleasures of marital sex, they nonetheless alluded to it. The Reverend Wetenhall Wilkes, rector of South Somerscotes, Lincolnshire, 1742–51, discussed 'conjugal love in all its native beauties and attractions' as preferable to the single state in his *Letter to Young Women* (1740). His passage on marriage used the polite vocabulary of feeling, of a spouse as 'a bosom friend', of marriage as 'a constant scene of delight' and 'mutual comfort and entertainment'. The fundamental bond between marriage, sex, and procreation was, however, still critical. He asked rhetorically: 'How much the hearts of those rejoice, who see a beautiful and numerous offspring of their own, playing about them, and endeavouring to excel one another, in little innocent sports, to please

their parents!'⁴⁶ This is the language of children as visible pledges of marital love, evidence of a happy union in all forms. It symbolised a satisfying marital sexual relationship since, in seventeenth-century midwifery texts, marital love was considered to improve conception and its absence to lead to barrenness.⁴⁷

Even in the later eighteenth century, the lack of children was used to highlight marital failure. In the criminal conversation case brought by Captain Parslow against Francis Sykes for his affair with a Mrs Parslow, in 1789, Counsel Thomas Erskine pointed out: 'There was every reason to believe, that but for the intrusion of this defendant, many children would have blessed the parents, and adorned the family – Children at once the care and happy fruits of the nuptial bed'.⁴⁸

Sexual Dysfunction in Marriage

Since sex and procreation were integral to marriage, what happened when either was problematic? Gendered biblical understandings of barrenness informed early modern medical thinking.⁴⁹ In the Old Testament barrenness was ascribed either to the state of land or women as unfruitful; and Jennifer Evans observes that 'fruitful' was the language used in medical literature to describe fertility. It continued into eighteenth-century descriptions of conception and child-bearing. In the seventeenth century newer ways of thinking about the body led to novel gender distinctions in the area of sexual dysfunction, and the term 'impotence' was adopted for male sexual incapacity.⁵⁰ Though men were understood to be responsible sometimes for the failure to conceive children, barrenness continued to be typically associated with women.⁵¹ The church courts did not offer assistance to those whose spouse encountered sexual difficulties after marriage when neither spouse had recourse to end their union in the eyes of canon law. Similarly barrenness was not a ground for nullity. Although procreation was one of the ends of marriage, along with mutual companionship, children were considered to be a providential blessing so that it was understood that some unions would be childless. The nature of providence changed over the period. In the Puritan mind barrenness was a divine punishment. In the eighteenth century, however, providence was the means by which Anglicans found solace in their inability to have children.⁵²

In effect it was non-consummation due to sexual dysfunction that was at issue; a marriage could be childless while still sexually active.⁵³ If a spouse could prove that their husband or wife was suffering from impotence or frigidity once the wedding occurred then s/he could seek an annulment of the union. In other words, marital sex was so essential to the function of marriage, that proving a partner's incapacity to engage in it from the wedding meant the marriage was voidable. The causes of a separation *a vinculo* were "impuberty, malformation, or frigidity," where the marriage itself was merely *void ab initio*, and the sentence of the court only declaratory of its being so'.⁵⁴ Following a sentence of nullification the couple could marry other spouses, and the wife had no claim to dower. Impuberty was defined as being married under the ages of consent. For impotency and frigidity the centrality of non-consummation in proving the case for annulment meant that impediment had to be demonstrated to have existed at marriage and be incurable. This explains the kind of evidence presented in annulment cases, such as that which came before London consistory court testifying that Charles Schutz 'in a sighing sobbing tone of voice' informed his wife on their wedding night in 1770 that he was unable to perform sexual intercourse. Clearly his wife needed to make a case that she was unaware until then of his impotency.⁵⁵ Acceptable proof included a certificate issued several years after marriage that a wife was a virgin, and a husband's confession to incapacity, or demonstrated by physical examination and medical witnesses.⁵⁶

Annulment cases were extremely rare, no doubt because they were so problematic to prove. In 1702 Elizabeth Tireman sought an annulment from her husband Samuel on account of his impotency. They were wed in Walmgate, York in 1696, and Elizabeth's libel alleged that she was still a virgin and was unable to have children due to Samuel's infirmity. Perhaps in order to strengthen her case she added the allegation that Samuel was cruel to her as a result of the problem. Samuel's personal response was to deny the allegation, claim he had carnal knowledge of his wife, but also allege Elizabeth's own physical problems and demand that Elizabeth's body be examined by older women and midwives.⁵⁷ In order to satisfy the need for the spouse's confession, Elizabeth's additional position stated that Samuel did not hide his impotency and had declared to various people that he had not had sex with his wife and was one of five in his family who had this condition. The deponents who

were called confirmed that Samuel was violent towards his wife and offered anecdotes which suggest that Samuel was not worried about his lack of virility. An upholsterer said that when he built a new bed for the Tiremans he advised Samuel to get his wife an heir in the bed. Samuel replied that he would do what he could, 'but he could not gett his Prick to stand'. Their servant alleged that on coming to York Samuel 'bought a watch and was to pay for it at the day of the birth of his first child or the day of his death at w[hi]ch he seemed very well pleased as tho' he had got a very good bargain'. Both deponents' comments suggest that masculinity and virility were equated, so it was surprising that Samuel was prepared to publicise his impotency and the degree of humour with which some of the stories were recounted. Certainly, the community in which he lived anticipated that married couples had active reproductive marital sex. The case was abandoned, the final entry in the Act Book in July 1703 stating 'Nil', perhaps due to the parties' reluctance or inability to establish physical proof of sexual incapacity.⁵⁸

Extra-Marital Sex: Adultery

Though outright policing of marriage was diminishing from the second half of the eighteenth century, the church courts increasingly became the forum for resolving marital conflict. Since marriage was the only legitimate site for sexual activity extra-marital sex was punished by the Church at the start of the period examined, as chapters one and three show. The church courts used office cases to prosecute people who committed adultery as well as fornication, punishing both with public penance. Prosecutions for adultery in church courts continued into the nineteenth century: in December 1803 Edward Greenwood, curate of Sowerby was presented to the York Chancery court by the chapel warden for 'the Heinous and Detestable Sin of Adultery with Jane Cochran the Wife of Thomas Cochran'. Greenwood was also alleged to be a drunkard and to neglect his duty, but his fathering of a child with Jane Cochran was more than the warden could bear.⁵⁹ Increasingly, however, as active presentment of adultery waned, the church courts became the venue for litigants seeking separation on the grounds of adultery and cruelty. It was thus through separation *a mensa et thoro* that ecclesiastical authorities continued to play a part in monitoring marital sex. Sexual fidelity was essential in the eyes of the Church. No better evidence for

this exists than the Seventh Commandment which instructs 'Thou shalt not commit adultery'.⁶⁰ David Turner argues that this exhortation had far-reaching application in eighteenth-century society. It had extensive meaning, in the first place, because adultery was understood to damage marriage, the building block of stable society. Nonetheless, for commentators adultery signified a worrying absence of basic religious and moral decency. Philogamus's *The Present State of Matrimony: Or the Real Causes of Conjugal Infidelity and Unhappy Marriages* (1739) stated: 'The first, and more general cause of Lewdness, is the want of Religion, and the Decay of Christian Piety'.⁶¹ The activities included within the commandment against adultery could be extensive. Gabriel Towerson, explaining the Ten Commandments, commented that adultery was not only 'the violation of the marriage bed' but in addition included 'all Deviations from the Institution of Marriage, such as Fornication and Concubinary'.⁶²

Just as the Seventh Commandment made no distinctions between men and women, the ecclesiastical authorities expected married men to adhere to the same standard of conjugal fidelity as women, presenting both sexes for adultery. Thus in adultery cases, the application of a double standard in the treatment of sexual offenders was only partial. It is true that separation suits for adultery tended to be brought by men, nevertheless, wives also alleged their husbands' infidelity alongside other marital offences in cruelty separations.⁶³ Evidence from adultery separation cases litigated at the London consistory court and the Court of Arches suggests that some wives accused of adultery also brought counter defences of cruelty and adultery against their husbands which helped them obtain alimony.⁶⁴ In 1701, Dorothy Cunliffe mounted a fairly comprehensive defence against her husband's separation suit against her. Not only did she allege his cruelty, she said he lived a lewd life and was adulterous, claiming he solicited his maids to lie with him and when they refused he tried to force them.⁶⁵ In such cases it is evident that husbands' sexual culpability was important and their sexual reputation deemed relevant to the decision-making process.

Attitudes towards adultery changed over the long eighteenth century. In parallel with the church courts moving from tackling adultery through regulation to facilitating couples' attempts to separate, the 'unity of moral vision' broke down and adultery was increasingly seen as an offence against civil society rather than simply a sin.⁶⁶ There is no

doubt that a discourse of sin coloured responses to infidelity in the early part of the period. According to the testimony he gave to the York church court in 1701, Richard Paper, a fifty-one-year-old gardener and public house keeper in Newton, Wakefield, reprimanded John Whealey for spending the night locked in a chamber with Dorothy Cunliffe, mentioned above, telling him 'what a Shame and Sin it was to lye with other women's wives and beg him gett one of his owne and live honestly'.⁶⁷ The change is evident in the altering vocabulary of adultery. Euphemistic 'refined' language like 'criminal conversation' and 'gallantry' replaced that of whoredom, 'dirt' and 'uncleanness'.⁶⁸ Yet, neither the 'criminal' vocabulary nor the scriptural underpinnings of objections to adultery disappeared in the long eighteenth century. Even the name of criminal conversation cases, the civil law suit used to claim financial damages from a wife's lover, retained this meaning. Generally, religion remained a fundamental reason given for avoiding adultery. Its framework continued to structure the separation cases for adultery that came before the church courts until the Matrimonial Causes Act of 1857. The standard formula in adultery separation libels throughout this period was to accuse the defendant of committing the 'foul crime or sin of adultery'.⁶⁹ Typical was William Chaworth's libel in his separation suit in 1760, which stated that his wife Alice was 'unmindfull of her conjugal vow and seduced by the Devil and her own wicked lusts and inclinations' to commit the 'foul crime of adultery'.⁷⁰

An Humble Attempt to Form a System of Conjugal Morality, published in 1787, was organised in a series of sermons. Sermon IV demanded that adulterers deserved a more severe sentence than delivered in modern 'bills of divorcement'. The author denounced adultery as a vice 'which, if not repented of, will certainly exclude from the Kingdom of God' and advised that calling adultery 'gallantry' was breaking the rules of decency and virtue.⁷¹ Religious language shaped more than the sermons couples heard in church or read at home. For instance, demands in the more sentimental conduct books of the mid-eighteenth century for female chastity as both a marker of femininity and preserver of marriages were rooted in biblical teaching, if somewhat softened by the language of enlightened sensibility. In his *Letter of Advice to genteel young women* (1740), the Reverend Wetenhall Wilkes, mentioned earlier, explained that virgins and widows were to practise abstinence and wives continence, for:

Shame is the eldest daughter of a defiled female. The appetites of lust are full of care, and the fruition is folly and repentance. "The ways of the adulterer is hedged with thorns". "Know ye not (says St Paul) that your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost?" This makes the defiling of it the more dangerous; but, as to the actual breach of this lovely virtue, forbid in the seventh commandment, it is, in its own nature, so vile . . . that I shall not take up your time, with a dissertation on a vice, so opposite to your temper, and so much below your thoughts.⁷²

The language of evangelicals calling for an end to aristocratic vice and adultery from the 1790s onwards was also as profoundly religious as any condemnations of one hundred years earlier.

Sexual Violence within Marriage

The church courts heard fairly graphic accounts of illicit sexuality in adultery separation cases, because they allowed circumstantial evidence to be brought before them. Thus court personnel and, by the end of the century, readers of published trials for separation, encountered descriptions of couples' disarrayed clothing, semen stains on bed-linen and dresses, heavy breathing and creaks emanating from locked parlours, curtained beds, and barns, and glimpses of bare legs and buttocks.⁷³ The courts seemed far less inclined to hear about marital sex as a form of violence, however. Canon law did not include acts of sex within its definition of the grounds of cruelty, in part because such definitions were fairly vague; indeed the law did not recognise that a man could rape his wife because the marriage contract stated the right of spouses to sex with each other. Generally, the legal definition of cruelty was understood to indicate the point at which discipline became abuse, and since sexual acts were not seen as a form of correction there was little concept that they could be a form of violence.

Nonetheless, although the evidence that couples presented to the church courts did not describe detailed sexual violence, some forms of sexual activity were deemed abusive, including coerced sex during a wife's pregnancy, and anal sex. There are also hints that sex could be seen as causing violence. In a number of cases, arguments and physical fights were described as originating in bed chambers, frequently at night.⁷⁴

The cruelty separation cases that the courts heard included a range of types of abuse as well as life-threatening violence, including threats that made it difficult for a woman to carry on her normal life, physical violence, and confinement in or outside the home. Cruelty libels often included acts of disrespect such as sexual insult; a vocabulary of whores and rogues which was the same as that fought over in defamation cases themselves influenced by the church's regulation of illicit sex.⁷⁵ Thus in 1696, Anne Shaw was accused of calling her husband Robert a 'Whoremasterly Beggary Rogue'.⁷⁶ In 1704, the wife of John Greaves, the mayor of Beverley, listed his insults in her libel seeking separation due to his cruelty and adultery: whore, bitch, and jade.⁷⁷ Even more specifically, Esther Bowes's cruelty libel stated that Jonathan Bowes beat her 'Calling her by Sev[er]all Unchristian and Reproachfull Names as Whore, Whitch [sic], Bitch'.⁷⁸ Although preventing a wife from governing her own household and economic neglect were also frequently alleged, it is less clear whether the act of withdrawing from the marital bed was considered as a similar form of abuse. It must have been discussed since Phillimore noted in Burn's *Ecclesiastical Law* in 1842 that 'The husband taking to a separate bed is not pleadable as cruelty'.⁷⁹

Furthermore, though not specified in canon law, the church courts seem to have accepted that a husband committing adultery was a form of abuse. In 1687 the Durham consistory court accepted Anne Fletcher's libel alleging her husband's cruelty, which stated that in order to grievously 'disturb, or disquiet and vex the minde of' Anne, her husband had several times bragged to her that he lay with Jane Snawdon and would keep, love, and maintain Jane as long as he lived.⁸⁰ Phillimore was vehement in 1842 that a husband's 'attempt to debauch his own women servants is a strong act of cruelty'.⁸¹ Defining adultery with female servants as cruelty related to the practice of wives alleging that their husbands elevated their servants over them, thereby undermining wives' household authority. Engaging in sex with household servants was a further abuse and cruel inversion of a wife's status.

A man's use of prostitutes was considered a particularly heinous version of adultery and was sometimes included in cruelty separation cases. In 1803, Margaret Lees sued her husband, James, a cotton factory owner in Manchester, detailing his physical violence against her and sometimes their young children in articles five to ten of her claim. The remaining articles alleged that James Lees led a vicious, lewd,

debauched life throughout their marriage, 'by carnally knowing diverse prostitutes and women of loose character'. A further claim was that he committed adultery with Ann Dimello, the wife of a volunteer militiaman, who he took to a house of ill-fame. Moreover on 23 June 1800, after the dissolution of his business partnership with Thomas Gillebrand, James visited 'a house of ill fame' where he stayed for two hours having carnal knowledge of one of the 'lewd women' there, before visiting a woman of loose character at her home. James said little in his defence other than to attack the reputation of the women who were brought as deponents, as well as accusing Margaret's lawyer of telling her to get a prostitute to commit adultery with James so that she could get her 'divorce'.⁸²

Of course, men's adultery had a very physical risk for their wives: since it could infect them with venereal disease. Although Margaret Lees's libel did not spell out the connection with venereal disease, one of her deponents did. Mary Ball, the Lees's servant from 1800 to 1802, explained that Margaret suffered continual verbal and physical abuse and slept separately from James, because she was 'afraid to sleep with her Husband for fear of catching any bad disorder from him that her Children were troubled with sore Eyes which she attributed to her Husband's going amongst bad Women'.⁸³ There is no sentence for the suit, though it is likely it was in Margaret's favour given that James appealed against it from Chester consistory court to York where in May 1806 the final entry in the act book stated 'Let it stand'.⁸⁴

The extent to which a husband who infected his wife with venereal disease was deemed as cruel by the church courts is, however, uncertain in the long eighteenth century. It was not discussed in Burn's *Ecclesiastical Law*, until Phillimore's edition of 1842 in which several pages were devoted to establishing what cruel behaviour was. By this point, Lord Stowell's judgements on what constituted cruelty at the turn of the nineteenth century had an impact on clarifying forms of abuse. Venereal disease remained ambiguous nonetheless. Phillimore offered his view that 'The husband's attempt, when infected with the venereal disease, to force his wife to his bed, is of a mixed nature, partly cruelty, partly adultery'. Here venereal disease continued to function more as proof of a husband's adultery than a form of cruelty in itself. As a judge, Phillimore had previously ruled in a separation suit brought by a Mrs Belcher against her husband, who had infected her with venereal disease every

time he returned home from his station on the West Coast of Africa. Phillimore decided the disease was accidentally and involuntarily communicated because it had been contracted before marriage and was not indicative of adultery and could not therefore constitute cruelty.⁸⁵ Indeed, it was only in cases heard by the Victorian divorce courts that precedents were laid down in which it was decided that husbands' communication of venereal disease to their wives was 'wilful', or intentional, and thus counted as cruelty.⁸⁶

For all that canon law did not clarify the issue and the church courts only entertained it as a context of dangerous marital behaviour, it is clear that husbands deployed the communication of venereal disease as a form of violence and wives perceived it thus. In the 1701 Cunliffe case, mentioned earlier, Dorothy counter-accused her husband of cruelty when he brought a suit against her in York consistory court accusing her of adultery. Listing his jealous outbursts of violence against her in front of their children and his beating her on her back with his cane on a journey from Barnsley to Staincross Moor, she also claimed he had turned her out of the house and enquired for a whore that was infected with venereal disease and swore that he would get clap on purpose that he 'might clapt [sic] his ... wife as soon as she returned'.⁸⁷ The fact that the proctors retained this complaint in the libel suggests that the church courts were prepared to consider this as a form of abuse, or at least as indicating the husband as abusive. After all, if life-threatening violence was defined as cruelty, then some sexually transmitted infections could lead to death.

Likewise, in 1793, Betty Rogers sued her husband, William, a clothier of Holbeck, Yorkshire, for separation, citing his numerous acts of violence since their marriage in 1784. The seventh article stated that in 1790 William returned from a visit of several weeks to Scarborough and:

infected the said Betty Rogers with the Venereal Disease which from her absolute Ignorance of the Disease took a deep hold upon her Constitution and remained upon her till her Life was dispaired [sic] of and so weakend and debilitated her frame that she hath never since been able to get restored to her perfect health.

Betty's proctor saw the long-term repercussions of the infection as sufficient to be included in her formal evidence presented to the court for

consideration. The court certainly retained the article in the libel. Although there is no sentence, the Act Book records that the case was 'agreed' in March 1794.⁸⁸

The Role of Religion and Piety in Making and Breaking Marriages

Moralists were not exaggerating when they advised people to seek a marriage partner with whom they shared parity in status, means, and religion. Despite ignoring the latter for too long, historians are now uncovering evidence that indicates that individuals considered religion, especially denomination, life style, and piety, as factors which made and broke marriages. Quakers who married non-Quakers had to leave the Society of Friends. More broadly, people took account of denominational niceties during courtship and sought to resolve potential differences before committing themselves to a prospective spouse. This is as true in the later part of the long eighteenth century as the start. Steve King's analysis of David Whitehead and Betty Wood's courtship shows how central religion was to selecting a suitable partner and to sustaining the courtship through to the wedding. David's autobiography and the couple's correspondence survive, providing insights into their motivation for marriage. David Whitehead, a partner in a very successful cotton manufacturing business in Lancashire, began officially courting Betty in 1817 when he was 27 and she was nearly a decade younger. David prioritised having a 'pious woman for my wife' over other considerations.⁸⁹ David asked Betty to marry him by letter in December 1817 and used entirely religious vocabulary:

I take you to be one of God's dear children which I do prefer before any other in the Kingdom ... We ought to pray to God for directions; and may you and I pray God that if it be for our present and eternal welfare to be married together, that it may be forwarded. And if He sees that it will not be for our good, that it may be by Him frustrated ... I have no doubt but that God, who made us, will join us together in holy matrimony.⁹⁰

Betty's polite postponement of David's proposal because of her youth observed that her stage of life was,

The most favourable time for the growth of religion in the soul. And to get married when so very young seems to me as if it was cropping it in the bud . . . I think the single state is the best time to get Grace, and the married one to try it.⁹¹

Their relationship continued nonetheless and in February 1818 they were both reading John Wesley's advice on marriage. By April, David had asked Betty's father to agree to the marriage of his daughter. He assured Mr Wood that he and Betty 'think it is the will of God for us to be partners in life. Prayers have been offered unto God on that account, and we think nothing has been done without His approbation.' They were married in July 1818. The importance of such religious sensibilities to marriage are too often overlooked, as King points out, and was not mere rhetoric. Spiritual compatibility was critical in making and sustaining marriage. David ended his autobiography in December 1850 by describing how much he valued his thirty-two year', marriage to a woman whose 'chief delight is the salvation of immortal souls'.⁹²

Religion could also play a contentious role in the marital relationship as revealed in Lady Sarah Cowper's diaries. Sarah and William Cowper wed in 1664 and according to Sarah's diary, begun in 1700, were very unhappily married. Sarah nursed numerous resentments against her husband, some of which stemmed from her faith. Sarah was a moderate Anglican, but according to her reports of quarrels with William, her rather conscious piety irritated him considerably.⁹³ Sarah was striking in her capacity to re-interpret the moral and religious dictates on marriage that she encountered in conduct literature and religious practice. Indeed, as Anne Kugler comments, 'it is in the sexual arena of her marriage that the most drastic of Sarah's reinterpretations of standard doctrine took place.' For example, Sarah took 'chastity' to mean sexual abstinence within marriage rather than avoiding adultery. In reconstructing Protestant doctrine that promoted marital sex and procreation, and disparaged celibacy as a state, it may even be that Sarah was justifying family limitation practices since her 'chastity' began after her fourth son and final child was born.⁹⁴

Denominational differences caused contention between couples after marriage. This is not particularly evident in church court separation cases since it was not relevant to the grounds for separation. However, it

occasionally appears in background detail. A rare cruelty separation case from 1719 reveals the significant role religion played in Zachariah and Anne More's marriage. Both were Catholic at marriage, Zachariah in possession of a manor at Loftus and owner of an alum works in the diocese of York. After a dozen years of marriage, Anne sued Zachariah for cruelty, alleging he had given her 'French Pox' soon after marriage, which she continued to have for several years being unaware of what it was. Zachariah concealed his 'wickedness,' she claimed, by telling her she had worms and had his physician make up a medicine for this, which she discovered was mercury, the treatment for venereal disease. Anne claimed that she asked another physician and apothecary for their opinion of this 'receipt' and they declared the mercury was strong enough to have killed her. Anne's allegation was that Zachariah was trying to poison her because she had returned to Protestantism. Anne was raised in the Church of England until she was around thirteen years old when, she claimed, she was 'unhappily seduced' by a family member to the principles of the Church of Rome. She married when she was a practising Catholic but had returned to Anglicanism and reconciled their daughter to the same. She accused Zachary of being a 'Bigotted Papist' and thus grieved by this and trying to prevent it. On a further occasion she alleged he tried to poison her by giving her wine while at supper with a Catholic priest. She sought the help of Mr Hawkins, Anglican incumbent of the parish, telling him that she was being poisoned for leaving the Church of Rome; and Zachariah, she claimed, prevented Hawkins from visiting, warning her that if he came again Zachariah would take their children from her.

Zachariah denied the accusations. He said he had treated Anne well, although admitted he had sometimes blamed her for her ill conduct abroad and in affairs of her family due to her 'disobliging, proud, passionate, haughty, cholerick temper, [and being] a great humourist and frequently uneasy by unnecessary disputes and quarrels in her family'. Moreover he claimed she used strong liquors which disordered her brain and led her to think he was poisoning her. Indeed, he was advised by three London physicians that the alleged 'French disease' was in fact a tumour of her tongue and that they had even certified that the distemper was not French Pox, although she had stolen these papers.⁹⁵ The witnesses largely supported Zachary's account of Anne as a very mentally distressed woman who had symptoms of a digestive and

gynaecological origin. Six London physicians, surgeons, and a pharmacist, and two Durham doctors gave evidence about her symptoms. Intriguingly, perhaps the most eminent, Hans Sloane, testified that on his first consultation he did not think her distemper to be venereal but considered it might lead to a cancer in the womb. On his second visit to her in London, however, he found her ulcerated in her mouth or throat which he thought might come from a venereal disease and advised a mercury method of treatment. The other London medical witnesses however did not know what caused the distemper.⁹⁶

Zachariah also rejected his wife's accusations about Mr Hawkins. In fact he asked Hawkins to visit his wife to pray with her and the parson warned him that Anne was so disordered in her head that he should get proper keepers for her. Indeed it was only in her illness that Anne sought out the Protestant faith and he had never obstructed this.⁹⁷ Perhaps the failed Jacobite rebellion, four years earlier, had exaggerated anti-Catholic feeling, and were expressed in Anne's attitudes towards Zacariah. However, almost none of the witnesses represented him in inflammatory terms. Indeed, while those outside the family were sceptical of Anne's accusations, it was only Zacariah's eighteen-year-old married niece, Elizabeth Scraston, of Broughton, who deposed that he was cross and harsh towards his wife. She recalled Anne telling her that she had been 'poisoned on the account of Religion,' which she had said was very common in Portugal. Elizabeth's statement was contradictory since she said she believed Anne's accusations of being poisoned were due to lack of sleep, but then went on to say that she did believe Zachariah attempted to poison Anne by Zachariah because he was 'a Bigotted Roman Catholick'.⁹⁸ Elizabeth clearly resented her uncle, since she also claimed that while she lived with him he had tried to get her to be a Roman Catholic and go beyond the sea, and that she did not dare to go to the parish church in Lofthouse [Loftus] for fear of him.⁹⁹ Nonetheless, given the weight of testimony against her, Anne did not prove her case and a sentence in favour of Zacariah was issued in 1720, followed by Anne's appeal to the Court of Delegates. Religion and sex were clearly at the heart of the couple's differences, wherever the truth lay about Zachariah's treatment of his wife.

Autobiographies and family correspondence also hint that religion could exacerbate marital conflict even when the doctrinal differences were less striking. Thomas Wright married Lydia Birkhead in 1766, eloping

with her to Gretna Green in Scotland, where different marriage laws applied, in order to circumvent her parents' disapproval. This may have been partly religious, though it was Thomas who told his story in his memoir so only his perspective survives. Even so, he attributed much of the conflict between him and his wife and her parents in religious terms. He repeatedly contrasted his Methodism with the Birkheads' Calvinism, distinguishing between his espousal of 'the doctrine of Free-agency and Universal Redemption' and their strict Calvinism. The Arminian-Calvinist split in Methodism was growing from the mid-eighteenth century, and perhaps made the rift more significant. Thomas also believed the denominational differences led to his wife's inferior upbringing, their incompatibility, and his parents-in-laws' many wrongs.¹⁰⁰

Conclusion

Throughout the long eighteenth century, and regardless of denomination, religion was fundamental to people's ideas about marriage. A partner's religious views might be considered in courtship and it was recognised that religious differences could seriously weaken marriage. For most couples, the Church of England exercised a monopoly on marriage, despite anxieties about Fleet and clandestine marriages in the period leading to Hardwicke's Marriage Act in 1753. The majority of couples only felt properly married when the ceremony was celebrated by an Anglican priest and used sermons and conduct advice, frequently penned by clergymen, for guidance on appropriate behaviour during wedlock. Those who suffered serious marital conflict often turned to their local parson for mediation and the church courts remained the last resort to address failed unions. It was only in 1837 that the bonds connecting marriage and the Church began to be weakened with the Civil Registration Act which enabled couples to be married before a civil registrar instead of a clergyman and twenty years later when specialised courts were introduced to hear couples seeking divorce and separation.

The next chapter continues the focus on the Church's relationship with the institution of marriage by examining evangelical views. It demonstrates that evangelicals' attitudes towards sexual behaviour, marriage, and family, were critical to public reception and acceptance of this hotter form of faith.

CHAPTER 5

EVANGELICALS, SEX, AND RESPECTABILITY

Sexuality, marriage, family, and gender were central to the changing ideas of evangelicals during the long eighteenth century. The term 'evangelical' is a slippery one which obscures as much as it reveals since evangelicalism was marked by heterogeneity, encompassing Anglicans and Nonconformists and theological divisions, covering the spectrum from moderate to extreme, and doctrines such as Arminianism and Calvinism. Moreover evangelicalism differed over time, with distinct phases in its development in this period.¹ Nonetheless there were common features of evangelicalism which underpinned this diversity and merit collective investigation here. For many evangelicals, humans were born in a state of Original Sin, the consequence of the Fall, and life was a state of trial. As has been seen in chapter one, ideas of Original Sin were declining in the eighteenth century, but nevertheless they were prevalent in evangelicalism for longer, although many evangelicals found that Original Sin was less relevant in a world in which sin entailed choice. For the moderate evangelical, good works were important as signs of redemption, though grace, faith, and repentance of sins preceded them.² Evangelicals derived doctrinal authority from the Bible, were convinced that Providence played an active part in the world, and that the Holy Spirit directed their feelings and thoughts. Miracles and divine revelation were a vital part of their religious landscape. A personal sense of conversion gave assurance of salvation and was a stimulus to urge others to come to God. Considerable stress was thus laid upon the

sinner's individual conscience and personal conversion experience with an often deeply emotional understanding of innate sinfulness. Consequently, the inner life and emotions were a focus as individuals grappled with self-knowledge and attempted to remake themselves into 'saints'. Another shared quality of evangelicals, therefore, was the fervent nature of their piety.

There were two major waves of evangelicalism in the long eighteenth century. The first dated from the 1730s, when John Wesley and George Whitefield spearheaded a period of conversion and 'vital' religion, and the second emerged in the 1770s, by which point Anglican evangelicalism was more institutionalised. The period of acute national crisis in the 1780–90s ushered in a very active evangelical movement headed by laymen and women like William Wilberforce and Hannah More. Although Nonconformists were also swept up in the evangelical tides, this chapter focuses principally on those who emerged from within the established church.³ It specifically proposes that a shift occurred over the period in the relationship between society, evangelicalism, and sex and gender. In the earlier period, evangelicals such as Wesley and Whitefield were conceptualised as a threat to social and familial order, with widespread allegations of illicit sexuality, the destruction of family life, and disruption of gender conventions. By the later period, however, evangelicals espoused a rhetoric which placed them at the centre of familial, gender, and therefore social order. Indeed arguably in the period 1780s to 1840s the relationship between evangelicals, sexual morals and respectability came to define and distinguish middle-class culture.⁴

Evangelicals and Sexuality

Early scholars saw the evangelical movement, and especially Methodism, as highly sexualised. Max Weber, for example, noted that sexual repression and fear of erotic temptations were important ingredients in Puritanism and prompts for spirituality for eighteenth-century evangelicals.⁵ In *Evangelical Conversion in Great Britain 1696–1845* (1959) Bullock also identified 'the influence of sex' as one of the impulses to religious conversion. For Bullock, Ignatius Loyola's 'failure to find satisfaction in the normal sexual relationship,' for example, caused the

transfer of 'the love sentiment to an ardent devotion to religion.' Bullock saw sex as an element in the conversions of, among others, John Wesley, John Newton, and William Huntington.⁶

Contemporaries certainly linked enthusiastic and ecstatic religion with sex in order to attack religious groups. Samuel Keimer denounced the highly sexualised behaviour of the 'French Prophets', a group of émigré Frenchmen and women who practised 'enthusiastic', ecstatic religion in London between 1706 and 1730. The fact that women played an important role in prophecy and as followers of the movement spurred on accusations against them. Keimer's *Brand Pluck'd From the Burning* (1718) claimed that 'prophets' would kiss and tickle their women followers. He also made more serious accusations: a butcher was ordered to 'lie carnally' with a woman follower; another woman was told to kiss all the men at a meeting. A follower, Elizabeth Grey, apparently impersonated the Whore of Babylon by stripping naked and posing indecently on the altar of the Duke Street Catholic chapel in November 1707. In another episode there was a display of lesbian behaviour when one woman touched the body of another in an attempt to indicate that the imminent punishment of sinners was at hand. Perhaps the most graphic account was of Dorothy Harling, also known as 'Permanent Spring', who whipped male spectators with a lash with pins attached and then lifted her skirts to expose herself, shouting 'Christ come in,' and finally urinated on the wounds she had inflicted on the men she had whipped.⁷ These revelations aimed to show the unacceptability of such religious groups. Alongside their religious behaviour which broke acceptable bounds, orgies and sexual transgression represented their unorthodox theology. The 'French Prophets' were both lionised and denounced by Anglican churchmen and the memory of their activities lasted long into the eighteenth century. As late as 1742, Charles Chauncey published a *Wonderful Account* of the episode, and John Wesley denounced them for their behaviour. While the eighteenth century was an era in which the miraculous still played a powerful role in people's religious ideas, it was also one in which credulity could be manipulated for specific ends.⁸

Methodism and Sex

The most controversial analysis of the role of sex in evangelicalism is associated with Methodism, notably Edward Thompson's *Making of*

the English Working Class. Thompson described Methodist expressions of ecstatic faith as 'Sabbath orgasms' and the worship of Christ as 'necrophily'; he noted the way in which one convert identified Satan with the phallus, and also claimed that Methodist hymns were a form of sublimation of sex into desire for the crucified Christ.⁹ John Wesley, like some other churchmen, certainly used the imagery of the bridegroom and the husband for the Church, faith, and God. For women this analogised faith to sexual consummation and for men it hinted at homoerotic bonds. It also represented faith as feminised and delicate, which could be interpreted as denying masculine qualities. In later life, Wesley decided that what he called 'fondling words' of Methodism created a wrong impression and that there was a danger in a feminised Christ.¹⁰ Methodism was also highly gendered: David Hempton has claimed that 'Methodism was predominantly a women's movement'; though principally led by men.¹¹ One account of Wesley and Whitefield's gatherings described them as 'crowded with young women enquiring about their sensation' and even older women were 'coquetting in a song-of-Solomon way with these illustrious fathers.'¹² Wesley was clearly drawn to accounts of women's religious lives and in his narratives of religious conversions their experiences significantly outnumber those of men. In his diary there are four times more references to women than to men. This emphasis on women's religion meant that when, in 1740, the Fetter Lane Society split, most of the women in the Society left with Wesley, which has been ascribed to his sexual attractiveness to them.¹³

Methodism stereotyped women; in the same way that conversion narratives became convergent and normative, so did the ways in which women were depicted. Phyllis Mack has identified three evangelical female stereotypes, all of which related to marital status and sexual activity: the 'fallen woman redeemed by faith', such as Sarah Ryan who was a 'slave' to sex but became a confidante of Mary Bosanquet, John Fletcher, and also John Wesley; the 'ardent virgin' who was passionate and chaste in her faith; and the 'venerable mother in Israel' who was often an older widow who supported the movement financially.¹⁴ For some commentators, therefore, the appeal of the movement to women was threatening. The author of the poem 'The Field Preacher' wrote of a Methodist who formed a following of

Women following him good store,
With great guilt Bibles to turn o'er ...',

which suggested that women were inveigled into giving money to preachers 'and what their husbands earn, to spend on't.'¹⁵ To critics, if women could be persuaded into giving preachers their money, they could be seduced into worse things. Such a strong female constituency was an indication of why Methodism appeared to some to be unacceptable; it did not endorse the prevailing ideas of masculinity and patriarchy. The Toleration Act of 1689 had gradually promoted the idea of voluntary religion, but it had not been envisaged that women would be able to choose which religious group to join separately from their husbands.

Moreover, Methodism was a form of Christianity that emphasised emotion, desire, feeling, urgency, and sensation. It used the language of sex: heat, blood, and flesh to evoke the immediacy of spiritual experience. Both Whitefield and Wesley spoke in the language of the desire, pain, fulfilment of conversion, and also of the sense of being overwhelmed by God.¹⁶ Whitefield's hell fire sermons were especially erotic in their overtones. In response, the ecstatic behaviour of some of Whitefield's congregations was unambiguously erotic with orgasmic overtones: swooning, convulsing, shuddering, moaning, and weeping.¹⁷ Whitefield's sermon, *Christ the Best Husband*, which was preached to a Society of Young Women in Fetter Lane and which was often published with the subtitle 'Or an Earnest Invitation to Young Women to Come and See Christ', is an example of the sexually-charged imagery that he employed. If Christ was the husband, the young women were by implication brides. Whitefield urged them that 'in other loves' coyness was becoming, but that in the case of embracing Christ it was folly and he asked them to abandon 'modesty and the virgin blush.' He spoke of Christ's looks as 'ravishing' and his smiles as 'delightful.' By emphasising such physical attributes, Whitefield, suggests McInelly, depicted Christ as the 'perfect lover' and created a 'sexualised spirituality'. By addressing women exclusively, there was also a suggestion of preying on their sensibilities.¹⁸ In time, even John Wesley became concerned at Whitefield's 'amorous way of praying to Christ' and his 'luscious' preaching.¹⁹

As a consequence, Whitefield was accused of lustfulness; the author of *The Amorous Humours and Audacious Adventures of One Wh____d* described in crude terms a Methodist love feast at which Whitefield was able to observe a 'youthful Creature's lily Breast.'²⁰ George Whitefield himself was described as of 'almost hermaphroditic attractiveness, the combination of the masculine and feminine', when, as a young preacher travelling in America, one observer claimed he looked like an angel: slim, white and smiling.²¹ Whitefield's squint furthered implied a lustful nature, since in the eighteenth century a squint was seen as a physical sign of lasciviousness; a claim that also attached itself a generation later to the cross-eyed John Wilkes who certainly lived up to the reputation.²² Charges included same-sex desires. William Seward, a follower of Whitefield, who travelled with him to America in 1739, observed that he was close to John Symms with whom he shared a cabin and a bed during the voyage. There was nothing unusual in this, but Seward went on to write of Symms's relationship with Whitefield that he was: 'like the beloved Disciple lieth always in his Bosom and is as Dear to him as his own Soul.'²³

McInelly makes the point that contemporary authors saw conversion and 'new birth' as highly sexualised and implying penetration.²⁴



Figure 5 John Wesley and the Mob at Wendesbury, c. 1743, unknown artist. This suggests some of the opposition that Wesley faced. By Permission, Oxford Centre for Methodism and Church History.

Contemporaries also linked Methodism with sex more broadly; for instance, anti-Methodist riots sometimes led to sexualised treatment of women. In such a riot in Exeter in 1745 women Methodists were stripped naked and rolled in the gutter and their faces smeared with lamp-black.²⁵ John Wesley's tendency to experiment in the esoteric could raise unwelcome associations with sexual activities. An example was Wesley's use of electricity as a cure for various maladies. He had championed the use of electricity in a 1760 tract called *The Desideratum: Or, Electricity Made Plain and Useful*, which recounted his own use of the phenomenon in medical treatment. Wesley regarded electrical shock treatment as 'the desideratum, the general and rarely failing remedy in nervous cases of every kind.'²⁶ Accordingly he set up a clinic to administer electrical treatment to those who presented themselves with a wide range of symptoms and the speed with which he expanded the clinic from an hour a week, to an hour a day and then all day at four rooms in London (at Southwark, St Pauls, Seven Dials and the Foundery) suggests that it was hugely popular. Wesley applied electric shocks to all types of maladies from headaches and epilepsy to stuttering; many patients were women suffering from hysteria, difficulties in swallowing, headaches, rheumatism and 'knots in the flesh.'²⁷ While Wesley made no claim that electricity was a treatment for sexual disorders, electricity was closely linked with sexuality. The satirical poem *The Electric Eel* of 1777 was not just poetic pornography but one which showed how electrical charges could be used for sexual stimulation.²⁸ Similarly Dr James Graham used electricity to treat sexual dysfunction in his 'celestial bed.'²⁹ And Robert Middleton's etching, *Galvanism in Picadilly* of 1800, showed a man receiving electrical stimulation to revive his libido and, spotting a young woman from his window, planning to run after her.³⁰ Certainly a significant proportion of the patients treated in Wesley's electrical therapy rooms were women, and the single largest group sought treatment for 'hysterias' as well as headaches and stomach pains.³¹

Such mixing of the medical and therapeutic with the religious was a potent formula. It was perhaps the reason why some people sought to be touched by John Wesley. One woman follower wanted him to touch her cheek to cure her headaches, and when Wesley did so, she claimed to be perfectly cured. Since Wesley himself believed in the efficacy of the royal touch for scrofula, his use of thaumaturgical acts in medicine is perhaps

not surprising. But the use of sparks and touch to cure women seemed to have overtones of sexuality. The author of *Perfection* satirised Wesley's electric treatment and regarded it as a sexual cure:

And if, perchance, th' electric Force they feel,
Another Glance they do not take but steal:
With thy Perfection arm'd, in that they trust
They peep and peep again, but never lust.³²

It is unsurprising therefore that attacks on Methodist morality and sexuality were made. There is a danger, however, of reading too much into such evidence. Phyllis Mack observes that, relative to other denominations, there is little evidence that Methodism was more prone to erotic imagery and language, pointing to the Quakers and the hymns of Isaac Watts as equally charged. She also asserts that 'it is in [the] context of apostolic ambition, not that of sexual neurosis, that we should view Wesley's concern for excessively emotional language.'³³ John Wesley may have been 'emotionally needy' but that does not mean he was sexually exploitative. Nor was ecstatic behaviour an expression of sexual frustration.

It is, in fact, more useful to ask why contemporaries were so concerned about the sexual proclivities of John Wesley and Methodists more generally. Crucially, Methodist opponents deployed accusations of immorality as a weapon against the movement. Methodism could be divisive in both religious and civil society and those who sought to blacken and attack Methodism did so with any means at their disposal. Methodists were attacked as both fellow travellers with Protestant Dissent and as crypto-Catholics and with political principles as disparate as Jacobitism and Fifth Monarchism. Its leading figures were often suspected. Charles Wesley was accused of a sexual relationship with a prostitute in 1744 by a vengeful Methodist whose ordination he had blocked. Four years later the prostitute recanted her account of the event and Charles Wesley was shown to be innocent. But the episode indicated how vulnerable clergy in general, and Methodists in particular, were to this sort of accusation.³⁴ Indeed, preachers were often accused of illicit behaviour. Adversaries such as Bishop Lavington were swift to point out that Methodist preachers sometimes ran off with women and that there was something sinister in the emphatic appearance of sexuality in Methodist activity.³⁵

Using sexual immorality as a weapon was relatively easy since Methodist practice and vocabulary lent itself to sensationalism. Methodism developed an emphasis on spiritual intimacy as a mode of piety, in particular, the confession of sin and transgressions between converts. In the band meetings which Wesley established, small groups were told that they should begin by asking one another about their sins. There were standard questions to prompt this process: what sins had been committed since the last meeting, what temptations had they experienced, how had band members overcome temptations, what had they done that might have put them in a state of sin, and what did they wish to keep secret?³⁶ The last question was so problematic that it was dropped after a while, but even the others inevitably led some conversations into matters of vice and sex. In such an atmosphere men and women on occasion shared their sexual transgressions openly, and seemed drawn to the same sins; one Methodist noted that when he admitted his sins his fellow band members 'answered to mine as face to face in a glass.'³⁷ Outsiders became suspicious of this activity, Leigh Hunt claimed that love feasts, watch nights, and revivals were really opportunities for promiscuous sex.³⁸ Others, like John Ryland senior, who became a Methodist in 1741, used his diary as a confessional account of sins and misdeeds. In 1743, Ryland noted 'my heart is exceeding full of sin and darkness' and made promises for reform. Two years later he recorded that: 'my affections [are] very carnal and corrupt.'³⁹

Private and intimate conversations arose from Wesley's injunction that conversion required introspection. Methodists, like their Puritan forebears, were encouraged to record their experiences of faith and sin in journals, letters, and conversion narratives, which were shared and disseminated in print. Once the *Arminian Magazine* had been established in 1778, such narratives were widely published and became a recognised feature of Methodism. Horace Walpole wrote that 'the Methodists love your big sinners, as proper subjects to work upon – and indeed they have a plentiful harvest.'⁴⁰ Of course, elevating the sinfulness of the unconverted increased the divine achievement of the conversion experience and the efficacy of evangelicalism. Some found the revelation of sins inherently troubling because it had overtones of the priestly Catholic confessional; the author of *Perfection* commented:

Ye sons of Loyola, now say, with Tears
 Why Sisters shou'd confess their sins and Fears?
 Why ev'ry Weakness to a Knave reveal,
 Who keeps the Key that he may freely steal?⁴¹

Moreover, an atmosphere in which secrets were shared and sins were confessed was thought to breed intimacy and there were occasions in which divine and human love became confused. Kissing and touching sometimes led to the allegation of impropriety. In July 1781 in the London Calvinistic Methodist chapel of Lady Huntingdon's Connection, a Mr Browne and a Mrs Hanna, both married, were investigated because they seemed unduly familiar with one another. The investigation found that 'there did not appear to have been any criminal connection; but as their sitting together and going home together gave offence to several of the congregation, they were desired, and promised, to avoid the same in future.'⁴²

The concerns associated with conversion narratives were particularly strong in George Whitefield's publications. He opened himself to prurient speculation by publishing a journal in which he confessed that by the age of eighteen he had violated every one of the Ten Commandments. He later claimed to have been a sinner and to have been tempted by the devil to commit abominable secret sins. Consequently one poet claimed that 'Slovens and sluts are Christ's head-volunteers.'⁴³ Another response to Whitefield's journal drew attention to his sex life. *Genuine and Secret Memoirs, Relating to the Life and Adventures of that Anti-Methodist, Mr. G. W-f-i-d* (1742) claimed to be an account of Whitefield from first-hand knowledge of what people in Gloucester and Oxford had told its author.⁴⁴ The author placed great significance upon the report that Whitefield's mother had experienced serious problems with flatulence during and after her pregnancy with him. The author interpreted Whitefield's claim to have committed early acts of uncleanness as more likely to have been 'b-sh-tting' himself rather than 'groping his nurse.'⁴⁵ The author also examined Whitefield's recollection that he had 'evil communication' with his schoolfellows. By speculating on this reference, he cast slurs on Whitefield. He even questioned whether Whitefield had experienced a sexual relationship with his mother since Whitefield claimed to have slept on the floor in her room, but dismissed it because of his mother's 'unblemish'd

character'. The author considered whether the reference to uncleanness related to adultery, bestiality, or sodomy but in the end concluded it was most likely to refer to masturbation, in part because Whitefield was obviously still a virgin.⁴⁶

The author confirmed his suspicions by noting the double entendre in Whitefield's comment that 'the wicked one makes use of men as machines, working them up to just what he pleases.' Later, when Whitefield had joined the Holy Club at Oxford, the author emphasised his claim to have spent 'many sweet and delightful hours' in which the Club members 'kept their bodies under.' The author wrote that he could not believe that the members of the Holy Club practised mutual masturbation, though 'we have already sufficiently shown in what kind of entertainment Mr W-----d passed away his sweet and delightful hours.'⁴⁷ Later on, the *Genuine and Secret Memoirs* related information from Whitefield's college bedmaker:

Mr W-----d's uneasiness did not end here, for the Devil being his constant bedfellow at night; and the college beds of size only for a single person, there was a necessity for their lying one upon another: Satan always made choice of the upper station, which he occupied with much intolerable weight and pressure ... this his bed-maker divulged to me, among other secrets that she has frequently found the bedstead broken down: and the poor gentleman's shirt, as well as sheets, so dismally tinged from the violent suffusion of the Devil's sweat ...⁴⁸

The suggestion that the Devil lay on top of Whitefield, undoubtedly implied that he played the active role in their intercourse and further confirmed Whitefield's femininity.⁴⁹

Methodist Preachers, Sexual Scandals, and Itinerancy

Methodist preachers were especially open to suspicion about sexual misdemeanours. James Wheatley (an enormously successful evangelist in Wiltshire in 1751), Westley Hall (John Wesley's former student and brother-in-law),⁵⁰ and Roger Ball (who led Wesley's initiatives in Dublin) were all expelled from their societies for sleeping with women members. Hall even openly advocated polygamy. Abelow suggests that

this may have been the tip of the iceberg, if those expelled without stated reason were also because they had seduced women.⁵¹ The case of Wheatley, who had engaged in sexual misconduct with seven women, was particularly troubling because he claimed that he was only doing what other Methodist preachers did. In the wake of Wheatley's expulsion in 1751, Charles Wesley undertook an investigation and conducted a purge of other unsuitable preachers.⁵²

Other accounts of sexual scandal dogged evangelical preachers. The Welsh evangelical Howell Harris's marriage and reputation collapsed because of his relationship with another woman. Harris had married Anne Williams in 1744; four years later he met Mrs Sydney Griffiths, the wife of a drunken squire from whose house she fled to Trevecca in 1749 to live with the Harrises. Harris quickly fell under Sydney's spell, calling her his 'prophetess', his 'eye' and his 'light'. While his wife was ill, 'Madam Griffiths' accompanied Harris on preaching tours. There were accounts that Harris and Griffiths stayed up all night talking and Harris wrote in his diary of his wife's anxiety that he did not love her any more. When in Trevecca the household comprised the three of them, 'three cords in one' as Harris put it; Harris was clearly obsessed with Griffiths who he said had changed his life. In one of her prophetic moments Griffiths predicted that Anne Harris and her own husband would soon die, which sounded to some like wishful thinking. Harris's friends begged him to abandon Griffiths for the good of the evangelical movement which was already becoming split by Calvinist-Arminian disputes and for which Harris's infatuation with Griffiths was another source of division. But Harris was adamant that he would not reject her. There were dark rumours that Anne Harris was living separately from the pair at Trevecca or that she was shut up in the basement. The relationship ended when Griffiths died in 1752. Even then Harris's extravagant grief caused gossip, as did the fact that he continued to mourn her passing for the rest of his life.⁵³

Seduction by Methodist preachers soon became a popular literary trope. In Smollett's *Humphrey Clinker*, the evangelical spinster, Tabitha Bramble, recognised that a Methodist preacher was a seducer of women who would 'penetrate and instill his goodness, even into your most inward parts.'⁵⁴ Other satires suggested that a Methodist preacher who had been converted after a life of lust sold absolution to men, but to women 'the penance of the lass to the friar.'⁵⁵ It was widely thought that

Mr Barville, the flagellant parson in the pornographic novel *Fanny Hill or Memoirs of a Woman of Pleasure*, was a thinly veiled depiction of either Wesley or Whitefield. And others claimed that the account of the brothel in the same novel was an allusion to a Methodist meeting.⁵⁶ It was not just in fiction that evangelicals were depicted as lustful: the rumours circulated by Bishop Lavington of Exeter that Wesley had seduced a maid at an inn in his diocese in 1749 was the cause of an acrimonious exchange between the two and one reason why Wesley felt it was sensible to be married.⁵⁷

A persistent feature of anxieties about the sexual behaviour of Methodist preachers stemmed from their itinerancy. After 1746 the circuit system developed and the use of itinerant preachers became widespread. The consequence of this was that preachers moved from place to place and could leave behind illegitimate children, abandoned women, and sexual misbehaviour. Itinerancy also meant that preachers could reinvent themselves when they moved. One Methodist who literally reinvented herself was Jane Davison. In 1793–4 she travelled through the northern counties of Durham, Northumberland, and Cumberland professing to have a call from the Holy Spirit and she was well received in Methodist chapels. Her preaching was so successful and her special ability to convert women was such that she gained some notoriety. In Morpeth a farmer's daughter, Miss Bowrie, even abandoned her family and went off with Davison. As a later writer put it 'Miss Bowrie had benefitted from Miss Jane Davison's private lectures; and thus had more of the spirit of grace instilled into her than those who heard the truth with their ears in public.' Later, in Alnwick, Miss Davison lived in the house of Mr Hastings, a local Methodist, and became especially close to his two daughters. It was only when one of them was discovered to be pregnant that Davison's secret was revealed: Jane was a man. How Davison pulled off the disguise for two years is unclear, although it seems that he made love to Hastings's daughters in a wardrobe, so perhaps they did not see his body. A wave of shock passed through the Methodist communities in the North where Davison was well known. Rumours spread that Davison, whose real name was never known, had stolen money and even that in York he was caught stealing dead bodies.⁵⁸

The case of Jane Davison was one of the first of a series of Methodist sexual scandals that shocked the public in the later years of the long

eighteenth century and which seemed to derive an element of their scandal from the ability of the preacher to move from place to place. In the 1820s the behaviour of Preacher Orenshaw was revealed. Orenshaw was 'one of those notorious Methodists who infest the North of England and impose upon the poor.' At Hexham, Orenshaw seduced a girl called Ellen Pots who was one of thirteen children and earned a living as a farm servant, by which she supported her disabled father and siblings. When Pots was revealed to be pregnant by Orenshaw she was dismissed and forced into the workhouse. Orenshaw went on his way, embezzled funds from another young woman and moved to the West of England.⁵⁹

A more remarkable case in the 1820s was that of John Holland, a Methodist preacher, who was in turn a blacksmith, soldier, colonial agent, gaol chaplain, and finally convert Catholic priest. During his period as a Methodist, he fled from Newcastle to London: 'the hue and cry of a bastard child, that appendage to all Methodist preachers, served not a little to quicken his pace.' Thomas Day, a Methodist preacher, was tried for bigamy, having married his first wife in 1809 and a second ten years later. Day's defence was that his first marriage was broken by the fact that his first wife's 'heart lusted after variety and she laid down unto other men in violation of the laws of Moses.' However it later appeared that Day had a third wife as well as maintaining a relationship with a prostitute.⁶⁰

Jonathan Saddler was another instance of a Methodist preacher who attracted gossip perhaps from ignorance of what happened at love feasts. One account was that his love feasts were poorly lit:

which served only to render darkness visible ... nor was there wanting young men in their prime, who, by their energy of their passions, were ready to demonstrate the frailty of the other sex, for which purpose little persuasion seemed to be necessary.

Saddler, besides presiding over these orgies, seduced 'artless girls in the different counties through which he passed.'⁶¹ Sex could, of course, be a spur to faith and conversion as well as a source of anxiety and conflict. Joseph Carter converted to evangelicalism when he realised that his 'reigning sin' of adultery was wrong and when he saw a young boy advocating religion of the heart.⁶²

Evangelicalism thus appeared to threaten the institutions of marriage and family. The French Prophetess, Mary Lavington, provided a troubling example of how ecstatic religious movements could damage matrimony. Mary Lavington came to John and Charles Wesley's attention in 1739 when Charles investigated her and wrote an account of the encounter. Lavington, a former Quaker, had attracted a large following for her eschatological prophecies. She claimed to be able to speak to and call on angels.⁶³ More worrying was her open adultery with Mr Wise and her use of mixed sex meetings. Lavington also arranged for her followers to marry or remarry at her whim and often broke up families, since she held all existing marriages were invalid. Lavington had taken one follower, Mr Scholey, and removed him from his wife and children and told him to take another woman as his spiritual spouse. These matches were, she claimed, made in heaven.

Such cases led people to be gravely suspicious of evangelical and charismatic marriage teachings.⁶⁴ In 1743 *The Progress of Methodism in Bristol; or, The Methodist Unmask'd* suggested images of sin by describing women admirers of Whitefield and Wesley as 'Women [who] are most prone to fall, Like *Eve*, their Mother, first of all.'⁶⁵ In the poem *The Mock-Preacher* it was suggested that a 'fallen' evangelical woman had become enamoured with an evangelist. When she told her husband that the preacher would show the 'Way to Heaven', he joked that he would also be guaranteed a 'place' there, since 'cuckolds go to Heaven.'⁶⁶ The 'cuckold' was accusing his wife of adultery and clearly believed that his wife had been both sexually and spiritually seduced thereby undermining his authority.⁶⁷ Husbands often worried that when their wives were at Methodist meetings they were being cuckolded for God.⁶⁸

One of the reasons for speculation about the erotic potential of Methodism was that its meetings appeared to be secretive and, despite Wesley's Arminian theology, a closed world to outsiders. In parodies, the Methodist events at which others were excluded, band meetings, class meetings, and love feasts, could be depicted as orgies. The damage Methodism inflicted on families was also a recurrent theme in anti-Methodist works. One opponent of Whitefield enquired, 'How many weak women, surprized by his Enthusiasm, will neglect the care of their Families?'⁶⁹ In 1755–6, Joseph Boyes, curate of St Samson's York, accused William Williamson, a vicar choral in the Minster and incumbent of St Mary Bishophill in York, of frequenting a Methodist

meeting in his parish, which Boyes regarded as an illegal conventicle. The dean and chapter of York found Williamson not guilty but Boyes appealed to the archbishop. Boyes's concerns were not just that the meetings might be illegal, but that they took place at night, with men and women together behind locked doors and porters placed on the doors to keep out the public. Inside, he claimed, 'profane and superstitious practices' took place with crucifixes and popish paraphernalia. Moreover, the place of the meeting was 'of bad fame and reputation.'⁷⁰ Although Boyes lost his case, it reflected the anxiety caused by the secrecy of Methodism. He was not alone; one poet claimed that Methodist love feasts were excuses for group sex:

There saints, new-born, lascivious orgies hold,
Meek Lambs by Day, at Night no Wolves so bold
There the new Adam tried the old one's Fort,
And Children of the Light in Darkness Sport . . .

The account even suggested that incest was rife in these meetings.⁷¹

Temptation and Self-Control

To some extent, the fact that the charismatic dimensions of evangelicalism appeared to encourage physical and psychological arousal often meant that Methodists were far more concerned about self-control rather than excess. In many cases the focus of self-control was on sexual temptation and the role of masturbation as an outlet. The first mention of the term 'Methodism', in *Fog's Weekly Journal* for 9 December 1732, referred to Methodists as following the behaviour of Origen who performed 'a particular Operation on himself . . . if they knew how to make a proper Incision, they would quickly follow him.' Origen had castrated himself and thus the reference seems to have represented Methodists as both unhealthily interested in sex and sublimating it.⁷² Wild rumours sometimes had their origins in more substantial evidence. William Warburton, later bishop of Gloucester, wrote to Thomas Birch in September 1738 with an account of Wesley and some other Methodists on their travels staying at the home of a local Anglican clergyman.⁷³ In the morning the parson went into their chamber and 'perceived their chamber-pot full of blood; and on asking the occasion,

was told it was their method, when the blood grew rebellious to draw it off, by breathing a vein in this manner ... to cool themselves.⁷⁴ The 'rebellious blood' seems to suggest sexual tension, and presumably bleeding when sharing a room with others was far preferable to masturbation. Even so, Warburton also commented that 'if common report may be credited, the men from whom they [the Methodists] sprung, as Hicks and Collier, had a more natural way of evacuation,' which implies masturbation or some other sexual outlet.⁷⁵

The claim that these Non-jurors, those who had refused the oaths to William and Mary and denied the legitimacy of the Church of England because it had endorsed the Glorious Revolution, practised masturbation to resolve sexual tension suggests that they, as much as Methodists, were the target of Warburton's political and religious condemnation. Yet of course Wesley himself claimed to owe a great debt to Non-juring spirituality and the implication was that Methodism was a means by which unhealthy, and politically dangerous, Non-juring ideas might enter the religious mainstream.⁷⁶

The use of mortification of the flesh to suppress sexual urges was common in Christendom and included flagellation as well as bleeding. According to humoral theory, blood, semen, and sweat were connected.⁷⁷ It is likely that Wesley was aware of widespread monastic practices of bleeding and other forms of mortification of the flesh as a means to suppress lustful thoughts.⁷⁸ There had been a significant debate in England less than a decade earlier about whether semen, if unused, returned to the blood stream. The debate included the tract *A Whip for the Quacks* (1727) which suggested that 'retention of the seed' was unnatural and as dangerous as trying to prevent other secretions such as sweating and urination. The tract asserted that if men who used bleeding as a 'customary evacuation' of the impurities caused by semen's return to the blood stream left off the practice they would become 'plethorick or costive.' The author also claimed that it was the return of semen to the blood that caused men to grow beards and for their voices to break in puberty. Paradoxically, the tract concluded that such were the dangers of seed returning to the blood that masturbation was not dangerous or sinful.⁷⁹ This Galenic view of humours and secretions remained widely held throughout the eighteenth century and encouraged masturbation as a relief of the pressure of the bodily fluids.⁸⁰ From the

same premises it seems Wesley, however, decided that bleeding was the lesser of two evils.

Moreover, Wesley was also interested in, and knowledgeable about, Orthodox Christianity among whose various sects in eighteenth century Europe and Russia, blood-letting featured strongly in combatting lust.⁸¹ Interested in medical matters, Wesley later wrote his own medical guide, *Primitive Physick* (1761) in which he recommended bleeding as a limited treatment for consumption, ague, and other conditions.⁸² Although he probably also knew of William Hervey's recommendation of bleeding as treatment for many conditions,⁸³ Wesley seemed to see bleeding, in Warburton's account, as curing a moral rather than a medical condition.⁸⁴ An additional aspect of this was that, as a fellow of Lincoln College, Oxford, Wesley was required to be unmarried and it was assumed that such unmarried fellows were celibate. In these circumstances, masturbation to relieve feelings of lust was unacceptable.

Such sexual sublimation may also have been related to John Wesley's troubled personal relationships with women, which had some impact on his reputation. As a young man in Lincolnshire and in Oxford, Wesley formed romantic attachments to women, but seems to have been shy and ambivalent about whether to pursue them. His relationship with Sally Kirkham, or *Varenese* as she was nicknamed, was especially close. But though he wrote of her in code in his diary, in the end he did not continue the relationship.⁸⁵ Probably John's most troubling relationship with a woman is that largely ignored by Methodist historians. In February 1735, during his missionary venture in Savannah, Georgia, Wesley, then thirty-two, met the seventeen year old Sophia, or Sophie, Hopkey and was smitten. He found the experience of sexual attraction bewildering, writing to his brother Charles that he felt in jeopardy from young women of refinement but prayed that 'I know none of them in the flesh.'⁸⁶ Sophie Hopkey seems to have been similarly attracted to Wesley. She nursed him when he fell ill and thereafter they formed a strong bond. Sophie even asked others what form of dress would please Wesley and made a point of wearing it. Over the following months, Wesley and Hopkey became closer, at one point spending several nights together on a deserted island though they only indulged in hugging and kissing.⁸⁷ Her uncle, Mr Causton, arranged for Wesley to instruct Sophie in religion and she regularly visited his lodgings alone. Luke Tyerman referred to this religious instruction as Wesley's 'ghostly care'.⁸⁸ Wesley's Moravian

friends warned him against Hopkey and said that he should not proceed to ask her to marry him. Nevertheless, Wesley did so and in March 1737 Wesley noted in his diary that God seemed to have given him a companion. Thereafter, however, Wesley equivocated; as was his custom he drew lots to divine God's will and picked a slip of paper which read 'Think no more of it.'⁸⁹ Indeed Wesley took so long to act on his vague proposal of marriage that Hopkey married another man, Mr Williamson.

Unfortunately, the matter did not rest there. The new Mrs Williamson still regularly met Wesley, which her husband resented. In July 1737 Sophie and Wesley fell out, and in August Wesley took the extraordinary step of publicly refusing to admit Sophie to Holy Communion. This became an open scandal when Williamson sued Wesley for a thousand pounds for defaming his wife by refusing her Communion. Wesley, unconvincingly, claimed that he had refused to admit her to Communion because she had not given the notice that she intended to receive it, as he required. Few believed this explanation. With the support of Mr Causton (Sophie's uncle, who was also a lawyer) the case came to trial, with additional complaints that Wesley deviated from the principles of the Church of England. The grand jury found by a majority that there was a case to answer that Wesley had forced his attentions on Sophie, had wrongly denied her Communion, and had deviated from the Church's practices. The case dragged on and after seven court appearances, when Wesley was asked to provide £50 bail, he fled Georgia and returned to England without the case having come to court.⁹⁰ At least two of Wesley's contemporaries thought that he had behaved both immorally and improperly.⁹¹ Even his most apologetic biographers regarded Wesley's part in the affair to have been reprehensible and some have seen deeper psychological problems arising from Wesley's need to be admired and to control.⁹² Wesley seems to have been deeply affected by it, apparently abandoning thoughts of marriage for the next decade.

Wesley's relationships with women in Georgia were even more complex and troubling since he also had another close relationship with Margaret Bovey, who Wesley ministered to after her sister died. He taught her French and seems also to have been preparing her to become a deaconess. Like Sophie Hopkey, Wesley's relationship with Bovey continued on a daily basis even after her marriage to a man of whom Wesley disapproved.⁹³ Wesley's relationship with Bovey was

'disguised' by his rewritten diary of the events and he often obscured his relationships with women by the use of shorthand in his diary. He used shorthand when he was recounting the events in Georgia which he clearly regarded with shame. Sometimes he used it to report scandals about him, such as on one occasion when it was alleged that he had imprisoned a man so that he could seduce his wife. On other occasions he used it to commit his amorous thoughts to his journal as when he recalled a woman who attended him 'like a guardian angel' and to whom he wished he had not 'discovered myself.'⁹⁴

A decade after he had left Georgia, in 1748, Wesley again became involved with a woman to whom he promised but evaded matrimony: Grace Murray, a housekeeper at the Methodist society in Newcastle. Since he did not follow up his promises, Grace became engaged to a local Methodist supporter, John Bennet. Wesley's response was one of horror. He told Grace that she must accompany him on a preaching tour of Ireland and that her engagement to Bennet could not be binding as it came after her agreement with him, though he still made no move to marry her. On their tour of Ireland, Grace was referred to as Wesley's 'servant and friend as well as fellow-labourer in ye Gospel.' On their return to England, Grace equivocated between Bennet and Wesley. Gossip and innuendo followed, that Wesley had turned away from Grace because his desire for her had already been sated in Ireland. Charles Wesley, realising the scandal of his behaviour, travelled to Whitehaven and remonstrated with his brother. The reputational repercussions were significant enough that George Whitefield also joined the brothers fearing the Methodist societies would break up over the matter. To save his brother and Methodism, Charles abducted Grace and persuaded her to marry Bennet.⁹⁵ The problem was twofold: John Wesley was ambivalent and equivocal about marriage and seemed in no hurry to wed, and secondly did not see Grace's class as a barrier to their marriage.⁹⁶

In the end, in 1751, Wesley married Mary Vazaille, an older, rich and independently-minded widow, a contrast to Sophie Hopkey, Margaret Bovey, and Grace Murray in most respects. Wesley expected marriage to reduce his vulnerability to gossip, but not to alter his regular itinerant preaching. However, Mary Wesley was concerned about Wesley's meetings with other women, particularly Sarah Crosby, who Wesley seemed to have identified as a remarkable woman even permitting her to

preach. After seven years, Mary Wesley's suspicions escalated to violence: one helper found Mary beating John, tearing at his hair, and dragging him around by it.⁹⁷ This was a shocking matter which undermined Wesley's standing since he was unable to govern his own household. Nor did his marriage restore his reputation. After the couple separated, satirists attacked Wesley's broken marriage and his attraction to young women. One wrote:

At sixty-three could such Perfection burn?
 No Victim but in Teens then serve your Turn,
 Till on a Widow Int'rest made you fix
 Faithless alike in Love and Politics?
 Stronger than Marriage-Vows rank Lust inclin'd
 Sinless Perfection soon to change its Mind;
 The Wife grew stale – you found some Converts kind . . .
 Thus 'tis some Saints can master for their Blood
 That ev'ry carnal Appetite withstood.⁹⁸

In later life, John Wesley had a series of passionate, though probably chaste, friendships with younger women which risked his reputation but showed his capacity for sexual sublimation. He indulged in an intense friendship with Elizabeth Ritchie expressed in ardent letters which Vicki Tolar Burton has called 'a sort of spiritual (not physical) seduction'.⁹⁹ Another was with Anne Bolton, forty years Wesley's junior, who received over a hundred letters from him and played the role of a confessor to Wesley, to whom he sent his private thoughts and anxieties. John Banks, the editor of Bolton's journal, despite being a defender of Wesley, conceded that he was a 'snare' to women and noted that, after his death, his letters to Bolton were destroyed by his executors, presumably because of the construction that could be put upon them. He even likened Wesley's relationship with Bolton to a courtship.¹⁰⁰

Evangelicals and External and Internal Moral Regulation

As evangelicalism became more established, it was perceived less as a source of moral disorder and more as a saviour of the family, eventually being harnessed to the objective of securing broader moral discipline. From the mid-1780s, voices were raised about England's moral decay.

Political ferment in the shape of American and French revolutions, economic change, and military crises prompted an era of anxiety that lasted until the Great Reform Act.¹⁰¹ As Alan Hunt points out, the results were conservative reaction, a stimulated demand for legislative reform, and a resurgence in civil society's philanthropic efforts directed at moral reform.¹⁰² As has been seen in chapter two, moral campaigns were aimed at a range of activities. Sabbath-breaking, gambling, and swearing were targets and activists aimed to regulate sites of illicit sexuality such as brothels, and to halt the publication of licentious and obscene books and prints. A generalised language of moral reform was used, however, especially the term vice; so that sexual irregularity tended to be an implicit or obscured component of the campaigns. For instance adultery was included, but euphemistically referred to as 'gallantry'.

Even so, worries about the regulation of sexual behaviour coloured many of these moral reforming activities. This is because vice was still seen as a journey on which the vicious travelled from minor offences to much worse ones.¹⁰³ As Joanna Innes observes, three co-existing traditions of thought underpinned concerns about morals throughout the eighteenth century: an association of moral failings with social consequences which led to poverty, vagrancy and crime; a political inflection which feared loss of selfless actions for public good; and a religious stance 'in which sexual offences and offences of impiety were among the moral failings, the 'sins most reprobated, and God's wrathful judgements the consequences most feared'.¹⁰⁴ Although the three strands often overlapped, for evangelicals the latter stance was critical. Moral reform thus involved evangelicals in several modes of action, including persuading others through words and print, joining and funding voluntary reform associations, and teaching basic morals to poor children.

The reanimated desire for moral reform from the 1780s was not solely an evangelical drive. Conservative moral instincts were shared by Anglican clergy, such as Bishop Samuel Horsley.¹⁰⁵ Nor was it specifically metropolitan. Historians rightly note that it was much broader, originating particularly in Yorkshire and Middlesex, and drawing on lay as well as clerical proponents and a variety of evangelicals. Still, the moral discourses were 'articulated in the assumption of a generalised Christian doctrinal framework, in particular that of evangelical Protestantism'.¹⁰⁶ In general, as Hunt argues, this age

of anxiety 'revived providential religious ideas that interpreted each symptom of crisis as evidence of God's wrath with a sinful nation brought low by admixtures of the immorality of the lower orders and the luxury, pride and folly of the upper classes;' all of which was grist to the evangelical mill. Campaigners who led or spoke for moral reform were frequently moderate evangelicals. They were prominent as members of organisations like the Bible Society, the Church Missionary Society, the School Society, Sunday School Society, and the Bettering Society, all of which had at their heart the regulation of morals.¹⁰⁷ Roberts argues that evangelicals of the 1780s were especially susceptible to the drive to reform morals. As a new generation of converts, predominantly from the social ranks of the upwardly mobile and more marginal fringes of the governing elite, evangelicals combined self-appraisal and conviction in improving society (to prevent falling back into their unredeemed ways) with a degree of guilt at their new wealth and worldly success. In Roberts's view, such active evangelical moral reformers sought evidence of their salvation through their good works.¹⁰⁸

The evangelical reform movements have been especially identified with William Wilberforce and Hannah More. Following his much discussed conversion on his Grand Tour in 1785, Wilberforce committed himself to campaigning to end slavery and to improve the morals and manners of the nation.¹⁰⁹ Though a powerhouse of moral reform, he was only one of several eminent men, known as the 'Saints', who lived near Clapham Common, and who would be dubbed the Clapham Sect. The Sect included Henry Thornton, Edward Eliot, Charles Grant, John Shore, Zachary Macauley: evangelical bankers, MPs, and colonial administrators linked by friendship, 'vital religion,' and marriage who were at the forefront of many efforts to reform the morals of England.¹¹⁰

Wilberforce transferred his conversion from theory to practice by convincing Queen Charlotte, the Archbishop of Canterbury and other church dignitaries to persuade George III to issue a royal proclamation on 1 June 1787: 'For the Encouragement of Piety and Virtue and for Preventing and Punishing of Vice, Profaneness, and Immorality'.¹¹¹ Like its predecessors, the societies for the reformation of manners, it demanded the enforcement of laws against drunkenness, gaming, and profane, licentious, and disorderly behaviour in order to tackle moral degradation. Wilberforce was at the forefront of the Proclamation

Society, made up predominantly of higher clergy and nobility, endorsed by nineteen of the twenty-six English and Welsh bishops, and including leading evangelical Bishops Shute Barrington, and Beilby Porteus.¹¹² Innes suggests that this elite composition was part of Wilberforce's strategy to make 'the cause of moral reform respectable: to remove from it any lingering taint of Puritanism and social subversion'.¹¹³ The Proclamation Society was absorbed into the Society for the Suppression of Vice (begun in 1802), from 1803–5; a broader organisation than the Proclamation Society, aimed at encouraging the respectable metropolitan classes to take action.¹¹⁴ It had a wider membership, representing the urban professional and commercial classes, and also far more women, by 1804 a third of the membership was female. The Vice Society extended the Proclamation Society's reforming objectives to the selling of false weights and measures and cruelty to animals. While restricted to Anglicans, one third of the people at the inaugural meeting were evangelical.¹¹⁵

Another means to reform moral behaviour was through publications. This included sermons and advice on a proper religious life, aimed at the religiously complacent middle and upper classes.¹¹⁶ Here, Hannah More excelled. Her *Thoughts on the Importance of the Manners of the Great* (1789) for example, was a response to the Royal Proclamation against 'vice and irreligion';¹¹⁷ she also wrote numerous tracts for the working classes which adopted the format, though not the 'vulgar' content, of popular literature like chapbooks and ballads. *The Cheap Repository Tracts*, which she edited and often wrote from 1795 to 1798, were a lynchpin of her loyalist and reforming endeavours.¹¹⁸ Also aimed at the lower classes were the Sunday and charity schools spreading across the country, inspired by Robert Raikes's Gloucestershire schools. The movement was the inspiration for the More sisters' Mendips schools, which sought to deliver Christianity, sobriety, industry and morality to miners' children. Ultimately, taking literacy and moral and religious education to poor children was intended, in the words of the interdenominational Sunday School Society (1785), 'to prevent vice'.¹¹⁹ Indeed, Wilberforce and More congratulated themselves that they had brought about 'the greatly improved state of society in this country'.¹²⁰

Although sometimes condemned for targeting only the poor in their moral campaigns, evangelicals sought also to reform elite morals, and therefore by extension their sexual behaviour. More's *Thoughts on the*

Importance of the Manners of the Great (1788) and *An Estimate of the Religion of the Fashionable World* (1791), and Wilberforce's *A Practical View of the Prevailing Religious System of Professed Christians* (1797) addressed the upper classes directly. As More explained, it was critical to reform elite manners to act as exemplars to the rest of society: 'Reformation must begin with the Great' for they were examples for the 'vulgar'.¹²¹ She identified three enemies of virtue in genteel life: 'Inconsideration, Fashion, and the World.' Before her conversion Hannah More had fully understood the attractions of the fashionable world and her recommendation to 'persons of rank and fortune' who were irreligious, despite being reasonably pious and humane, was to look inwards and seek individual virtue, self-denial, and 'purity'.¹²² It is pertinent that evangelical condemnation of adultery, like More's attack on 'gallantry' in *Thoughts on the Importance of the Manners of the Great*, was aimed firmly at the highest social ranks. For More (and others) the use of the word gallantry to describe adultery was abhorrent: 'Atrocious deeds should never be called by gentle names'. Hiding sin in pretty language 'must certainly contribute, more than anything, to diminish the horror of vice in the rising generation'.¹²³ For the leaders of the Proclamation Society, widely publicised example-setting was critical.¹²⁴ So too was the institution of the family.

The significance of the family was deemed so important in the difficult years between 1780 and 1830 that it was not only extra-marital sex that was condemned as immoral by evangelicals. As numbers of the poor increased, together with a general rise in population, concerns grew about sustainability; a population that was expanding and could not be fed threatened the nation – partly due to economic viability, but given the context of European war, also military viability too.¹²⁵ Fertility was thus so critical that not only illicit sexuality needed to be regulated; according to a new generation of political economists, so did marital sexuality. Thus evangelicals targeted marital sex as a form of vice, supporting the Reverend Thomas Malthus's proposal that 'sexual indulgence, leading to procreation' by labouring men who did not have the means to support their families threatened society because it increased the population without a growth in the food supply. The answer was 'moral restraint' or Malthus's preventive check: not only sexual abstinence outside wedlock, but also not marrying.¹²⁶ This was the only alternative to a positive check on population numbers that

brought death by famine, disease, and war.¹²⁷ Self-control in sexual terms was hugely important. Malthus was not an evangelical, but evangelicals took up forcefully his proposals for sexual self-control. The Scottish Presbyterian minister Thomas Chalmers claimed that people ‘rush with precipitation in matrimony’ and thus:

the tendency to excessive population, can only find its thorough and decisive counteraction, among the amended habits, and the moralized characters, and the exalted principles, of the people themselves ... it is necessary, to go forth among the people, and there to superinduce the principles of an efficient morality, on the mere principles of nature – and there to work a transformation of taste and character.¹²⁸

For Boyd Hilton, these evangelicals were attempting to rescue labourers from ‘the dominion of sensuality’. Not only would this save the population from brutal checks, it would evangelise it because such sexual restraint would make labouring people ready to receive divine grace.¹²⁹

Evangelical reformers sought to eradicate vice from the inside out by promoting the same model of self-control and self-help that Wesley had advocated. As Roberts observes, at its core moral reform ‘became a debate about the cultural control of “animal appetites” – greed, lust, violence and ... indolence’.¹³⁰ Of particular relevance was that the evangelical inward-looking gaze was coupled with more authoritarian, coercive forms of moral regulation so that it was a mix of “governing others” and “governing the self”.¹³¹ The other tool in evangelicals’ armoury, and what marked out the Clapham Sect from the earlier generation of evangelicals such as Wesley, was the emphasis on the family as a location for the inculcation, dissemination and maintenance of morals (and hence weeding out of vice) and the appropriate gender conventions of family members.

Virtuous Men, Women, and Homes

The view that the family was the primary location for virtue, due to its child-rearing role and hierarchical structure, was not exclusively evangelical. But evangelicals saw and used this cultural trope with great

conviction when describing and planning their own lives.¹³² In his popular poem *The Task* (1785), William Cowper described 'Domestic happiness' as 'the nurse of virtue' and such sentiments spread far beyond print.¹³³ In 1776, William Gray, later a wealthy lawyer, was just starting out and experiencing a phase of intense religious introspection – often expressed in correspondence with his father. Gray was, like many young professional men, considering future marriage. Economic calculations about the burdens of future children and household, however, were less significant than his future wife's piety. He explained to his father:

In short, both with regard to the Union between Husband and Wife, the managing a Family, and the bringing up Children in the Nurture and Admonition of the Lord, a person unawakened must be highly improper and dangerous – I could urge a thousand more arguments equally strong, and I am so well convinced of them, with regard to myself, that I would not for a million of worlds engage myself to an unregenerate person if she had every accomplishment Heart could wish; for (as pious Bishop Beveridge observes) I should only have possession of her Body whilst the Devil had possession of her soul.¹³⁴

Gray clearly conformed to Davidoff and Hall's observation, based on case-studies of evangelical families in the midlands and Essex, that 'every serious Christian knew that the [home was the] one place where moral order could be maintained and recalcitrant time and nature be brought more securely under control'.¹³⁵

This view of the family as a moral nexus became even more acute from the last quarter of the eighteenth century as a series of crises heightened rhetoric about its national as well as personal importance in moral regeneration. From 1795 to 1815 the domestic was valorised since decades of war, hunger, and disorder brought with them a demand for a return to the safety of tradition and custom. This was particularly acute in the evangelical outlook which tended to interpret economic and political dislocation as warnings from God, and looked to the Bible as the source of forgiveness of sin. The emphasis on biblical virtue, Roberts claims, accelerated sympathy for arguments asserting the sacramental view of marriage and divinely ordained 'separation of spheres'.¹³⁶ As Roberts says of the period, the domestic environment was coming to

be seen 'as a moralising force in its own right'.¹³⁷ The evangelical parson Thomas Robinson of Leicester, for example, preached a sermon late in 1792 which sought to remind the lower ranking members of his congregation to remain loyal and be moral agents. Not only were they to be grateful that God had placed them where they could comfortably subsist, he told them 'exert your influence in your family and neighbourhood to preserve peace and order; explain to your families their duty; inculcate subordination; catechise your young people'.¹³⁸

Evangelicals at the end of the long eighteenth century were particularly vocal in linking sexual immorality with damage to family life. Hannah More, for instance, declared that adultery was a 'crime which stabs domestic happiness and conjugal virtue'.¹³⁹ Her work illustrated the heightening of the language of domestic virtue as a safeguard against immorality. More's postscript to the 1809 edition of *Thoughts on the Improvement of the Manners of the Great* answered criticisms of her condemnation of carrying out worldly activities on Sundays. She stood by her warnings and emphasised that keeping Sundays free of gay and elegant scenes by receiving no visitors would allow persons of fashion to enjoy the 'sweet and delightful pleasures of family society'. Not only would this let them cultivate friendship for each other and affection for their children, it enabled intercourse with God.¹⁴⁰ Mixed with the ideal of separate spheres, this model of behaviour gave wives considerable power within their confined sphere. Thomas Gisborne's *Enquiry into the Duties of the Female Sex* (1797) recognised that families of means living in London faced considerable distractions from virtue, due to the numerous possibilities for leisure, sociability and, thanks to business, separation from husbands. His solution was to warn women that they could keep their husbands away from temptation and being 'allured into the haunts of luxury, riot, and profaneness' by cultivating 'the cheerful tranquillity of domestic pleasures'.¹⁴¹

The idealised rhetoric of separate spheres was by no means reflected in practice, nor was it solely evangelical.¹⁴² In fact its complexities can be seen in evangelical families which deployed the family as a means to reform their members, neighbours, and nation. By the 1820s, second and third generation evangelical families were transmitting reforming values across the generations through upbringing and marriage, forming 'cradle Christians' rather than converted ones. The marriage of Thomas Buxton and Hannah Gurney is an example of 'how one major strand of

moral reform commitment was forced ... in the heart of the *haut bourgeois* evangelical family'. Buxton was an Anglican brewer who entered Parliament and became a country gentlemen, undergoing a late evangelical conversion. Gurney came from an extremely active banking evangelical Quaker family and was the sister of Elizabeth Fry. Such kinship promoted ideas of moral behaviour and offered family models for how they were to be attained.¹⁴³ The Buxton-Gurney family connections became a force of collaborative political labours which promoted Buxton's parliamentary drive against slavery. Despite this, the roles of male and female family members did not rewrite conventional formulations of gender within the family and Buxton remained the 'dominant force within this dynamic'.¹⁴⁴

Even so, there is evidence that evangelicals helped to reconfigure aspects of feminine and masculine identities in the middling, professional classes. As has been seen, for much of the middle years of the eighteenth century, Methodism represented a challenge to, even a disordered form of, gender identity. By the end of the eighteenth century, evangelicalism became much more normative in its identification of gender roles. John Wesley's tolerance of women preachers was replaced by a ban after his death. As evangelicalism came to be professed by the governing classes in the 1780s, a particular form of masculine identity came to the forefront for middle-class and some elite men. It was organised around two key concepts: 'domesticity' and a 'calling'. Though its timing has led some earlier historians to suggest that it was distinctive to evangelical men, it was part of a much broader idealised masculinity that was rooted in previous fashionable versions.¹⁴⁵ Van Reyk argues that common across denominations was the adoption of Christ as the model for manly behaviour.¹⁴⁶

Masculine identity merged with the ideals of behaviour promoted by the culture of sensibility, such as tenderness and benevolence.¹⁴⁷ This is evident in higher-ranking men like William Wilberforce who took on the mantle of sympathy for the oppressed as well as the cause of reforming the nation's morality. However, it was especially identified with the middle classes. Usefully, it was a safer form of behaviour for evangelical men because it retained emotion but discarded the fervour expressed by earlier proponents of masculine vital religion who had been criticised as irrational. With tender feelings based on domesticity and homely pursuits and, of course, retaining male authority and

independence, effeminacy was avoided. Coupled with the astounding levels of hard work arising from a calling, it became a recipe for earnest Christian manliness usually associated with the 1830s.¹⁴⁸ The emphasis on piety, tenderness, reliance upon home and family for stability and succour, and hard work, accompanied a focus on male self-sacrifice. This was not only economic and charitable; it included facing down temptation and the control of appetite in order to achieve manly virtue. As such, for evangelical families male chastity was important and the sexual double-standard least likely to be tolerated.¹⁴⁹ It is no accident that evangelicals would be at the forefront of the drives for male sexual purity later in the nineteenth century.¹⁵⁰

Appropriate behaviour for women was also explicitly discussed in this period in the wake of political and economic changes. Though imperfectly translated into practice, the concept of separate spheres was powerful as an ideology. Women shaped the home and as more middle-class professional men worked outside it, they were increasingly seen as restoring and soothing their husbands when they returned home. They were also appropriate vehicles for inculcating moral purity since, by the later eighteenth century, women were idealised as having a greater capacity for moral purity and virtue than men. This stands out in evangelical advice literature. Gisborne's *An Enquiry into the Duties of the Female Sex* informed readers that his tract offered 'the most prominent of those instances in which the moral activity and the moral vigilance of the female mind are to be guided into practical channels'.¹⁵¹ His explanation of the tasks of women was conventional: first, constant attention to the comfort of husband, family, relations and friends in domestic life; second 'forming and improving the general manners, dispositions, and conduct of the other sex, by society and example'; and thirdly, 'modelling the human mind during the early stages of its growth'. Gisborne's evangelical views coloured these conventions, nonetheless. For instance, women were peculiarly suited to diffusing virtue through the breast of their husbands because women were more religiously disposed than men with:

minds more susceptible than the other sex to the temptations of open vice; they have quicker feelings of native delicacy and a stronger sense of shame, no inconsiderable supports to virtue; and they are subjected, in a peculiar degree, to vicissitudes of health

adapted to awaken serious thought, and to set before them the prospect and the consequences of dissolution.¹⁵²

The latter was no doubt their frequent exposure to childbirth. Women's third duty was also tailored to evangelical needs; Gisborne deemed mothers better at forming children's minds than school teachers despite their lack of knowledge, because they can 'lead the affections to bear their reasonable part in preparing the heart for the service of God, and animating it with the desire of diffusing happiness among mankind'.¹⁵³ If the purpose of this was inculcating openness to God, it also promoted personal moral regulation.

Women were afforded the particular role of disseminating virtue outside the home too. This was partly in an exemplary fashion. Gisborne took care to remind the clergyman's wife of the heightened demands on her to enable her husband to live up to their promise at admission into holy orders to 'frame and fashion his family, as well as himself, according to the doctrine of Christ, that both may be wholesome examples and patterns to his flock'.¹⁵⁴ But it also enabled women to operate outside home in social and increasingly political activism, precisely because it was aimed at personal morals. Hannah More, for instance, saw women as the key to a reformed, civilised society.¹⁵⁵ As her 1799 publication on female education argued, pious women could only influence the moral conduct of men for the better if their own behaviour was reformed and they were educated more soundly than through decorative accomplishments.¹⁵⁶ She sought out gentry women as the saviours of Britain from 'infidel confederacies' that undermined society.¹⁵⁷

Conclusion

As this chapter shows, during the eighteenth century evangelicals saw sexual self-control as essential to both personal and social morality. Young suggests that although the late eighteenth and early nineteenth-century evangelicals had similar moral concerns to Methodists, they saw the godly family and household as the most effective way to control the disruptive effects of sexuality. For example, Hannah More's *Coelebs in Search of a Wife* (1809) celebrated marriage above all else.¹⁵⁸ The discourses produced by both early and later evangelicals reveal, however, that managing sexual reputation and temptation was complicated and

could bring condemnation as well as praise. For evangelicals, sexual self-management was also part of a narrative of marriage and encompassed a range of behaviour from no sexual activity at all, both outside and within marriage, to avoiding certain sexual practices and thoughts. The next chapter explores the complicated ideology of celibacy and chastity in more depth.

CHAPTER 6

CELIBACY, 'CONJUGAL CHASTITY', AND 'MORAL RESTRAINT'

The state of celibacy, or being single and not having sex, was central to much public discussion in the long eighteenth century; indeed Jacqueline Hecht calls it the 'Enlightenment Obsessional Neurosis'.¹ Sex made and maintained marriage since the Church of England declared matrimony's function to be procreative and that it should provide mutual comfort to those it united. In addition, the institution of marriage sustained gendered authority and was deemed the primary institution of social order. Consequently, the unmarried state was perceived to be inferior. Sir Robert Filmer's *Patriarcha* (1680) opened with the observation that the first kings were fathers of families; by implication the unmarried, or unfamilied, were outside the legitimate state and religious authority. Unmarried men and women appeared to destabilise natural order.² At times they were seen to pose a risk to society and the nation, not least because extra-marital sex could increase illegitimacy and the burden of supporting bastards. Hence, modern readers might expect this discussion of celibacy to be about the rejection of sex. Moreover, since this century is identified with sexual revolution, they might assume that changing attitudes to sexual continence were driven by a secularising process. After all, given that the Church's ability to discipline illicit sexuality diminished, and a discourse of sexual liberty circulated among some elite men, so it seems logical to infer that celibacy was increasingly marginalised, losing its political, rhetorical,

and ideological force over the century. Yet such assumptions are problematic.

In fact, although the Church was at the forefront of commentary on celibacy, whether attacking it or promoting a modified version, it did not always present sex as either intrinsically sinful or problematic. Indeed, chapters one and four show that some clergymen celebrated sex and its pleasures as long as it was the right type: marital, procreative and heterosexual. This chapter shows that celibacy was indeed disparaged, not least because Anglicans identified it with Roman Catholicism and therefore it appeared dangerous, and links changing concerns around celibacy to political, economic, and cultural shifts. Yet, the debate remained rooted in a religious framework, which in some respects encouraged a degree of ambiguity about the celibate state, from denigration in the later seventeenth to cautious approval in the early nineteenth century. Definitions of celibacy were not fixed, with a variety of different terms in use, a range of views about the merits of abstinence in general, and, critically, the possibility of temporary celibacy. When Anglican clerical writers discussed sexual continence (which sometimes served several political purposes) they rarely rejected the value of celibacy outright, instead arguing that few people possessed the gift of chastity and therefore must marry. It is also possible to find individuals who practised the single, non-sexually active life because they were legitimately side-stepping patriarchal authority, or avoiding the distractions of family life with the goal of greater spiritual conviction, or from professional necessity.

A Short History of Celibacy

Writers on celibacy in the long eighteenth century recognised its deep roots in the ancient world, both pagan and Christian, though it was the latter that they focused, typically beginning with the Pauline advocacy of the celibate state. In a much quoted passage from Corinthian, St Paul advised the unmarried and widows: 'It is good for them if they abide even as I. But if they cannot contain, let them marry: for it is better to marry than to burn'.³ The Gregorian reform movement of the eleventh century introduced compulsory clerical celibacy, a development that indicated the sacerdotal function of the priesthood and signified that the clergy were set apart from the laity, as a distinct caste.

In the medieval Church, it was popularly thought that the priests who participated in the Eucharist should be pure and it was celibacy that gave the clergy an untainted state.⁴ In the sixteenth century, Protestant reformers attacked celibacy for two main reasons. First, they saw clerical celibacy as unnatural, a corruption of scripture, and a direct cause of sexual sins such as masturbation, fornication, and sodomy. Secondly, they denied that sexual renunciation was possible for most people to achieve, given human nature, and so defined marriage as the only way to avoid sin for both clergy and laity, and was a superior state.⁵

These two principles were firmly in place by the long eighteenth century. In 1688 the Calvinist Bishop Thomas Barlow of Lincoln pronounced marriage the '*Means appointed by God to preserve Chastity, and where that is forbidden (as in the Church of Rome it is) abominable pollutions will be a fatal consequence*'.⁶ Inevitably this made those who voluntarily sought the single life seem suspect; as William Secker warned in 1705 in *A Wedding Ring*, they 'had rather fry in the grease of their own Sensuality, then extinguish those Flames with an allowed remedy'.⁷ Like earlier Protestants, most eighteenth-century writers on celibacy attacked it through a defence of marriage. John Dove wrote in 1769 that marriage was instituted by God as a 'needful remedy' against the evils following from the 'promiscuous mixing of the sexes'. For Dove, sex was a gift from Heaven and people were created to worship God, promote the happiness of each other and raise their posterity to do the same. So people were not at liberty to choose or refuse to marry and procreate.⁸

Anti-Catholicism was a powerful imperative underlying the attacks on celibacy in the late seventeenth and first half of the eighteenth centuries.⁹ From the sixteenth century religious reformers had denounced priests for feigning celibacy and committing illicit sexual acts with women from their parishes, or with cloistered women and men. This served as a convincing means to criticise the traditions and structures of the medieval Church, as well as the personal morals of its clergy, and demand doctrinal reform.¹⁰ Anglicans took up this rhetoric with relish in times of national crisis in the seventeenth century. For example, Henry Wharton's *Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy* (1688) was devoted to showing that the veneration of celibacy arose from an accumulation of errors and corruptions in the Church of Rome.¹¹ This was manifested in the long-standing links forged by religious reformers

between clerical celibacy and deviant sexual behaviour since 'compelled chastity' was seen as a precursor to unclean living.¹²

Sarah Apetrei points out that late seventeenth-century Anglicans' criticism of austere discipline was rooted in popular anti-popery (especially in the wake of the Popish Plot and the ejection of the Catholic James II) in which 'Spurious celibacy signified actual whoredom'.¹³ A narrative of clerical abstinence in the Western Church, published in 1688, was titled *Sodom Fair* and deemed immorality to be the 'Crab-Fruit of a constrained celibacy'.¹⁴ Henry Wharton claimed that clerical celibacy caused 'open incontinence' which was not only bad for the clergy, but affected the laity who were most influenced by example.¹⁵ In his *Answer to a Discourse Concerning Celibacy* (1688) George Tully devoted a section to the pernicious effects of the law of celibacy and, like many writers, cited St Bernard in the twelfth century 'complaining of the fornications, adulteries, incests, and the unnatural bestialities of men with men, reigning in the sacred orders' due to clerical inability to live celibate.¹⁶ Another author in 1721 asserted that 'forc'd Celibacy of the Clergy and Monks introduc'd first, fornication; 2dly Adultery; 3dly, Incest; 4thly, Sodomy; 5thly, Bestiality; 6thly, Nothism [sic]; 7thly, Infanticide'.¹⁷ Caleb Fleming was especially vehement in 1751, describing celibacy as 'a doctrine of demons', and remarking that 'vows of it made by persons only as religious obligations are the most stupid compliments that can be paid the deity, expressing contempt of an institution of the God of nature'. Indeed it seems that Fleming's thoughts on divorce, polygamy, and celibacy were formulated as a means by which to denounce popery as 'demonism and not Christianity'.¹⁸

For these churchmen, celibacy was not therefore the absence of sex, but a perversion of sex; this was true of later commentators too. Though sometimes less explicitly anti-papist, writers on celibacy in the second half of the eighteenth century linked it with libertinism, itself associated with Catholicism. For example, *The Essay on Celibacy* (1753) stated that celibacy was a vice as wrong as 'incontinency [which] is a too free exertion or abuse of the natural powers'; celibacy was a defect of natural powers, and incontinence an excess of them.¹⁹ For this author, it was celibates who had 'destructive, immoral, and abandoned principles'.²⁰ He explained: 'It need not seem wonderful, that celibacy often produces leachery [sic]. For warm desires are inseperable [sic] from it, and these, by continency, are apt and almost sure to be inflamed. It is as likely to

produce leachery as libertinism'.²¹ John Dove referred to the 'celibate debauchee' in 1769.²² His reprehensible bachelor replaced the Catholic priest. Dove linked 'bachelorship and bastardy', attacking the celibate for not propagating and caring for his young 'for he has either none to care about, or leaves his bastards to starve on dunghills', reducing the deserted mothers to consider murdering their 'innocent' infant out of distress. At other times, Dove warned, 'rapes, adulteries, fornications, &c are committed'.²³

Anti-Catholic discourse in the nineteenth century continued to link sexual renunciation with sadism and depravity, and the unnatural breakdown of male authority in the family and household. Against the backdrop of Tractarianism and Anglo-Catholicism, nineteenth-century Catholic clergy were caricatured as 'simultaneously tyrannical and sexually predatory' with particular concerns over practices in convents, no doubt stimulated by the expansion of female cloistered communities within Anglicanism.²⁴ When communities of nuns and deaconesses were set up in the Church of England from 1845, members worked in nursing, teaching, and reforming prostitutes. Some members of the Church of England objected in Convocation to the women's vows of chastity (less so of poverty and obedience) because they saw celibacy as leading to immorality. For this reason they suggested that the vows be postponed until women were older.²⁵

As this chapter illustrates, however, the commentary on celibacy and marriage was also driven by wider political, social, and national concerns. By the end of the eighteenth century, it was common to discuss celibacy in a broader, global context. The Reverend John Hawkins justified his *Essay on the Law of Celibacy* (1785) by acknowledging that, although Britain was not a kingdom where celibacy was prescribed, it was so extensive elsewhere that 'every Citizen of the world' should be interested.²⁶

Definitions and Degrees of Celibacy

One of the difficulties in tracing attitudes towards celibacy across the period is the imprecise terminology used by some scholars and contemporaries. For example, the former did not always distinguish between religiously-inspired vows of celibacy and voluntarily living a single life, which could impose an artificial sense that the decision was

either religious or secular. Contemporaries did not always define distinctions between celibacy, continence, and chastity. Celibacy was derived from the Latin 'coelibatus', the state of being alone; the *Oxford English Dictionary* defines celibacy as the single state – not being married. This conveyed two meanings in the past: first, sexual abstinence, and, second, the voluntary or involuntary seclusion from marriage. In this context, the religious celibate acquired special status because s/he was exempted from procreative arrangements in order to perform special services to the community.²⁷ Thus, strictly speaking, celibacy should be distinguished from chastity, which means abstinence from illicit sexual behaviour (although, as will be seen, the term 'conjugal chastity' complicates the matter).²⁸ In this sense celibacy meant that the individual renounced licit sexuality. As Sarah Apetrei remarks, nonetheless, there is a paradox in the reluctance to give dedicated celibates special status in Protestant England, yet all adults were expected live as a celibate outside marriage.²⁹

Some writers did define their terms. At the start of his *Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy* in 1688, Henry Wharton stated: 'By Celibacy, we mean a perpetual abstinence from the use of the Nuptial Bed in those already Married, and not Contracting of Marriage in single persons, after taking of Holy Orders, or making a Vow of Chastity'.³⁰ Several authors stated that they discussed the religious aspect of celibacy. In 1743, John Wesley referred to celibates as those who '*made themselves Eunuchs* (have abstain'd from Marriage all their Lives, have remain'd Single till Death) *for the Kingdom of Heaven's Sake*'.³¹ Still, this was not solely a concern of thinkers on clerical or religious celibacy. In 1753 the author of *Essay on Celibacy* stated that he used 'the word Celibacy for the single state of both sexes'. He defined bachelors as 'adult males as live and die in virginity, or never use their bodily organs in the propagation of their kind'. Although he did not specify that celibacy was a vow for religious purposes, this was not a secular development, because he used the role of God to justify the argument that celibacy was unnatural because it deviated from God's law as well as nature.³² To some extent, it seems that contemporaries used a variety of terms synonymously, including celibacy, purity, chastity, and continence.

Writers on celibacy used the word chastity, however, to identify degrees of celibacy. The *Oxford English Dictionary* offers two relevant meanings of chastity: abstinence from all sexual intercourse, or celibacy,

and purity from unlawful sexual intercourse. Commentators used the second meaning when defending marriage against celibacy, applying a distinction between moderation and abstinence. For example, Wharton stated that when the Apostles condemned drunkenness and covetousness, they did not advocate abstinence from alcohol or acquiring things, but advised moderation. He applied the same distinction to their calls for sexual continence: explaining that they recommended restraint not abstinence.³³ So Anglican writers stressed that marriage was not simply recommended as an alternative to 'burning', but as a superior status in that it was the institution in which restraint could be practised. In George Tully's words, the preferred state was 'not, virginal, but conjugal chastity'.³⁴

This concept of 'conjugal chastity' stood at the heart of much of the discourse on celibacy and chastity. Wharton explained it in some detail. His history of celibacy stated that the Apostolic Fathers taught that the virtues of chastity and continence were 'not incompatible with the moderate use of Marriage'. He observed that 'Chastity in the notion of a total Abstinence, is a thing wholly indifferent'. In his view it was no paradox that 'true and proper Chastity and Continence may be observed in Marriage.' Celibates imbibed the 'false notions of Chastity' advocated by the Catholic Church. In this way Wharton was able to prove his point that 'Marriage and Virginity' were in equilibrium with the latter having no 'intrinsick Excellence beyond the former' because chastity could be compatible with marriage. Yet in many ways it was also a rewriting of chastity shaped by the distinction between moderation and abstinence, in which chastity was not solely about avoiding unlawful sex, but was a definition of good, lawful sex. Wharton offered evidence of conjugal chastity by citing Apostles who declared that embracing a lawful wife was chaste and that children could be gotten with 'honest and chaste will' by using continence to prevent a man feeling lust for his wife.³⁵ By 1790, the Reverend John Hawkins still attacked 'the idea of uncleanness in marriage, [which] is evidently contrary to both reason and to scripture' in the second edition of his *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*. He cited Paphnucius, a bishop at the Council of Nicaea, who pronounced 'the embraces of a lawful wife to be Chastity. This consists in a moderate and well-regulated use of our passions and senses'.³⁶

The condemnation of celibacy as reprehensible was never just a form of anti-papery in England. By the long eighteenth century it also

stemmed from an understanding that the desire to procreate was natural, even unavoidable. In George Tully's opinion, the impossibility for some of receiving the grace of celibacy, 'proceeds, not from sin, but from an inbred, and warrantable, desire of procreation'.³⁷ Thus Tully attacked the idea of large numbers of people in receipt of the gift of celibacy because he argued that the natural propensity of one sex for the other was heightened since the fall; as a result 'this is absolutely the most violent and predominant Passion to which Humanity is subject'.³⁸ Similarly, Henry Wharton declared 'desire' the 'greatest most vehement passion'.³⁹ This was such a powerful argument that Catholic apologists had to confront it. In 1715 Edward Hawarden published an *Appendix* to his *True Church of Christ* in which he tackled four areas that caused disputes between Protestants and Catholics. Protestants used these to argue that the Church of Rome was idolatrous and superstitious.⁴⁰ One of the appendices dealt with celibacy, and as a defender of Catholic faith and of celibacy, Hawarden rejected the Protestant argument that sexual desire was a natural state:

And the Grace which our Lord, and St Paul after him, owns in them that do this, is not a peculiar Temper of the Body, obliging him that hath it to live single; and him that hath it not, to Marry; but a singular Zeal, to waive that which God makes Lawful for us, that we may the better come to his Kingdom.⁴¹

In contrast, for Anglicans, the view that sexual desire was natural and therefore best contained within marriage supported a very positive view of marital sex and its benefits. The *Essay on Celibacy* of 1753, addressed to unmarried adults of both sexes, was dominated by the thesis that marital sex was both essential and pleasurable. Like some of the writers discussed in chapter one, for this author, it was possible to modestly discuss the procreative ends of the body because 'All the works of God are good'.⁴² The benefits were not solely to boost procreation to replenish and expand the population in the Britain and her colonies, but had merit for individual as well as social benefits. Church and state worked in harmony 'for as it [marriage] is a natural, so the wisest nations have always made it a civil and established churches often a sacred, institution'.⁴³ The author thus recommended that people 'regularly indulge the generative inclination.' This was firmly a religious sentiment. The essay proposed

that all those who reached maturity should marry because that was of 'one spirit with nature, virtue, and true religion'.⁴⁴ Nature fed faith: 'The body must regularly gratify its sensations, otherwise the soul will be immoral'.⁴⁵

By using a vocabulary of natural law, procreation, and restraint, or 'conjugal chastity', the Church offered an extremely positive account of sex. Edward Barry's essay on wedlock (1799) stated that 'in nature there are desires which are neither criminal nor shameful, under due obedience and restraint'. He argued that these were common to the human race and likened them to the emotions of fear, hope, and sorrow, explaining that if it was accepted that these feelings had dominion in the mind then the 'ardent desire of procreation' should be admitted its power.⁴⁶

Anglican Reluctance to Condemn the 'Gift Of Celibacy'

Even after proving to his satisfaction that the Church of Rome's imposition of celibacy on the clergy was contrary to the law of God, Henry Wharton still concluded that 'true Virginitie' was honourable and that he had 'great veneration' for it 'when a matter of choice, not of force', and when entry into it and continuance of it were undertaken for the 'increase of piety' rather than 'secular ends'.⁴⁷ Sarah Apetrei's examination of attitudes towards celibacy in Anglicanism from 1660 to 1700 reveals its ambivalent status for theological writers, representing both sexual hypocrisy and self-discipline. Some Anglicans acknowledged the place of sexual purity in primitive asceticism, while others saw sexual abstinence as ending in perversity, and most were unclear about the extent to which sexual desire should be regarded positively and how it should be channelled.⁴⁸ Such views have been described as a 'long Anglican debate over clerical celibacy' that originated in the inherent ambiguity of the Thirty-Nine Articles' statement on clerical marriage, which made it permissible but not obligatory. Article 32 stated that God's law did not require clerics to vow to abstain from marriage; thus priests could marry if they felt this served their spiritual ends. This phrasing, argues Young, permitted a priest to choose not to marry on religious grounds, thereby opening space for tensions.⁴⁹

In the seventeenth century a few voices from within the Church of England upheld the superior status of clerical celibacy, because it enabled the individual to pursue spiritual life more fully.⁵⁰ These included major

bishops of the era who practised celibacy, such as Archbishop William Sancroft of Canterbury, and Bishop Thomas Ken of Bath and Wells. Non-jurors, as 'the strongest proponents of a patristic, deeply Catholic spirituality' were more likely to promote ascetic spirituality.⁵¹ The Non-juror and devotional writer, William Law, who lost his Cambridge fellowship due to his Jacobite sympathies, for instance, praised celibacy and virginity in *A Practical Treatise Upon Christian Perfection* (1726) acknowledging that they were 'not necessary to Christian perfection, but are much to be commended in those, who chuse them as *helps* and means of a more *safe* and *speedy* arrival at it'. From 1740 to his death in 1761, Law retired to Northamptonshire where he lived an ascetic life of celibacy, prayer and charity.⁵² Some Anglican clergy were not prepared to define celibacy as inferior, only insisting that marriage should not be disparaged. Thus William Secker asked in 1705 'Who knows not that Virginity is a Pearl of sparkling lustre?' The benefits of abstinence for spirituality continued to be argued. Anthony Horneck, for example, insisted that it was the abstemious, disciplined life that elevated the faithful above their brute nature and enabled them to become 'equal to Angels'.⁵³ Nearly forty years later, Thomas Humphreys remarked that both single and married lives had their comforts and uneasinesses.⁵⁴

There are a number of reasons for this toleration of sexual renunciation. The cult of the Virgin Queen, Elizabeth I, had left its legacy.⁵⁵ Anglicans were driven by anti-papery, but their strong interest in 'primitive' Christianity meant that the ascetic ideal continued to have theological power. This asceticism included sexual continence and discussion of celibacy was particularly acute from 1687 to 1688 when the Church and state were in crisis and national moral reform of great concern.⁵⁶ Apetrei points out that the writings of Anthony Horneck (1641–97) inspired the voluntary societies for the reformation of manners, discussed in chapter two. This married clergyman advocated sexual self-control, praising early Christians who were 'Chast and Modest' within marriage, husbands abstaining from their pregnant wives, and engaging only in innocent, procreative sex. Moreover, primitive Christianity encouraged a providentialist belief that sexual discipline facilitated religious and social purity.⁵⁷ Apetrei observes that later Stuart Anglicans struggled to reconcile such providential convictions with the stirrings of enlightened ideas of reason and moderation.⁵⁸

Revealed religion also praised celibacy, partly because it was rooted in primitive Christianity. Thus the Methodists adopted primitive Christian ideals of 'a fellowship composed of unmarried, celibate Members'.⁵⁹ Wesley had been influenced by practising celibates, corresponding with William Law and following his advice on self-restraint and reading from 1732.⁶⁰ Wesley remarked in his list of reasons for remaining single that he was persuaded it "was unlawful for a Priest to marry", grounding that Persuasion on the (supposed) sense of the Primitive Church'.⁶¹ In his publications on single and married life John Wesley cited I Corinthians to agree that, while celibacy was not a universal rule, continence was a gift because it freed the individual from the entanglements, or distractions, of relationships.⁶² For those without the gift of continence, marriage was preferable. Wesley told the 'happy few' who could attain celibacy that they were liberated 'from a thousand nameless domestic trials'.⁶³ He thus recommended that male itinerant preachers and some female exhorters abstain from marriage. For example, in 1782 he wrote to the preacher Zachariah Yewdall that it was the duty of 'a preacher, and . . . a Methodist preacher above all' to remain celibate. Anne Lawrence terms this 'temporal celibacy' and argues that preachers were advised not to marry on predominantly practical grounds, a practice guided by the demands of itinerancy rather than solely spiritual reasons. First, such men could not afford to marry and support dependents while preaching.⁶⁴ Secondly, marriage and family distracted the itinerant preacher from his religious duties. Indeed the majority of Methodist preachers tended to settle in one place and marry only after the intensive period of preaching.⁶⁵ This guidance was certainly taken seriously. The preacher John Valton used his journal writing to consider whether he should marry. In the pros and cons of matrimony he listed in 1767 were that love and a wife would divert him from his spiritual life and role.⁶⁶ Consequently, it is difficult to conclude that pragmatism outweighed religious motivation in Methodist men and women's decisions to live celibately.

Other writers on celibacy differed from Wesley, denying that marriage and children were a distraction from spiritual matters. The author of *An Appendix, containing the Thoughts of Dr Prideaux, Concerning the Celibacy of the Clergy* (1721) rejected the premise that wives side-tracked their clergymen husbands or directed them into secular affairs.⁶⁷ Another pamphlet, published in 1789, also rejected the view that

marital and parental tenderness diverted people from heavenly objects. The author argued that most men looked upon their wives and children as heavenly objects to whom they owed religious duty. Indeed 'our children are the tribute which we owe to Heaven'.⁶⁸ There is also evidence that male Methodists sought wives who would allow their husbands to fulfil their corporate as well as personal spirituality. Thus Samuel Bradburn wrote to his second wife: 'Help me, my lovely and better self by your prayers, your example, to devote my whole self, my life to the glory of the one and blessed God'. In 1798, the itinerant preacher Thomas Dixon prayed in his diary: 'Direct my heart in the choice of one who will truly be helpful to me in the way to glory and keep me from any thoughts that stain my soul and from any one that would hinder me in my work'.⁶⁹

Wesley was also distinctive in that he was one of the most forthright commentators on the merits of celibacy, observing that a man was blessed if he was a 'eunuch' for the Kingdom of Heaven's sake. The ability to resist sexual temptation was for Wesley a sign that the individual was a truly converted Christian.⁷⁰ In his *Thoughts on Marriage and a Single Life* first published in 1743, he asked "'But who are able to keep themselves this pure?" I answer, Every Believer in CHRIST".⁷¹ Such a claim for the single life endorsed Wesley's own sanctity since, he wrote:

Whoever finds Redemption in his Blood, in that Hour receives this Gift of God. Lust then vanishes away: And if they that are born of God, keep themselves, shall never return. So long that wicked one toucheth them not ... So then he that marrieth ... doth well. But he that, having no Necessity, marrieth not, doth better.⁷²

This account, written before Wesley's marriage, was sharply different from the revised edition issued after his marriage had broken down. He stated his belief that celibacy signified redemption more succinctly in his revised edition, renamed in 1765 *Thoughts on a Single Life*: 'In general, I believe, every man is *able to receive it* [gift of celibacy], when he is first justified'.⁷³ The new edition was a much more emphatic endorsement of remaining single. Wesley claimed that the gift of celibacy was often withdrawn, usually because of the fault of the

individual, and for these people marriage was the solution. In such a model, marriage was a flawed, lesser state for people who were sexually incontinent. He accepted that marriage *could* be as holy as remaining single, but sex would always be a problem because it was bodily gratification and diversion from God. To the older Wesley the single life seemed to be unencumbered with such physical matters as sex and raising a family, all of which caused introspection rather than seeking the divine.⁷⁴

In these circumstances it was unsurprising that, as a priest, Wesley rarely conducted marriages and only four are recorded for his whole ministry from 1738 to 1791.⁷⁵ Abelow even sees Wesley's hostility to marriage as the cause of his decision that his mother should be buried in Bunhill Fields with her dissenting forebears, and no mention of his father on her gravestone, rather than in Epworth as the wife of the rector, as was customary.⁷⁶ Wesley described his own marriage to Mary Vazaille as a 'cross' which he undertook out of duty. Some of his followers certainly perceived Wesley to favour celibacy over marriage. In 1785, John Pawson wrote to Charles Atmore, bemoaning that 'Mr Wesley should still endeavour to make us believe that marriage is sinful in the sight of God, when the Apostle tells us it is honourable'.⁷⁷ Nevertheless, though Wesley might stipulate sexual abstinence for itinerant preachers he accepted they would marry once they gave up travelling.⁷⁸ However, there were some Methodist figures who advocated marriage, including John Fletcher, vicar of Madeley, Shropshire, who lived both an ascetic and celibate lifestyle for part of his life. In 1764, for example, he declared his celibate state as a marriage with Christ.⁷⁹ In 1781, in a contrast to Wesley's experience, he married, and then argued that marriage promoted a tender passion, avoided scandals and added a pious and zealous wife to the work of a parish or a preacher. He even told his congregation that he had married not for his own sake but for the parish's.⁸⁰

Consequently the status of celibacy remained ambivalent for Methodists because John Wesley was equivocal about the merits of marriage. In the circumstances of his own relationships, Wesley saw celibacy and a single life as preferable to marriage. Fundamentally, Wesley was ambivalent about sex. At the age of twenty three he had gone to Georgia partly so that he would not be tempted by women's breasts, and his departure to America was an avoidance of sex.⁸¹

John Wesley's uncertainty can also be seen in many of his relationships with women Methodists, as was seen in chapter five. In his correspondence with Anne Bolton, for example, his love for her and their mutual love for God seemed to merge. He asked whether Anne had forgotten him, whether she thought of him, reassured her that he thought of her and that he wanted to receive her letters. This sort of sympathetic correspondence and responsiveness to women's concerns was inevitably attractive and part of his charisma.⁸² Yet Wesley could be stern and paternalistic and sought to restrain their expressions of what he saw as overly emotional language.⁸³ One contemporary observer emphasised that Wesley sought perfection in women and was perhaps therefore always doomed to disappointment.⁸⁴ Wesley's self-conscious conservative piety in matters of sex was also apparent in his brief 1748 tract *A Word to the Street-Walker*. He asked whether the prostitute thought that she was going to heaven or to hell. He told her boldly that she was going to the fires of damnation and that she should turn to Jesus. Wesley argued that a prostitute ruined her body as well as her soul and that if she was worried about how she would eat if she gave up her trade, she should know that God would provide. It was standard Christian fare but few other Anglican clergy in the century directly addressed themselves in writing to prostitutes.

Wesley's support for celibacy was deep rooted. In his list of reasons for remaining single in the 1740s, he explained that reading 'Mystic Writers' had persuaded him that marriage was a less perfect state and that 'some Degree (at least) of "Taint upon the Mind, necessarily attending the Marriage-Bed"'.⁸⁵ Thus sexuality even within marriage was a risk, distracting the individual from spiritual development and religious duties. One concern, in fact, for Methodists about marriage was whether Christian perfection, of which Wesley had become a strong advocate, could be achieved when a married couple engaged in sex. His *Thoughts on Marriage and a Single Life* (1743) he had come to the conclusion that sex within marriage did not 'defile the bed' and was therefore free from uncleanness; he claimed that only a husband and wife 'had power' over each other's bodies. However he also suggested that adultery was a valid cause for divorce: 'it is not lawful for a Man to put away his wife (nor consequently, a Wife her Husband) except only for the Case of adultery.' The revised editions of *Thoughts on a Single Life* conceded that marriage was compatible with perfection: 'persons may be

as holy in a married, as it is possible to be in a Single, State'.⁸⁶ Nonetheless, John Wesley drew clear distinctions between Methodist sexual abstinence and Catholic celibacy.⁸⁷

It may well be that those who condemned celibacy, while conceding that it was a gift for the minority who naturally possessed it, were able to reconcile the two views because it was the Catholic imposition of compulsory celibacy that was their main objection. For example, in 1688, George Tully, rector of Gateshead, published his response to a pamphlet which stated that single life had the advantage over marriage in acts of piety and devotion. Although he took great pains to dismantle his opponent's argument Tully did not entirely denounce celibacy. It was a physical means to a spiritual end but had no intrinsic worth of its own.⁸⁸ It was 'forc'd celibacy' that Tully most condemned.⁸⁹ Similarly, Wharton's condemnation of celibacy lay in the Catholic unjust imposition of it on the clergy: 'an enforced Vertue, and servile Piety, is neither acceptable to God, nor venerable to Men'. Thus he was less critical of celibacy in the early Church because 'their Celibacy was no less chaste than voluntary'.⁹⁰ This remained a feature of anti-celibacy writing for a further century. In 1790, Hawkins described Catholic imposition of clerical celibacy as a 'despotic power'.⁹¹ The somewhat uncertain status of clerical celibacy in Anglican thinking was still evident in the early nineteenth century, and, according to Brian Young, exposed by the position of John Henry Newman. Young proposes that Newman's celibacy was not attributable to latent homosexual desires, nor Roman Catholic leanings, but informed by a 'distinctively Anglican and firmly intellectual tradition'.⁹²

Problems with Achieving Celibacy

As has been seen, John Wesley's later editions of *Thoughts on a Single Life* (1765, 1770, 1784) differed from the original *Thoughts on Marriage and a Single Life* (1743) because he recommended a range of 'helps' towards remaining celibate. Most of these were guides to withstanding temptation. The first bulwark was God, since the celibate was urged to consistently and earnestly pray. A second was social support: to converse frequently with like-minded members of the same sex, disclosing his or her secrets and weaknesses. Others were physical: Wesley advocated exercise and fasting. Crucially, the celibate should

avoid any kind of 'needless Conversation, much more all Intimacy, with those of the Other Sex.' In organising his societies into bands and classes Wesley ordered that preachers should ensure that the young in particular were in large groups, and that men and women should meet separately. Attending worship together in families was something of which Wesley disapproved; the sexes had to be segregated in Methodist meetings. This was not popular with members, but Wesley was insistent, even refusing to preach where the sexes were not separate.⁹³ The final helps against failing in continence were that the celibate must avoid idleness and 'all softness and effeminacy' along with any self-indulgence which would breed appetites and passions'.⁹⁴

Controlling sexual desires effectively undoubtedly preoccupied some of Wesley's followers, despite his reassurances.⁹⁵ John Walsh, for example, who was converted in 1756, found Christian perfection impossible to achieve because of his sexual urges, and when he quizzed other Methodists found that they also struggled. A Mr Joyce claimed that Satan showed him images of naked women at night to tempt him away from righteousness. Walsh was troubled that Christ was perfect, but his own soul was unredeemable because of his lust, consequently he regarded sex as an impediment to real sanctification. Walsh and Joyce were not alone; the preacher John Valton found that lurid sexual imagery occupied his nightmares and waking thoughts, and Zachariah Yewdall was also troubled, in his case by masturbation.⁹⁶

Wesley recognised that celibacy might lead to masturbation. In his *Thoughts on a Single Life*, when offering advice on how to preserve the gift of celibacy, Wesley pointed out 'Need I say. To avoid the Sin of Onan: Seeing Satan will not cast out Satan?'⁹⁷ As discussed in chapter one, masturbation was also a topic on which Wesley wrote. In 1767 he published *Thoughts on the Sin of Onan, Chiefly Extracted from a Late Writer*. The 'late writer' was a Swiss physician, Samuel Tissot. Tissot's original work had been a medical treatise of more than two hundred pages, which Wesley reduced down to twenty.⁹⁸ Wesley's was a surprisingly popular work, being reprinted in 1774 and 1779 and was available for sale at Methodist preaching houses across the country.⁹⁹ It was also one of the books which popularised the idea that masturbation was deleterious to health. Wesley wrote that through masturbation:

the young of both sexes frequently contract the infirmities of old age. They become pale, effeminate, dull, inactive; they lose their Appetite, weaken their sight, their memory, their understanding, and contract all the disorders attending weak nerves. Many bring on thereby a general weakness, and paralytic disorders of all kinds: Yea, lethargies, epilepsies, madness, blindness, convulsions, dropsies, and the most painful of all gout. ¹⁰⁰

What Wesley added to Tissot's original medical treatise was a theological interpretation. This was that masturbation was subject to biblical injunction, and punished with the death penalty in the Bible, and was therefore a sin. The first half of the tract gave an account, in lurid terms, of the various maladies that masturbation caused. The second warned of the spiritual dangers. The notion of masturbation as sin was powerful. One American Methodist preacher, William Ormond, for example, recorded his struggles against the 'sin of masturbation' in his diary in the 1790s. ¹⁰¹ In the conclusion of *Thoughts on the Sin of Onan*, Wesley recommended that the treatment of masturbatory conditions should consist of beef-tea, fresh air and the avoidance of alcohol, acids and fruit, fatty or greasy foods. In their place the patient should eat the 'flesh of all young animals (roasted in their own gravy)', eggs, milk and root vegetables. Above all, he recommended Peruvian bark and cold baths – both of which Wesley had adopted as his own regimen. ¹⁰² Other writers on celibacy only alluded to the dreadful consequences of the physical evils of celibacy. Hawkins, for instance, relegated the awful results of celibacy to a footnote in which he referred the reader to Tissot's *Dissertation sur L'Onanisme* to learn of what happened to those whose passions could not be controlled. ¹⁰³

It is mentioned in chapter seven that Wesley's emphasis on the young may indicate that Wesley found that masturbation was common at Charterhouse and at Oxford. While this is speculative, it is no doubt significant that the universities of Oxford and Cambridge were the main institutions that required male celibacy, with students and fellows required to forego marriage. Young argues that many of those who found celibacy appealing had spent time when young men as college fellows. Indeed these 'most influential bastions of institutionalised clerical celibacy' continued to be influential, shaping John Henry Newman's stance on celibacy adopted before his conversion to Roman

Catholicism.¹⁰⁴ Even though this institutional celibacy lasted until the late nineteenth century, it was already under attack in the late eighteenth century. John Dove criticised the requirement of Oxford and Cambridge that fellows be celibate. He argued that it was inappropriate that such men instructed youths in virtue and pupils in divinity.¹⁰⁵

The fellows themselves also grappled with sexual desire, as will be seen in chapter seven. For instance, the correspondence of the Revd Richard Roach (1662–1730), a fellow of St John's College, Oxford, who did not marry for spiritual and theological reasons, refers to the concerns and struggles in maintaining a celibate lifestyle. He also discussed another fellow who was worried about his feelings of lust. The fellow did not fear fornication, a consequence of forced celibacy which would have been ascribed to Catholic priests, instead he turned his attention to a variety of forms of abstinence, such as restricting diet, which, as Wesley's advice indicated, was considered useful in diminishing desire.¹⁰⁶

The Appeal of the Single Life: Gender, Authority, and Sexuality

Celibacy had gendered attributes. Virginity tended to be seen as a particularly female form of holiness.¹⁰⁷ In the early Church, following the example of the Virgin Mary, women's virginity was accorded great importance and by the later middle ages virginity was gendered almost exclusively as female. The status had not disappeared by the long eighteenth century. *The Ladies Dictionary* (1694) called the 'virgin state' the 'divinest, as coming nearest to that of Angels and blessed Spirits, who live free and unincumbred'.¹⁰⁸ Edward Stephens (d. 1706) who was a Non-juror who set up a religious society for women in 1696, wrote *A Letter to a Lady* in the same year which stated that female voluntary celibacy, whether through virginity or widowhood, was esteemed as honourable in the Church.¹⁰⁹ Male celibacy could also be respected since it required considerable self-restraint. Indeed, a mainstream, middle-class version of mature masculinity throughout the long eighteenth century was bound up with self-restraint, even a degree of abstinence. This self-control extended to sexual behaviour for Protestant men in the ages of politeness, feeling, and domesticity. Though commentators sometimes associated celibate men with effeminacy, this was related to their likely resort to masturbation which was seen as weakening them.

Apetrei also links this focus on sexual restraint over sexual prowess to moral condemnation of the behaviour at the later Stuart court which was seen as lewd, debauched and effeminate, as discussed in chapter two.¹¹⁰

Voluntarily adopting the single life also offered some women the opportunity to overcome various gender restrictions and, as Sarah Apetrei observes, to transcend their gender identity. For some elite women writers in the later seventeenth century, for example, the single life was perceived to be a rejection of female identity and a route to religious freedom, even a higher masculine style of spirituality.¹¹¹ Mary Astell, for example, advocated chastity in her *Serious Proposal to the Ladies* (1694) which recommended that women organise themselves into communal monastic retreats. Astell was influenced by Neo-platonism and Jeremy Taylor's work *Holy Living* (1650) in which he stated that life 'being empty of cares, it is full of prayers'.¹¹² Ruth Perry sees Astell's proposal for women to remain single as a call for women to nurture their rational independent selves. She also argues that women like Astell saw celibacy as a way to avoid the dangers of the reproductive aspects of marriage which brought the risk of death and disability from childbirth at worst, and the distractions of child-rearing at best.

Celibacy may well have elevated some women's status. Catherine Talbot (1721–70) garnered great respect for her pious Anglicanism in her lifetime and thereafter thanks to the posthumous publication of her devotional writings. She never married and served as amanuensis, secretary, housekeeper, and de facto curate to her adoptive father, Thomas Secker, who became Archbishop of Canterbury. Secker's household is considered in chapter eight. In the final year of her life, Elizabeth Montagu described Catherine as 'the most pure, holy, & righteous. To the strictness, regularity, & abstraction, of an almost Monastick [sic] retirement, she added all the meritorious acts of a busy life ... I know not such another instance of a perfectly good life'.¹¹³

Celibacy was not restricted to single women. Glimpses of the sex life of married couples in the past are rare. Unusually, however, among the prolific writings of Lady Sarah Cowper are insights into the part of sexual abstinence within their forty two years of married life. As discussed in chapter four, Sarah wed William Cowper in 1664 and they had four sons from 1665 to 1669.¹¹⁴ The union was a disaster with conflict over who held power in the household and his inadequate control of their servants. Sarah reflected on this retrospectively in her diary begun 1700 when she

was fifty-six and continued after William's death in 1706. She was a pious moderate Anglican and though her natal family was Whig she adopted a nonpartisan political stance. Both positions contributed to her 'redefinition of feminine domestic roles in order to assert her own righteousness versus her husband'.¹¹⁵ Typically Sarah compared her own and William's behaviour with scripture and leading writings on marital conduct and found his wanting, often through her personal reinterpretation and reordering of the sources she consulted. As her biographer notes, one of the most drastic of her reconfiguring standard gender doctrine was 'to cast sexual abstinence within marriage as a virtue' and to earn praise for herself as a wife.¹¹⁶ Sarah explained:

[I] reckon my Self a Mirrour of Chastity, Even beyond the most intact virgin, for to Conceive four Children without knowing what it is to have an unchast thought or Sensual pleasure and being but 26 when the last was born have Ever since then remain'd pure – is a thing Scarce to be match'd by a married woman, and a Reflection that without Vanity may justly delight me'.¹¹⁷

Anne Kugler observes that Sarah misinterpreted commentaries on St Paul's first letter to Timothy and conduct books, conflating advice that wives be pure and chaste to mean celibate. For Kugler, Sarah 'failed to fulfil her sexual obligation, she went on to dramatically misconstrue, or at least wilfully ignore, two Protestant doctrinal points regarding marriage: first, that chastity should not be equated with celibacy; and second, that celibacy is not a virtue'. Given the discussion above, however, about the Anglican church's degree of ambivalence in condemning celibacy, the lack of clarity about the terminology of sexual continence, and the concept of 'conjugal chastity', it is perhaps easier to understand how Sarah arrived at her pride in her sexual abstinence within matrimony.¹¹⁸

The ability to side-step conventions through celibacy was shared by a few women of more modest social rank, particularly Methodists, since the movement celebrated the single life.¹¹⁹ A significant number of Methodist women, inspired by Wesley, chose to remain single.¹²⁰ Mary Bosanquet, wife of a leading Methodist, John Fletcher, thought that 'every deviation from [Jesus] is a degree of spiritual adultery'.¹²¹ Some Methodists regarded themselves as obliged to make a choice between

love of God and human love. Susannah Claggett, who had internalised the Methodist faith-language of bridegrooms and marriage, noted in chapter five, found herself attracted to a man and contemplated marriage in the middle of the century. Then she heard an inner voice which she took to be Christ 'as if I had heard His voice with my outward ear' and it said 'give up that person; or give me up' and later, on a walk, she felt that Christ had revealed himself as her 'eternal bridegroom'.¹²² Such Methodist women were accorded the title 'Mothers in Israel' and generally undertook roles in exhorting, preaching, and promoting the cause, all of which were difficult to do within married life.¹²³ For example, when Sarah Crosby was deserted by her husband she deliberately followed a life as a 'celibate Mother in Israel'.¹²⁴

Some celibate female Methodists recounted their route to sexual renunciation through problematic marriages or sexual relationships, such as Sarah Ryan who was embroiled in scandal over her polygamous marital state.¹²⁵ Lawrence defines this as self-determination, with the women deploying celibacy to reject parental, spousal, or societal control.¹²⁶ Timothy Jones similarly concludes that from the mid-nineteenth century Anglican women who chose to be celibate and live within the homo social community of a sisterhood were empowered by living in this (only) alternative to the patriarchal family.¹²⁷ Some contemporary commentators certainly viewed women withdrawing from marriage as indicating an attempt to escape dependence upon men.¹²⁸ Seeman argues, for example, that ministers in New England utterly condemned celibacy because the settlers relied upon patriarchal familial authority as the key to social order, which sexual abstinence and non-normative family types undermined.¹²⁹

It is unwise, however, to see such women's decisions as primarily motivated by the desire for personal liberty. While Mary Astell was offering an alternative to marriage this was not a socially radical move, for example, in the sense of disparaging wedlock.¹³⁰ Astell was High Church rather than Latitudinarian, a Tory who believed that the submission and obedience owed to the monarch was absolute rather than contractual.¹³¹ As such, her proposal that women retreat to all-women communities instead of marrying was an argument for withdrawal not gender upheaval.¹³² This view is most evident in her *Some Reflections upon Marriage* (1700), in which she reminded women that the marriage contract necessitated their absolute obedience to their husbands. Women

could therefore either select a husband who deserved such obedience or they could abjure entering such a contract. Thus, as Ruth Perry comments, she 'advised women to think long and hard before entering voluntarily into the tyrannical relationship of marriage'.¹³³ Catherine Talbot may have been admired as a model of angelic virtue, but she did not choose to be unmarried since she turned down marriage with George Berkeley due to family opposition.¹³⁴ Moreover, the transcendence and agency that Methodist women sought was spiritual and achieved through personal surrender to God. It was common for female celibates to write of Jesus as their loving bridegroom. In 1773 Sarah Crosby wrote in her diary, following the dissolution of her marriage, 'I need no man, who all possess, In Jesu's heart-felt love'.¹³⁵ Anne Cutler, or 'praying Nanny', recorded in her journal that she kept her body and soul pure as a 'chaste virgin to Christ for ever'.¹³⁶

Changing Ideas About Celibacy, Society, and Well-Being

Several of the social, cultural, and intellectual factors that shaped ideas about celibacy changed over the long eighteenth century. Enlightenment thinking also influenced negative judgements of celibacy. In 1799 the Reverend Edward Barry tackled celibacy among a number of essays on subjects as diverse as suicide, temperance, and boxing. He observed that 'religion, however it may in darker and superstitious ages, have been disguised to impose on mankind a life of *celibacy*, surely ought not in this enlightened day, to be used as an argument of *itself* for continuing in that state'.¹³⁷ He suggested that other 'sufficient reasons' could be presented, such as health, convenience, and poverty. Nonetheless, this was by no means a secular, enlightened, reasoning replacing a religious argument. Barry still deployed scriptural evidence to argue against celibacy, and in promoting wedlock as a 'sacred institution' noted its scriptural and moral benefits, as well as its medical ones. Essentially, the Enlightenment seems to have added additional factors to the discussion of celibacy rather than secularised it.¹³⁸ Religion remained one of the main rhetorical frameworks for discussion and a key weapon wielded against lifelong celibacy.

Apetrei argues that late seventeenth-century commentators on female celibacy were concerned that it undermined civil ties and sociability. A woman's letter published in *The Athenian Gazette* on 1 October 1695,

enquired whether 'a contemplative life withdrawn from "the delights of Society and Conversation", was not venerated' in the past and permissible for those who held this gift from God. The editors replied that "'A Solitary Life" was not "a State of Life which God has designed for mankind. He has made us Sociable, and required us to be so"'.¹³⁹ The conceptualisation of celibacy as withdrawal from society and an attack on civil society was further developed in the eighteenth century. So, although the religious framework remained intact, the deliberately unmarried were condemned for corrupting sociability. One author in 1753 stated that celibacy produced 'a dissolution of manners or civility'.¹⁴⁰

Celibates were also attacked for their selfishness, refusal to serve the world, failure to contribute to its expansion and improvement by not reproducing, and their hobbling of the economy by restricting the circulation of property. *The Essay on Celibacy* observed that it was a form of ingrossing and hoarding since their property was retained rather than distributed.¹⁴¹ Indeed the link between celibacy and a less civilised state was increasingly pronounced. Despite the relatively traditional style of Hawkins's *An Essay on the Law of Celibacy Imposed on the Clergy of the Roman Catholic Church* (1728), he also commented that only in places where matrimony was esteemed 'will mankind become more civilised, more virtuous, and more happy'.¹⁴² In 1794 another author observed that the 'wisdom of modern ages has corrected this unjustifiable perversion of the laws of nature, reason, and revelation'. Not only were those countries which revolted against the 'tyrannical injunction of Celibacy upon any set of men' reformed (presumably in the Protestant sense), they were civilised.¹⁴³

Originally denounced for its effect upon society, later eighteenth-century writers also condemned celibacy's impact on the individual. Thus condemnation of institutionally-directed celibacy was joined in the later eighteenth century by attacks on voluntary celibacy more generally. For instance, the author of *Essay on Celibacy* declared that 'determined celibacy, during the whole meridian of life, is a vice, as it is a practical denial of the wisdom and rectitude of our formation. To justify it is to reproach our Maker . . . to corrupt our reason against the law of God'.¹⁴⁴ By this point, the emphasis was upon the individual who was 'determined' to abstain from marriage. Thus Hawkins's *Essay on the Law of Celibacy* . . . claimed celibacy was 'destructive of the happiness of

individuals and of society' whether viewed from moral, physical, or political perspective.¹⁴⁵ This would appear to fit the shift from illicit sex as a sin, to a more 'private' individualised issue.¹⁴⁶

This attention to the individual may help explain a further changing feature of discussions of celibacy from the mid-eighteenth century in which some writers shifted their attention from the Catholic corruption of scriptural statements on celibacy to a harsher attack on single people. This former did not disappear, by any means. For example, Hawkins's *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*, was a learned denunciation of celibacy which followed earlier formats in arguing against the state as divinely instituted through a lengthy exposition of its history. Yet the ire of writers was increasingly directed at the celibate more widely, and not just the question of clerical continence, in the form of unmarried men and women. An *Essay on Celibacy* accused 'the whimsical, selfish and petulant train of rusty, or impotent, superannuated bachelors, and wilfully barren old maids' and thought they should be 'beaten with many stripes'.¹⁴⁷ The majority of this essay described the physical, emotional, and personality deficiencies of the voluntarily single person. John Dove went even further in 1769 denouncing the bachelor as 'a stagnant nasty pool' who was more inclined to mischief, cruelty, bloodshed, and murder. He told his reader that such men could be recognised from their 'leer' and 'rank smell'.¹⁴⁸

This emphasis on a voluntary celibate life may well explain comments on celibacy in Oxford and Cambridge. In 1794 'a member of the University of Cambridge' published *A Letter on the Celibacy of Fellows of Colleges*. He was responding to a letter in a newspaper which attacked the university's demand for celibacy, offering different reasons to condemn it. While using the standard arguments against celibacy, the writer took pains to defend the fellows against the observation that they were voluntarily celibate. Effectively, the men's tacit agreement was due solely to inexperience. He explained that the fellows were so dazzled by the honours attached to a fellowship that they overlooked the hardships when they accepted it. In his view, the men simply did not know at that point how difficult celibacy was, only realising its discomforts 'when it is imposed'.¹⁴⁹ This author's proposed solution to the structural barriers to fellows' marriage was practical, not religious. Nonetheless, he did not relegate the central religious grounds for their imposed celibacy; he argued that the fellows' professional duties would be improved by their

marriage; after all, he insisted, the clergy who were married had characters and modes of life that were more clerical and were more successful since they possessed larger congregations who regularly attended.¹⁵⁰

Discussions of celibacy were also spurred on by understandings of population; a field contributed to by both Enlightenment thinkers and Anglican clergymen.¹⁵¹ Such discussions were rooted in the procreative function of marriage. Tully's 1688 work on the merits of the married state over celibacy observed that God made people to increase and that propagation was the first end of marriage and that there was no evidence that God exempted those who ministered at the altar.¹⁵² The long eighteenth century saw a transition in thinking about population from a determination to increase numbers, believing this strengthened the nation, to a concern at the turn of the eighteenth century that population increase was unfettered and would damage the economic and social well-being of nation and people. This was closely linked to ideas about celibacy. The correlation also existed in Catholic countries. Hecht's study of France shows that Enlightenment thinkers argued that celibacy caused debauchery, spread sexually-transmitted infections, and increased illegitimacy, although less militantly anti-Catholic authors saw celibacy as merely one cause of depopulation. Indeed she sees this as a 'populationist ideal' that expanded with the Protestant Reformation in which lay and religious celibacy was categorised as immoral and stunting population growth.¹⁵³

When the population was perceived to be too small (or when a large population was celebrated), celibacy was condemned because it limited demographic expansion; when population growth was deemed to undercut national advancement, some form of celibacy was recommended.¹⁵⁴ For example, Erik Seeman found harsher attitudes towards celibacy in New England from 1600 to 1800 compared with England due to different population pressures and disciplinary structures. He points out that English clergy were less willing to denounce celibacy from the later sixteenth century, when demographic expansion led to competition for resources and left people abstaining from marriage (up to 20 per cent did not marry in the seventeenth-century whereas 8.16 per cent remained single in the cohort born 1751).¹⁵⁵

This is a convincing argument and helps explain the Anglican ambivalence over celibacy; but it should be noted that some criticism of

celibacy was due to its potential to weaken the nation by draining its population, as remarked by William Lloyd, a Whig bishop.¹⁵⁶ Around the mid-eighteenth century the risks of celibacy in reducing the population were firmly argued. The author of *An Essay on Celibacy*, for example, discussed the bad effects of celibacy under three characteristic discourses: first that it diminished the inhabitants of the world, second, with them would also disappear the conveniences and necessities of life, and third that celibacy weakened civil ties.¹⁵⁷ Families with lots of children were the best members of society who brought benefits for their nation.¹⁵⁸ Celibates attacked public welfare, weakened the nation, were unpatriotic and held back the nation economically, culturally, and intellectually.¹⁵⁹ This could facilitate harsh condemnation, as demonstrated by 'a Friend to Procreation', published in 1789. This author condemned celibacy as 'a doctrine criminal, fallacious and unjustifiable; and expressly against the laws of God, and (of course) the *inalienable rights of nature*'.¹⁶⁰

This view came under pressure at the start of the nineteenth century as perceptions of population growth changed again. The archetypal example of this was Thomas Malthus's *Essay on the Principle of Population*. He identified an unsustainable relationship between population expansion and food supplies, the first increasing geometrically and therefore outstripping the second, which expanded arithmetically. Malthus prophesied that populations faced vice and misery since they were subjected to natural controls through positive checks such as famine and disease and by preventive checks such as vice (artificial contraception, abortion). His solution was 'moral restraint' where men who could not afford to support a family voluntarily remained unmarried or celibate.¹⁶¹ This was intended to be temporary and indeed a spur to industriousness since like other clergymen, Malthus was of the opinion that sexual desire was a natural passion that should be fulfilled – though only in marriage. So Malthus shared the same language as those who denounced celibacy and its deleterious impact on population growth. Like them, he saw sexual desire as a law of nature, strong, and general and extremely difficult to control, especially for those in their late teens and early twenties. Similarly, he insisted that sex outside marriage was a violation that produced evil because illegitimacy would increase population, as well as being sinful. He discussed marital sex in a positive manner and acknowledged the harshness of his warning that

those without means should abstain from marriage, indeed he acknowledged that it was liable to withhold happiness from them.¹⁶²

Malthus produced a twist on the later eighteenth-century criticism of the individual celibate's failure to contribute to society, however. Earlier clergymen warned that celibates damaged social ties, whereas Malthus claimed that those who married without the means of supporting children diminished general happiness. This was not a secular argument of course; he explained that he who 'commits this act . . . offends against the will of God, as well as violating his duty to his neighbours'.¹⁶³ Other clergymen were influenced by Malthus's thesis of celibacy in the form of 'moral restraint'. Edward Barry's essay on celibacy in 1799 offered poverty as a tolerable plea for remaining celibate: 'Poverty also offers various excuses for continuing in the unwilling state of *celibacy*; her fears of giving misery to children as yet unborn, fix where she is; but this objection to marriage is perhaps more humane and plausible, than it is real and adviseable'.¹⁶⁴

Conclusion

Hecht sees the French debate over celibacy as related to secularisation. She links the 'revolution' in perceptions of celibacy and population (and a shift in practice from temporary celibacy to coitus-interruptus) to Enlightenment and revolutionary ideologies, albeit for different reasons. The former, she proposes, sought to encourage nuptiality and procreation; thus an enlightened society aimed to punish celibacy and reward fertile marriage. The latter fought to promote welfare, freedom, and happiness, so for them celibacy was a 'capital crime', although their goal was to achieve more equality rather than population growth. In France, argues Hecht, the shift from condemning celibacy to approving it was a sign of French society 'dechristianising itself'.¹⁶⁵ Such views offer a crude polarity between supposedly religious and secular positions which did not in fact exist. David Nash defines this as 'the secularisation thesis – fundamentally the argument that the importance of religious practice and belief is in inexorable (and inevitable) decline as a fundamental process introduced by the arrival of modern society and its consequences', and shows that this is far from the case.¹⁶⁶ It was often clergymen who discussed celibacy and even when it was tacitly recommended in the form of 'moral restraint', by Malthus,

most notably, secular and religious reasons were entwined to promote economic wellbeing, personal happiness, and moral virtue. As these debates about celibacy indicate forcefully, it was non-procreative sex that was identified as dangerous to society. The following chapter explores one of the aspects of non-reproductive sex that was seen as most threatening: same-sex desire and sodomy, to reveal the complex part that the Church played in shaping both its regulation and its toleration.

CHAPTER 7

THE CHURCH, SODOMY, AND SAME-SEX DESIRES

Most historians of sexuality follow David Halperin's lead in considering a variety of pre-homosexual discourses and patterns, rather than pursuing a single history of homosexuality. These discourses include sodomy, friendship, and effeminacy.¹ Historically the term 'sodomy' often included a wide array of sexual behaviour, including illicit heterosexual sex and masturbation, as well as homosexual behaviour. The definition of sodomy, from the Tudor period onwards, was unnatural sex, which was defined as non-procreative in purpose. Even masturbation and nocturnal emission was therefore regarded as sodomy by some.² However this chapter addresses the narrow use of the term to mean sexual contact between men. In the eighteenth century popular and religious responses to same-sex behaviour and desire were unstable and inconsistent; it is problematic therefore to identify a single conception of same-sex activity and desire. As seen in chapter two the Church appeared to be willing to overlook monarchs' homosexuality in the face of the more pressing demands of defending the Protestant settlement of 1689. Nevertheless the Church acted with remarkable savagery towards the molly culture in the 1720s and 1730. Paradoxically, at other times, churchmen seemed unwilling to prosecute or condemn sodomy, and even willing to collude in the evasion of punishment in some homosocial environments in which tolerance was more prevalent. So if there is a field of religion and human sexuality in this period which most exemplifies the need to avoid a Whiggish interpretation of an upward path from

darkness to sunlit uplands it is that of same-sex activity. This is reflected in wider discussions of the nature of homosexuality in the eighteenth century and the historical divergence of interpretations between those who emphasise the repression and punishment of sodomy and those who lay stress on its gradual toleration.³ These divergent opinions should not be viewed as exclusive categories since both repression and tolerance were evident in the period.

The Contribution of a Religious Perspective to Debate about Same-Sex Desire

The eighteenth century has been identified as a period of changes in attitudes towards same-sex behaviour.⁴ There are two main arguments to consider. The first is whether the century saw a long-term shift from understanding same-sex behaviour as a cluster of sinful acts to perceiving it to be a form of self-identity. Initially, the late nineteenth century was proposed as the era in which same-sex acts became associated with a homosexual identity. Randolph Trumbach and Rictor Norton, however, identify this shift earlier in the eighteenth century with the advent of mollies and molly houses. The most widely known of these was Margaret Clap's molly house in Field Lane, Holborn. Clap's molly house was raided in 1725 and forty men were arrested, including Gabriel Lawrence, mentioned later in this chapter. Accounts by informants included that the men dressed as women, and the house had a 'chapel' and 'marrying room' in which they were 'married' before they had sex. The ceremonies seem to have been a bitter parody of the Church's sanction, which homosexuals were denied, though in their mimicry there might also have been a desire for the legitimising vows and communal witness. Moreover there were other instances in which long-term relationships were celebrated in the marriage ceremonies.⁵

Trumbach and Norton have argued that mollies' cross-dressing and gender-inversion helped create a form of homosexual identity before the late nineteenth century, or at least a recognisable sub-culture with which homosexual men could identify. For Trumbach, the effeminacy associated with mollies in the early eighteenth century led to its increasing identification with homosexual activities, helping to form a homosexual subculture or identity.⁶ This shift is often represented by the statement made by William Brown, one of the mollies prosecuted in

May 1726 in the raid on Mother Clapp's molly house and condemned, with another three of the men arrested, to the gallows for sodomy. At his trial Brown claimed that 'there is no crime in making what use I please of my own body.'⁷

Brown's statement also links to the other major claim about attitudes towards same-sex activities in the long eighteenth century. As part of his broader assertion that the Enlightenment led to a sexual revolution, Faramerz Dabhoiwala argues that the eighteenth century saw sexual liberty extended to homosexual acts. He suggests that 'the new approaches to human nature, law, and ethics that had advanced the idea of heterosexual liberty also made it increasingly possible by the later eighteenth century to defend homosexual freedom in equivalently wide-ranging, cogent, and dispassionate terms' though it was 'a semi-clandestine, alternative, minority pattern of argument in justification of same-sex relations'.⁸

These stances need to be carefully considered and nuanced. The view that homosexuality has a unitary history has been largely overturned, and scholars understand same-sex activities as diverse behaviour and identities subject to considerable change over time and place.⁹ The current scholarly consensus is that there was homosexual behaviour in the premodern world without homosexual identity. Phillips and Reay observe that a dichotomy of 'acts versus identities' is simply too crude, cautioning against placing modern sex categories on people in the past.¹⁰ Harry Cocks argues that it is impossible to support the 'idea that sex/gender "systems" succeed each other in a temporal, linear sequence'.¹¹ In fact there is substantial evidence that different patterns of sexual behaviour co-existed, shaped by class, gender, and ethnicity. So it is unlikely that a new effeminate sexual identity was created in the first two decades of the eighteenth century which came to define all men who participated in homoerotic acts. There is little conclusive evidence that the term molly (or later equivalents such as Margery and Maryann) became pseudonyms for a homosexual 'type'. Scholars have shown that sodomy tended to be used as a descriptive term rather than molly.¹² Furthermore, sodomy continued to be understood as a range of behaviour in the nineteenth century, mostly sexual, but still related to general immorality, excess, and intemperance. Like early modern people, Victorians thought 'that "unnatural desire" resulted from a long process of moral degeneration. In this reading, minor infractions led to greater

ones, the final destination being the ultimate symbol of moral abandonment: sodomy'.¹³ So it is difficult to accept the claim that the eighteenth century saw a coherent rethinking of sodomy. Dabhoiwala acknowledges that official and unofficial attacks on sodomy increased at the same time as arguments justifying sodomy emerged. Moreover the texts he drew on were small in number and in some cases unpublished, so he probably overstates the claim of a major change in attitudes.¹⁴

For the most part, the prevailing view in the long eighteenth century was that male same-sex activities were a form of lust, the result of loss of self-control rather than a specific personal identity. This spanned the libertine behaviour of the Restoration through to the Romantic movement.¹⁵ Explanations for such loss of control included that younger men prosecuted for sodomy were often held to have been seduced by older wealthy men in London: 'drawn away to such lewdness for the lucre of money.'¹⁶ Others regarded it as sin into which men fell under the influence of alcohol. The Revd Lewis Stephens, writing to his friend the MP Francis Gregor commented:

I seldom drink any wine but when I have Guests: my method of living is quite abstemious . . . it w'd be well, if small beer was restored again; & the plain food & the great industry of the first Reformers. Within a few years two heads of Houses in Oxford have withdrawn on strong Suspicions of Sod[o]my, nothing but drunkenness could beget such an unnatural daughter. Bridles govern the violent heats of the horse; and Temperance is the only bridle that restrains the violent passions of men; and leads them on, in a gentle & stately pace, to ye pleasant fields of Virtue.¹⁷

Sodomy was typically cast as a vice in formal statements by Anglicans; in 1727 Bishop Richard Smalbroke of St Davids congratulated the Society for the Reformation of Manners for having prosecuted 'unnatural vice' by targeting molly houses.¹⁸

Sermons and discourses that raised the issue of sodomy treated it similarly; William Harris preached on the issue in 1739. In two sermons he claimed that one of the features which led to God's destruction of Sodom was the open sinfulness of its inhabitants: 'they did not artfully conceal their wickedness, or run into corners to commit it; but they did it in the face of the sun, as well as before the Lord . . . they gloried in their

shame, and foamed out over their shame.¹⁹ For Harris, sodomy was thus a marker of excessive and public sin. Harris also developed his analysis of sodomy as a sin through a medical analogy: the pride which lay at the root of sodomy was 'as contrary to nature, and as great a deformity to the mind, as a tumour or swelling is to the body.' The root cause was growing affluence and independence from God: 'the pride and luxury, and extravagance of life, beyond men's figure and fortune in the world.'²⁰ Here the road to moral ruin was set in motion by luxury and could endanger men in higher as well as lower social ranks.

The language of homosexual acts as sin and vice was just as prevalent in the nineteenth century. Accounts of the executions of convicted sodomites were often reported in extraordinarily religious terms. In 1812 David Thompson Myers, a Stamford draper, was convicted of sodomy at Peterborough and executed there on 8 May. In his last few days, while a petition for clemency to the Prince Regent was submitted and rejected, he was attended by the vicar of Peterborough, Joseph Pratt, and the incumbent of Orton, Septimus Courtney. Pratt and Courtney seemed to have done their work well as Myers said he was grateful to them for being the agents of divine providence in persuading him to repent of his sin. On the Sunday before his execution he took Communion and on the morning of his execution said he had never been happier in the last fourteen years. On the gallows, in front of a crowd of six thousand, he prayed and when he was dropped on the noose was heard to shout 'Lord remember me!' Before his death he asked that a statement be inserted in the local newspapers which crafted his declaration of guilt in a religious tone:

I desire to repent before God with a broken and contrite heart. I forgive, from the bottom of my soul, every one who has wronged me; and I earnestly pray to Almighty God that *my untimely end may be a warning to others, who are walking in the same path*. Oh! may my shameful death put a stop to that dreadful crime! *may those who have been partakers with me in my crimes be brought to true repentance!!* I am a miserable sinner in the sight of God, and I am deservedly degraded in the sight of man. But I commit my guilty polluted soul into the hands of my blessed Saviour, to be pardoned and cleansed by him. And though I deserve nothing but punishment for my sins, I trust, thro' the merits of my Redeemer, when I leave

this wicked and miserable world, to be received into a World of Purity and Peace.

The statement was countersigned by Mr Pratt.²¹

Such accounts retain the flavour of the Newgate Calendar, in which convicts served as repentant exemplars of deterrence, portraying the road to ruin which they had taken, intended to dissuade others from committing the same offence. Presumably, the language of escalating vice also held the potential for forgiveness and repentance in life. For example the Independent preacher John Church remained popular after his conviction for sodomy and on the evening of his release from gaol in 1819 preached to a huge congregation. He resumed the life of a respectable dissenting minister, publishing a number of sermons.²²

Some men, including clergymen, indulged in homosexual behaviour, but this did not amount to a coherent personal identity. In December 1721 Mr Duffus, a Nonconformist, had been charged with a homosexual assault on Nicholas Leader. Duffus had kissed Leader and got on his back and 'forcibly entred his Body about an Inch'. Duffus told Leader that he should not be concerned as he had done the same with a number of men. Leader was nevertheless prosecuted; Duffus, who tried to run away, said 'they were all Sinners, and it was hard for a Man to suffer for the first Fault.'²³ Duffus defined his behaviour as a strong inclination, performed with several men. Nonetheless he adopted the language of sin not identity. In fact, his claim, that all men were sinners and that it was unfair to prosecute a man for Original Sin, was one that seemed to suggest homosexuality was no different from other moral crimes which did not carry a criminal liability.

Equally, Mary Griffiths, servant of Robert Fawcett who she discovered had participated in a same-sex act, reported that 'upon her asking her Master if he was not ashamed of being Guilty of such An Action, he replied that it was an Unhappy gift that God has given him, and he could not Live without it.'²⁴ Other men used the concept of inclination to demonstrate that same-sex behaviour was far easier for some to resist than others. Joseph Horler's account of the life of the Deist Thomas Chubb reported that:

I have heard a Reverend Vicar of a neighbouring Town, whose Clark (sic) had more than once adorned its Pillory for Sodomitical

Practices, declare often, that he never had the least Inclination to a Woman in his Life, though then near Seventy; and some Folk will pronounce as strong an Aversion to Wine, or other good Liquors. That these People “kept their Bodies in Temperance, Soberness, and Chastity,” was very well; but surely no great Virtue in either, any more than it would be in me, or another Man, to abstain from Parmesan, to which we have a like natural Antipathy.²⁵

So the complete absence of heterosexual inclination seemed to be a condition of nature rather than an abandonment of God. Perhaps this was the reason for Chubb's rejection of ideas of Original Sin and his universal sense of religious toleration.²⁶

One of the few significant defences of homosexuality in the eighteenth century was written by Thomas Cannon, son of the dean of Lincoln and grandson of a bishop of Ely.²⁷ Cannon's *Ancient and Modern Pederasty Investigated and Exemplify'd* (1749) defended sodomy through precedent in antiquity and as a natural act. Dabhoiwala observes that by the 1740s classically educated men such as Cannon used classical precedent to construct a 'homosexual consciousness'.²⁸ The text of *Ancient and Modern Pederasty* contained pornographic stories from Ancient Greece and Rome, together with occasional gossip about more recent individuals whom Cannon only identified obliquely. Cannon wrote:

Among the many unspeakable benefits which redound to the world from the Christian religion, no one makes a more conspicuous figure than the demolition of pederasty. That celebrated passion, seal'd by sensualists, espoused by philosophers, enshrin'd by kings, is now exploded with one accord and disowned by the meanest beggar.²⁹

Cannon asked why so many ancients had enjoyed homosexuality. It was not, he suggested, because it had 'the flavour of forbidden fruit' and concluded that 'the theology of the ancients plainly shews, they preferred the horrible passion to the love of women.' He implied that sodomy was in part a response to the male disquiet at sex with pregnant women and the fear of injury to embryos. For Cannon, same-sex desire was natural, and to suggest otherwise was 'downright nonsense.' He went on:

Desire is an amatory impulse of the most inmost human parts. Are not they, however constructed, and consequently impelling, nature? Whatever modes of thinking the mind from objects receives, whatever sensations pervade the body, are not the mind and body part of nature, necessarily receiving these thoughts, necessarily pervaded by these sensations? Nature sometimes assume an unusual appearance; but the extraordinary pederast seeking fru-t-on [fruition] is as naturally acted as the ordinary woman's man in that pursuit.³⁰

It is important not to assume that Cannon represented the birth of a secularised, modern view of homosexual desire. Fellow authors regarded him as a sodomite seeking to defend his sinful sexuality. Indeed, *Ancient and Modern Pederasty* attracted public attention and was prosecuted for its 'wicked, lewd and obscene notions' because it challenged Christianity for condemning homosexual acts. Cannon fled to France and remained there for three years; his printer, John Purser, was arrested and imprisoned. In 1755 Cannon's mother petitioned the Duke of Newcastle to drop the charges against him and this seems to have happened. He was permitted to return without prosecution on condition that he retracted his views in *Ancient and Modern Pederasty*, though this was never published. Thereafter Cannon lived a reclusive life near Windsor and devoted himself to religious observance.

It is unlikely that Cannon's work was particularly influential. In fact *Ancient and Modern Pederasty* was not widely read and no copy seems to have survived. Its contents are only known from the indictment of John Purser, the printed copies of which sold for a shilling and contained extracts which the authorities regarded as the most shocking.³¹ Nor can Cannon's defence be seen as a moment in the formation of a homosexual identity. Charles Upchurch observes that there were several 'moments' in time when men built an identity around a positive interpretation of same-sex desire. The most studied moment is of course in the late nineteenth century. However, there were similar configurations in the 1820s with 'elite men in both periods, under the threat of intensified persecution from the state, us[ing] their economic and cultural capital to craft a narrative using available cultural texts that allowed them to form a positive interpretation of their internal desires.' Like Cannon in the mid-eighteenth century, the elite establishment of the 1820s used

the texts of antiquity to define themselves. Upchurch also observes that these sexual identities were transitory and restricted to a small group of men and neither confirm nor deny that there were individuals who exclusively felt same-sex desires.³²

The Church's Attitudes towards Sodomy in the Long Eighteenth Century

The Church placed such a high value on procreative sex that this understanding of sexuality moulded ideas about non-procreative sex, which included hetero- and homosexual anal sex, oral sex, and masturbation. Christianity regarded homosexual acts as sinful; a view informed by the Old and New Testaments, as well as Church teaching.³³ The source of the name for sexual acts between men were the passages in Genesis 19, in which God destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah to punish the townsmen's sexual depravity. Leviticus 18 and 20 described sodomites as an 'abomination' who should be punished by death. The view of sodomy as heinous was linked to its definition as 'unnatural' intercourse. In the New Testament, Paul's letters condemned sodomy, and included male prostitutes and sodomites in the list of those 'wrongdoers' who would be unable to inherit the Kingdom of God.³⁴ By the thirteenth century 'vice against nature', or non-procreative sex, including anal sex and same-sex practices, headed the list of sinful lust above fornication, adultery, incest, violation or debauchery, and abduction-rape.³⁵ Thomas Aquinas's writings also promoted the idea that 'unnatural' non-procreative sex should be subject to ecclesiastical and secular punishment.³⁶ Protestant reformers further elevated the status of procreative sex within marriage, and in their attacks on the Catholic Church associated priestly celibacy with both illicit and unnatural sex.³⁷

Eighteenth-century clergymen continued to deploy the concept of sodomy as unnatural. In 1702 'a minister of the Church of England' published: *The Sodomites Shame and Doom, Laid Before them in Grief and Compassion*, a three page broadsheet intended for a popular readership, which explained that sodomy was a sin against God which consigned the sinner to Hell. The author condemned sodomites as 'unclean, beguiled, odious and monstrous' and wrote that it was 'a riddle to all virtuous men to find any temptation in your odious vice . . . for it could not fill us with greater distain to see to see a man eating human

excrement ...'. He explained that sermons and books rarely commented on sodomy because it was 'so foul that it cannot be toucht without offending the company by the intolerable stench of it.' The only solution for the penitent sodomite was to pray, guard his thoughts, refrain from the company of other sodomites and follow the church's teachings.³⁸ Josiah Woodward, who was a member of the societies for the reformation of manners, published a pamphlet that was distributed free to troops in 1701–2. *The Soldier's Monitor* warned soldiers to avoid uncleanness: 'let your soul abhor the very thoughts of that unnatural and abominable kind of it, which brought fire from heaven upon Sodom ... This is a monstrous piece of villainy, condemned to death by the laws of God and man, and ought to be chased from off the earth, by the general abhorrence of mankind'³⁹ Such denunciations were rare; for the most part sodomy was included with other vices and immoral sexual behaviour in more general attacks. *Hell Upon Earth* in 1729, for instance, considered sodomy alongside perjury, immorality, and impieties.⁴⁰

As sodomy was increasingly theologically constructed as a turning away from God and the natural order, some writers compared it with atheism. The author of *A Treatise Wherein Are Strict Observations Upon The Destestable and Most Shocking Sin of Sodomy, Blasphemy and Atheism* argued that sexual attraction was a feature of the world, like the sun and the moon, and thus to violate the 'natural order' in sex was as sinful as to deny the existence of God.⁴¹ The idea of violation of nature was also apparent in *Hell Upon Earth*, which explained the natural order of things: 'the birds of the air couple male and female to propagate generation, and every animal moves by a natural instinct ...' a model which sodomites seemed to reject. Consequently they were 'repugnant to divine institution and the fundamental laws of nature.' It was not only religious tracts that correlated same-sex activities with abandoning God: in indictments for sodomy in civil courts, the phrase 'by the Instigation of the Devil' and 'he not having the fear of God' were common as reasons for the crime.⁴²

Though sodomy was deemed a sin, it was not prosecuted in the ecclesiastical courts in this period. As seen in chapter one, in 1534 the offence (defined as anal intercourse between men and between men and women) was moved into the criminal courts and categorised as a felony punishable by death. For the most part, the Church regarded it

as a matter for the criminal courts. In 1726, however, William Townshend, parish clerk of Warminster, saw his prosecution for sodomy in the King's Bench court stopped and an ecclesiastical case prosecuted, in which he was convicted but only sentenced to be deprived of his place.⁴³ Of course clerical attitudes towards appropriate punishment varied according to the individual clergyman involved. For example, the author of *Hell Upon Earth* advocated that sodomites should be 'excluded from all civil society,' which implied a rejection of biblical condemnation and the death penalty. On the other hand, the Revd William Rowland was so obsessed with the prosecution of sodomy that in 1729 he libelled two magistrates who he felt were too lenient in such cases. He also addressed an inflammatory tract to the Lord Chief Justice on the subject, signed 'Sodomastix', for which he was sentenced to stand in the pillory in his canonical dress. He may have represented wider views, since the crowd treated him lightly and some women collected alms for him.⁴⁴ The 1534 law on sodomy survived until 1861, although no one was executed after 1835. However in an attempt to increase conviction rates the proof of the offence was amended in 1821 from requiring proof of penetration and emission, to only requiring proof of penetration. As juries remained reluctant to convict because of the death penalty, the maximum punishment was also reduced to life-imprisonment and additional offences were introduced including attempted buggery, genital contact, and the invitation to participate in sexual activities.⁴⁵

By the 1830s, sodomy was becoming associated with the absence of faith rather than a perversion of it. One homosexual, Charles Baring Wall, was arrested by a constable, John Palmer, for soliciting him in the street one night. Palmer's account of the conversation, during which Wall made an assault on him, included the following exchange: 'He then asked me of what religion I was', Palmer continued. 'I told him I was of no religion in particular, any more than the rest of us. He then said 'D—n and — all the — religions, it is all a humbug, a parcel of boys 14 or 15 years of age, are sent to college and brought up to govern the country'.⁴⁶ Whether this was designed to initiate a conversation with Palmer, or genuinely expressed Wall's views, his comment on religion when he was seeking to engage Palmer in sex suggests that he expected the views to be reciprocated.

Sodomites, Religion, and the 'Other'

Since sodomy was perceived to represent untrammelled vice, commentators thus used it to signify individual and national corruption. Indeed, the Protestant Reformation's association of sodomy with institutionalised Catholicism firmly fashioned the sodomite as the 'other' against which identities were constructed. The association of same-sex activities with political and religious heterodoxy was a stubborn one. During the Popish Plot of 1678-80 both the accuser, Titus Oates, and various Catholic victims were associated with homosexuality.⁴⁷ In the chaotic events of late 1689, when James II had fled London and William of Orange had not yet secured the capital and the throne, Thomas Pilkington, Lord Mayor of London, claimed that 'men and women in the evening ... wander about the streets and impudently solicit others to wickedness.'⁴⁸ And by 1690 it had been firmly established that sodomy, Jacobitism, and popery went hand in hand.⁴⁹ Protestant use of homosexual accusations to demonise political and religious opponents continued well beyond the end of the seventeenth century and was alive in the period covered by this book. Thus, much of the popular rage and antagonism towards those punished for same-sex activities in the pillory was accompanied by expressions of religious sentiments.

Eighteenth-century clerical attacks perceived sodomy to be increasing. The author of *Hell Upon Earth* claimed that such 'unnatural' behaviour was on the increase: twenty houses of sodomites were open in London and he feared a subsequent rising tide of sin.⁵⁰ This perception of a growth of homosexuality was clear in Thomas Bray's warning that sodomy was worse than all other forms of sin and uncleanness and that 'the Sodomites are invading our land'.⁵¹ Following the Lisbon and London earthquakes of 1756, Dr Allen preached that the destruction of Sodom was 'a warning to Great Britain.' Although he did not claim outright that Lisbon had been destroyed because of its sodomy, conceding that 'Lisbon no doubt had her sins; but let us of all things beware of uncharitable interpretations ...' he nonetheless claimed that God showed 'the red of his anger and the staff of his indignation to correct and punish a people'. Asserting that Britain was a sinful nation, Allen warned that London invited correction for its sins.⁵² Likewise, Charles Churchill, who supplemented his income as curate of Rainham

with writing satirical tracts and poems, published a poem, *The Times*, in 1764 in which he lamented that the nation was in the grip of sodomy:

Go where you will at ev'ry time and place
Sodom confronts and stares us in the face.
They ply in public at our very doors
And take the bread from much more honest whores.⁵³

The same theme was taken up in the Rev. William Jackson's 1776 poem *Sodom and Onan* in which Jackson attacked the actor Samuel Foote for being homosexual; the poem went well beyond a personal attack:

Oh! That with legal power I were endued
To punish sodomitic turpitude . . .
Pandora I invoke to ope her store
And add some plagues she never us'd before
Pour on them Aristoph, nor e'er relent
He merits in their pains in full extent.⁵⁴

Such public concern about the growth of homosexuality was complemented with a toxic element of xenophobia since homosexuals were often portrayed not just as unnatural but also influenced by soft and effeminate foreign influences. Homosexuality was thought to have originated among, and to be variously practised by, the French, Bulgars, Turks, Italians, and a host of other nations. In a century in which Britain was rarely at peace with continental nations, it was therefore easy for xenophobia to merge with homophobia and for homosexuals to be viewed as alien and dangerous as well as sinful.⁵⁵

This was not a universal view, however, since the 'other' was shaped further by social and cultural dimensions. For example, after the dissolution of monasteries, accusations of sexual vice focused on Catholic priests' incontinence rather than sodomy as they moved into the domestic sphere. It was not only the Catholic 'other' which was linked to sodomy. Writers associated other religious denominations with sodomy in order to undermine their position. A pamphlet, published in 1633, accused Puritans of being a society of sodomites, showing that this was

not a simple reversal of Protestant accusations against Catholics, but specific to Puritan activities in London.⁵⁶

The eighteenth-century Church also fell under the long shadow of Bishop John Atherton of Waterford and Lismore, who had been executed for buggery in Dublin in 1640. Atherton was an outsider, an Englishman in Ireland. He was of the 'wrong' theological hue, a High Churchman; he had made political enemies; he was unpopular for his strict application of the law and for his ability to recover alienated diocesan property.⁵⁷ The extent to which Atherton was accused of fornication, adultery, and sodomy as revenge or because he had committed the acts is debatable. More pertinently, however, the accusation of sodomy meant he was both condemned to the severest punishment of Church and state and also nearly torn to pieces by the mob that attended his transport to the scaffold.⁵⁸ Despite the passing of time, Atherton was held up as an example of shame and sin that haunted the Church long after he was executed. As Peter Marshall has shown, the case of Atherton was repeatedly cited in the following century in cases in 1736, 1739, 1742, 1754, 1783 and even as late as the nineteenth century. In each re-telling, Atherton's sins gained a new patina of significance and exaggeration. By the middle of the eighteenth century his sodomy had been joined by accusations of bestiality, incest, and even infanticide.⁵⁹ Atherton's case remained potent in the century and a half after his death because it was useful for polemicists. Jonathan Swift claimed in 1730 that he had a vision of Atherton, who reminded him to use his case against Thomas Sawbridge, dean of Ferns, who had been charged with rape. Consequently Swift penned the lines:

To give thee lawn sleeves, a mitre, and rochet,
Whom wouldst thou resemble? I leave thee a guesser.
But I only behold thee in Atherton's shape,
For sodomy hang'd; as thou for a rape.⁶⁰

The case of Sawbridge had all the ingredients of Atherton's: an English churchman transplanted to Ireland and into an environment of political grievances which stimulated a legal suit. In 1823 Atherton's case was raised again to declare that the clergy had long been guilty of such crimes.⁶¹

The political and religious 'othering' of the sodomite also shaped the savagery of the prosecution of London sodomites in the raids on molly houses. In 1726, for example, Bishop Edmund Gibson of London ensured that one offender was not reprieved. Gabriel Lawrence, mentioned earlier, who had been caught in the 1725 molly house raid, was sentenced to death for sodomy. However a group of aristocrats, the Earl of Essex and the Dukes of Richmond and Rutland, sought to obtain a commutation of his sentence from George I. Gibson, together with Secretary of State Charles Townshend, the Attorney General Phillip Yorke, and Archbishop Wake of Canterbury, blocked the request for a reprieve. Gibson and Wake seem to have taken a close interest in sodomy trials and had been sent details of such a case in Colchester.⁶² As Farid Azfar has made clear, the trial of Lawrence came at a time when Gibson felt insecure in his role as the principal ecclesiastical advisor to the government. His request that the King abandon masquerades had failed, as seen in chapter two, and the societies for the reformation of manners were falling into disrepute; only the year before the use of general warrants by the societies was deemed illegal. Azfar regards the Lawrence case as a test of Gibson's authority and ability to flex his political muscles, rather than the result of a 'rising cultural homophobia'.⁶³

Nevertheless beneath such motives also lay a firm religious zeal and the fact that Lawrence was a Catholic may have affected Gibson's judgement.⁶⁴ Gibson told Wake that in opposing the reprieve he was trying to prevent 'the rescue of this vile creature from the hands of justice.' Azfar overstates the case in suggesting that Gibson's determination to see Lawrence hang was 'a consciousness of his own isolation bordering on a martyr complex,' but there seems little doubt that Gibson was seeking to reassert his moral and political authority after a number of setbacks.⁶⁵ Gibson certainly also saw sodomy and molly houses as part of the wider threat to public and moral order presented by masquerades, prostitution and moral laxity, and he said as much in his pastoral letter of 1728.⁶⁶ After the execution of Lawrence, Gibson was sufficiently encouraged to claim that he might be able to suppress the 'abomination' of sodomy altogether.⁶⁷ Indeed Norton claims that thereafter the London homosexual sub-culture went underground until the 1770s. However there is little evidence of the existence of such a sub-culture.⁶⁸

The relationship between sexual and religious deviance extended to Nonconformist and evangelical groups. In 1757 it was noted that 'among the Dissenters there are several Instances of this Vice, even in their pious Pastors.'⁶⁹ Andrew Gifford, who was Baptist minister at Little Wild Street in London, was ostracised by his congregation after one of its members made an unproven allegation of sodomy against him. Eventually he formed a separate meeting and in 1757 he became assistant librarian at the British Museum.⁷⁰ At the end of the century, John Church, an Independent minister mentioned earlier who had originally been ordained as a Baptist, was dogged by repeated allegations of sodomy, and that he had acted as unofficial chaplain to a male brothel in Vere Street in London, and was convicted in 1817.⁷¹ It was claimed that he blackmailed some of the attenders at Vere Street to fund his defence lawyer. In his defence, he claimed of the assaults on the young man by whom he was accused: 'it was the Lord's will, if he [Church] did make the attempt, it was to be so, and was meant to punish and humble him'.⁷²

Evangelicals and Sodomy

As seen in chapter five, attacks on Methodism deployed accusations of sexual impropriety. Misty Anderson has shown the way in which Henry Fielding's 1746 short story *The Female Husband*, based on the life of Mary Hamilton, a woman who masqueraded as a man in order to marry other women, treated religious conversion as analogous to sexual inversion: both were unnatural and dangerous. Several aspects of Methodist organisation opened it to accusations of same-sex sexual activities. For example the same-sex band meetings raised questions about motivation. The intimate style of Methodist rhetoric may have also aroused and facilitated the expression of same-sex desire. Mrs Stonehewer, a Methodist woman in Macclesfield, found herself falling in love with a member of the same band, Hester Roe. Roe's diary records that Mrs Stonehewer became jealous of her own sister, who was also Roe's friend. Mrs Stonehewer seems to have become increasingly demanding and distressed; and Roe found her unrequited affections difficult to cope with, despite encouraging her to love God instead of herself. Mrs Stonehewer's expression of passion for Roe fluctuated but eventually she talked of suicide and despair before Roe broke away from her altogether.⁷³

While homosexual sex is not mentioned in surviving Methodist journals and accounts, there were some aspects of behaviour that has led scholars to question whether it was wholly absent. Kissing members of the same sex during ecstatic religious events seems to have occurred on more than one occasion.⁷⁴ The concern about allegations of Methodist homosexuality may have been heightened by the fact that both in London and Bristol Methodist premises were close to places of homosexual assignation. In London, Wesley's headquarters at The Foundry was next to Moorfields which included the area known as 'Sodomites' Walk.' In Bristol, the Horsefair area, another homosexual gathering site, was the site of Wesley's New Room. Peter Forsaith has pointed out that sodomy was a likely reason why a number of Methodist preachers were ejected from the organisation.⁷⁵

In 1755 an apprentice accused the Revd Charles Bradbury, an Independent minister, of sodomy. The apprentice claimed that Bradbury had often committed sodomy with him in the chapel where he preached, and in other places. Bradbury was eventually found not guilty, perhaps because the evidence of an apprentice was outweighed by that of a respectable master and preacher.⁷⁶ In December 1784 a Methodist preacher was found guilty of abusing one of the boys in a school where he taught in Hammersmith.⁷⁷ Critics used such cases to demand that the Church take a harder line against Nonconformists. Two years later a report from Bath noted:

John Lad, a Methodist Preacher, was executed at Peckham, for an unnatural crime; – and not many days since, another *gentleman*, of the same profession, was detected in robbing the altar. Is it from want of power, or want of zeal in religion, that these hypocrites are permitted to impose on the lower orders of the people, and delude them from the established Church? The environs of the town are crowded with these miscreants, and the Bishops see it with indifference.⁷⁸

In 1785 a Methodist, James Perfect, ceased preaching for 'repeated acts of immodesty such as I could not name to a woman.'⁷⁹ Eight years later Andrew Inglis was expelled for a 'shocking crime',⁸⁰ and William Dieuaide in 1797 for 'reprehensible acts'.⁸¹ In 1807 John Kingston, who had been a preacher in the Caribbean and Cornwall, was charged with

the theft of funds and also with 'improper behaviour towards two young men, the circumstances of which must be explained to the Conference . . . Mr. Kingston's conduct in this matter has been very vile: that he shall be suspended to the Conference.'⁸² Similarly, Nathaniel Ward left Wesleyan Methodism in 1785 apparently because of financial malfeasance,⁸³ and joined Lady Huntingdon's Connexion. Subsequently Lady Huntingdon made enquiries and was told:

He has in Time past, too near approached a Line of Conduct, unnatural in itself and too indelicate to mention. Rom. 1.27. . . .⁸⁴
Mr Ward had been very acceptable, and much respected, in Mr W—'s⁸⁵ Connection. But being suspected in a certain Particular, he had been admonish'd; acknowledg'd his Error; and promis'd future Amendment. In this, however, he fail'd; the consequence of which was, he was dismissed the Connection.⁸⁶

Lady Huntingdon's Connection also faced two other cases of same-sex desire among its preachers: William Ellis, dismissed for a 'besetting evil' and one said to be too indelicate to be mentioned.⁸⁷ A more curious case was Morris Hughes, a member of the chapel committee of the Spa Fields Chapel in London, who in August 1782 was accused that 'in a shameful manner exposed his person under pretence of being made free as he called it'. Hughes had done this in the homes of a baker, a chimney sweep, a plumber, and a cabinet-maker. His behaviour had even been publicly reported in the *General Advertiser*. Three days later his behaviour became even more eccentric: 'such as his playing at blindmans-buff with the boys in the neighbourhood, and making a barber's boy thrust his curling irons up his nostrils to make his nose bleed . . .' It was decided that 'Morris Hughes, having been guilty of practices shamefully indecent, unbecoming a man, much more a Christian, and which are become of public notoriety, is a very unfit and improper person to continue a member of this committee.' More worrying was that Hughes had presided over the Monday evening society at which they chapel members practised 'electrifying'.⁸⁸

More surprising was a suspicion raised about John Wesley's sexuality. In the 1770s, one of Wesley's fellow evangelicals, Augustus Toplady, who was by nature fractious and splenetic, seemed to accuse Wesley of

same-sex activities. He wrote of one of Wesley's journals, in the *Gospel Magazine* of 1771/2:

He [Wesley] has already, in a former journal, acquainted [readers] with having once had a boil on a part that shall be nameless and which, we presume, was ripened and cured by an application of *shoe-maker's wax*, wherewith he might easily be supplied by several of his own lay-preachers.⁸⁹

Toplady's crude reference to a boil on Wesley's bottom was a coded hint that Wesley was a homosexual. Toplady was well known for his precise knowledge of English, and also for his use of occluded and slang terminology. He italicised 'shoe-maker's wax' because it was a slang term for a penis.⁹⁰ Toplady was hinting that Wesley was 'cured' by the attentions of a cobbler's penis. Of Wesley's preachers one 'shoe-maker' stands out: Thomas Olivers, who had been apprenticed as a cobbler and practised it to support himself whilst he was an itinerate preacher. Olivers was known to be a close friend of Wesley. He managed the core of Wesley's income, the Book Room, and was recognised by the Methodist Conference in 1773 as John Wesley's 'travelling companion'. Toplady wrote of Wesley that he 'skulks for shelter under a cobbler's apron' and even put the following words into Wesley's mouth about Olivers:

He wields, beyond most other men
His awl, his razor and his pen;
My beard he shaves, repairs my shoes
And writes my panegyric too ...⁹¹

Certainly the modestly educated Olivers was a strange choice as overseer for the Book Room press. More remarkably, neither Wesley nor Olivers was buried with their wives, but together with others in a grave at Wesley's Chapel in London, Olivers having been buried after Wesley in 1799.⁹² Of course, as a Calvinist, Toplady fiercely opposed Wesley's Arminianism, but in his attack on Wesley in *More Work for Mr. John Wesley: or A Vindication of the Decrees and Providences of God from the Defamations of a late printed 'The Consequence Proved'* (1772) he went as far as to claim that Wesley would be judged by God for his assaults on his sovereignty. In the light of Toplady's slur, Wesley's earlier assertion that

he had married Mary Vazaille as 'a precaution against scandal' takes on a different light.⁹³

Wesley's encounters with same-sex activities may have started at Charterhouse, where he was educated. Tyerman, one of Wesley's earliest biographers, wrote 'terrible is the danger when a child leaves a pious home for a public school. John Wesley entered Charterhouse a saint and left it a sinner.'⁹⁴ Wesley's account of Charterhouse suggests strongly that the boys indulged in some sort of same-sex activity. In his *Plain Account of the People Called Methodists*, written twenty-eight years after he left the school, Wesley wrote that the boys not only learned to read and write, but learned 'all kind of vice so that it had been better for them to have been without their knowledge than to have bought it at so dear a price.'⁹⁵ His brother, Charles, wrote in *Sending a Son to School* 'from youthful lusts preserve him pure, pure in a cage of birds unclean, in learned nurseries of vice.'⁹⁶ In consequence, Wesley's own experiments with establishing a school at Kingswood were so austere and ascetic that it eradicated all possible sources of pleasure for fear that it would lead to indulgence in vice.⁹⁷

Wesley was remarkably sympathetic to one man accused of sodomy. Visiting prisoners as a member of the Holy Club at Oxford, Wesley encountered Thomas Blair who was imprisoned in the Oxford Bocardo on a charge of sodomy, and was being tormented by other prisoners. Wesley soon made Blair one of his protégés and frequently visited him.⁹⁸ Wesley also seems to have taken on the task of defending Blair to the Vice-Chancellor.⁹⁹ He also acted as intermediary with Blair's lawyer who was based in Thame, some miles from Oxford. Finally, when Blair's case came up for trial, Wesley got up at four o'clock in the morning to walk to Thame to help Blair with his defence. When the Recorder of Oxford found him guilty, Wesley recorded in his diary that nevertheless the court had not awarded costs against Blair. Wesley continued to think about Blair and made eight entries about him in his diary in the following year; as Green noted, Blair 'continued to be much in his mind.'¹⁰⁰ Wesley's association with Blair became widely known in Anglican circles.¹⁰¹ In December 1732 Thomas Wilson, the parson son of the Bishop of Sodor and Man and a friend of Wesley, noted in his diary that he discussed the issue of Blair with Thomas Horn.¹⁰² Wilson wrote that they:

had rather a warm dispute about the Methodists taking the part of Blair, who was found guilty of sodomitical practices and fined

20 marks by the recorder. Whether the man is innocent or no they were not proper judges, it was better he should suffer than such a scandal given an countenancing (sic) a man whom the whole town think guilty of such an enormous crime. Whatever good design they [the Methodists] pretend it was highly imprudent and given the occasion of terrible reflections.¹⁰³

The 'terrible reflections' were presumably that people would assume that the Holy Club was a place where sodomy was countenanced or even practised. That Wesley did not easily shake off this reputation is evident from *Perfection, A Poetical Satire*, published forty-six years later:

With Tears you cleans'd Bocardo from all Sin
And Lodg'd in Stews to lay the fiend within.¹⁰⁴

Clergymen and Same-Sex Friendships

A further way to investigate how the Church viewed homosexuality is to consider intimate same-sex relationships. There are several examples of life-long, same-sex friendships in the period that do not appear to have been clandestine or challenged by the Church or its personnel. Some of these friendships were celebrated in monuments in churches. In 1731 a memorial to the enduring relationship of Granville Piper and Richard Wise was erected in St Mary Magdalen, Launceston. Piper and Wise had both been mayors of Launceston. Piper died in Bath in 1717 and Wise buried him there; when Wise died in 1726 his remains were interred with Piper's. Wise left instructions that a *monumentum mutui eorum Amoris*, 'a monument to their mutual love', be erected in the parish church in Launceston, located close to the Piper family tombs and near the family pew. The monument shows figures representing fortitude, wisdom, faith, hope, and charity as well as busts of Piper and Wise with interlinking heraldic arms. An inscription paid tribute to them as *fidissimum amicorum par*, 'a most faithful pair of friends'. There was some opposition to the location of the monument, though whether this was due to any rejection of Wise and Piper as a same-sex couple is unknown.¹⁰⁵ Still, the monument attracted little subsequent comment or criticism.¹⁰⁶

Close female same-sex friendships were not uncommon either and were not considered threatening to religious precepts. Indeed, the women involved were often renowned for being strongly Christian and charitable in their outlook. One example is the relationship between



Figure 6 R. J. Lane (after Mary Parker), *The Ladies of Llangollen*, c. 1828. Sarah Ponsonby (left) and Lady Eleanor Butler, seated in their library. Wellcome Library, London, no. 2443i, Photo number: V0007358.

Sarah Scott and Lady Barbara Montagu. Scott had met Montagu in 1747 before her marriage to George Scott; when the marriage failed Scott agreed to repay the marriage settlement and Sarah went to live with Barbara Montagu in Bath. They cohabited for fourteen years until Montagu's death, sharing a small income, running a school for girls, and publishing translations of French novels.¹⁰⁷

Perhaps the best known instance of intimate same-sex female relationship is that of Lady Eleanor Butler and Sarah Ponsonby, who was sixteen years younger. Butler and Ponsonby were two aristocratic Irish women who fled from their families in 1778 when they were pressured to marry or enter a convent. The women went to Wales where they set up house in Llangollen and lived a life of rural seclusion. They spent their time reading and improving their house and running a dairy. Their books and crockery were embossed with their initials entwined into a monogram. On the death of Lady Eleanor Butler, in 1829, she was buried in the parish churchyard and on her death two years later Sarah Ponsonby joined her, described on their gravestone as 'her beloved companion.' The women's relationship was regarded as charming and romantic and in time obtained a certain celebrity; among their visitors were the Duke of Wellington, Lady Caroline Lamb, Josiah Wedgwood, William Wordsworth, Thomas de Quincey, and the Duke of Gloucester. Their correspondents included Queen Charlotte, Lord Byron, and Louis XVI's aunt. Prince Pückler-Muskau dubbed them 'the most celebrated Virgins in Europe'.¹⁰⁸ Nor did the Church disapprove; they were received by the bishop of St Asaph, Jonathan Shipley, and a number of clergy visited them and found their friendship admirable.¹⁰⁹ Anna Seward also reported that 'they both regularly attended the services in the Church of Llangollen, and received the Sacrament of the Lord's Supper, both there, and at their own cottage during the last illness of Lady Eleanor Butler, from the vicar.'¹¹⁰

Clergymen also shared life-long friendships which were celebrated. Herbert Croft and George Benson, respectively bishop and dean of Hereford, were intimate friends. They had both suffered during the Commonwealth period, having been thrown out of their livings; but after the Restoration of the monarchy and Church in 1660 they returned to Hereford. Given the history of the cathedral, Croft and Benson should have been wary of each other: since the Middle Ages the cathedral had rejected the bishop's authority and refused to accept successive episcopal attempts to hold visitations. However at Easter 1677, Croft and Benson

agreed to a visitation and the bishop proceeded to examine the cathedral. Croft died in 1691 and Benson a year later. Neither chose to be buried with their wives or family. They were interred together in front of the altar in the cathedral with grave stones which carefully abutted one another so that an engraving of two hands clasped in friendship could be interconnected. The inscription ran from one stone to the other: *In Vita Coniuncti, In Morte non Divisi*, 'in life united, in death not divided'. The first phrase was derived from a medieval oath of brotherhood and the second from David's lament for Jonathan in the second Book of Samuel. This appropriation of Scripture to record a burial of two friends may have seemed to legitimise their relationship. The tomb's prominent position in the cathedral, close to the bishops' throne, meant that it was seen by all who approached the altar and thus sanctioned their life-long friendship.¹¹¹ This tomb was also noted without observation of any significance by topographical writers.¹¹² In the mid-nineteenth century it was moved from its position near the altar to the east transept of the cathedral, though there was no evidence that this was from any sense of the impropriety of the depiction of Croft and Benson's relationship.¹¹³ A memorial was not the only form of marking close male friendships. In premodern Europe there were several examples of rites which celebrated the commitment and affection of male friendship, with descriptions of them as marriages of the soul and men exchanging oaths of sworn brotherhood.¹¹⁴

Nor was this type of friendship restricted to highly educated men. It is possible to see in the genres to which lower-ranking writers contributed: notably conversion narratives. The autobiography of Private Sampson Staniforth (1720–99) described his conversion to Methodism while he was serving as a soldier in the War of the Austrian Succession, 1739–48. The key figure in his spiritual conversion was his fellow private Mark Bond. Staniforth referred to him with great love and affection. What is striking about his descriptions of his relationship with Bond is his use of religious metaphors. For example he discussed their 'sweet communion' with each other.¹¹⁵

Charles Wesley found himself the unwitting object of the passion of a fellow Methodist, John Hutchinson. Since Charles Wesley lived in Bristol and Hutchinson in Leeds, correspondence was the principal means by which he expressed his affection. Phyllis Mack claims that she has found no letters to the Wesleys from women that contained the same

emotional intensity as those of Hutchinson to Charles Wesley.¹¹⁶ In September 1751 Hutchinson wrote that he could not easily describe his feelings for Charles: 'my heart is ready to break that Providence hath allotted me to be so far separate from you, I could live and die with you . . . write to me often and love me more . . .'. He asked Charles not to allow the covenant of faith to be his rival in love and to 'admit no one to have a greater share of your affection.' Hutchinson compared how Charles affectionately addressed him in letters as 'dear Johnny' and 'dear Youth', which he took as an encouragement. He also wrote melodramatically that he wanted to die if he ever stopped loving Charles. A year later, Hutchinson proposed to come to live in Bristol and 'make my abode with you'. Charles wrote on the first letter *uno avulso non deficit alter* which is translated as 'one torn away, another takes its place' suggesting perhaps that Hutchinson was not the first man to express passionate feelings for him.¹¹⁷

If Hutchinson's passionate feelings threatened Charles, he might have avoided him, but he did not. In September 1753, Wesley wrote to his wife that he had seen Hutchinson, who was seriously ill. Hutchinson was weak but rallied when he saw Charles and after some lengthy conversations had recovered some happiness and did not seek 'joy and comfort so much as power over & deliverance from all sin.' Charles went on to reassure his wife 'you cannot tell how happy we are together: only your presence could make us happier. We pray and sing and weep over each other, in love stronger.' At the end of the same month Wesley wrote again to his wife that he was in Carlinghow with Hutchinson where they stayed the night with Miss Norton. Wesley felt the need to clarify that he and John Hutchinson had slept 'in separate rooms I mean, *my* bedfellow being T. Hutchinson, brother to John & a poor prodigal who cleaves to me.' By December 1753, Hutchinson, who had been thought likely to die, had recovered and he was Charles's travelling companion in London and Bristol. By 1754, Charles was writing of Hutchinson's repentance and his hope that he would stick to it.¹¹⁸ But in March 1754 he wrote of Hutchison as a 'weak inmate' and that 'his weakness as to me, gave me no pain. Many a treacherous wound I have received from professed friends', suggesting that he had broken finally from Hutchinson.¹¹⁹

What can we make of these close same-sex friendships and the public declarations of fulsome love and intimacy? Historians have been divided.

It has been speculated, for example, that, as with other men who discussed their fulsome feelings for a male friend, Staniforth's and Bond's relationship may have been sexual.¹²⁰ Similar suggestions have been made of Sarah Scott and Barbara Montagu; Norma Clarke proposes that despite her pious charitable work, 'Sarah had some things to hide' because her letters to her sister show a remarkable care to avoid self-disclosure.¹²¹ However Phyllis Mack has claimed that there is no evidence of lesbian relationships in early Methodism; but there may have been the 'erotics of friendship, a valorisation of romantic gestures and emotions' that blended divine and human love, but no evidence of physical expressions of it.¹²² The degree to which the ladies of Llangollen's relationship can be regarded as sexual or lesbian is also contested, not least because they appeared to live a celibate life.¹²³ Even so, there were rumours about the women, such as that they were men, that they wore men's clothing, and that they were nymphomaniacs. In fact Anna Seward described them in later life as looking 'exactly like two respectable superannuated old clergymen.' On the other hand, they lived in an era of romanticism in which sentimental friendships were construed as charming and this is what most people, including clergy, thought. Moreover, Alan Bray cautioned that while the expression of spiritual bonds and intimacy of male friendship can seem sexual to modern eyes this was not necessarily so for men in the past.¹²⁴ Thus he situated Wise's and Piper's tomb in a Pauline theology of friendship, and a faithful anticipation of the bodily resurrection of both men. He was also careful not to assume that Croft and Benson were sexual partners.

The debate about the meaning of a shared passionate spiritual language is, Cocks notes, centred on how far it denoted sexual feelings or whether it is anachronistic to subsume romantic friendships into homoeroticism. Cocks concludes that it is ill-judged to see a romantic friendship as lacking a physical component, although it was not in the sense of a homosexual identity as modern society expects.¹²⁵ Valerie Traub also observes that Bray defined same-sex desire with a single erotic practice, which narrowed the categorisation of friendships as homoerotic. George Haggerty offers an alternative stance by refusing to categorise such men's relationships as either friendship or sexual. He uses the definition of love to describe same sex relations and does not distinguish between emotional and sexual expressions of love.¹²⁶ Other scholars are also prepared to acknowledge the possibility of

homo-eroticism in male friendships.¹²⁷ Male friendship was a form of intimacy claimed and celebrated by men. Phillips and Reay argue that since the discourse of friendship allowed men to express love and passion for other men, such relationships are an important aspect of the history of same-sex desire. They recommend that the 'dividing lines of homosociality, homoaffectivity and homoeroticism should not be drawn too crudely'.¹²⁸

Certainly, the emotionally-intimate friendship between men held inherent tensions for contemporaries. Pre-modern society condemned sodomy, but it also idealised male friendship. Bray identified a 'cognitive dissonance' where people were unable to recognise signs of sodomy in such intimate friendships.¹²⁹ Thus the 'slippage between approved and condemned categories was always present' and sodomy was used to defame men who fell out of favour.¹³⁰ Perceptions of close homosocial relationships were just as complex and freighted in the nineteenth century. A regularly debated example is the extent to which contemporary attacks on the Oxford Movement after 1830 linked effeminacy with homosexual acts and identities. Charles Kingsley's attacks on the Oxford Movement are often central in this debate. The most recent view is that Kingsley, as a Low Church parson, questioned the unmanliness of the Oxford Movement rather than accusing it of containing members who sublimated their homosexuality. As has been seen in chapter six, Kingsley deplored celibacy and thus he interpreted the Movement's approval of ritual and celibacy as undermining British national traditions and, as in earlier attacks on celibacy, as likely to threaten female virtue.¹³¹ Cocks reminds us that the criticism of Tractarian 'deviancy' was far broader than sexuality, including fears about national identity, religious ethics, secrecy, manliness, and the role of the Church.¹³² Furthermore religion is seen by some scholars of sexuality as a 'congenial location for the expression of unconventional sexuality' in different periods.¹³³

Clergymen Accused of Sodomy

It is possible to speculate that some homosocial spaces were relatively congenial to same-sex desire. Trumbach suggests that in the eighteenth century there remained a vestige of an earlier tolerance of homosexuality among the upper classes. And perhaps such views therefore persisted in homosocial scholarly circles.¹³⁴ This might explain the response to

accusations made against John Pointer, fellow and chaplain of Merton College, Oxford University. Pointer was sixty-four in 1732 and had been at Merton for thirty-nine years, he also had a considerable reputation as an antiquarian and scholar of Roman antiquities. But in 1732 two undergraduates accused him of 'sodomitical practices'. The Warden of Merton, Dr John Holland, was horrified and examined Pointer, presenting him with the evidence of two scholars who were prepared to swear to the charge on oath. The diarist Thomas Wilson soon heard the story that was circulating in Oxford that Pointer had got into a student's room, plied him with drink and tried to do 'some very indecent things to him,' adding that Pointer had long been suspected of similar activities. Nonetheless, Holland refused to take the students' evidence on oath, and 'for quietness' turned Pointer out of the College.¹³⁵ Pointer retired to the rectory of Slapton, Northamptonshire, which he had held with the chaplaincy of Merton. When he died in 1754 a tablet was put up in the church praising his work as a parson.¹³⁶ Perhaps the medieval wall paintings in Slapton Church of 'the weighing of souls' had had their effect on Pointer since there were no further accusations against him.

The consistency with which a blind eye was turned on same-sex activities in these homosocial institutions suggests that some college members did not see such desires as sinful. In 1739 Robert Thistlethwaite, who had been Warden of Wadham College, Oxford since 1724, was accused of making a 'sodomitical attempt' on a handsome undergraduate, William French, having plied him with wine in the Warden's lodgings. When French complained to one of the fellows an investigation revealed that Thistlethwaite had assaulted a number of others, including the barber who visited him in his lodgings. The barber complained that the Warden had 'tickled' him in his breeches while he was shaving him leading him to have to forcibly reject Thistlethwaite's advances. Thistlethwaite defended his behaviour towards the barber by telling him that homosexuality was very common so he should not be troubled by it. The college butler, William Langford, revealed that Thistlethwaite had also frequently importuned him so that he was forced to avoid the warden to prevent such advances. William Boxley, a college fellow, admitted that he had been sodomised by the Warden, though this appears to have been consensual. Thistlethwaite was arrested and opinion against him hardened when he was discovered attempting to cajole and bribe his accusers to retract their accounts. The

grand jury found that Thistlethwaite should stand trial, but before he did so he absconded to France.¹³⁷ On his death, his body was returned from France and buried in St Mary's, Dover.¹³⁸ What is remarkable about the Thistlethwaite case was that he clearly did not regard what he had done as sinful. On one occasion he claimed that there was no harm in what he did, that it was an expression of love and that it was very common in Oxford.¹³⁹

Within a few weeks of the Thistlethwaite case, another scandal broke in Wadham. A former student of the College wrote to Mr Baker, the fellow who had taken the lead in investigating Thistlethwaite, complaining about another fellow, the Revd John Swinton.¹⁴⁰ Swinton, a friend of Thistlethwaite, had apparently taken in a ragged boy, Robert Trustin, and accommodated him in his rooms in the college. Some believed that Swinton was using Trustin for 'sexual play'.¹⁴¹ Baker interviewed Trustin, who admitted that Swinton had fondled him under the covers and that femoral intercourse had taken place and repeated his account to the Vice-Chancellor. Before a formal meeting to lay a charge could be held, however, Swinton's bedmaker, John Kimber, bribed Trustin to retract his evidence. The case was abandoned and Swinton pursued his accuser, Baker, to insist that he retract the accusation.¹⁴² Thereafter Swinton was appointed first to the rectory of Barrow, Cheshire, and then in 1753 to the rectory of Newchurch, Hampshire, which he held until his death in 1777.

In all three cases Pointer, Thistlethwaite, and Swinton evaded formal proceedings. Was this evidence of toleration of same-sex desire in some religious environments? It seems implausible that the sexual inclinations of these and other college fellows were not known by people in Oxford, if not more widely so. There is some evidence that homosexuality was known to be fairly common in Oxford University. Dudley Ryder wrote of Oxford in November 1715 that 'among the chief men in some of the colleges sodomy is very usual and the master of one college has ruined several young handsome men that way, that it is dangerous sending a young man that is beautiful to Oxford'.¹⁴³ As late as 1790 it was reported that:

the master of a principal inn at Oxford found means to escape from the constable, who had him in custody by virtue of a warrant from the Vice-Chancellor of that University, fully charged with

attempting an unnatural crime upon the servant of a noble Lord during the late races.¹⁴⁴

Perhaps in the supple intellectual and homosocial environment of the universities the traditional teachings of the Church were, if not suspended, overlooked. Informally, of course, the reputations of the three fellows were tainted and poets had much glee in rhyming Wadham with Sodom. It may also be that in the minds of the eighteenth-century academic clergy, if Pointer and Swinton were placed beyond the temptation of young men they might be entirely worthy parish priests, as they appear to have been. The same indulgence was rarely afforded to men outside the homosocial confines of Oxford and Cambridge even in other homosocial locations. For example, when in 1725 a Dutch sailor was tried on board ship for having a homosexual relationship with a boy, the chaplain argued that they should both be thrown overboard. The captain was more lenient and only the sailor was put ashore on Ascension Island with basic supplies, although he died of thirst and his body was found by the crew of a British ship the following year.¹⁴⁵

A limited degree of compassion was evident outside the homosocial environs of Oxford University even when the accused was subject to the discipline of the Church. In 1764, Thomas Secker, Archbishop of Canterbury, deprived the Revd Sir Samuel Bickley Bart of his vicarage at Bapchild on a charge of attempted sodomy for which Bickley had been imprisoned. Nevertheless Secker gave Bickley ten pounds as an act of charity when he deprived him.¹⁴⁶ Beyond episcopal indulgence, however, Bickley's case reveals little charity for a convicted sodomite parson. In August 1773 Bickley was found dead in the King's Head Inn at Enfield. In his pockets were three manuscript sermons and a petition to the Archbishop which read:

Your petitioner, therefore, most humbly prays, that, if an audience from your Grace should be deemed too great a favour, that you will, at the least, grant him some relief, tho' it be only a temporary one, in his deplorable necessity and distress; and *let your Grace's charity cover the multitude of his sins* there never yet was any one in England doomed to starve; but I am nearly, if not altogether, so; denied the exercise the sacred function wherein I was educated;

driven from the doors of the rich laymen to the clergy for relief; by the clergy denied.¹⁴⁷

In the case of Richard Trevor, Bishop of Durham, one of the Church's senior clergy, the rumour that he was homosexual was treated casually in a piece of clerical gossip between two Kent clergy in July 1770. Joseph Price noted in his diary that a neighbouring clergyman had 'a suspicion that the late Bishop Trevor was a sodomite.'¹⁴⁸ There was no further condemnation or scandalising, or evidence: Price passed on to the next topic of tittle-tattle.

The willingness of the Church authorities to condone the flight of clergy arrested for sodomy or attempted sodomy should not be confused with sympathy for their conduct or sexual inclinations, nor that particular religious spaces were conducive to same-sex relationships and activities. How far there was a degree of toleration in such actions is debatable.¹⁴⁹ Sodomy and same-sex desire, with their association with popular ideas of 'unnatural' behaviour and irredeemable sin, were especially potent weapons for critics to use against the Church. Such accusations undermined the Church's status in society and challenged its moral purity. Consequently, the eighteenth-century Church, like that of other eras, often sought to cover up cases where it could. In the first half of the eighteenth century the cause of the inaction of the authorities seems to have been to avoid scandal which would bring the Church and its teachings into disrepute. Dr Holland's desire for 'quietness,' for example, which led him to dismiss the chaplain of Merton College was principally concerned to avoid scandal attaching to the college. Perhaps he was also motivated by Pointer's status as a priest and he sought to avoid undermining popular confidence in the priesthood.

By the end of the eighteenth and in the first half of the nineteenth century, safeguarding the Church's reputation became more pressing. The French Revolution and the growth of radical agitation in Britain after 1815 meant that the established order felt beleaguered and under strain. In such an environment, the Church was increasingly important as a buttress of the state, reminding people of the divine nature of the social and economic ordering of society. Cases that diminished the standing of the Church and brought opprobrium onto the clergy were politically damaging. It was much better that homosexual clergy be permitted to flee to France and live there quietly than that the peace of

society should be affected by the discordant notes of a trial and public punishment of men who were expected to lead by example.

The situation became more difficult in 1820s, an era of considerable anti-clericalism with appeals for ecclesiastical reform. Tithe demands, clerical benefit from the enclosure movement, and the emergence of clerical magistracy all prompted anti-clerical sentiment. While much of this turned on economic and political concerns, critics used accusations of clerical sodomy to undermine the Church's position. Percy Jocelyn, Bishop of Clogher in Ireland, had already had a brush with scandal when in 1811 his brother's coachman, James Byrne, a member of the Society for the Suppression of Vice, accused the bishop of an unnatural crime. Bishop Jocelyn fiercely denied the charges and under duress Byrne withdrew them. Jocelyn prosecuted him for the allegation and Byrne was sentenced to flogging and two years in prison. Despite this, it seems likely that Byrne was telling the truth, since in July 1822 Bishop Jocelyn was caught with a twenty-two-year-old guardsman in the White



Figure 7 Robert Cruickshank, *The Arse Bishop Josselin a Soldier or do as I say not as I do*, 1822. Bishop Jocelyn arrested for a homosexual act with a soldier. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Percy_Jocelyn_Bishop_of_Clogher_by_Cruikshank.jpg. Accessed 15/06/2016.

Lion pub in London. The Bishop and guardsman were both nearly naked when they were marched by the publican to the watch house in Vine Street. After some evasion, the Bishop's identity was revealed and he was allowed bail for £1,000 surety. The popular press had a field day when the news was widely known. One epigram read:

The Devil to prove the Church was a farce
When out to fish for a B—r
He baited his hook with a Frenchman's arse
And pulled up the Bishop of Clogher.¹⁵⁰

Neither Bishop Jocelyn nor the guardsman attended their trial, having fled to the continent. Some years later, after he had been deprived of his see, Jocelyn returned to Scotland where he worked as a butler using the name Thomas Wilson, perhaps a nod at the fierce bishop of Sodor and Man, dying in 1848 aged seventy seven years.

This scandal had significant consequences; in its wake, Lord Castlereagh killed himself in a moment of mental instability, fearing that he too was going to be exposed as a homosexual.¹⁵¹ It also had an impact on reporting of clerical same-sex scandals by triggering further exposes of clerical vice and crime.¹⁵² A further case in 1825 marked a watershed in homosexual crime reporting, after which cases were more frequently covered, and in more graphic detail, so that the public became more widely aware of such instances.¹⁵³ John Grossett Muirhead, a devout Christian who was a member of the Society for the Suppression of Vice and vice-president of the Auxiliary Bible Society, was arrested in August 1825. His arrest followed twenty years of picking up young men and taking them upstairs in a London oyster shop where he showed them obscene prints and then had sex with them. It is clear that Muirhead was known for his activities, since a local printer and the owner of the oyster shop were well aware of his behaviour as were the local youths of the area. When he was finally arrested and charged, a host of witnesses testified to his activities. This prosecution seems to have been pursued because Muirhead's behaviour was so flagrant and he had ignored warnings to stop. He was, exceptionally, granted bail of £4,000, far more than he could afford and consequently was unable to evade a trial which convicted him and imprisoned him for fifteen months.

The association between clergy and sodomy placed parsons in some jeopardy. Blackmail was all the more likely in a society attuned to the

possibility of clerical misbehaviour. Thus Upchurch claims that the huge growth in the reports of cases of homosexuality in the wake of the Jocelyn case also led to a change in the law, since the concern that men, including clergy, were subject to false accusations of homosexuality led to the Threatening Letters Act of 1825. This made it a felony to accuse a man of homosexuality with the intention of extorting money from him.¹⁵⁴ One of the earliest prosecutions under the law was in defence of the inventor the Rev Edmund Cartwright, vicar of Arundel, in 1825. Cartwright had paid a bargeman, Charles Houlder, to bring some flowers to his house; later that day he received a letter from Houlder, and an accomplice David Gardener, threatening to say that Cartwright had a relationship with a boy who lived in the vicarage, the note indicated that if they were paid 'we will keepe it seckered as thou we was meacons.' Cartwright, having consulted a lawyer, gave the men some money for which he asked for a receipt, when they supplied it they were arrested, charged, convicted, and transported for life.¹⁵⁵

Such cases of clerical sodomy were familiar enough for critics to use them to attack the Church. For example, William Benbow's *Crimes of the Clergy* of 1823 emphasised how frequently such cases occurred and stressed the lenience of the Church in letting such clerics evade prosecution and punishment. He assembled numerous instances. Benbowe claimed that John Fenwick, vicar of Byall, Northumberland, for example, who had been an active sodomite since his school days was caught in bed with a male musician while at Oxford but evaded a charge.¹⁵⁶ More shockingly in 1795 he was charged with the rape of a nine year old girl at Newbiggin where he was sea bathing, although the prosecution failed when the child did not appear in court. After this, Fenwick confined his sexual activities to soldiers. He would have been ejected from his living if he had not used his status as squire of Byall to intimidate parishioners into supporting him. Finally he was arrested for having a sexual relationship with his curate, and for locking his wife out of the vicarage. While on bail he fled to France and then to Italy. Benbow similarly condemned the escape of Richard Mills, vicar of Kenwyn, Cornwall from 1781 and also chaplain to the bishop of Exeter, who had been charged with 'an unnatural offence' and granted bail in large sums. Later Benbow noted: 'without aspiring to the gifts of prophecy, we ... foretold that he would flee his country and he, as might be expected, has done so.' Benbow also deplored that the rector of Ewhurst, Mr Cooper,

was caught 'in a situation with a servant too hideous... to name,' but bribed the authorities to release him, enabling him to flee to France.¹⁵⁷

In Benbow's view, such lenience was endemic in the Church. In recounting another scandal in which William Walker, rector of St Pancras, Chichester, from 1785, 'was caught in a situation with one of his own sex, which the reader may judge, but we will not shock him by describing,' he declared that Walker received 'the usual indulgence which parsons receive on these detestable occasions extended to him – time was given to him to fly the country.'¹⁵⁸ Likewise, he pointed out, Verney Peter Littlehales, rector of Burton, Lincolnshire from 1797–1813 also fled to France in 1812 when he sexually assaulted a male servant in the house of Dr Wollaston where he was staying.¹⁵⁹ For Benbow clerics were treated preferentially in such situations. He commented, for example, on the case of Thomas Jephson by observing that if he had been a layman, rather than a fellow of St John's College, Cambridge, he would have been treated very differently. In 1823 Jephson had attempted to seduce a boy on the Cherry Hinton Road and gave him a shilling to return later the same day. When the boy returned with his father hidden in the hedge, Jephson proceeded with an act 'that rendered a speedy interference highly necessary' and the father trapped him. In the wake of the scandal Jephson fled to London but returned and claimed his right to be tried in the Vice-Chancellor's court rather than by the magistrates. Jephson claimed the boy's father had robbed him, but the account of the boy's father was believed and Jephson fled abroad.¹⁶⁰ Benbow claimed that Jephson's right to be tried by his peers in the University meant that bail was granted to him too easily.

Conclusion

In many ways, Benbow's attack in *The Crimes of the Clergy* was simply another weapon in the armament of anti-clericalism. He was a political radical, one-time Nonconformist preacher, who from 1819 to the later 1820s was a major radical bookseller. Significantly, Benbow was also a publisher of bawdy and obscene literature; indeed he concentrated on publishing pornography during the quieter political climate of the mid-1820s.¹⁶¹ As the next chapter indicates, Benbow used sexual scandal in this way to undermine the Church's position as an institution. Iain McCalman proposes that as a member of the ultra-radical press from

1819–21 Benbow influenced the ‘populist-radical aesthetic’ by combining ‘traditional plebeian street genres such as sensationalist posters and popular prints. Both were urban art forms that could be sophisticated or “crudely blunt and obscene”; Benbow’s publications fitted the latter description’. For pressmen such as Benbow, the tenets of libertarianism tied Enlightenment philosophy to their obscene publications. This radical political attack fits with the libertine context described by Faramarz Dabhoiwala, since both Libertinism and freethought were antagonistic to religion and the religious establishment in its role in enforcing moral law.¹⁶² The next chapter explores the impact of broader sexual scandals on the Church to argue that sexual scandal should not be assumed to represent the decline of the Church’s moral standards or its discipline.

CHAPTER 8

SCANDALS, THE PUBLIC, AND THE CLERGY

Role of Sexual Scandal as a Weapon

Scandals provide insights into major political and religious issues.¹ They also reveal social and sexual norms such as virtue, continence, modesty, and conscientiousness, since scandals challenged and violated them. Sexual scandals negotiated clarification of the boundary between private and public, defined whose opinions mattered in public life, and identified what issues were beyond the public interest and a matter of individual faith or conscience. Thus they played a particular role in society: Lord Rochester said that the purpose of satire was ‘to instruct the people by discrediting vice’ and Swift thought that it had a didactic purpose to reform the sinful. So sexual scandals and satires on scandals often had a levelling effect, since they stimulated popular engagement in public life, and were a method of moral and political improvement. After all, the unlettered and those without theological education needed only to have a modest grasp of scripture to know what canons scandals violated. T. J. Matthias therefore even claimed that satires and scandals were necessary for the welfare of the state.²

This chapter explores sexual scandals relating to Church personnel and Church doctrine and its breaches, which, like those attached to the monarchy, could challenge institutional authority, as well as the ideas of moral absolutes on which ecclesiastical influence rested. Clerical sexual scandals presented women as playing a distinctive role in religious life. In some cases, women were assumed to be Eve-like temptresses, but

elsewhere they were victims and subjects of predatory male authority and power.³ Moreover, doctrinal and clerical sexual scandals reveal that the individuals concerned regarded themselves as governed by a sense of natural law (where human nature was the source of moral norms) rather than traditional or biblically-based teaching. Such cases implied that the individual had evaluated the accepted principles which governed their behaviour and rejected them in favour either of their own conscience or of self-indulgence. The former might suggest a growth of a sense of natural law, the latter the decline of obedience to the Church. It would be unwise to make too much of this. There is no evidence that there were greater numbers of scandalous clergy in the eighteenth century compared to earlier or later eras, and there is no evidence that they thought more or less deeply about their actions than churchmen of other ages. The print revolution of the eighteenth century made scandals more widely known but the earlier absence of print culture did not imply the absence of scandal.

Public and Private

The Church and sexual scandal were long-standing bedfellows; there have been few ages in which the discovery of a bishop, clergyman, or pious member of the laity involved in illicit sex did not excite condemnation, attention, and amusement. It was certainly so for the eighteenth century when scandals seemed to strike at the heart of lay commitment to faith. A question which one writer in the century asked was whether clerical sexual misbehaviour should 'reflect upon the whole body, on account of the misconduct of a few, who set very ill examples.'⁴ Despite the teachings of the Church of England that the moral character of the clergy did not affect the efficacy of the sacraments they dispensed, it seemed to many parishioners that their parson's morals must affect their own worship.⁵ This was a common theme in the print coverage of scandal. Most lay men and women seemed to support George Herbert's view that the clergy were Christ's deputies and should model their lives on his.⁶ While expectations of clerical behaviour might have been high, the motives for attacking clergy were not always so pure. Donald Spaeth has noted that accusations of sexual scandals rarely came alone, they were often associated with other claims of, for example, drunkenness, neglect, and financial irregularities. In fact complex combinations of allegations

of sexual misconduct and tithe and political disputes suggests that allegation of clerical sexual misconduct were often aspects of wider disputes. Spaeth shows how vulnerable clergy were to such accusations and even to false testimony from members of their congregations aggrieved about other matters. Indeed, one of the themes of this chapter is that sexual scandals were often associated with wider social and political factors.⁷

Towards the end of the eighteenth century, the increasing emphasis on the theoretical separation of the public from the private in space and finance was accompanied by an inverse movement in matters of sexual behaviour. Sex bridged the supposed barriers between public and private. William Hone, the satirist and bookseller, asserted that 'I know no distinction between public and private life' and thus he argued that the people he satirised should be consistent in public and domestic lives.⁸ Privacy as a way of disguising hypocrisy was no longer tenable.⁹ There were growing calls for the clergy to be alert to the need to maintain a consistency between their personal lives and their public principles in order to maintain their reputations. Bishop Thomas Burgess of St Davids insisted upon this in his 1804 charge to his clergy and in 1817 Bishop Majendie of Bangor asserted that clergy should be 'zealous and indefatigable in public duties; faithful and conciliatory in private life'.¹⁰ The Revd W. Bruce Knight, preaching the Llandaff visitation sermon in 1827, suggested that clergy in 'their own lives and those of their families should be so fashioned to the doctrine of Christ that they would be an example and a pattern to their people.'¹¹ Such calls placed a burden on clergy to be above reproach, and were perhaps counsels of perfection.

Some clergy were scrupulous in avoiding any hint of scandal. Richard Venn, later rector of St Antholin's in London, found himself in a difficult situation while a student at Cambridge from 1709. He had been invited by a gentleman acquaintance to visit, and a carriage was sent to collect him. When he arrived at the house, the gentleman's wife, an attractive young woman, said her husband had been unexpectedly called away but would be home soon. She pressed Venn, said to be 'a handsome person', to stay, first for tea and then for dinner, promising that her husband would return directly. In the end Venn discovered that the gentleman was in fact in London and the lady wanted 'to enjoy the pleasure of his society' and indeed asked him to spend the night there. Venn was

horrified and, though it was some miles back to Cambridge, immediately left the house and walked back, stopping at a church en route to reflect on 'his happy escape' and his 'fleeing from temptation.'¹² Venn was clearly determined to present himself as a virtuous man, able to avoid temptation. No doubt this was part of his persona as a polite gentleman.

Clergymen were less cautious in recording their sexual interests and conversations in their personal writings. The Revd Joseph Price noted in his diary in July 1770 that a neighbouring parson 'when talking of fornication and sodomy used the words *a parte ante* for cunt and *a parte post* for the other beast'.¹³ The diary of a young Cambridge graduate, John Thomlinson, later curate of Rothbury, Northumberland and rector of Glenfield, Leicestershire, freely recorded his ribald sexual discussions with his peers. In March 1717, Thomlinson noted in his diary that 'Sir John Brownlow's lady abuses other women with her clitoris' and later the same day that:

Dan Burgess one rainy day complained in the pulpit of the absence of the ladies, saying they were afraid of spoiling their fine clothes etc and so indulged themselves in bed he wished he was with them, he would fuck them into devotion.

Thomlinson also recorded cases of polygamy, Cambridge students' use of brothels, and on 3 April 1717 decided that the 'greatest wonder in the world is women's & lawyers' tongues, for they always lie and yet never lie still.' Two days later he recorded a joke that Simon Ockley, Adams Professor of Arabic, had made: that he had stayed up late one night to see if he could speak to spirits and found that the candle was blown out when he was alone with a maid. On 24 April he wrote that a friend had told him 'a story of a strange young gent in Northumberland that courted and married a lady near Hexham and was afterwards found to be a woman.' And two days later that Lord Exeter's house contained a painting of 'a woman lying naked with her hand upon etc.'¹⁴ A year later, by which time Thomlinson had been accepted for ordination, he wrote that he had 'tried one woman and did not like her, I was to try another shortly and if I found her answer the description I intended to attack her very briskly and reduce her by storm.'¹⁵

The Church instructed clergy and laity to avoid sinful thoughts, so Thomlinson was clearly violating the Bible's teachings about sinning in his heart. Indeed, in 1910, the Surtees Society excised what they deemed his 'sordid' opinions from their publication of extracts of the diary.¹⁶ The ease with which Thomlinson discussed sexuality in a fairly humorous, bawdy way, both with his friends (often clergymen) and in his writings reveals another aspect of clerical masculinity and sociability. This conforms with Kate Davison's conceptualisation of 'occasional politeness' in which gentlemen were permitted to be ribald amongst each other in familiar situations without breaking polite conventions. Such 'intimate bawdiness' could thus be a legitimate resource for sociability among clergymen without undermining their position as long as this familiarity was kept within approved confines.¹⁷

Some clergymen were successful in containing the potential damage caused by sexual scandals. Edmund Keene, later bishop of Ely, obtained early preferment in the Church from Sir Robert Walpole, who appointed him to one of the wealthiest livings in the country, Stanhope, county Durham, on condition that Keene married his illegitimate daughter, Mary. Keene accepted the living but when Mary came of age he refused to marry her: she had a 'squat, short, gummy appearance . . . by no means deformed, or misshapen, but rather undersized.' However Keene was forced by Horace Walpole to settle £600 on Mary in compensation. The evidence of Keene's abandonment of Mary only survives because the antiquary Parson William Cole recorded the story.¹⁸ It was consequently not a scandal that reached the public ears; perhaps because clerical hypocrisy committed through callousness was less interesting to a public than when it was demonstrated by sexual misdemeanours.

Similarly Bishop Hoadly successfully kept his friendship with Viscountess Sundon from becoming a public scandal that could undermine his professional reputation. Over more than twenty years, and despite two marriages, Benjamin Hoadly sustained a close friendship with Lady Sundon which was expressed in a gossipy, affectionate correspondence. The editor of Lady Sundon's letters described them as 'the effusions of a friendship which seems to have bordered on the most romantic and enthusiastic attachment.'¹⁹ Both correspondents were of some status: Hoadly became bishop of Bangor

in 1716 and subsequently held the sees of Hereford, Salisbury and Winchester; Lady Sundon was a lady in waiting and then mistress of the robes to Queen Caroline, wife of George II. They shared similar political and theological views and exchanged letters which dealt with the minutiae of life as well as topics of significance. In the 1730s Hoadly was approached by a Mr Case, the brother-in-law of a Welsh parson, who had seen copies of the letters and threatened to blackmail the bishop. In some anxiety, Hoadly asked his friends Dr Chapman, Master of Magdalene College, Cambridge, and Bishop Green of Lincoln whether they thought the letters would embarrass him if made public. Both advised him that they were effusive but innocent and to do nothing. His bluff called, Mr Case dropped the matter and Hoadly's reputation was not affected.²⁰

The Revd John Kynaston, a literary scholar and fellow of Brasenose College, Oxford, was less successful at keeping allegations of sexual misdemeanours out of public view. In 1764 Kynaston brought a suit in the Chancellor's court of the University of Oxford against another fellow of Brasenose, Matthew Maddock, who accused Kynaston of adultery and fathering a child on Martha Kendrick. Kynaston was convinced that Maddock had trumped up the charge to get him dismissed from his fellowship at Brasenose, arguing that Maddock's claims were simply to cover his own misbehaviour. The men's relationship was clearly troubled. Kynaston had previously claimed that Maddock had debauched 'the woman I was solemnly engaged to marry'.²¹ Moreover there were sharp political divisions between the two: Maddock's brother, Samuel, had been one of the Jacobite rebels in 1745 though he later gave evidence against them.²² In an attempt to clear his name, Kynaston travelled to London and then to Eltham, where Martha Kendrick lived. There, with the help of the curate of Eltham, he discovered that a young stage coach driver was in fact the father of the child. Nonetheless, Maddock convinced opinion in Oxford that Kynaston was guilty. Despite Kynaston's publications of affidavits and evidence of his innocence, and though he sent letters to the Principal of Brasenose and the Vice-Chancellor, he was deprived of his fellowship, retiring to Wigan where he lived for another nineteen years.²³ Kynaston's mistake was perhaps that of making public what ought to have remained private for the good of the two institutions, the University and the Church.

Scandals and the Parish

Clerical hypocrisy was perhaps the central feature of parish sexual scandals since, as has been seen, it was popularly expected that those who preached the strict sexual principles of the Church, ought not break them. The Church acted to punish sexual misconduct by the clergy; Archbishop John Sharp of York, for example, prosecuted a number of such clergy in his diocese. He prosecuted William Mompesson, for seducing one of his maidservants. He certainly gave no allowances to this heroic and celebrated vicar of Eyam who had taken action to isolate the Derbyshire village in 1665–6 to prevent the spread of plague to other communities, and who progressed to be a prebendary of Southwell and vicar-general of the diocese of York.²⁴ Similarly Sharp acted against Henry Gaches, who was charged with both fornication and procuring an abortion.²⁵ Sharp was also presented with the case of Francis Hewardine, rector of Swine, who in 1702 was charged with the rape of a parishioner's daughter, recounted in graphic terms by her father.²⁶

Archbishop Sharp was not alone in disciplining clergy who caused sexual scandal, most bishops adopted high standards of clerical behaviour. William Wake, while bishop of Lincoln, prosecuted Edmund Vernon, rector of Redmile, despite the fact that Vernon had as aristocratic patron. In 1705 Vernon's patron, the Duke of Rutland, arranged for him to leave his living and for a curate to cover the parish for him to possibly suppress a scandal. But on Vernon's return he began a relationship with Elizabeth George, a servant at an inn at Melton Mowbray who was publicly known as 'a lewd, wanton and unchaste person.' Vernon was also a drunk, and on one occasion accidentally got into bed with a man, assuming it was Elizabeth George, and later tried to bribe the man not to reveal what had happened. Vernon had also become so drunk at the fair at Waltham on the Wolds that he had sex in public. Such openly immoral behaviour could no longer be tolerated and he was prosecuted in the ecclesiastical courts for fornication and deprived of his living by Bishop Wake.²⁷

No doubt this type of action served to reassure parishioners that clerical hypocrisy did not go unpunished. Sexual scandal could be a lever for expelling incompetent clergymen too. Thomas Gronow, rector of Cilybebyll and vicar of Cadoxton, was a pluralist, non-resident parson who was lax in his attitude to his duties. Consequently when presented

with evidence of his sexual immorality, in the 1830s, Bishop Copleston of Llandaff threatened Gronow with prosecution unless he resigned his livings, which he did.²⁸

Nonetheless, penitence may have enabled clergymen to recover from professional damage following illicit sexual activities. Thomas Rimbron, curate of Bedwas in Llandaff diocese, previously a shop clerk and schoolmaster before his ordination in 1767, quickly gained a reputation as 'a populous preacher.' He married his predecessor's widow but, five years after his appointment to Bedwas, in 1775, Rimbron admitted before Llandaff consistory court that he had committed adultery with his wife's cousin, who had been their servant in the parish. The court deprived him of his living.²⁹ After fifteen years, however, the scandal was forgotten and Rimbron was able to obtain the post of lecturer at St Nicholas's Church, Bristol. Nor did his history prevent him from publishing, in December 1790, *The Domestic Monitor, A Director and Guide to Parents and Children, to Masters and Servants in Religion and the Way to Salvation*, a pious work of advice on good conduct.³⁰ In it he warned against sin and argued for repentance; and in the section on prayers included one for servants to 'contently bear my lot' and serve a master as they would serve God.³¹

It may well be that by the later eighteenth century the print revolution and the growth of literacy among a mass audience enabled the behaviour of clergymen to become more widely known.³² An example was the obituary in the *Gentleman's Magazine* in 1775 for the Revd Luke Imber of Christchurch, Hampshire. Imber's obituary was included principally because it had become known that, as a parson of eighty-three, he had married a girl of thirteen.³³

A case in which the Church was less effective in acting to discipline a sexually abusive incumbent is that of Edward Drax Free, which was so notorious that it entered the public sphere and shaped debates about ecclesiastical law. Free was a fellow of St John's College, Oxford from 1784, and in 1801 became vicar of St Giles in Oxford which he was able to hold with his fellowship. Free was a difficult and vexatious man who did not regard himself as accountable to anyone. In 1806 he refused to give details of how he spent vestry funds to the churchwardens of St Giles and consequently they prosecuted him before the archdeacon. His colleagues at St John's also complained of his violent behaviour and in the end he was even refused the right to eat with the other fellows. But as

he was a senior fellow, the others did not have the fortitude to press home their opposition to him. In 1808, when the rector of Sutton, Bedfordshire, died, the fellows of St John's saw an opportunity to rid themselves of Free and appointed him to the parish. The College even paid money to repair the rectory to induce Free to accept the living.

One scholar has described Free at Sutton, rather charitably, as 'an accident waiting to happen'.³⁴ There he gave free rein to his violent temper, regularly attacking parishioners and creditors who had the effrontery to ask for payment of bills, and fell out with his parishioners through a combination of unpaid debts, tithe disputes, instances of unrestrained temper and neglect of the duties of the parish. From 1816 the parish church was almost completely shut up because he had alienated his parishioners. He held services at erratic and unpredictable hours, for which he was admonished by the bishop of Lincoln. More seriously, Free also preyed on the insecurity of women servants in the period; from 1810 he coerced his employees Maria Crook, Catherine Siggins, Margaret Johnson, Anne Taylor, Maria Mackenzie, Eliza Pierson and probably others into sex, fathering over half a dozen children.³⁵ Only by 1828 did he face prosecution in the church courts for his immorality. Montagu Burgoyne, the local squire, paid the expenses of many of the abused servants to give evidence against Free, which finally secured Free's deprivation from the living in February 1830. Nevertheless, for almost a decade thereafter, Free pursued both Burgoyne and St John's College in legal disputes and appeals against the deprivation. Burgoyne was so incensed by the long drawn out process of getting rid of Free that he published advice to churchwardens in 1830, which included much of the damning evidence of Free's sexual behaviour.³⁶

The case of Free is troubling. A negligent college rid itself of a troublesome fellow at the expense of the rape of more than half a dozen women who bore his illegitimate children as a result. The criminal and ecclesiastical courts operated in favour of a parson, and only after twenty years in Sutton did the intervention of a layman with moral stamina and determination finally free the parish of its rapacious incumbent. Free himself was clearly someone entirely unsuited to Holy Orders and regarded them as a means to both a comfortable life and to exercise his sexual whims with women who could not deny his advances. Still, in many respects Free's case is so egregious that it stands out, indicating

that it was quite exceptional for a parson to behave so badly and escape punishment for so long.

Sympathetic Clergymen and Sexual Immorality

Not all parish scandals had deleterious effects. Carolyn Steedman has recovered an instance of a parson's remarkable support of a fornicator in his parish. In 1801, Phoebe Beatson, a maidservant in the household of the Revd John Murgatroyd, incumbent of Slaithwaite, West Yorkshire, declared that she was pregnant. Her baby's father, George Thorp, refused to take responsibility for the child, despite Murgatroyd's pressure. If he had conformed to the pattern of the forbidding churchman, Murgatroyd might have cast Phoebe out of his house, not least to avoid scandal, since he was a childless widower. Indeed, before Phoebe's pregnancy, Murgatroyd recognised the harsh consequences of pre-marital sex. He was much more severe in his opinions of adultery, which he regarded as a form of robbery, and which he described as next to homicide. In part, these views of adultery were formed because of the consequences for children: abortion, unwanted children and sorrow.³⁷ They also shaped the sympathetic protection that he offered to Phoebe and her baby, Elizabeth, to whom he became a proxy father and left a significant bequest when he died in 1806. Murgatroyd's behaviour was a theological response to sexual licence and sin.

At the root of Murgatroyd's sympathy for Phoebe was his view of childhood and his rejection of Original Sin. This is an example of the growth of Pelagianism discussed in chapter one. In some of his sermon notes, Murgatroyd rejected the idea of Original Sin, instead arguing that sin was a matter of choice and decision. Children were innocent and could not be regarded as born sinful; views that came to prevail in the nineteenth century. While Murgatroyd had a progressive view of the nature of Original Sin, and the sinlessness of children, he did not regard sex as intrinsically benign. In 1788 he wrote that chastity was a means by which people could control the excesses of love and lust; being chaste at marriage was a means to secure the blessings of a happy marriage: faithfulness, honour, and true friendship. To give way to passion led to 'wretchedness, infamy and the ruin of ye person once beloved . . . who reposed too great trust in the slippery faith of man.'³⁸ Nevertheless,

confronted with an instance of fornication and an innocent child, Murgatroyd's compassion exceeded his censure.

Scandals and Politics

One of the recurrent themes in this book is the close connection between the Church, sex, and politics. The same is true as far as sexual scandal is concerned: in an era in which religion and politics were inseparable people saw sexual behaviour as having political ramifications. One example is the case of Anthony Farmer. In April 1687 James II tried to impose a Catholic onto Magdalen College, Oxford, as its president. When he announced his candidate, Anthony Farmer, college members attacked him for his sexual behaviour. Farmer was alleged to have procured women for undergraduates, to have made women dance naked before him and had kissed 'and tongu'ed a woman' as well as put his hands up under the dress of a lady visiting the college.³⁹ It is likely that Farmer's reputation for sexual misbehaviour was a convenient means to discredit a man whose religious principles were dangerous; clearly people continued to connect and merge the idea of transgressive sexuality with heterodox religion.

As noted earlier, charges of sexual misbehaviour were rarely advanced from untainted motives. An example is the life of William Durston, parson of Ripple, Worcestershire. In 1702 his churchwardens accused Durston of stripping his housemaid naked, attempting to rape another of his parishioners, and stalking others at night. Durston was clearly unpopular, and this was not the first parish in which he had fallen out with his congregation. He had also abused a parishioner, saying that 'his arse was torn.' At the same time as the sexual allegations, Durston was accused of stealing cattle from common land and tithe malpractice.⁴⁰ Overall, however, Durston's accusers were probably deploying the accusations of sexual misdemeanours because he was the son-in-law of Bishop Thomas Cartwright, one of the 'scabby sheep' who had supported James II's attacks on the Church and who other bishops suspected of informing on them to the king. James Fleetwood, son of the bishop of Worcester who had strongly opposed James II, was the archdeacon who tried Durston. Untangling the thicket of motives to accuse and prosecute Durston is problematic, but his case shows that clergy were obliged to balance the personal, spiritual, financial, and political in their

relationship with their parishioners who could use scandal as a weapon against them.

Perhaps unsurprisingly, some scandals were the inventions of political opponents and in an age in which verification of evidence was rudimentary, allegations were sometimes made on flimsy grounds.⁴¹ An example of this was an allegation advanced against Bishop Gilbert Burnet of Salisbury. Burnet was a strong Low Churchman and Whig who presided over a distinctly High Church and Tory diocese. In 1705 he had sought to influence the election of two Whigs MPs for the city of Salisbury and was rebuffed by the voters. Following the general election there was a by-election in the Wiltshire borough of Chippenham. During the campaign, Colonel Chivers, the High Church Tory candidate and 'the profoundest rake and bully in the county',⁴² claimed to have seen Burnet 'in an infamous place and in scandalous deportment.' Most took this to mean that the bishop had visited a brothel. Burnet was a churchman who set exacting standards for his clergy and, as has been seen, his *Discourse of the Pastoral Care* was the standard manual for clerical behaviour and values from the 1690s until the middle of the nineteenth century. Rather than sue Chivers for libel, Burnet threatened him with prosecution on a charge of *scandalum magnatum*, criminal libel of a peer, a much more serious offence. Chivers was forced to retract, and paid £50 to the poor in compensation. Burnet felt that the libel was a consequence of the Salisbury election of 1705 which had raised 'an anger against me which will follow me as long as I live here.'⁴³ Of course, Burnet had the financial resources and clout, as a member of the House of Lords, to initiate proceedings against Chivers.

Lancelot Blackburne, Archbishop of York from 1724 to 1743, was one of the most slandered clergymen of the eighteenth century.⁴⁴ Some of the slander appears to have been motivated by the political and theological differences of contemporaries and later historians. Thus Blackburne was reputed to have been a Caribbean pirate in his youth, a churchman of morals so lax that he was prepared to conduct the wedding of George I to his mistress in secret, a hard drinker, and a lecher.⁴⁵ His reputation as the latter led to the claim that his closest clerical ally, Thomas Hayter, was his illegitimate son, to whom he gave a series of Church livings. Much of this was without foundation. It seems likely that Blackburne had a long-term mistress, Mrs Cruwys, to whom he left

a generous bequest.⁴⁶ Nevertheless, though Blackburne was in the Caribbean as a young man, he was an incumbent of the church on Antigua rather than a pirate and there is no evidence that he married George I to his mistress.⁴⁷ The allegation that Blackburne fathered Thomas Hayter, originated with the inveterate episcopal gossip-monger Horace Walpole. Walpole wrote in December 1780, more than thirty years after Blackburne's death:

I often dined with him [Blackburne], his mistress, Mrs. Conwys, sat at the head of the table, and Hayter, his natural son by another woman, and very like him, at the bottom, as chaplain: he was afterwards Bishop of London. I have heard, but do not affirm it, that Mrs. Blackbourne, before she died, complained of Mrs. Conwys being brought under the same roof . . .⁴⁸

In fact research has shown that Hayter was the son of George Hayter.⁴⁹ However it is clear that Blackburne lived with his mistress fairly openly for many years.

Sexual misbehaviour was a weapon wielded against the archbishop. As a Whig and a Low Churchman, Blackburne had plenty of High Church Tory opponents who were happy to blacken his name and spread rumours and innuendo. Alexander Pope composed verses on clerical scandals and threw Blackburne in at the end:

My Lord of L[ondo]n, chancing to remark
A *noted* Dean much busy'd in the Park
Proceed (he cry'd) proceed, my Reverend Brother
'Tis *Fornicatio simplex*, and no other:
Better than lust for Boys, with *Pope* and *Turk*
Or others spouses, like my Lord of [York]⁵⁰

Another example dates from Blackburne's time as Archbishop of York in a poem called *The Farmer's Daughter* in 1737. It targeted Blackburne in references to a prelate who lived by the River Ouse. Blackburne's eye for women was treated as an instance of worldliness and also class distinction:

In minster set; with holy Leer,
 No bawdy Chorister's lewd Eye
 To ogle was so keen as he.
 No Eli's wicked Sons of Yore
 Did half so much admire a Whore,
 Tho they lay with them at Church-door.
 Such petty trifling Crimes as these
 Might trouble squeamish Consciences
 And what's a Sin in private Priest
 To sacred Lawn is all a jest
 For there's a Diff'rence in the Case
 Betwixt the Noble and the Base.⁵¹

The poem recounted that when the bishop caught sight of Lucinda, an attractive milkmaid, he sent his chaplain to procure her for him. Her parents, Hob and Nell, agreed that she could work for the bishop on the understanding that Numps, her half-witted brother, would receive ordination and appointment to a local parish. Before long a parish fell vacant and Lucinda asked the Archbishop for the appointment for her brother:

This said, she stroak'd his grizly Face,
 Long Life she cries attend your Grace;
 The vacant Vicarage I claim,
 That Brother *Numps* enjoy the same
 Thus yielded was to Beauty's Pow'r,
 What long was promis'd to another.⁵²

The purpose of the satire was only incidentally to accuse Blackburne of sexual misconduct; its principal aim was to attack the distribution of clerical livings according to whim and connection rather than merit. Numps, who could hardly serve a parish satisfactorily, was appointed simply because of his sister's sexual services to the ageing archbishop.⁵³

Blackburne continued to be attacked after his death. The anonymous poem *Priestcraft and Lust: or Lancelot to his Ladies* was published in 1743. It was a general attack on the clergy with Dryden's lines 'Heathens and Christians differ but in name, for Priests of all religions are the same' on

the title page. The poem claimed to be a cry from Blackburne in hell, remembering his earthly lusts:

No longer thro' the Town I range with raging flame
To seek the Virgin Nymph or married Dame . . .

It also declared that Blackburne was a man of 'due proportion,' and that beneath his cassock his 'parts are perfect,' with a manhood 'of such a size.' Blackburne was made to bemoan that the Church's teaching would deny parsons the bliss 'that beggars, under hedges, seldom miss' of an active sex life, 'a panacea for all pain.' The poem claimed that when a parson surveyed his congregation from the pulpit he was as likely to be looking for attractive women as anything else. Blackburne recalled of one woman:

Short-breath'd and panting, ye receiv'd each thrust
And wept my Fall, but twas in tears of Lust . . .
Reeking from thence the Homilies I sought
Heav'n in my mouth, all lechery in thought.

According to the poet, lust was not the monopoly of Anglicans, referring to the Dissenters' meeting at Salter's Hall:

And thus, at S—lter—'s Hall, the Holy Dames
Fume out their pray's the smoke of am'rous flames.

The poem should not, however, be taken entirely at face value. It was written by a High Church Tory and attacked Blackburne as much for his politics and churchmanship as for his morality, charging him also with voting for the land tax and supporting the government's foreign wars.⁵⁴ Moreover Blackburne's Low Church Whig colleagues were virulently attacked for their lack of learning, moderation, and loyalty.⁵⁵

In contrast the unorthodox household of Blackburne's fellow archbishop, Thomas Secker of Canterbury, avoided public comment and rumour. In 1725, as a young chaplain to Bishop Talbot of Durham, Secker had married Catherine Benson.⁵⁶ On their marriage, Thomas and Catherine Secker agreed that they would share their home with Mary, widow of Edward Talbot who had been Secker's great friend before he

died four years earlier. Secker's marriage soon proved to be problematic: Catherine was frequently ill and he was forced to move from an extremely lucrative parish in the north for one in a warmer, southern climate which suited her better. Catherine began taking large quantities of opiates and, when bishop of Bristol, Thomas was spending two thirds of his income on her medical care. While Catherine became a semi-invalid, Mary Talbot became the bishop's housekeeper and assistant, and her daughter, also Catherine, was treated as Secker's daughter. The most recent assessment of Catherine Talbot elevates her role in Secker's work, suggesting that their voices merged in some of his writings.⁵⁷ The odd ménage that Secker inhabited might have given rise to scandal and gossip, but for two factors. First, Secker and Catherine Talbot were people of noted scruple and of considerable reputation for conscience; and the Archbishop was a man of high principle, as his correspondence as bishop of Oxford shows. Secondly, Secker showed similar charity to other women: he took in the widow and children of Bishop George Berkeley in 1753 and in the late 1730s he had also taken in two aristocratic daughters, Jemima Campell and Mary Grey.⁵⁸ Thus the cases of Blackburne and Secker are instructive of how reputations, once gained, could stubbornly determine public perception. Both men of piety and exemplary bishops, Blackburne was a politically sectarian figure who attracted controversy, while Secker was not and thus his reputation reaped the benefit.

Clergymen and Sexual Madness

The personal situation of clergymen caught up in sexual scandal could also work to humanise them, creating them as figures requiring sympathy, and positioning them as men of feeling in contrast to aristocratic rakes and libertines. An example is the celebrated case of the Revd James Hackman and his role in the murder of Martha Ray in April 1779, mistress of the fourth Earl of Sandwich, who took an interest in the pornographic *Essay on Woman*, discussed in the next chapter. Sandwich had bought Martha's virginity when she was fourteen with a payment of £400 to her father and an annual payment of £30. Hackman had been ordained in 1776 after a short career in the army; he then fell in love with Martha Ray although it is unclear whether they had an affair. He first met her when he visited Lord Sandwich's country estate,

Hinchinbrooke, as the Earl often invited army chaplains to dine. Despite his appointment on 1 March 1779 as rector of Wiveton in Norfolk, Hackman became obsessed with Martha and pursued her to London appalled that Sandwich was her lover.⁵⁹



Figure 8 Robert Laurie (after Robert Dighton) mezzotint. *Portrait of the Rev. James Hackman (hanged 19 April 1779), who murdered Martha Ray, mistress of the 4th Earl of Sandwich, c. 1810.* https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Rev._James_Hackman.jpg. Accessed 15/12/2016.

On the evening of 7 April 1779, Hackman shot Martha outside a theatre in Covent Garden and tried to shoot himself immediately afterwards but was captured, tried, and hanged ten days later.⁶⁰ The public was astonished by the sight of a parson-murderer who seemed mentally unbalanced by love and newspapers and tracts recounted how Hackman had become obsessed with Ray.⁶¹ In general, the public regarded Hackman with sympathy as a young man driven to madness by passion and willing to abandon the teachings of the Church because of a desire to save Martha Ray from her corrupt life as a nobleman's mistress.⁶² *The Case and Memoir of the Late Revd James Hackman*, written by Hackman's unscrupulous lawyer, Manasseh Dawes, went through nine editions in a few weeks in 1779.⁶³ Dawes's account of the trial declared that the courtroom was in tears when Hackman made his defence, especially when it appeared that, before the shooting, Hackman had asked his brother in law to take care of Martha after his death. Dawes also suggested that Hackman had gone to the theatre intending to commit suicide and had been momentarily inflamed and killed Martha too. A year later Herbert Croft wrote a highly emotive account of the murder in a series of imaginary letters from Hackman to Ray in *Love and Madness: A Story Too True*, which sold in thousands and earned him huge sums. The combination of the passionate love of a parson, a predatory libertine earl and a beautiful but doomed woman was a heady mix for the reading public.

The popular sympathy for Hackman was evidence of a view that clergy were as fallible and human in their emotions as their congregations. Yet in some respects, accounts of Hackman's contrition after the event, especially the description of his desperate sorrow when he saw Martha Ray's body and of the poignant note he left for his brother-in-law seeking forgiveness, along with his composure and resignation before his hanging, subtly endorsed the teaching of the Church. Hackman was also regarded as a model of a different sort by some; James Boswell asked: 'think ye that this unfortunate gentleman's general character is, in the eye of Heaven or of ungenerous men in their private feelings, worse than yours? No it is not. And unless ye are upon your guard, ye may likewise be in his melancholy situation.'⁶⁴ In Croft's fictionalised account of the murder, Hackman's letters to Martha spoke of the chasteness of his feelings

towards her and even suggested that they had only ever kissed. Moreover Hackman's motives were presented as a desire to save Martha from Lord Sandwich's predatory clutches; Hackman even seemed to acknowledge that it was the devil that tempted him to murder Ray and commit suicide. In contrast, Sandwich appeared as a predatory, dissolute libertine who had abused his status to ruin Martha Ray. Anti-aristocratic feeling seemed stronger than anticlerical sentiments in this narrative. Croft was not alone in ascribing moral motives to Hackman: *The Gazetteer* also claimed that Hackman had been motivated to save Ray from Sandwich's clutches after Ray herself said she wanted to 'enter the Temple of Hymen'.⁶⁵

Following hard on the heels of Hackman's killing of Martha Ray, was the case of another mentally ill parson, James Altham, incumbent of St Olave Jewry and St Martin's Ironmonger's Lane in London.⁶⁶ Whereas the Hackman case had been marked by sentimentality and romanticism, that of Altham was principally one in which the public fixed on the prurient details of a clergyman's sexual behaviour. Altham was a graduate of St John's College, Oxford, who had held livings in Hampshire and Essex before he came to his London parishes in 1782. According to the case against him, Altham sent a letter to a maid servant, Anne Saunders, asking her for an assignation and promising her money for sex. On meeting, they had sex in the shrubbery and again later in a passage nearby; it was claimed that Altham returned from the assignation and also had sex with his wife. This was not Altham's only offence: he had boasted of his sexual intimacies with a Mrs Wenham, whose husband 'was not a sufficient man for her' and claimed to have had sex with fifty women when he was vicar of Harlow.⁶⁷ He was also alleged to have forced himself on a woman called Anne Taverner, putting his hands up her petticoats and on her breasts, and to have sought to employ Anne Saunders as a servant in his own house.

The account of Altham's trial was published three years later in 1785, 'setting forth the whole of the evidence at the astonishing trial', with engravings of Altham with women in a field, in the shrubbery and in Harlow.⁶⁸ The published account of the trial and evidence of the witnesses was recounted at such length that the publisher was obliged to issue it in two volumes. The account included that Altham had sent Anne Saunders a poem:

Dear maid, since thou hast charm'd my sight,
 O let my arms thy neck enfold;
 Those breasts so fair, those eyes so bright
 What joy, what pleasure to behold.⁶⁹

During the trial however it became clear that Altham was mentally disordered and a number of people claimed that he sometimes behaved oddly. It also emerged that Altham had been treated by Dr Munro in Brooke House, his private 'mad-house.' All that could be evinced in Altham's defence was that 'barring his attachment to women, which was generally thought to be the weak part of his character, he was generally esteemed to be a good clergyman.'⁷⁰ The second volume of evidence against Altham revealed more indications of his insanity from witnesses including his wife's relatives.⁷¹ It was only in this volume that the fact was disclosed that Mrs Wenham's husband was a Dissenter and that Altham seemed to have a delusion that he was being persecuted by Dissenters. Dr Munro testified to Altham's periodic insanity, and an apothecary, Mr Legas, of his treatment of Altham by bleeding.⁷² For one hundred pages, Altham's sexual mania was exposed and dissected for public entertainment. In the end the case against Altham was superseded by his committal to an asylum on the grounds of his insanity, and the court of Chancery Commission and Inquisition of Lunacy assumed responsibility for his affairs.⁷³ Altham died two years later and was buried in St Mary's, Latton.⁷⁴ Despite the sad nature of Altham's case, the *Monthly Review* and other periodicals widely publicised the availability of the lurid published accounts of the trial.⁷⁵ Yet alongside the entertainment there was some sympathy for Altham. For example the author of *The cuckold's chronicle: being select trials for adultery (sic), incest, imbecility, ravishment*, regarded Altham's case as one of tragedy, especially as most of the witnesses testified that, when sane, Altham was a conscientious parson.⁷⁶

Polygamy and Public Debates

An individual clergyman's views on sex and the resulting publicised scandals could shape far wider debate, as the case of Martin Madan, an evangelical clergyman, demonstrates. After graduating from Oxford in 1746 he had lived a dissolute life before a conversion experience under

the influence of John Wesley. Thereafter he was an itinerant and celebrated preacher for Lady Huntington's Connexion, a Calvinistic branch of Methodism. Madan had trained as a barrister before his ordination and often made use of his rhetorical skills in his sermons, claiming to plead the cause of God. Madan was also appointed as chaplain to Lord Aspley, an evangelical peer; he enjoyed a private income which meant he was not dependant on a church living.⁷⁷ His brother was later bishop of Peterborough, which meant that the brothers enjoyed an ecclesiastical status. In 1780 Madan published *Thelyphthora*, subtitled 'A Treatise of Female Ruin'. Drawing on his experiences as chaplain to the Lock Hospital for venereal diseases, Madan claimed that polygamy would combat 'whoredom and fornication, adultery, polygamy [and] divorce' and was sanctioned in Exodus 22: v16, and Deuteronomy 22: vv28–9. In his view polygamy would prevent men promiscuously seducing women; and oblige them to marry any women that they seduced.

Madan was not the first writer in the early modern period to explore polygamy; Milton and Luther had advocated it in specific circumstances.⁷⁸ It was the subject of conversation in London clubs



Figure 9 'G.M.', *Polygamy Display'd OR Doctor Madman restored to his senses*, 1780, depicting the consequences of polygamy advocated by Martin Madan in *Thelyphthora*. Courtesy of The Lewis Walpole Library, Yale University.

and coffee houses in 1715.⁷⁹ In 1731 a tract claimed that Bishop Gilbert Burnet had argued in favour of divorce and polygamy in response to the infertility of Queen Catherine of Braganza, Charles II's wife. Burnet's conclusion was that 'if a Woman can only Receive a Man, That makes her fit only for Venery' suggested that annulment of marriage was reasonable. The tract also declared that Burnet sanctioned polygamy, with even 'crossness of humour' as grounds for taking a second wife although a plurality of husbands was against the laws of nature.⁸⁰ This popular tract went into three editions in two years although it is clear that the publisher Edmund Curll, a fierce enemy of Burnet and the Bishop's opinions, misrepresented his views.⁸¹ Indeed Curll had for some time campaigned in favour of the legalisation of divorce and in 1732 issued a tract that sought to assemble all examples of polygamy, divorce, concubinage and legal adultery from the Bible and other ancient writings and by implication endorse them.⁸² Samuel Johnson's play *Rasselas* also discussed polygamy, suggesting that the *seraglio* was a sterile environment, rather than a sexual fantasy of a man able to satisfy his desires with many women. Imprisoned in their cage, the women in *Rasselas* became dull, illiterate, and lacked virtue. The sexually starved man needed the intellectual stimulation of one woman. Thus Johnson endorsed and supported marriage rather than polygamy.⁸³

Published in the 1780s, a decade that saw widespread debates on the nature of marriage, Madan's *Thelyphthora* elicited a storm of protest and public debate, with about ten organised public discussions of his views ranging across related fields of theology, law, the nature of marriage, and public welfare.⁸⁴ The scandal obliged him to resign his chaplaincy of the Lock Hospital. The most scholarly response to Madan was James Cookson's *Thoughts on Polygamy*, published in 1782, and which ran to more than four hundred pages and addressed theological, biblical, legal and social questions. Although Cookson was a fellow of Queen's College Oxford, as well as being rector of Colemere, Hampshire, his work was accessibly written and priced at just sixpence.⁸⁵ Madan's evangelical colleagues and friends lined up against him. Lady Huntington was especially vocal in her opposition, obtaining thousands of names on a petition against *Thelyphthora*. His evangelical friends, Henry Venn, Richard Hill, Thomas Haweis, and Thomas Wills, wrote opposing the tract. One of the earliest of a series of tracts in opposition was from a layman who argued that Madan was proposing 'revolutions in the

manners of the world' and confusing the Mosaic behaviour of the Jews with modern Christianity. The author argued that Christ laid down a new law for men and women in which there was no mention of polygamy.⁸⁶ Another critic, 'H.W.', also accused Madan of heterodoxy by suggesting that the Mosaic law was immutable and that Christ had not power to alter it. In short, 'Christ, therefore hath prohibited, what our Author asserts was before permitted or dispensed with.'⁸⁷

A more popular response was in the form of an imaginary dialogue written by the Dissenter John Tower between 'Philaethes' and 'Monogamus'. Tower claimed that Madan's real motive for his support for polygamy was making wives humble and obedient. He also amused his readers by asking Madan where the necessary supply of eunuchs would come from since 'if those wives should happen to be inclined to *variety* themselves, a keeper may perhaps be necessary for them.' He speculated:

what curious female wars would follow, if the practice of taking a plurality of wives should take place: And as I have seen some ladies, in a very striking manner, imitate the appearance of warriors, I think there might be some danger of their learning the use of arms.

Tower observed that marriage had changed over the preceding century; previously marriage might have been treated as a 'mere carnal union' but to continue to hold this view would mean that 'all which is worthy the name of marriage would bid farewell to the Christian world':

If we consider men and women as rational creatures, it surely becomes them to obtain some knowledge of each other in a mental way, before they unite together carnally; but if men and women, at first sight, marry, in Mr. M[adan]'s sense of marriage, it is most likely, that as they marry like beasts, they will be apt to divorce one another as beasts likewise.⁸⁸

In other words, the modern idea of an 'affective' or companionate marriage acknowledged the importance of marital sex but also required sympathy between spouses. Madan's aim of reducing the numbers of young prostitutes was simply too utilitarian for most. 'Philaethes' also

countered Madan's claim that legalised divorce would free men from scolding and cold women, by suggesting that the prospect of polygamy would turn women to these emotions.

Tower used the same New Testament cases as other writers to challenge Madan but saw his motives as more dangerous for religion. His character 'Philaethes' said: 'I am grieved to think how much he strengthens the hands of the Deist, by this impious (as I will call it) method of argument.' Worse, he saw Madan as 'a professed friend to what is called Divine Revelation.' This positioned Madan's evangelicalism as the source of his heterodox ideas.⁸⁹ Indeed, the danger that Madan's views on polygamy damaged the reputation of all evangelicals led Thomas Haweis to publish a rebuttal too. Haweis was a leading Anglican evangelical supporter of Lady Huntington and later to become one of the trustees of her Connexion. His *A Scriptural Refutation of the Arguments for Polygamy* took a year to write – for which he pleaded delays through ill-health – and was motivated by the view that Madan's opinions were 'as inimical to the peace of society, as opposite to the purity of the gospel.' Haweis also made a display of disclaiming knowledge of ancient languages, or of the intellect of Madan, and denied any 'claim to superior piety and veneration for the holy law of God.' Still he did not mince his words, declaring that Madan made Christ a bastard and would have given joy to infidels. Indeed he suggested that Madan should go and live among the polygamists of the Congo.⁹⁰ Haweis worked his way systematically through both the New Testament and the social consequences of polygamy and refuted both its biblical origins and its social usefulness. However, it was perhaps as an evangelical that he wrote when he concluded his tract with the words:

I might, indeed, enlarge in just defence of female rights; endued with equal faculties, and, strength of body excepted, in nothing inferior to the men. If I spoke of them as the most amiable part of humanity, and never intended in the law of creation to be sold as cattle, treated as slaves; or confined as prisoners, to minister to the lawless passions of tyrants, the field would be wide, and arguments rush on my view.⁹¹

This attack on polygamy, rooted in female equality, was another expression of the contribution of evangelicalism to modern ideas of sex,

and human relationships discussed in chapter five. Haweis also refuted Madan's view that having a vituperative wife was grounds for divorce, writing:

I may venture to affirm, where such unhappiness is found between a married pair, to once that it originates from the ill-humour, or ill-behaviour of the wife, it ten times oftener springs from the incontinence, fickleness, brutality, or intemperance, of the husband.⁹²

Evangelicals had long appreciated that women's conversion, testimony, virtue, and even preaching were the equal of men's, and in Haweis's attack on Madan, women's civil liberties were an important element. Another evangelical, Richard Hill, who was a friend of Haweis, Wesley, and Whitefield and an MP who repeatedly sought to persuade Parliament to punish Sabbath-breaking more severely, entered the fray with his work, *The Blessings of Polygamy Displayed* (1781). His acerbic response to Madan claimed that the scheme did not even have the value of utility since it would increase the numbers of prostitutes in cities as husbands discarded their wives and took up with other women. It would, he claimed, also mean that husbands would create offspring from different wives competing for resources. Hill addressed his tract to the women of England in an attempt to mobilise them as a group against Madan.⁹³

Few clergy ventured to address Madan's ideas from the pulpit, but John Smith, the rector of Nantwich in Cheshire, did so in two sermons in 1780. In a letter to Madan, attached to the printed sermons, Smith argued that *Thelyphthora* 'contains many very dangerous and pernicious tenets. Viewing the matter in this light, I think it is my duty to caution my flock against them, as being of a dangerous and licentious tendency.' Smith was perhaps particularly concerned since he noted that Madan's views on polygamy were 'the general topic of conversation, in almost every company where I go.'⁹⁴ Smith's attack was all the more significant as he was an admirer of Madan's work at the Lock Hospital and had counted Madan as one of his friends; he wrote 'I am attacking Mr. M.'s errors, and not Mr. Madan. I trust I can truly say that I love Mr. Madan, though I detest, abhor, and renounce his polygamous principles.' Smith told his congregation that the subject was 'unfit in a general way for

public discussion' but that he felt obliged to speak of it from the pulpit. He informed them that not a single passage in the New Testament endorsed polygamy and that there were numerous social reasons against polygamy, not least Smith's view that 'one and the same house can never peaceably contain a variety of women, each of whom, thinks she has an undoubted right both to the person, and property of the husband.'⁹⁵

Smith gave an instance of the pernicious effects of Madan's teachings through testimony from 'one of the most capital trading towns in the kingdom' of a parish clerk who sought to commit adultery with a member of the congregation and, when reproved, admitted his guilt and accepted the punishment of the parson. When Madan's *Thelyphthora* was published, however, the clerk renewed his attempt to seduce the woman in the congregation and brazenly defended himself by referring to Madan's book. Smith wrote that he feared there would be more of such instances. In his second sermon Smith also turned his mind to the lot of women who expected defence and protection from husbands but might in polygamy be treated to harassment, confusion, and cruelty instead. In his view polygamy would turn women into a new class of 'upper servants' for men's exploitation.⁹⁶ Smith's sermons against Madan reached beyond his congregation in Cheshire since they were published in a single volume; but also because they attracted comment in the *Critical Review*; fairly soon the sermons ran to a second edition.⁹⁷

The issue of polygamy remained in the public mind for some years after Madan's advocacy of it. In 1801 in a cheap tract an account was given of a countryman reading his Bible to his wife and pointedly telling her that King Solomon had three hundred wives and many concubines. His wife, who was surprised by the fact, read the Bible herself and then wryly joked to her husband 'what a simple Solomon wouldst thou make!'⁹⁸ While Madan's views were scandalous they initiated a national debate on the role of women, sex, marriage, and the Church that could not have happened in earlier centuries before the combined forces of the expansion of print culture and the suppression of Convocation which freed the clergy to speak their minds.

Conclusion

Sexual scandals offer insights into the reputation of the Church and its personnel and how far it could be damaged by illicit sexuality, raising

questions of what evidence was needed to condemn a sexual transgressor in the public mind. Allegations of misconduct were often difficult to counter, but not always so. It was not simply Christian charity that determined whether some scandals were forgiven and others not. In the eighteenth century ideas of remorse, repentance, and the prevention of repeating the offence emerged as criteria for the public absolution of sexual transgressors. In some cases, issues of the mental health of those who aroused public scandal were significant and also influenced public opinion. Nonetheless, the case of Edward Drax Free shows the limits of what the public would tolerate. Perhaps there was a hardening of attitudes over time as scandals reached a wider audience. In an industrial society, in which ideas of merit in advancement were coming to the fore, the response to those who so obviously lacked merit or principles was one of condemnation. This chapter also shows that scandal had the opportunity to associate censure with excitement and titillation, so that it was rarely unambiguous in its perception.⁹⁹ The final chapter explores this in more detail by examining that most ambiguous of genres: erotic narratives and their relationship with the Church and its clergymen.

CHAPTER 9

SEXUAL NARRATIVES, OBSCENITY, AND THE CHURCH

This chapter explores the ways in which sex and religion in erotic narratives served as a conduit for political, social, and cultural debates in the long eighteenth century.¹ Erotic narratives illustrate the complex relationship between the Church and sexuality. At times Anglicans and Dissenters united to campaign against obscene literature and attempted to prevent its circulation among society because it threatened morals. However, the Church and the clergy were often protagonists in erotic literature, which developed eventually into the genre of pornography. Erotic narratives targeted different denominations, particularly Roman Catholicism, featured fictional clergyman as characters in erotica, and named and shamed real clergyman in order to advance political views. They also ranged from the bawdy and 'low' to the voyeuristic, erotic and titillating, there was not one form or type of erotica. Moreover technological advances meant that images were, by the end of the century, much more clearly reproduced than before and this perhaps altered the nature of imagination in the use of erotic narratives. As such, sexual narratives complicate Faramerz Dabhoiwala's view of increasing sexual liberty during the period. They do not exemplify sexual modernity by developing into pornography by the early nineteenth century, a genre defined as material containing graphic description of sexual organs and actions written with the primary intention of sexually exciting the reader. It is not possible easily to define the works investigated in this chapter as pornographic in this way. What can be

said is that they contained sexual content that might have sexually aroused readers, but it was not their *sole* intent.² They may also have appealed to different readers. For example, pornography with a radical message could be purchased and enjoyed by readers seeking depictions of graphic sexual intercourse, and by those who held distinct political views.³ As Roy Porter observed, sexual narratives, perhaps especially in the seventeenth and eighteenth century, were ambivalent; they sought to arouse and excite, but also aimed to shock and revolt. Writings were rarely unambiguous or unequivocal either in their intent or reception.⁴

In order to evaluate the relationship between the Church and the clergy in publications which deployed accounts of sexual activities, this chapter adopts a broad term of erotica as an overarching description for books including sex, bawdy and amorous texts, which might or might not include images, as well as pornography. This captures the range of publications available. There is evidence that young men masturbated using midwifery texts, which were clearly not intended for that purpose.⁵ In the period examined, some authors were aiming predominantly to arouse and entertain readers through the medium of fiction and bawdy humour. This included expensive erotica aimed at the wealthy, novels like Cleland's *Memoirs of a Woman of Pleasure* (1749) which was advertised in the *Gentleman's Magazine*, as well as stories and ballads in cheap chapbooks and pamphlets which might be sold for as little as sixpence. Nonetheless, there was no clear shift of this form of publication in this period from authors writing about sex to attacking institutions.⁶ Indeed Norbert Schurer points out that political subversion shaped seventeenth-century sexual satire, while eighteenth-century erotic narratives reacted against domesticity, and in the final decades of the century they were often shaped by middle-class resentment against a decadent aristocracy.⁷ Thus, erotic narratives contained sexually-explicit descriptions or images, but not merely to stimulate the viewer. Erotic writing of this kind was part of a satirical genre.⁸ For the most part, many of the works discussed here were 'political exposes, and anti-ecclesiastical tracts' and they used sexual scenarios to attack religious and political authorities since illicit sexuality was increasingly associated with corruption.⁹ Recent scholarship demonstrates that there was no generic category of pornography before 1750 and few stable boundaries between the genres that included

sexual content. Instead, a number of types of print 'made use of "pornographic" strategies and techniques'.¹⁰

It has been claimed that pornography replaced erotic and bawdy publications as political and religious satire and attacks were displaced. However, more recently there has been a move away from distinguishing early modern erotic writing from modern pornography to seeing an overlap between the bawdy and the quasi-obscene materials in terms of diversity, themes and content.¹¹ Ian MacCalman, for instance, suggests that London radical printers also published pornography, and so selling both political and erotic writings was an economically sensible strategy.¹² As was seen in the last chapter, William Benbow was both a pornographer and a radical publisher. Ironically it was from accounts of 'criminal conversation' or adultery proceedings in church courts that much sexually explicit material circulated. *Crim. Con or Celebrated Trials in the Ecclesiastical and Civil Courts for Adultery*, published in 1789, ran to twelve volumes of lurid accounts of sexual misbehaviour. This was a sub-genre of sexual narratives in trial reports, made more potent by the apparently authentic witness statements.¹³ At first these were verbatim court reports, becoming more mediated and edited later in the eighteenth century. In many of the reported cases erotic narratives were placed in an ecclesiastical institutional framework due to the connections between judicial separation, divorce and the Church. Occasionally, clergymen also acted as protagonists in these accounts of infidelities, such as the case, of Mrs Errington in *The Cuckold's Chronicle* (1793), in which she was caught in the bedroom with a parson. This trope continued into the nineteenth century in publications that were not sexually explicit, but included sexual activities and were read by those interested in 'sensation and sex'. The crossover of formats is demonstrated by the fact that they were published by printers of overtly erotic material such as Edmund Curll who published collections in 1715 and 1732 and was prosecuted for obscene libel.¹⁴ Indeed, Schurer identifies only a glacial movement in erotic literature across the eighteenth century 'from a politically loaded statement into a sexually and financially motivated enterprise ... [as] political elements persist even in later eighteenth-century erotica'.¹⁵ Since erotic writing retained anti-religious and satirical facets, sexual liberty was not yet in place by the turn of the eighteenth century.

Obscenity and Faith

The relationship between erotic narratives and religion was complex. The historical assumption that the Enlightenment facilitated a progressive liberalisation of attitudes towards pornography should be questioned. In the early part of the period there were instances in which personal faith halted such a permissive trajectory, with individuals eschewing obscenity due to their religious commitment. Adrian Beverland is an example of a biblical scholar and philologist who wrote erotica but who later recanted his work following a religious experience. Beverland saw religion as a discourse through which he could write erotic texts, but also a set of rules about moral behaviour which restricted his capacity to produce and enjoy sexual narratives. Beverland was born in Holland in 1653 and educated at the University of Leiden, where he published the treatise *Peccatum Originale* in 1675 which argued that the 'curse' of Original Sin was simply the natural sexual desires of human beings.¹⁶ He argued that sex was enjoyable and 'natural' rather than sinful and tainted. For him the 'tree of knowledge' was a metaphor for genitalia. At about the same time he began his career publishing pornography with an edition of *De Laudibus Sodomiae Seu Paederatiae*.¹⁷ His other work *The Law Concerning Draped Virginitie* included descriptions of women's underclothes and also discussed ways to fake virginity.¹⁸ He also wrote on women's sexual appetites, adhering to the early modern view that women were innately lecherous. Despite using scholarly and arcane Latin forms, Beverland's work circulated beyond the academic community and he was imprisoned for obscenity. His work on Original Sin, and his challenge to Mosaic authorship of part of the Old Testament led to his ejection from the University of Leiden; and later the authorities of Utrecht also threw him out. Beverland came to London since he had links in England: he had visited Oxford in 1672, and his stepfather, Sir Barnard Gomme, lived in England, and another relation, Isaac Vossius, was a canon of Windsor. He continued to produce manuscript pornography, including pieces on prostitution, which may have eased his appointment as Gentleman of Horse to the Earl of Carberry, a libertine friend of Lord Rochester; he also secured a small pension from the court.

Beverland led a dissolute life in England, building up a large collection of indecent prints, drawings, and books, and engaged in many

kinds of sexual liberties. For example, along with Henry Bull, he took part in an orgy with three girls from the countryside and there were accounts of him groping women in Covent Garden in the 1680s. During the 1690s Beverland became prone to melancholy, and wrote verses lamenting the death of Queen Mary II. However, in 1698, a religious experience led Beverland to something of a conversion and he published *De Fornicatione Cavenda*, a public confession in which he denounced his 'imprudent youth' and thanked God for removing the veil from his eyes which had blinded him to his crimes.¹⁹ He claimed that he had burnt all his books and manuscript pornography and sent some items to the rector of Leiden and asked 'all persons who have procured any manuscripts of my writing ... to return it to me, that I may burn it myself.' Sexual liberty was thus no easy path for Beverland. Thereafter, he descended into poverty and by the years leading to his death in 1712 he suffered paranoid delusions and mental illness.²⁰

Even that most notorious rake and pornographer, the second Earl of Rochester (1647–80), renounced his earlier ways under the influence of his faith. By popular repute, Rochester was 'debauched' from the age of thirteen, while a student at Oxford. He later eloped with an heiress, whom he married against her parents' wishes, but certainly did not remain faithful to her. In the poem 'The Isle of Britain' Rochester depicted Charles II's court as sexually obsessed, a situation to which he contributed significantly.²¹ In the 1670s he became increasingly dissolute and drunk and eventually fell out of favour with Charles II who had indulged him for some time. It has even been suggested that he offered his sexual services to women whose husbands were infertile.²² Much of his time was devoted to writing and publishing obscene satires and poetry. Among these is thought to be *Sodom: The Quintessence of Debauchery* in which an imagined king legalised sodomy.²³ The result was the collapse of society, so the king decreed a new policy of 'Fuck women, and let Bugg'ry be no more'. His drama *Valentinian* shocked Restoration society by depicting a rape. Many of his works were too indecent to be printed and were only circulated in manuscript with the consequence that they have not survived.

Nevertheless Rochester remained friendly with churchmen and, as he grew ill from the sexually transmitted infection from which he would die at the age of thirty-three, he turned to Gilbert Burnet, a leading churchman, for comfort. Burnet wrote in his biography of Rochester

how, in a series of conversations, the Earl gradually came to repentance and conversion to a firm faith. Certainly in June 1680, a month before his death, Rochester wrote to Burnet that 'I begin to value churchmen above all men in the world' and 'I abhor what I for so long loved ... I glory in repentance,' and he hoped for time to 'shew a true repentance and amendment of life for the time to come.'²⁴ He asked that all his poems should be burnt after his death. So the late Stuart period was one in which religion exerted a gravitational pull away from obscenity.

Predatory Clergymen in Erotica and Satire

The complex relationship between clergymen and erotica is also exemplified by the appearance later in the century of parsons in satirical erotic images and jokes. For example *The Merry Jester* (1773) contained the following joke:

A Bishop of Durham had a slovenly habit of keeping one Hand in his Breeches. Rising up once in this Posture in the House of Peers, with some Papers in the other Hand, *I have something*, said he, *in my Hand, to offer for the Benefit of Officers' Widows*. — *Pray, my Lord*, said the Duke of Wharton, *in which Hand?*²⁵

Such images suggest something of the anti-clericalism of the later eighteenth century, and of the ambivalent relationship clergy enjoyed with parishioners. However, they do not necessarily endorse a secularising or enlightening view of society. Quite the reverse: the images often show the parson as a central figure in society, however dissolute, and the images cannot be thought of as 'polite' or models of sociability, two of the great pillars of Enlightenment society. Rather, they support recent research which argues that politeness was occasional and did not foreclose bawdiness.²⁶ Moreover attacking clergy for failure to follow the teachings of the Church had a rhetorical force which drew on the political taproots of anti-clericalism.

In some cases, erotic images of clergy were predominantly intended to titillate. Rowlandson's graphic image of a cleric having sex with a young woman resting on the back of a servant, for example, was explicit and clearly intended to arouse the viewer. It deployed a number of Rowlandson's erotic motifs, of an elderly man, often a parson, engaged

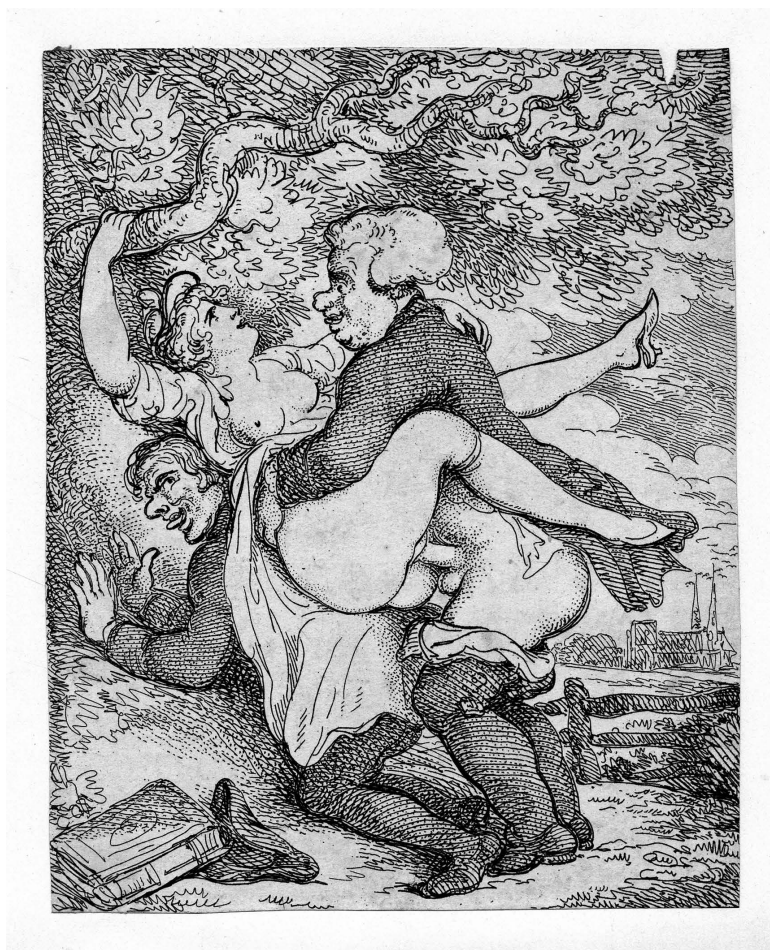


Figure 10 Thomas Rowlandson, *Untitled Erotic Print*, c. 1790–1810, © The Trustees of the British Museum.

in sex with a young pretty lower-ranking woman. Despite historians' claims for the period as one in which sociability and politeness grew, it was also one in which impoliteness and prurience was common, demonstrated by an avid interest in the sexual behaviour of others conveyed through bawdiness and vulgarity.²⁷ The clergy were portrayed in this material, largely no doubt because they were a means to illustrate hypocrisy. For instance, clergy were sometimes assumed to enjoy looking at vulgar

displays. Following the 1737 introduction of theatrical censorship by the lord chamberlain, the process of censorship was itself ridiculed. George Woodward's print of *A Minute Regulation of the Opera Step – or an episcopal examination* in 1796 depicted a bishop looking up the skirts of a dancer to make sure she was not revealing too much.²⁸ T. Rowlandson's *The Man of Feeling* of 1788 showed a parson feeling the breasts of a young woman. With a knowingly astute play on the contemporary ideal of the 'man of



Figure 11 Thomas Rowlandson, *Man of Feeling*, 1788: a clergyman fondling a young woman in front of his place of employment, with 'Essay on Women' in his pocket, Royal Collection Trust /© Her Majesty Queen Elizabeth II 2016.



Figure 12 Thomas Rowlandson, *Man of Feeling*, 1811, published in *The Caricature Magazine, or Hudibrastic Mirror* by G. M. Woodward, vol 2, Folio 75, Courtesy of The Lewis Walpole Library, Yale University.

feeling', this was a standard depiction of the hypocrisy of the parson who preached sexual restraint, but was sexually unrestrained. Rowlandson's 'Man of Feeling' also used a clergyman fondling a young woman to satirise the depravity and hypocrisy of the Church and its clerics.²⁹ The picture on

the wall indicates that the parson in his rooms does no work and simply luxuriates in the sensual sides of life, from food, alcohol, to sex.

'The Amorous Reverend Rewarded' (1784), aimed to portray clergy as corrupt.³⁰ Here the cleric had clearly taken advantage of his ability to access a home to seduce a married woman, as indicated by her bare bosom and his discarded wig, but is disturbed by her husband who seeks his revenge. This is a descendant of the anti-papist rhetoric which imagined priests as a sexual threat to the family (see chapter six), and demonstrates some anxiety about the figure of the clergymen who had permission to intrude into the domestic.

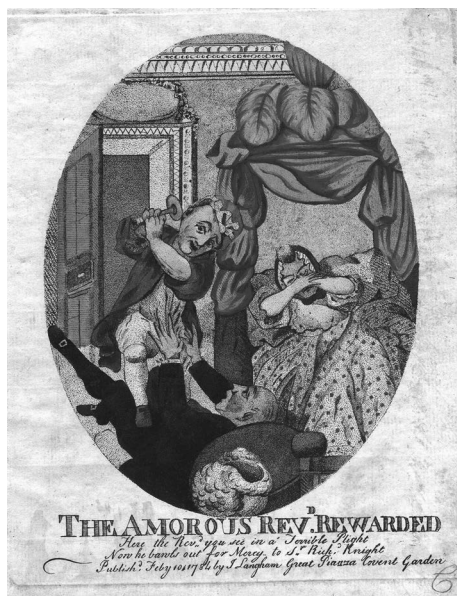


Figure 13 'The Amorous Reverend Rewarded' (1784). Published 10 February 1784 by J. Langham, Great Piazza, Covent Garden, 1784. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

The caricature 'The Virgin Shape Warehouse' (1799) is an example of such an attack on a real clergyman, in which the trope of the sexually predatory cleric was deployed to condemn the reputation of the Revd John Trusler. Trusler published collections of published sermons for other clergymen in the 1770s.³¹ Church authorities and contemporaries



Figure 14 Charles Ansell, 'The Virgin Shape Warehouse'. Published 1 September 1799, by S. W. Fores, No. 50 Piccadilly, 1799. © The Trustees of the British Museum.

saw the traffic in printed sermons as corrupt.³² This satirical print thus played publicly on Trusler's name and actions to criticise him as a clerical mountebank. By placing Trusler at the centre of the warehouse, naming him Dr Trussup, with a knowing look and a hand fondling a woman's very large buttocks, the image positioned his behaviour as corrupt. It also mocked his publishing career for extending beyond the clerical profession, no doubt referring to his publications on female etiquette.³³ Thus while the activities and values of the Church in some respects contributed to the move to politeness, the continued involvement of the clergy in erotic narratives also resisted its growth. The clergyman depicted in sexual activities was a symbolic debauched everyman parson, deployed to attack aspects of the Church.

Anti-Clerical and Anti-Papist Sexual Narratives

English pornography in the eighteenth century frequently included priestly protagonists, in part because it was influenced by French pornography and was published in an era of strong anti-Catholic sentiment. French erotica, which was published in England, included attacks on lewd priests and lusty

nuns. This was adapted to English tastes with an anti-Papist stance.³⁴ The emphasis of the sexual-religious genre shifted over the century, however. In the early years its primary aim was to attack the Catholic Church through the depraved, corrupting behaviour of the clergy. The anti-papist thrust deployed the tropes of French pornography where priests exploited their position and access to women in the closed, confined worlds of the confessional and nunnery. In *The Book of Rates Now Used in the Sin Custom House of the Church and Court of Rome*, published in England in 1674, there was a fictional table of fines to be paid for Catholic priests' sexual misconduct.³⁵ *The Frauds of the Romish Monks and Priests*, published in 1691, reached its fifth edition by 1725.³⁶ As chapter six argues, the anti-celibacy rhetoric of the first half of the century viewed the Catholic Church's imposition of celibacy as a cause of sexual depravity and predatory priests. The result was that prosecutors sometimes found it difficult to distinguish obscene publications from anti-Papist ones, indicating the extent to which such erotic narratives were a vehicle for attacking religion.³⁷

The anti-Catholic publications containing sexual content, which were circulated in England usually from Europe, took a variety of forms. One example was a French scandal, dating from 1728 to 1730, concerning Marie-Catherine Cadiere, a penitent who accused Father Jean-Baptiste Giraud, her Jesuit confessor, of seducing her. It became a publishing sensation in Britain; one account, *The Case of Mrs. Mary Catherine Cadiere*, reached eleven editions by the end of 1732. Like other anti-Catholic erotic works the accounts described sexual misbehaviour, but they were not particularly explicit, and it is unclear how far readers found the publications sexually stimulating. Other examples used crude sexual description to attack all Catholics clergy with humour. 'Jeremy Jingle's' *Spiritual Fornications*, 1732 pronounced:

*Priests, wbeth'er Jesuits or Frayars,
Are Pious Cheats, Religious Lyars;
Who use their Function as a Gin,
To catch unwary Maidens in.*

More specifically it declared:

*The goatish Giarard, Satan's Imp,
Uses Religion, as a Pimp;*

*Under a Mask of holy Grace,
Allures Cadriere to his embrace;
Kisses each Part about her gratis,
And often Firks her Nunquam satis'.³⁸*

Colin Haydon identifies common themes which marked out this corpus: the confessional's threat to the patriarchal family, the way that celibacy inverted sexuality by leading to sexual perversion, and the latent threat of religious enthusiasm.³⁹ French anti-clerical pornography was adapted in England by the mid-century to focus on sexual initiation and flagellation, as in Cleland's *Memoirs of a Woman of Pleasure* (1749). By the later decades of the century, religion was increasingly a setting for sexual activities and in some cases this material's dominant aim was to arouse readers.⁴⁰ Nonetheless it stubbornly retained its anti-Papist form, such as *The Nun in the Cloister or, the Amours, Intrigues and Adventures of the Marchioness of Beauville*, a reprint in 1828 but based on a much older work and one which had led to the prosecution of its printer Edmund Curll in the 1730s. Like other convent-themed erotica, the gentry girl entered a convent and was sexually exploited by an older father-confessor.⁴¹

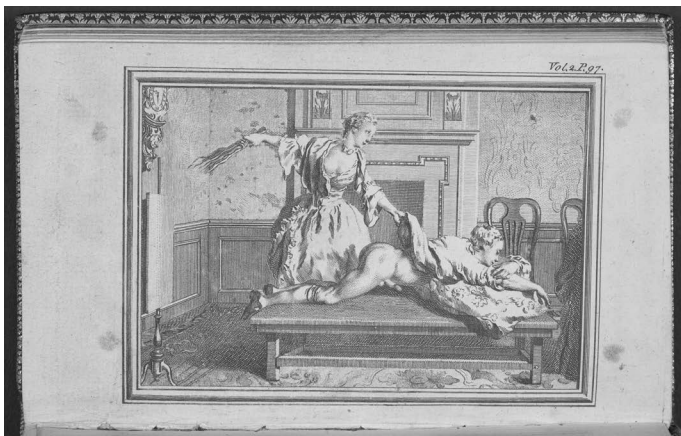


Figure 15 Fanny Hill depicted flagellating the parson, Mr. Barville, © The British Library Board (John Cleland, *Memoirs of a Woman of Pleasure*, 1766, in *Memoirs of a Woman of Pleasure*. From the original corrected edition. With a set of elegant engravings [ascribed to Gravelot]. [By John Cleland.] London 1766, Shelfmark(s): General Reference Collection P.C.30.k.27).

Too Hot to Handle: The Moravian Sexual Narratives

Catholics were not the only religious group targeted by publications that contained descriptions and allegations of unacceptable sexual activities. The Moravian Church was the victim of such an attack and suffered considerable setbacks as a result. The example of the Moravian Church also suggests that, at least in ecclesiastical and polite circles, society was not yet ready to adopt liberal and tolerant attitudes to sexual narratives. The Moravian Church enjoyed something of a charmed existence in England in the first half of the eighteenth century. In origin the Moravians were a seventeenth-century persecuted Protestant sect from Bohemia, which could trace its origins to the Hussite sect of brothers called the 'Unitas Fratrum' of the fifteenth century. The name 'Moravian' was derived from the sect's period in German-speaking Moravia until its ejection from Bohemia and Moravia in the 1620s. By 1724 they had established a community in Herrnhut in eastern Saxony, led by Count Nicholas Zinzendorf. In reality the Herrnhut group, numbering less than three hundred to begin with, was an amalgam of Protestant refugees from a number of German states.

Nevertheless in early eighteenth-century England, foreign Protestants, especially those who had been persecuted by Catholics, like the Huguenots, gained a heroic status in the minds of Anglicans; particularly so after the Lutheran George I ascended the throne. From 1714 until the middle of the 1770s funds were raised in Anglican parishes for persecuted Protestants in the Vaudois Valley in France and in many parts of Catholic Germany. Even provincial clergy saw themselves as committed to the interests of European Protestants. In 1760, the rector of St Maurice's, Winchester wrote:

If we desert our allies on the continent there's an end of ye Protestant Religion in Germany ... The Hanoverians were permitted probably by ye French ye free exercise of their religion and so probably are ye Hessians now. But were they as likely to continue under ye power of France, as ye K of France's own subjects are, why should we suppose they would be treated with more mildness than the Huguenots in France are?⁴²

Up and down the country money was raised for such causes in 'church briefs'.⁴³

The influence of the Moravians on evangelicals such as John Wesley was profound. Wesley met Zinzendorf on board ship when they travelled as missionaries to Oglethorpe's new colony in Georgia and was impressed by his Pietism. It was at a Moravian society meeting that Wesley's heart was 'strangely warmed' in May 1738, and thereafter he visited Herrnhut. If, as John Walsh has suggested, Methodism was a combination of High Church Anglicanism and German Pietism, it was principally from the Moravians that the latter was derived (though Pietism predated Moravianism).⁴⁴ Indeed, the Moravians were astute and effective in building ecumenical relationships with the Church of England. For Anglicans, the Moravian Church's episcopacy and Lutheran links were important marks of a valid Protestant sister church. In 1749, the Moravian Church Act granted legal recognition to the Moravians as 'an ancient Protestant Episcopal Church' and permitted Moravians in North America to pay fines in lieu of military service, and in Britain and Ireland to affirm rather than swear oaths required by law. In effect the law recognised the Moravians as a privileged dissenting church in communion with the Church of England. To achieve the passage of the 1749 law, the agreement of the bishops in the House of Lords was required and most gave their consent readily.⁴⁵ The Moravians even managed to negotiate their path through the Jacobite alarms of the 1740s, when Methodism was accused of dangerous popery.

It seemed as if the Moravians' standing in England was assured. But in 1753 a Lutheran Prussian diplomat and opponent of the Moravians, Henry Rimius, published a shocking revelation: *Candid Narrative of the Rise and Progress of the Herrnhuters*, an exposé of Moravian teaching about sex.⁴⁶ He alleged that their hymns spoke of Christ's blood anointing the sexual organs of the newly married, and that Moravians practised communal sex. Rimius also claimed that women Moravians venerated the penis and used sex to reach the ecstasy of conversion. The effect of Rimius's work was explosive: the *Gentleman's Magazine* devoted a page to the work and denounced the Moravians as evil.⁴⁷ The public was agog and Rimius's publisher quickly planned a second edition to keep up with demand. Moreover Rimius's dedication of the book to the Archbishop of Canterbury, albeit without his permission, gave the book a veneer of respectability. In 1755, Rimius published *A Supplement to the Candid Narrative*, in which he brushed aside the few tracts defending the Moravians and asserted new scandals, including

that Zinzendorf believed Judas had been saved from damnation by kissing Jesus on the mouth.⁴⁸

The Moravian teachings on sexuality were certainly unorthodox: sex was regarded as a sacramental activity and sermons and hymns showed an intense interest in sexual organs. The penis, taught Zinzendorf, was not an organ of shame but a feature of humanity which men shared with Christ, since, as fully human, Christ had been circumcised and clearly had a penis. This seemed to elevate men in the church; although women's wombs, from which Christ was born, were also regarded as sacred. Moravians taught that the wound in Christ's side was analogous to a womb, and in it religious conversions happened.⁴⁹ Moravian teaching on sex led to the emergence of the idea of the 'mystical marriage,' which held that intercourse was a means of communion with God, and to the idea that religious conversion was as much an erotic as a spiritual experience.⁵⁰ The communal interest in marriage and the organisation of sex as an activity that happened on specific days and occasions, together with the practice of group confession of sins, led some to assume that there was an orgiastic element to it.⁵¹ There were also suggestions that Moravians elders watched newly married couples engage in sex. The Moravians' organisation into 'choirs,' segregated groups of men and women usually based on age, also encouraged the belief that homosexuality was rife, and, if not tolerated, at least recognised by the church.⁵² This period in Moravian history, in which there was an emotional and lurid interest in Christ's wounds and in sexuality, is often known as 'the sifting time.'

The sexual revelations about the Moravians, titillating or not for readers, certainly led Anglicans to abandon their connections with Zinzendorf. The first to do so was George Whitefield, who admittedly had always been cooler towards the Moravians than Wesley. Whitefield's *Expostulatory Letter* (1753) addressed to Zinzendorf attacked the Count and the Moravians from the position of a leader of an evangelical group. His *Letter*, published a few weeks after Rimius's book, sold for just fourpence and reached an even wider audience.⁵³ Prurience sold well. Whitefield's tract undoubtedly made the scandal of the Moravian unorthodox sexual teachings even more widely known. By August 1753, Bishop John Thomas of Lincoln warned Zinzendorf that the Moravians were a laughing stock and that they were no longer viable in Britain. It also became public knowledge that the Archbishop of Canterbury,

Thomas Herring, had decided against a plan to nominate Zinzendorf as a trustee of the British Museum and that they had exchanged acrimonious letters.⁵⁴

Several other published attacks which distanced the authors from the Moravians also focused on the Moravians' alleged sexual proclivities. In December 1754, George Lavington, Bishop of Exeter, repeated Rimius's lurid attacks in *The Moravians Compared and Detected*, and denounced the church as 'filthy' and 'horrible.' He concluded that their hymns were obscene, some were written 'in honour of your phalluses' and that Moravians anointed their sexual organs with oil during their weddings.⁵⁵ Lavington's tract was widely disseminated and the Moravian church was further undermined in the following year by John Wesley's *Queries Humbly Proposed to Count Zinzendorf*. In section nine he included sixteen questions on sex; simply by asking these questions Wesley undermined the Moravians.⁵⁶ All but one of the Anglican bishops were ranged against the Moravians; and when Rimius found himself in financial problems they supported him with contributions. As Podmore claimed, 'in 1749 the Moravian Church in England had been vibrant ... celebrated and admired ... after the crisis of 1753, however, it soon became regarded as fraudulent, immoral, unorthodox and dangerous.'⁵⁷ The attacks on the Moravians' unorthodox sexual ideas and practices destroyed the church's viability in England; even if the complexities of Moravian theology and their justification of their spirituality were lost on a public that simply enjoyed the salacious details. What Clark calls 'voyeurism and inadvertent titillation' affected sexual scandals in religion as much as in politics.⁵⁸

Clerical Pornographers

Clergymen and their families were involved in producing erotic literature of various kinds. Benjamin Hoadly, bishop of Winchester from 1734–71, found that his son, John, a playwright, had written a scandalous sex comedy called *The Suspicious Husband*. Bishop Hoadly, his chaplain later claimed, demanded changes to the drama which featured an old man who was gulled by his young, attractive wife.⁵⁹ More notorious was Thomas Potter, younger son of Archbishop John Potter of Canterbury, who penned *Essay on Woman*, the so-called dirtiest poem in the English language, which scandalised polite society, and was a

virulent attack on the Church.⁶⁰ Potter, rather than John Wilkes, was alleged to have written the notorious, obscene and blasphemous parody of Pope's *Essay on Man*. The poem began by echoing Pope's form but with very different content:

Awake, my Fanny! Leave all meaner things;
This morn shall prove what rapture swiving brings!⁶¹
Let us (since life can little more supply
Than just a few good fucks, and then we die)
Expatiate free o'er that loved scene of man,
A mighty maze, for mighty pricks to scan;
A wild, where Paphian Thorns promiscuous shoot,
Where flowers the Monthly Rose, but yields no Fruit.

Archbishop Potter had intended Thomas for a career in the law and obliged him to carry out a promise to marry a wife he detested. However, Thomas was an irredeemable rake who funded his brazen sexual behaviour from his father's fortune, reputedly £90,000, which had been left to him because, ironically, his older brother had been disinherited by the Archbishop for marrying a maidservant.⁶² One scholar has called Potter an old-fashioned rake: 'impulsive, misogynistic and resistant to sentiment.'⁶³

Thomas Potter was quite open about his dissolute life, passing on his sexual conquests to his fellow MP John Wilkes, the radical politician, who, some claimed, Potter had corrupted. Potter also frequented Sir Francis Dashwood's Hell Fire Club at Medmenham Abbey. The Club parodied Catholicism by its use of monastic dress and rites, but was in effect a private club for sex parties at which prostitutes were brought from London for public displays of sex. The Abbey also contained a large collection of pornography for its members, mainly imported from France.⁶⁴ Significantly, as Iain McCalman argues, libertines and freethinkers often shared an antagonism to religion and the religious establishment in its role in enforcing moral law and behaviour.⁶⁵ Potter was motivated to write *Essay on Woman*, by his fierce animosity for the Revd William Warburton, to whom Pope had bequeathed the rights to his *Essay on Man* and who used its frequent re-publications as a means of self-promotion and to advance his anti-clerical and political agenda. Potter had already seduced and fathered a child with Warburton's wife, who was twenty-eight years her husband's

junior, and the *Essay on Woman* further attacked Warburton. The poem in manuscript remained a private joke between Wilkes and Potter until the former published it in 1762, after Potter's death in 1759 aged forty-one of venereal disease. The poem was reported to the authorities as obscene by John Kidgell, vicar of Godstone.⁶⁶

The scandalous nature of the poem lay partly in its frontispiece which claimed 'Rogerus Cunaeus' – Roger Cunt – wrote it, along with a commentary allegedly written by Warburton. Its front page was decorated with images of an erect penis and testicles; which it said were 'most frequently in the crutch of the Most Reverend George Stone, Primate of Ireland, more frequently in the anus of the intrepid hero George Sackville,' both rumoured to be sodomites. Since Wilkes was an MP, he claimed parliamentary privilege for the publication against suits for libel, leaving Warburton to fulminate against the poem in the House of Lords, where he now sat as Bishop of Gloucester. It was in the House of Lords that the fourth Earl of Sandwich (a key figure in the murder of Martha Ray, discussed in chapter eight) read aloud obscene sections of the poem causing uproar. The wave of revulsion that greeted the poem led George III to exclude Wilkes from court, and polite society to shun him; following his prosecution for obscenity he escaped to France.⁶⁷ Wilkes's defence in the case against the *Essay on Woman* was that a man's public duties were the only matters on which he should stand condemned, his private life was irrelevant to his public role. This was however as unsustainable for an MP as it was for a clergyman. Both could reasonably be assumed to have a duty to live an exemplary life: the MP if he wished to represent a constituency and hold public office, and the clergyman if he sought to avoid accusations of hypocrisy for preaching one set of principles for his parishioners but living by another.

Some clergy were consumers of erotica, such as the Revd Edward Drax Free, mentioned in chapter eight. In court, his servants described how Free exposed himself to them in his dressing gown, showed them pornographic pictures and drunkenly entered their bedrooms which they were prevented from locking. Free also owned a copy of *Aristotle's Masterpiece*, an early book which was considered indecent, and which the rectory handyman saw and described as containing pictures of 'naked men and women in carnal conversation with each other; in different situations, standing, lying, sitting; all of the most indecent kind.'⁶⁸

Obscenity and Anti-Clericalism

In the first two decades of the nineteenth century, as political radicalism grew and social and economic grievances intensified, anti-clericalism became more pronounced. For example, writers like William Cobbett laid some of the responsibility for the era's social and economic ills at the door of the Church.⁶⁹ In the wake of the French Revolution, institutional scandals, whether political, royal, or ecclesiastical took on a new significance. Revelations about aristocratic and clerical scandals in France had preceded the Revolution and were also taken to be a prelude to dangerous activism in Britain. Moreover radical agitators were keen to associate all institutions with the aristocracy and government, and portrayed the Church as part of the corrupt elite. Some within the Church thought the same; for example, Hannah More implied that the Church was too closely associated with the aristocracy. The Duke of York, a son of George III, was swept up in an army corruption scandal in 1809 and portrayed in public prints as a bishop since he held the titular laicised bishopric of Osnabruck in Hanover. The royal family resorted to corruption to buy off satirical attacks in the public prints; between 1819 and 1822 George IV spent £2,600 bribing satirists not to attack him.⁷⁰ Indeed class antagonism underlay William Cobbett's question of why the Society for the Suppression of Vice prosecuted a woman apple-seller for working on a Sunday but did not prosecute the Prince Regent's wife, Caroline of Brunswick for sexual immorality.⁷¹

Not surprisingly, following the Napoleonic wars, a new generation of writers scrutinised the Church's income and clergymen's behaviour and attacked its position in politics and society by suggesting it was irredeemably corrupt and vice-ridden. The implication of many of their attacks on the Church was that people were too trusting of their parsons and should be ready to challenge and attack them. Undoubtedly the rise in clerical incomes at the close of the eighteenth and first half of the nineteenth centuries added to the radicals' view that the clergy were a class apart from their parishioners, and more disturbingly, from social and moral discipline.⁷² After the rise of political radicalism and the emergence of extreme anti-clericalism in the first years of the nineteenth century, the new print media treated clerical sexual scandal as evidence of the malevolence of priestcraft and of the need for reform of both the Church and wider economic and political structures. John Wade, the

author of the *Black Book* (1832) was an advocate of Church reform and left no overstatement unrecorded in his attack on the idea of an established Church. *The Black Book*, for example, claimed that 'within these last five years there have been discovered among the prostitutes of that dissolute sea-port [Liverpool] no less than twenty-five women, the daughters of Welch (sic) clergy.' Much of the material uncovered by radical writers was exaggerated and marked by inflated hyperbole.⁷³

In the years after the French Revolution, the government was increasingly aware of the dangers of unrestrained attacks on the aristocracy and the Church, and while the French and English churches and nobility were not comparable, this did not prevent political and religious leaders seeing scandal as a source of the labouring classes' leverage against the social elite.⁷⁴ Obscene publications were a staple of the radical attacks on religion and the Church. This continued into the nineteenth century when ultra-radicals published works that Iain McCalman calls 'a type of obscene populism,' which focused on the sexual misdemeanours of the Establishment. He points out that anti-clericalism was a major feature of this obscenity, with several radical-publishers like Cannon, Dugdale, Wedderburn, and William Benbow, the latter a friend of Cobbett and a radical political agitator, producing obscene accounts in the 1820s aimed at evangelical 'enthusiasts, "saints", and Methodists, as well as at the corrupt and bloated parson of radical demonology'.⁷⁵ Titles included Benbow's two volume *Crimes of the Clergy* (1823), and other titles such as the *Atrocious Acts of Catholic Priests*, *The Seducing Cardinal*, *Nunnery Tales*, and *A Peep at Popes and Popery*.⁷⁶

Benbow's pornographic publications exposing clerical sexual misbehaviour in the 1820s were both titillating and weapons against the establishment, whether political or religious.⁷⁷ Benbow had been a cobbler and Dissenting preacher who turned to politics and financed his radicalism through the sale of pornography, for which he was regularly prosecuted for obscenity.⁷⁸ Although *The Crimes of the Clergy* included accounts of drunkenness, financial misdeeds, and neglect of religious duty, Benbow also described the clergy's illicit sexual activities. His motivation, declared in his preface to the volume, was that clergymen assumed an apostolical character but were "'full of rottenness within;" remove the veil from them, and they will appear in their real characters – wolves in sheep's clothing, and are sevenfold more the children of the *Devil* than they who make no profession of having been *called*.' Benbow's

method was to list notorious cases and characters. He recorded clergymen's sexual acts from the most heinous to the mundane; intended to illustrate his claim that many clergy were 'led away with diverse lusts, men of corrupt minds'. Included were those who had abused children, such as Mr Horridge, incumbent of Newton, near Manchester, who was tried for violating an eleven-year-old girl pupil at the parish school. Horridge was convicted and sentenced to two years in Lancaster Gaol. Benbow commented that after this the church at Newton crashed to the ground, as if in some providential judgement on Horridge.⁷⁹

Another case was that of a Parson Eyre who was tried at Aylesbury assizes in 1823 for raping an eleven-year-old girl. Benbow claimed that the details of the case were so shocking that they had been suppressed, but still reported the girl's testimony that Eyre 'forcibly and carnally had knowledge of her person . . . [and] repeated the same acts every night at his own home.' When arrested, Eyre admitted to 'tickling' the girl but denied raping her; the jury found him not guilty. Benbow sarcastically concluded that he hoped the experience 'may be a lesson to him against the indecency of tickling little children all his future life.' He included another instance of a clergyman escaping punishment with the Revd Septimus Hodgson who used his status as chaplain to an orphanage to rape children there. He was dismissed after he made a thirteen-year-old girl pregnant but was not punished further and returned to the living of Thrapston, Northamptonshire where he continued to reside. Benbow used this type of instance to demonstrate the Church's hypocrisy. As he stated in his preface: 'It is monstrous to hear a person harangue against fornication, who has just come reeking from an adulterous bed'.⁸⁰

Benbow offered another version of clerical hypocrisy in the case of George Chisholm, curate of Hammersmith from 1822, a vocal supporter of the Society for the Suppression of Vice and a regular preacher against fornication, who nevertheless lived a double life with a Mrs Scott by whom he had five illegitimate children. Despite this, Chisholme progressed to be rector of Ashmore and later incumbent of St Peter's in Hammersmith. Benbow also deplored Edward Robson, rector of St Mary's Whitechapel from 1787–95 and a magistrate, who seduced Miss Raydon, a young woman in his parish. When the constables brought her to swear as to the paternity of her child, Robson was sitting on the bench which caused her to shriek and faint. Neither this, nor Robson's reputation as a regular visitor to prostitutes, prevented his

further successful career as chaplain to the duchess of Atholl and vicar of Orston, Nottinghamshire.⁸¹

Benbow cast even the rather more mundane adulterous priests as exploitative. Mr Sneyd, curate of Hanbury, Worcestershire was successfully sued in June 1790 for £1,000 in damages by Mr Cecil for committing adultery with his wife. Benbow portrayed the curate Sneyd as young and handsome and deliberately seducing Mrs Cecil into abandoning her aristocratic husband and children.⁸² Outside the adultery case upon which this account was based, it is clear that neither Mrs Cecil nor her husband were victims.⁸³ Four years later a similar case involved Lady Cadogan and a Parson Cooper who had formed a liaison. Lady Cadogan was affected by convulsive fits and it was concluded that Cooper had taken advantage of her, with the claim that 'every part of the house was by times made a scene of adultery.'⁸⁴ John Ratcliffe, curate of Littleborne in Kent from 1820, and former chaplain of Christ Church, Oxford from 1810, was a wife-beater who seduced his parishioners' wives. As Benbow declared, Ratcliffe earned the nickname 'Big Ben,' no doubt as a reference to the size of his penis. John Vause, curate of Garston, Liverpool, in the 1790s was an inveterate frequenter of brothels who 'ogled girls from the pulpit, and had, during the singing of Psalms, pencilled a note of assignation to give to a strumpet as he left the church' and even administered communion to his women as a 'washer away of sins.'

Such cases were selected to further Benbow's objective which was to offer lessons to pastors to demonstrate what public disgrace could be attendant upon private lusts.⁸⁵ Though the proportion of Anglican clergy who were exposed as breaking the Church's moral codes was small in the context of the more than 13,000-strong body of ordained churchmen, readers of Benbow's accounts of illicit sexual activities must have seen the Church as open to challenge. It certainly placed the behaviour of clergy under considerable public scrutiny. Moreover, Benbow clearly saw his lurid accounts of clerical sexual misbehaviour as a contribution both to his radical politics and his obscene publications.

Religious Censorship of Obscene Literature

Until the eighteenth century, when the common law courts heard cases against those circulating obscene material, the Church dealt with the

regulation of publications deemed obscene through ecclesiastical courts.⁸⁶ Most of the criminal cases against obscenity were brought by private groups of religiously-motivated members, rather than the government or individuals.⁸⁷ This occurred during the eighteenth century, though inevitably was heightened during campaigns for moral reformation. David Foxton argues that, in these prosecutions, 'we can trace the influence of the societies for the reformation of manners, and increasing concern of the Church with popular morality.'⁸⁸ Although some pornographic books were published in England, or imported into England in the final decades of the seventeenth century, they were rarely prosecuted for obscenity until the eighteenth century. *Venus in the Cloister*, for example, was first published in England in 1683 as a translation of a French work without any formal government response. But in 1724, when it was reprinted by Edmund Curll, it was caught up in a drive against pornography which included prosecution of *The Treatise of Flogging*. In the following year he was the first person to be prosecuted under the common law of obscenity for both works.⁸⁹ In 1728, Curll was also fined twenty five marks and required to provide a bond for good behaviour of £100. In prosecuting Curll, the attorney general argued that such works were against civil government and the public peace but a key plank in his argument was that 'it be against religion'. Similarly, *The Fifteen Plagues of a Maidenhead* had also been published in England in the seventeenth century but its publishers, James Read and Angel Carter, were only prosecuted in the Queen's Bench in 1707. *The Fifteen Plagues* was considered especially dangerous since, unlike other French imports, it was not published as a rare luxury item but as a cheap chapbook for popular consumption. In 1709 there was even a prosecution of a medical work, *Gonosologium Novum Or a New System of all the Infirmities and Diseases, Natural, Accidental and Venereal in Men and Women*, written by a noted surgeon, John Martin.

Perhaps the high point of ecclesiastical activism against pornography in the eighteenth century was the prosecution of John Cleland's *Memoirs of a Woman of Pleasure*, published in November 1748. It took almost a year until the nature of the book was apparent to the authorities, although there is some evidence that the publisher, Fenton Griffiths, had shown the work to a lawyer in the Secretary of State's office and had received an indication that it would not be proceeded against for obscenity. When he got wind that the government was concerned by the

book, Cleland wrote to the Secretary making various claims in an attempt to avoid prosecution. Among these were that clergymen had bought the book in significant numbers and that he had revised the book to change a flagellant from a parson to a layman. He then said that he wished he had not published the book and 'this too would probably be the case if the pious indignation of my lords the Bishops will give them leave to consider that they can take no step towards punishing the Author that will not powerfully contribute to the notoriety of the book and spread what they cannot wish suppressed more than I do.' He even referred to the recent publication of Thomas Cannon's *Ancient and Modern Pederasty Investigated and Exemplify'd* which had not been 'thoroughly forgot' (and is discussed in chapter eight).

In a further attempt to placate the authorities, Cleland published the two volume edition in an expurgated single volume edition renamed *Fanny Hill*. But this did not satisfy Bishop Thomas Sherlock of London, who wrote to the Secretary of State, Thomas, Duke of Newcastle describing the book as 'the lewdest thing I ever saw . . . if there is not law enough in this country to reach this vile book after all the pretence to correct it, we are in a deplorable condition.' On the same day, a warrant was issued against Cleland and Griffiths who were arrested. Cleland's prediction came true and, as often happens when books are banned, the book sold in much greater numbers after the prosecution, bringing the author a pension of £100 a year and the publisher, Griffiths, £10,000.⁹⁰

Conclusion

The end of the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries saw a renewed and systematic endeavour to suppress vice, which brought together members of the established Church, including evangelicals, in the reforming societies.⁹¹ The remit of the Proclamation Society, founded 1787, included to 'suppress all "loose and licentious Prints, Books, and Publications, dispersing Poison to the Minds of the Young and Unwary, and to punish the Publishers and Vendors" thereof,' was the objective 'to save "the rising generation" of the respectable ranks in society from the lure of indelicate literature and pornography.'⁹² The Society initiated prosecutions for obscene libel against disseminators of pornography, thereby setting a trend as a private body bringing obscenity prosecutions.⁹³ McCalman argues that the Queen Caroline affair

resulted in a heightened legal effort to eradicate pornography and an intensified campaign against immorality by the Society for Suppression of Vice. The Society for the Suppression of Vice, founded in 1802, declared its intention to prevent the 'publication of blasphemous, licentious, and obscene books and prints'.⁹⁴ Merging with the Proclamation Society, the Vice Society revived prosecutions against obscenity in the Quarter Sessions and Court of King's Bench.⁹⁵ It secured seven convictions against publishers of obscene literature in two years, and by 1812 its main focus had shifted from preventing profaning the Sabbath to the control of blasphemy and obscenity'.⁹⁶ By 1817 it had brought between thirty and forty successful prosecutions.⁹⁷

Although the societies had different membership: the Proclamation Society was largely aristocratic, and the Vice Society predominantly middle class, they were all members of the Church of England, driven by religious faith. The judiciary supported these voluntary societies, though individuals criticised them for acting independently of the traditional authorities of Church and State, for only prosecuting the humble rather than the aristocratic, and for using regulation to improve moral behaviour rather than by improving people's inner conscience.⁹⁸ For various elements of the establishment well into the nineteenth century, the conviction remained that blasphemy and obscenity were inseparable.⁹⁹

CONCLUSION

This book has made the case that in matters of sex, as with most other areas of life, the long eighteenth century was a period in which religious ideas and principles were powerful. The assumption that the universal solvent of the Enlightenment unglued the Church from sexual ideas and behaviour is erroneous. Throughout this book it is evident that laymen and women thought about and practised sex within a religious, and predominantly Anglican, framework. The approval or disapproval of sexual acts and ideas, the permission or proscription of them, the penance and punishment and the changes in all these, were largely Anglican. From pulpits and in chancels up and down the country parish clergy were the principal means of 'broadcasting' on matters of Christian doctrine and sexual morality.¹ The revisionist view of the importance of the sermon in the eighteenth century in England and Wales endorses the view that the influence of the clergy in the pulpit and in print cannot be ignored.² Those clergy who conducted baptisms, marriages and penances, and preached on all manner of moral issues were the most accessible and potent influence on society. In general, they knew whether the babies they baptised were illegitimate, or the result of fornication; they knew whether marriages were valid, or violated by consanguinity or adultery; they presided over the penances of their parishioners and offered advice and teaching on marital and sexual matters.

Historians sometimes give the impression that the process of the Enlightenment made the past more modern and more like today. This familiarity is often seen in the emphasis on 'modernity' and secularism which are associated with developments of rationalism, agency, liberty,

self-identity, and self-actualisation. In this view, comfortably, the past seems to point to the present, and some historians engage with it by seeking to identify moments which can be seen as points of the emergence of modernity. Yet much of the evidence in this book points to features which stubbornly defy such linear progressive interpretations. As David Nash concludes, 'the acceptance of rationalism and rationalisation was not a single unified historical process.'³ For example, for many people sex, religion, and politics occupied the same mental or imagined space, but this is not a feature congruent with modernity, it is a feature that survived into the eighteenth century from earlier eras. Such complexity and lack of linear development is true of many features of sex and religion in the period. Ideas of sin and transgression, and of biblical condemnation leading to legal or moral judgement, survived well into the nineteenth, and even the twentieth centuries; this was an inheritance from an earlier time.⁴

In fact the eighteenth century was a period in which moral precedent and the heritage of religious teaching was dominant. Indeed the adjective 'primitive' was positive and desirable in the period; eighteenth-century Christians sought to make the Church as primitive as possible, emulating the past and making it as authentic and close to the time of Christ. Men and women who were subject to the moral discipline of the church courts, and those who sought judgements in defamation cases, saw the institution that exerted authority over them as both divine in origin and sanctioned by centuries of legitimacy. This was the case even if some evaded its strictures because of the church courts' inability to operate as effectively in larger, more anonymous parishes. The same was true of ideas of sexual behaviour and morality. The world inhabited by the people we have discussed was one in which the past, and the patina of experience, was valued and highly regarded. When they considered matters like polygamy, homosexuality, adultery, and masturbation their stable point of reference was religious teaching and what had gone before.

As is clear in this book, this does not mean that nothing changed; much did. But the changes were not always, in fact rarely, generated by the science and reason of the Enlightenment. Many of the changes in attitude to sex in the eighteenth century were generated from within the Church. The growth of optimistic Pelagian theology which emphasised God's benevolence and minimised human sinfulness was an

Anglican ideal. The goal of a mutually satisfying marital sexual relationship was delivered by the Church and many people aspired to it. The ideas of moral restraint that gained increasing approval were derived principally from the Church and saw their strongest expression in the second wave of evangelical activism from the 1770s. Paradoxically both the tolerance and intolerance of homosexuality existed within the Church. Further ambivalence can be seen in the proscription of erotica and the emergence of pornography, the former was led by the Church and the latter inextricably bound up with anti-clericalism. Changes in moral and sexual ideas about the character of marriage, the nature and value of celibacy, and the nature of public sexual scandals were all derived from the religious rather than the secular world.

In short, there is no monolithic narrative of a decline in religion in tandem with sexual liberty's rise. As Nash argues, religion must be given a central part in any social and cultural history of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries because it is always 'actively chosen, actively embraced or equally rejected'.⁵ By attending to the Church's interaction with sexual behaviour at theological, conceptual, and practical levels, therefore, it emerges that the institution and its personnel played a central role in individual's encounters with sexuality, their sexual identities, and their sexual acts throughout the long eighteenth century.

NOTES

Introduction

1. For which see W. Gibson, *The Church of England 1688–1832: Unity and Accord*, London: Routledge, 2001, pp. 4–28. W. Gibson, *The Achievement of the Anglican Church, 1688–1800, The Confessional State in Eighteenth Century England*, Lampeter: Edwin Mellen Press, 1995, pp. 5–33.
2. For an account of the secularisation debate see J. C. D. Clark ‘Secularisation and Modernisation the Failure of a “Grand Narrative”’ *Historical Journal*, vol. 55, no. 1, March 2012, pp. 161–94.
3. An exception to this is Faramerz Dabhoiwala’s *Origins of Sex*, London: Allen Lane, 2012, and his article ‘Lust and Liberty’ in *Past and Present* vol. 207, no. 1, 2010.
4. T. Hitchcock, *English Sexualities, 1700–1800*, Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1997, p. viii.
5. R. Porter, *Enlightenment: Britain and the Creation of the Modern World*, London: Allen Lane, 2001. For a recent indication of how diverse the term ‘Enlightenment’ is see R. Carr, ‘A Polite and Enlightened London?’ in *Historical Journal*, vol. 59, no. 1 (2016).
6. This view is advanced in G. Rousseau’s ‘Sex, Medicine and Disease’ in J. Peakman (ed), *A Cultural History of Sexuality in the Enlightenment*, London: Bloomsbury, 2014.
7. T. Laqueur, *Solitary Sex, A Cultural History of Masturbation*, Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1990.
8. Anon., *A Supplement to The Onania, or the Heinous Sin of Self-Pollution*, London: T. Crouch, n.d., p. 141.
9. Dabhoiwala, *Origins of Sex*, p. 3.
10. As Rosalind Carr points out ‘this is disappointing, as more engagement with the heterogeneity of opinions regarding religion and morality in Enlightenment discourse would have enhanced this investigation of sexual liberty,

- sensibility and politeness in eighteenth-century London' in Carr 'A Polite and Enlightened London?', p. 629.
11. With the exception of Jeremy Gregory's "'Homo religiosus": masculinity and religion in the long eighteenth century' in T. Hitchcock and M. Cohen (eds) *English Masculinities, 1660–1800*, London: Longman, 1999, 85–110 and his 'Gender and the Clerical Profession, 1660–1850' in *Studies in Church History* 34 (1998), pp. 235–71.
 12. See for example D. Spaeth, *The Church in An Age of Danger, Parsons and Parishioners, 1660–1740*, Cambridge, 2000; W. M. Jacob, *Lay people and religion in the early eighteenth century*, Cambridge University Press, 1996. W. M. Jacob, *The Clerical Profession in the Long Eighteenth Century, 1680–1840*, Oxford University Press, 2007.
 13. R. Hyam, *Empire and Sexuality, The British Experience*, Manchester University Press, 1990.
 14. D. MacCulloch, *Silence, A Christian History*, London: Allen Lane, 2013, pp. 184–6, 201.
 15. For which see: V. Barrie-Curien, *Clerge et Pastorale en Angleterre au XVIIIe siècle, Le diocèse de Londres* Paris: CNRS, 1992; J. S. Chamberlain, *Accommodating High Churchmen: The Clergy of Sussex, 1700–1745*, Chicago: University of Illinois Press, 1997; J. C. D. Clark, *English Society 1688–1832* Cambridge University Press 1991; W. Gibson, *The Achievement of the Anglican Church, 1689–1800*, Lampeter: Edwin Mellen Press 1995; W. Gibson, *The Church of England 1688–1832: Unity and Accord*, London: Routledge, 2001; W. Gibson, *Enlightenment Prelate: Benjamin Hoadly 1676–1761*, Cambridge: James Clarke & Co, 2004; J. Gregory, *Restoration, Reformation and Reform, 1660–1828, Archbishops of Canterbury and the Diocese*, Oxford University Press, 2000; J. Gregory & J. Chamberlain (eds), *The National Church in Local Perspective: The Church of England and the Regions, 1660–1800*, Woodbridge: Boydell & Brewer, 2002; R. G. Ingram, *Religion, Reform and Modernity in the Eighteenth Century, Thomas Secker and the Church of England*, Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2007; W. M. Jacob, *Lay people and religion in the early eighteenth century*, Cambridge University Press, 1996; W. M. Jacob, *The Clerical Profession in the Long Eighteenth Century, 1680–1840*, Oxford University Press 2007; J. Jago, *Aspects of the Georgian Church: Visitation Studies of the Diocese of York 1761–1776*, London: Associated Universities Press, 1997; N. Sykes, *Church and State in England in the Eighteenth Century*, Cambridge University Press, 1934; N. Sykes, *Edmund Gibson*, Oxford University Press, 1926. N. Sykes, *William Wake*, Cambridge University Press, 1957.
 16. Lesley Hall, review of *The Modern History of Sexuality* (review no. 526) <http://www.history.ac.uk/reviews/review/526> (accessed: 25 December, 2015).
 17. A point made by Steven Seidman, 'Theoretical Perspectives', in Steven Seidman, Nancy Fischer, and Chet Meeks, *Handbook of the New Sexuality Studies*, London & New York: Routledge, 2006, p. 14.

18. J. Israel, *Radical Enlightenment: Philosophy and the Making of Modernity, 1650–1750*, Oxford University Press, 2001; *Enlightenment Contested: Philosophy, Modernity, and the Emancipation of Man, 1670–1752*, Oxford University Press, 2006; *Democratic Enlightenment: Philosophy, Revolution, and Human Rights 1750–1790*, Oxford University Press, 2011. J. C. D. Clark, ‘The Enlightenment: catégories, traductions, et objets sociaux’, in D. Masseau and G. Laudin (eds) *Les Lumières dans leur siècle*, special edition of *lumières*, no. 17–18 (2011), pp. 19–39. For the most recent discussion of the Enlightenment see W. Bulman and R. G. Ingram (eds) *God in the Enlightenment*, Oxford University Press, 2016.
19. M. Foucault, *The History of Sexuality*, London, Penguin books, 3 vols, 1978–86.
20. M. Foucault, ‘What is Enlightenment?’ in P. Rainbow (ed.) *Foucault Reader*, New York: Pantheon Books, 1984, pp. 32–50.
21. For an examination of the alignment of radical politics and sexuality see I. McCalman’s *Radical Underworld: Prophets, Revolutionaries and Pornographers in London, 1795–1840*, Cambridge University Press, 1988.
22. D. Cruickshank, *The Secret History of Georgian London*, London: Windmill Books, 2009, pp. 301–4. For Madan’s performances at the Lock Hospital see W. Gibson ‘The British Sermon 1689–1901: Quantities, Performance and Culture’ in K. Francis and W. Gibson (eds), *The Oxford Handbook of the British Sermon 1689–1901*, Oxford University Press, 2012, p. 10.
23. Though Rosalind Carr warns against too passive a view of womanhood in this period, in Carr, ‘A Polite and Enlightened London?’, p. 625.
24. J. Peakman, ‘Introduction’ in Peakman, *A Cultural History of Sexuality in the Enlightenment*, p. 28.
25. <http://www.oldbaileyonline.org/browse.jsp?id=17301204-22&div=17301204-22&terms=hollywell?highlight> (accessed 18 October 2013); on occasion these episodes too place inside the cathedral: Rictor Norton (Ed.), “William Holiwell and William Huggins,” *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. Updated 8 September 2000 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1730holi.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015). One of the participants in the above case was William Huggins, described as ‘a Religious Man, who kept to his Church constantly on Sundays’.
26. Rictor Norton (ed.), “Newspaper Reports, 1726,” *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 29 April 2000; updated 24 February 2005 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1727news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015). Norton also has evidence that in Bristol a church was a centre for homosexual activity. In 1737 a homosexual, about to flee to London wrote: ‘We got home very safe that Night, and are now bound for London: We wou’d willingly see you before we go, and caress one the other: We are three of us, you shall have your Choice; two are clean, wholesome, young, smooth fac’d Fellows, well dress’d, either of whom you shall have your Will. Pray appoint the Day, because we will be at home. Our Lodgings are private, at – in St. James’s Church-yard, and a private Room to ourselves. We beg you to bring some Money with you (as being Church-warden it will be nothing out of your Way)

- to bear our Charges to London.' Rictor Norton (ed.) 'Sodomy in Bristol,' *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 10 Dec. 2003; updated 28 Feb. 2007, enlarged 17 Feb. 2015 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/bristol.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
27. Rictor Norton (ed.), "Molly Christenings, 1728," *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 25 February 2013 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1728tayl.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
 28. F. A. Pottle (ed), *Boswell's London Journal 1762–3*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 1950, pp. 49–50.
 29. W. Matthews, *The Diary of Dudley Ryder, 1715–16*, London: Methuen, 1939, p. 218. Ryder's diary is a fascinating study of a young man of serious temperament (who ended his career as Attorney-General and a judge) who recorded his desire to kiss women but rarely acted on it.
 30. H. J. Jackson, *Marginalia, Readers Writing in Books*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 2001, p. 87.
 31. Cruickshank, *Secret History*, p. 539.
 32. E. E. C. Nicolson, 'Sacheverell's Harlots: Non-Resistance on Paper and in Practice' in M. Knights (ed.), *Faction Displayed: Reconsidering the Impeachment of Dr Henry Sacheverell* (Parliamentary history volume) 2012, pp. 69–80.
 33. Plate 3 of the the *Harlot's Progress* series by William Hogarth.
 34. This is certainly suggested in *A vindication of the Reverend Dr. Henry Sacheverell, from the false, scandalous and malicious spersions cast upon him in a late infamous pamphlet, entitled The Modern Fanaticke: Intended chiefly to expose the iniquity of the fact on the general without taking any considerable notice of their poor . . . and tool B---t in particular. In a dialogue between a Tory and a Wh---g*, London: Henry Clements, n.d. but 1711, p. 41.
 35. Cruickshank, *Ibid.*, pp. 30, 134–5, Cruickshank records a French estimate of 40,000 prostitutes in London in the 1720s; R. Trumbach, *Sex and the Gender Revolution*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998, vol. 1, p. 112.
 36. Cruickshank, *Secret History*, pp. 50, 105. This was clearly a common slur on bawdy house owners.
 37. Anon., *The History of the Human Heart: or the Adventures of a Young Gentleman*, London: J. Freeman, 1749, quoted in L. de Vries and P. Fryer, *Venus Unmasked: The Bawdy History of Eighteenth Century Love and Sex*, London: New English Library, 1968, p. 105.
 38. Anon., *The Whore's Rhetorick Calculated to the Meridian of London And Conformed to the Rules of Art*, London: George Shell, 1683, p. 68. The introduction to the Edinburgh reprint of 1868 suggests that the book was Italian in origin and adapted to London when it was translated.
 39. T. Purney, *The Life of Mr. John Stanley: Viz, of His Parents . . . His Education . . . of His Children by Mrs. Maycock . . .* London: John Applebee, 1723, p. 32. This is incorrectly cited by Cruickshank as *The Life of Captain John Stanley*.
 40. Anon., *The London Bawd, With her Character and Life: Discovering the Various and Subtle Intrigues of Lewd Women*, London: John Gwillim, 1705.

41. Ibid., p. 36.
42. *The Cuckold's Chronicle*, p. 66.
43. Steven Seidman, 'Theoretical Perspectives' in Steven Seidman, Nancy Fischer and Chet Meeks (eds), *Handbook of the New Sexuality Studies*, London & New York: Routledge, 2006, p. 4.
44. K. Phillips and B. Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality: A Premodern History*, London: Polity Press, 2011, pp. 7, 12.
45. S. Toulalan and K. Fisher (eds), *The Routledge History of Sex and the Body from 1500 to the Present*, London: Routledge, 2013, p. 3.
46. See I. McCalman's *Unrespectable Radicals? Popular Politics in the Age of Reform*, Aldershot: Ashgate, 2008.

Chapter 1 The Church's Teaching on Sex

1. T. Laqueur, *Solitary Sex: A Cultural History of Masturbation*, New York: Zone Books, 2003; A. D. Harvey, *Sex in Georgian England*, London: Phoenix Press, 1994; J. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books, The Development of Pornography in Eighteenth Century England*, Basingtoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2004; Dabhiowala, *The Origins of Sex*.
2. J. Potter, *Archaeologiae Graeca, or The Antiquities of Greece*, London: S & J. Sprint, 1697, vol. 2, pp. 306–7.
3. H. Stowell, *The Life of Thomas Wilson*, London: Rivington, 1819, pp. 193–8.
4. A. Ashley, 'The Spiritual Courts of the Isle of Man, especially in the Seventeenth and Eighteenth Centuries', *English Historical Review*, LXXII (CLXXXII) (1957), pp. 31–59.
5. C. W. Troxler, 'Wilson, Thomas (1663–1755)', ODNB.
6. Especially his *Parochialia, or, Instructions to the clergy in the discharge of their parochial duty*, he went through a new vogue in 1853 when his *Sacra privata: the private meditations, devotions, and prayers of the Right Rev. T. Wilson, D.D., lord bishop of Sodor and Man: now first printed entire, from the original manuscripts* was published.
7. [R. Challoner], *Philothea, or An Introduction to a Devout Life*, London: J. P. Coghlan, 1787, p. 84. This work was first published in 1724. We owe this to Prof Sabine Volk-Birke of the University of Halle-Wittenburg.
8. [H. Dodwell] *The Introduction to a Devout Life . . . Fitted for the Use of Protestants*, Dublin: Benjamin Tooke, 1673, p. 139.
9. P-G. Bouce, 'Some Sexual Beliefs and Myths in Eighteenth-Century Britain' in P-G. Bouce (ed), *Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain*, Manchester University Press, 1982, p. 36.
10. Hale made the comment in the blasphemy trial of John Taylor. D. Thomas, *A Long Time Burning, A History of Literary Censorship*, London: Praeger, 1969, p. 66. D. S. Nash, *Blasphemy in Modern Britain, 1789 to the Present*, Aldershot: Ashgate, 1999.
11. E. Gibson, *Codex Juris Anglicani*, London: J. Baskett, 1713, vol. 2, p. 966.

12. Ibid., vol. 2, pp. 1000, 1117.
13. The non-sexual moral crimes were blasphemy and profaneness, swearing and cursing, and drunkenness.
14. Gibson, *Codex*, vol. 2, pp. 1125–7. Benefit of clergy had become a way of reducing sentences for those who could recite biblical passages, rather than simply a privilege of the clergy.
15. Ibid., vol. 2, pp. 1129–31.
16. N. Sykes, *Edmund Gibson*, Oxford University Press, 1926, pp. 67–71.
17. R. Whatley, *A Discourse made to a Person in a Country Church, October 1, 1732, Doing Penance for the Sin of Fornication. Most humbly recommended to the consideration of the Committee of the honourable House of Commons, of Enquiry into the Abuses of the Ecclesiastical Courts*, London: J. Clarke, 1733.
18. W. Gibson, 'Electoral religion in the reign of Charles II and the limits of the confessional state?' in *The Historical Journal*, vol. 51 no. 1 (2008).
19. *Journals of the House of Commons*, London: HMSO, 1803, vol. 22, pp. 79–80.
20. E. Gibson, *Of Visitations Parochial and General, Being the Charges Deliver'd to the Clergy of the Archdeaconry of Surrey*, London: B. Barker, 1717, p. 101.
21. F. Dabhoiwala, 'Lust and Liberty' in *Past and Present*, no. 207 (May, 2010), p. 99.
22. W[illiam] B[arlow], *A Treatise of Fornication shewing what the sin is, how to flee it, motives and directions to shun it: upon 1 Cor. VI, XVIII*, London: J. Dunton, 1690, pp. 11–12.
23. Ibid., pp. 15–16. The argument of the pure and holy nature of the body was a common theme in sermons, including those that denounced fornication: E. Lawrence, *Two Funeral Sermons of the Use and Happiness of the Humane Body*, London: T. Parkhurst, 1690.
24. B[arlow], *A Treatise of Fornication*, pp. 23–4, 38.
25. Ibid., *A Treatise of Fornication*, pp. 42, 70.
26. A reference to the Duke of Monmouth's rebellion in 1685.
27. *Letter of Advice to a Friend Upon the Modern Argument of the Lawfulness of Simple Fornication, Half-Adultery and Polygamy*, London: W. Keblewhite, 1696, p. 10.
28. J. Ovington, *Christian Chastity: Or A Caveat against Vagrant Lust. A Sermon Preach'd at Lee in Kent, May 18th 1712*, London: J. Morphew, 1712, pp. 1, 3, 4, 8, 13, 22.
29. M. Tindal, *Christianity as Old as the Creation; or, the Gospel a Republication of the Religion of Nature*, London: n.p., 1730, p. 345.
30. A. Holbrook, *A Letter to the Author of Christianity as Old as the Creation Upon the Immorality of Fornication* . . . London: J. Knapton, 1731, passim.
31. R. Whatley, *A Discourse Made to a Person in A Country Parish Church, 1 October 1732 Doing Penance for the Sin of Fornication*, London: J. Clarke, 1733, p. 14.
32. Ibid., p. iv.

33. *Satan's Harvest Home, or the Present State of Whoredom, Adultery, Fornication, Procuring, Pimping, Sodomy and the Game at Flatts and Other Satanic Works Daily Propagated in this Good Protestant Kingdom*, London: n.p., 1749, p. 6.
34. *Ibid.*, p. 9.
35. *Ibid.*, p. 13.
36. *Ibid.*, p. 28.
37. *The Critical Review, Or, Annals of Literature*, vol. 21 (1766), p. 205.
38. Warburton's 'On the Nature of the Marriage Union' was published in R. Hurd (ed.) *The Works of the Right Reverend William Warburton, Lord Bishop of Gloucester*, London: Cadell and Davies, 1811, vol. 9, pp. 345–65. Stebbing's work was H. Stebbing, *Remarks on the Reverend Dr Stebbing's Dissertation on the Power of States to Deny Civil Protection to the Marriages of Minors*, London: John and Paul Knapton, 1755.
39. This was a widespread view expressed in B[arlow], *A Treatise of Fornication*.
40. *Antenuptial Fornication Considered in a Letter to a Young Gentleman*, London, 1766, p. 55.
41. For Thurlow's relationships see G. M. Ditchfield, 'Thurlow, Edward, first Baron Thurlow (1731–1806)', *ODNB*.
42. *A Letter to the Bishop of London. Containing a Charge of Fornication Against Edward Lord Thurlow ... With His Lordship's de Bene Esse Defence. By Cassandra*, London: n.p., [1788], pp. 3–5. Lord Thurlow was a great favourite of George III.
43. M. Moxon, *The Manchester Dæmoniack, Or, The White She Devil Ejected: in a Sermon Against Adultery*, London: n.p., 1703, *passim*.
44. Moxon was also the publisher of *The Character, Praise and Commendation, of a Chaste and Virtuous Woman: In a Learned and Pious Discourse Against Adultery in 1708*. For a discussion of this see D. M. Tuner, *Fashioning Adultery: Gender, Sex and Civility in England, 1660–1740*, Cambridge University Press, 2004.
45. In the KJV: v 27: 'Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not commit adultery: v.28 But I say unto you, That whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart.'
46. Moxon, *The Manchester Dæmoniack*, p. 20.
47. For the wider thesis of change in attitudes towards adultery, see Turner, *Fashioning Adultery*, *passim*.
48. A. Jephson, *The Heinous Sins of Adultery and Fornication Considered. In a Sermon Lately Preached at Craike in the Diocese of Durham*, London: J. Knapton, 1754, pp. i–xiii.
49. For the sexual double-standard, see Joanne Begiato (Bailey), *Unquiet Lives: Marriage and Marriage Breakdown in England 1660–1800*, Cambridge University Press, 2003, pp. 149–61; Bernard Capp 'The double standard revisited: plebeian women and male sexual reputation in early modern England,' *Past and Present* (1999) 162 (1): 70–100.
50. *Town and Country Magazine* (December 1765), p. 625.

51. 'A Chronological Account of Memorable Things From the Conclusion of the Treaty of Peace at Utrecht in the Reign of Queen Anne, Anno 1713: To the second day of September Anno MDCCCLII when the Julian Account Expired in Great Britain' f. 170. A manuscript history in the ownership of the author.
52. T. Pollen, *The Fatal Consequences of Adultery To Monarchies as well as to Private Families, With a Defence of the Bill Passed in the House of Lords in the Year 1771*, London: T. Lowndes, 1772, p. 104.
53. W. Cobbett, *Parliamentary History of England from the Norman Conquest in 1066 to the Year 1803*, London: T. Hansard, 1819, vol. xxxv, cols 243–4.
54. Anon., *A Letter to My Lords the Bishops on Occasion of the Present Bill for the Preventing of Adultery*, London: J. Dodsley, 1779, pp. 4, 12.
55. Anon., *The House of Peeresses or Female Oratory, Containing the debates of several peeresses on the Bishop of Landaff's Bill for the More Effectual Discouragement of Adultery*, London: G. Kearsley, 1779, pp. 9, 15–16, 52. Much of the second half of the tract was an oblique reference to the various sexual misdemeanours of the peeresses husbands.
56. G. M. Ditchfield, 'Church, parliament and national identity c. 1770–c.1830' in J. Hoppitt (ed.) *Parliaments, Nations and Identities in Britain and Ireland, 1660–1850*, Special Issue of *Parliamentary History* (2003), p. 64.
57. D. T. Andrew, 'Adultery à-la-Mode': Privilege, the Law and Attitudes to Adultery 1770–1809' in *History*, vol. 82, no. 265 (1997), pp. 5–23.
58. E. Fowler, *A Short Dissuasive from the sin of uncleanness*, London: J. Dowling, 1701; A. Holbrook, *Christian Essays on the Immorality of Uncleanness and Duelling delivered in two sermons preach'd at St Pauls*, London: John Wyat, 1727.
59. J. Woodward, *A Rebuke to the Sin of Uncleanness*, London: Joseph Downing, 1717, pp. 4, 5, 6, 8–9, 10, 20–1.
60. R. Perry, 'The Veil of Chastity: Mary Astell's Feminism' in P-G Bouce (ed.), *Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1982, pp. 142–3.
61. T. Laqueur, *Solitary Sex: A Cultural History of Masturbation*, New York: Zone Books, 2003, pp. 13, 20, 94, 95, 147, 174–9.
62. S. Patrick, *A Commentary on the First Book of Moses Called Genesis*, London: Richard Chiswell, 1695, pp. 502–4. It was a book that was reprinted in 1698 and 1704. This was rooted in part in the belief that semen contained complete human beings, which were merely gestating in the womb, making men the sole agents of procreation. We owe this to David Nash.
63. *God's Judgement Against Whoring, being an Essay towards a General History of it from the creation of the world, to the reign of Augustus (which according to common computation, is 5,190 years) and from thence down to the present year 1697 being a Collection of the Most Remarkable Instances of Uncleanness*, London: Richard Baldwin, 1697, vol. 1, pp. 27–8.
64. Though as Laqueur points out the work may have been available as early as 1710 – *Solitary Sex*, p. 179.
65. Laqueur, *Ibid.*, p. 191.

66. 'Math. Rothos.', *A Whip for the Quacks* . . . London: Jos. Marshall, 1727, p. 15.
67. Anon., *A Supplement to Onania, Or the Heinous Sin of Self Pollution* . . . London: T. Crouch, 1729, pp. 36, 50, 71, 139–46.
68. 'Philo-Castitatis', *Onania examined, and detected: or, the ignorance, error, impertinence, and contradiction of a book call'd Onania, discovered, and exposed* . . ., London: J. Marshall, 1724, pp. 15, 67, 86, 89–90, 110–1.
69. R. Cornwall (ed.) *Bishop Burnet's Discourse of the Pastoral Care*, Lewiston: Edwin Mellen Press, 1997, pp. 4–5, 170, 178, 192.
70. It is now widely assumed that it was written by Richard Allestree. J. Spurr, 'Allestree, Richard (1621/2–1681)', *ODNB*.
71. T. Rawlet, *The Christian Monitor* . . ., London: S. Tidmarsh, 1696, pp. 24–38.
72. I. Green, *Print and Protestantism in Early Modern England*, Oxford University Press, 2000, pp. 353–5.
73. S. Tye, 'Religion, the SPCK and the Westminster Workhouses: 'Re-enchanting' the Eighteenth Century Workhouse' Oxford Brookes University PhD thesis, 2014.
74. *The Whole Duty of Man*, London: E. Wicksteed, 1745, preface.
75. *Ibid.*, pp. 260–1.
76. *Ibid.*, pp. 367–75, 460.
77. A. M. Lord, "'The Great Arcana of the Deity": Menstruation and Menstrual Disorders in Eighteenth-Century British Medical Thought' in *Bulletin of the History of Medicine*, vol. 73, no. 1 (Spring 1999), pp. 38–63. K. Harvey, *Reading Sex in the Eighteenth Century: Bodies and Gender in English Erotic*, Cambridge University Press, 2004, pp. 119–20. A. Shail & G. How, *Menstruation: a Cultural History*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005. P. Crawford, 'Attitudes to Menstruation in Seventeenth Century England' in *Past and Present*, vol. 91, no. 1 (1981) pp. 47–73.
78. C. Dannel, *Death and Burial in Medieval England 1066–1550*, London: Taylor and Francis, 1998, p. 127.
79. W. Jacob, *Lay People and Religion in the Early Eighteenth Century*, Cambridge University Press, 1996, p. 74. D. Cressy, 'Purification, Thanksgiving and the Churching of Women in Post-Reformation England' in *Past and Present*, No. 141 (Nov., 1993), pp. 106–46. The liturgy of churching was used well into the twentieth century.
80. W. Jacob, *The Clerical Profession in the Long Eighteenth Century, 1680–1840*, Oxford University Press, 2007, p. 196.
81. C. Ancillon, *Eunuchism Displayed* . . ., London: E. Curll, 1718, pp. vi–xxiv.
82. J. Butler, *The true state of the case of John Butler, B.D., a minister of the true Church of England, in answer to the libel of Martha, his sometimes wife: treating of a marriage dissolved and made null by desertion, and of a lawful concubinage in a case of necessity, wherein lawful marriage conveniently, or possibly cannot be obtained*, London: n.p., 1697.
83. He cited King David of Scotland, William the Conqueror's father and John of Gaunt.

84. Butler, *The true state of the case of John Butler*, p. 30.
85. J. Butler, *Explanatory notes upon a mendacious libel called Concubinage and poligamy disproved; written by a nameless author, in answer to a book writ by J.B. as being a scurrilous libel, as not fit to be stiled an answer. As may appear, by a catalogue of notorious and villainous lies, and Billingsgate raileries, and dunghil language, to be shewed therein*. By J.B. B.D., London: n.p., 1698.
86. Anon., *The genuine and uncommon will of a clergyman lately deceas'd; whose son now deservedly possesses one of the highest stations in the church: . . .* London, 1750. There is no evidence that Bishop Butler was his son, since he was not consecrated until 1777, N. Aston, 'Butler, John (1717–1802)', *ODNB*.
87. Quoted in T. E. S. Clarke and H. C. Foxcroft, *A Life of Gilbert Burnet . . . with an Introduction by C.H. Firth*, Cambridge University Press, 1907, p. 348.
88. E. Haven, *Youthful Pleasures Must Be Accounted for At the Day of Judgement, A Sermon on Ecclesiastes xi, 9, Preached at . . . Wrentham, May 27 1741*, Boston: J. Draper, 1741.
89. S. Wigglesworth, *A Sermon Preached to a Society of Young Men at Ipswich . . .*, London: T. Hancock, 1728, p. iii.
90. J. Tottie, *The Pernicious Effects of the Intemperate Indulgence in Sensual Pleasures, A Sermon Preached before the University of Oxford on Sunday March 13 1747/8*, Oxford: Mary Fletcher, n.d., pp. 2–3.
91. D. G. Bloesch 'Evangelicalism' in *Dialog*, vol. 47, no. 1 (Spring 2008), pp. 16–20.
92. D. Greene, 'Latitudinarianism and Sensibility: The Genealogy of the "Man of Feeling" Reconsidered' in *Modern Philology*, vol. 75, no. 2 (1977), pp. 159–83; F. De Bruyn 'Latitudinarianism and Its Importance as a Precursor of Sensibility' in *The Journal of English and Germanic Philology*, vol. 80, no. 3 (1981), pp. 349–68.
93. J. Marshall, *John Locke, Toleration and Early Enlightenment Culture*, Cambridge University Press, 2006.
94. Wigglesworth, *A Sermon Preached to a Society of Young Men*, p. 4 et seq.
95. Tottie, *The Pernicious Effects of the Intemperate Indulgence in Sensual Pleasures*, pp. 3–4.
96. Tottie, *The Pernicious Effects of the Intemperate Indulgence in Sensual Pleasures*, pp. 9, 14, 22. He also warned of the danger of trying to indulge oneself in youth with the aim of future improvement: 'I do not indeed say that there never have been Persons in whom the strong Ferment of Youthful Lusts may have happily subsided, and who may have brought forth Fruits of Amendment and displayed many eminent Vertues. God forbid ! that even the most licentious Vices of Youth should be absolutely incorrigible. But I may venture to affirm that the Instances in this cafe have been so rare, that it is very dangerous for any one to trust to the Experiment upon a presumption that he will add to that number. The only sure way to make any Proficiency in a Vertuous Life is to set out in it betimes. 'Tis then, when our Inclinations are trained up in the way that they should lead us, that Custom soon makes the

- best Habits the most agreeable; the Ways of Wisdom become the Ways of Pleasantry, and every Step we advance they grow more easy and more delightful.' *Ibid.*, p. 25.
97. G. Burnet, *Some Passages of the Life and Death of the Right Honourable Earl of Rochester*, London: R. Chiswell, 1680, pp. 110–1.
 98. Cornwall Record Office, G/1968, Letter Book from Lewis Stephens to Francis Gregor, c. 1710–47, Letter from Lewis Stephens, to, Francis Gregor, 6 July 1745. We owe this reference to Daniel Reed our doctoral student.
 99. F. A. Pottle (ed.), *Boswell on the Grand Tour: Germany and Switzerland 1764*, London & New Haven: Yale University Press, 1953, p. 241.
 100. P. Smethurst, *Travel Writing and the Natural World, 1768–1840*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012, p. 53.
 101. An example is William Prior's sermon *The Reasonableness and Pleasures of the Christian Life, A Sermon Preached in St Thomas's Southwark, January 1 1754, for the Benefit of the Charity School in Gravel Lane Southwark*, London: J. Noon, 1754.
 102. A. Pink, 'Order and Uniformity, Decorum and Taste: Sermons Preached At the Anniversary Meeting of the Three Choirs, 1720–1800' in Gibson and Francis, *Oxford Handbook of the British Sermon 1689–1901*, pp. 215–29.
 103. Huntington Library, San Marino, California, HM 2100, Sterne manuscript sermon 'The Temporal Advantages of Religion'.
 104. Dabhiwala, *The Origins of Sex*, p. 80.
 105. J. Shower, *A Sermon Preach'd to the Societies for the Reformation of Manners in the Cities of London and Westminster, Nov. 15, 1697*, London: J. Lawrence, 1698.
 106. J. Locke, *A Letter Concerning Toleration*, London, n.p., 1698. Interestingly, Locke's library included John Butler's defence of his actions. J. Harrison, P. Laslett, *The Library of John Locke*, Oxford University Press, 1971, p. 98.
 107. *Ibid.*, p. 5.
 108. *Ibid.*, p. 34.
 109. Dabhiwala, *The Origins of Sex*, p. 82.
 110. M. Goldie, 'Introduction' to John Locke, *A Letter concerning Toleration and Other Writings*, Indianapolis: Liberty Fund, 2010.
 111. Locke, *Letter Concerning Toleration*, pp. 7–8.
 112. For a discussion of Locke's views see Dabhiwala, 'Lust and Liberty', pp. 106–8.
 113. A. Bedford, *The evil and danger of stage-plays: shewing their natural tendency to destroy religion and introduce a general corruption of manners*, Bristol: W. Bonny, 1706.
 114. *The Rambler*, no. 23 (5 June, 1750).
 115. M. Goldie, 'Voluntary Anglicans' in *Historical Journal*, vol. 46, no. 4 (December 2003).
 116. W. Gibson, *Enlightenment Prelate: Benjamin Hoadly 1676–1761*, Cambridge: James Clarke & Co, 2004, chapter 3 & 4.

117. J. Hoadly (ed.), *The Works of Benjamin Hoadly DD*, London: Cadell and Davies, 1773, vol. 2, p. 404.
118. B. Hoadly, *Several Discourses concerning the Terms of Acceptance with God*, London: J. Knapton, 1719.
119. *Ibid.*, pp. 136–8.
120. R. Fiddes, *Theologia Practica, or the Second Part of a Body of Divinity* London: W. Bowyer, 1720, vol. 2, p. 84.
121. Gatrell, *City of Laughter*, p. 305.
122. D. Donohue, *Jonathan Swift, A Critical Anthology*, London: Penguin, 1971, p. 390; L. Damroch, *Jonathan Swift, His Life and Work*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, chapter 29: 'the disgusting poems'.
123. P. J. DeGategno, R. J. Stubblefield (eds), *Jonathan Swift: A Literary Reference to His Life and Works*, New York: Facts on File, p. 404.
124. C. Probyn, 'Swift, Jonathan (1667–1745)', ODNB.
125. J. Swift's Introduction to 'The Tale of a Tub, Written for the Universal Improvement of Mankind' in *Volume XX of the Author's Works*, Dublin: George Faulkner, 1769, pp. lxvii–lxviii.
126. 'A Preface to the Right Burnet Bishop of Sarum's Introduction to the third volume of History of the Church of England' 1712, in *The Works of Dr Jonathan Swift, Dean of St Patrick's Dublin*, Edinburgh: A. Donaldson, 1768, vol. IX, p. 35.

Chapter 2 The Church, Sex, and the Public Sphere

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2. D. W. R. Bahlman *The Moral Revolution of 1688*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 1957.
3. J. Redwood, 'Lord Rochester and the Court of Charles II' in *History Today*, vol. XXIV, no 5 (1974).
4. F. W. A *Letter to a Bishop from a Minister of his Diocese*, London: n.p., 1691, pp. 14–15.
5. L. Stone, 'Libertine Sexuality in Post-Restoration England: Group Sex and Flagellation among the Middling Sort in Norwich in 1706–07' in *Journal of the History of Sexuality*, vol. 2, no. 4 (1992), pp. 511–26. Stone doubted that antinomianism was a sufficient explanation for their behaviour.
6. E. Hamilton, *William's Mary: A Biography of Mary II*, New York: Taplinger, 1972, p. 278.
7. A *Proclamation for Preventing and Punishing Immorality and Prophaneness*, 24 February 1698 and again on 9 December 1699, London: C. Bill, 1699.
8. *Royal Proclamation for Preventing and Punishing Immorality and Prophaneness ...* London: C. Bill, 1699.
9. T. Tenison, *His Grace the Lord Archbishop of Canterbury's Letter to the Right Reverend the Lords Bishops of His Province*, London: C. Bill, 1699, p. 1.

10. J. Harris, *The Practice of Religious and Moral Duties, The Best Way to Make a Nation Happy, A Sermon Preached in the Parish Church of St Mary Magdalen* London: n.p., 1701.
11. *His Majesties Letter to the Bishop of London*, London: C. Bill, 1689, dated 13 February, p. 4.
12. It was said that Queen Mary was ‘incessantly employed in possessing her mind with the nest schemes, that are either laid before her by others or suggested by her own thought, for correcting everything which was amiss . . .’, W. Yates, *An Account of the Societies for Reformation of Manners in England and Ireland*, London: J. Downing, 1701, p. 6.
13. Bahlman, *Moral Revolution*, p. 22.
14. A. Lashmore-Davies, “The Casuistical Question”: Oaths and Hypocrisy in the Writings of Johnson and Bolingbroke’ in J. C. D. Clark and H. Erskine-Hill (eds) *The Interpretation of Samuel Clark*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2010, p. 88.
15. L. Stone, *Road to Divorce: A History of the Making and Breaking of Marriage in England*, Oxford University Press, 1990, pp. 313–17.
16. M. McKeon, *The Secret History of Domesticity: Private, Public and the Division of Knowledge*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2009, p. 144.
17. M. Nicolaou, *Divorced, Bebeaded, Sold: Ending an English Marriage, 1500–1847*, Barnsley: Pen and Sword, 2014, p. 119.
18. D. Turner, *Fashioning Adultery: Gender, Sex and Civility in England, 1660–1740*, Cambridge University Press, 2002, pp. 180–1.
19. Stone, *Road to Divorce*, p. 316.
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21. M. Lowman, *A Sermon Preach’d To the Societies For Reformation of Manners at Salters Hall, June 27. 1720*, London: Eman. Matthew, 1720.
22. G. Burnet, *Charitable Reproof. A Sermon Preached at the Church of St Mary Le Bow to the Societies for the reformation of manners, the 25th of March 1700*, London: R. Chiswell, 1700, p. xxx.
23. *The Archbishop of Canterbury’s Late Circular Letter, with the Concurring Letters of all the Bishops of that Province for Persons Frequently Meeting and Uniting in the Work of the Reformation and their Obligation to give Informations to Magistrates of the Breaches of the Laws Against Prophaneness and Immorality*, quoted in E. Fowler, *A Short Dissuasive from the sin of uncleanness*, London: J. Dowling, 1701, p. 2.
24. Hull History Centre, GA.D3549/6/2/3, letters from Archbishop Sharp of York to the Society for Reformation of Manners in Kingston upon Hull. We owe this reference to Daniel Reed.
25. Yates, *An Account of the Societies for the reformation of manners*, p. 51.
26. D. E. Jenkins (ed.) *Religious Societies, Dr Woodward’s Account*, Liverpool: H. Evans, 1935, p. 53.

27. Dan Cruickshank refers erroneously to Collier as a 'theatre critic' in his *The Secret History of Georgian London*, p. xiv.
28. J. Collier, *A Short View of the Immorality and Profaneness of the English Stage, Together with a Sense of Antiquity Upon this Argument*, London: S. Keble, 3rd edition, 1698, pp. 6–7.
29. R. Norton, 'Homosexuality' in Peakman (ed.), *A Cultural History of Sexuality in the Enlightenment*, pp. 60–1.
30. M. Cordner, 'Playwright versus priest: profanity and the wit of Restoration comedy' in D. Payne Fisk (ed.), *The Cambridge Companion to English Restoration Theatre*, Cambridge University Press, 2000.
31. *A Humble Address to the Queen . . . to suppress Playhouses . . . by John Field*, London: T. Sowle, 1703. G. V. Portus, *Caritas Anglicana*, London: Mowbray, 1912, p. 70.
32. T. B. Macaulay, *The Comic Dramatists of the Restoration*, London: Longman, Brown and Green, 1856.
33. St Paul's First Letter to the Thessalonians, chapter 5 v. 11.
34. See E. Chandler, *A Sermon Preached to the Societies for the reformation of manners at St Mary-le-Bow on Monday January the 4th*, 1724, London: J. Knapton, 1724, pp. 9–10.
35. *The Tryals of Peter Messenger . . . and fourteen other apprentices for High Treason*, London: S. Popping, 1688, p. 9.
36. G. Stanhope, *The Duty of Rebuking Sin, A Sermon Preached at Bow Church, December 28th 1702 before the Lord Mayor and Aldermen of London and the Societies for the reformation of manners*, London: T. Leigh, 1703, pp. 1–2, 8.
37. Stanhope, *The Duty of Rebuking Sin*, p. 24. A malepert, or malapert servant was a saucy or impudent one.
38. Chandler, *A Sermon Preached to the Societies for the reformation of manners at St Mary-le-Bow*, p. 6.
39. J. Disney, *An Essay upon the Execution of the Laws against Immorality and Profaneness*, London: J. Downing, 1708.
40. D. Nash and A-M. Kilday, *Cultures of Shame, Exploring Crime and Morality in Britain, 1600–1900*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2010, pp. 7, 18, 44.
41. Quoted in Gatrell, *City of Laughter*, p. 86.
42. J. Disney, *A Second Essay upon the Execution of the Laws Against Immorality and Profaneness*, London: J. Downing, 1710, p. 48.
43. Details of these laws and blank warrants were printed in, among other places, *An Account of the Societies for the reformation of manners in London and Westminster and Other Parts of the Kingdom . . .* London: B. Aylmer, 1699. Portus, *Caritas Anglicana*, includes a copy of the blank warrants in Appendix 3.
44. J. Wilcocks, *The Righteous Magistrate And The Virtuous Informer, A Sermon Preach'd Before the Societies for the reformation of manners in the Parish Church of St Mary-Le-Bow on Monday December 31 1722*, London: J. Downing, 1723, p. 9. Later in the same sermon he said 'as loud as our complaints are of the wickedness of the times . . ., religion is not without its influence in our land;

and that piety and virtue have in every corner of it their disciples and proselytes. The many full and serious congregations, particularly in and about this populous city, that regularly attend upon the service of God, the hearing of his word, and the partaking of his sacraments; and their various and plentiful benevolence to the poor, which is lent unto the Lord, are in all appearance, and should in charity be admitted, as tokens of their being mindful of the one thing needful; that they have their spiritual interests and the care of their immortal souls at heart ...' p. 11.

45. Wilcocks, *The Righteous Magistrate And The Virtuous Informer*, pp. 18–19.
46. Cruickshank, *Secret History*, p. 123.
47. G. J. Barker-Benfield, *The Culture of Sensibility, Sex and Society in Eighteenth Century Britain*, London: University of Chicago Press, 1992.
48. *A Modest Defence of Publick Stews: Or, An essay Upon Whoring, As it is now practis'd in these Kingdoms*, London: A. Moore, 1725.
49. *Ibid.*, pp. ii, x.
50. *Ibid.*, pp. 22, 30. Mandeville claimed the same was true for women: 'all our late discoveries in anatomy can find out no other use for the clitoris but to whet the female desire for its frequent erections, which are doubtless as provoking as those of the penis ...' To counterbalance their appetites, women had a much stronger innate sense of honour 'inculcated into them from infancy' pp. 41–2.
51. *Ibid.*, pp. 53, 69. He rather undermined his own argument by later suggesting that the Biblical injunction against fornication was in the same passage as anathemising the eating of blood, by which black puddings might be banned, p. 70.
52. *A Sixth Black List of Eight Hundred and Forty Three Lewd and Scandalous Persons, who by the Endeavours of a Society for promoting a Reformation of Manners in the City of London and Suburbs thereof, have been legally prosecuted*, London: J. Downing, 1701.
53. *The Six and Twentieth Account of the Progress Made in the Cities of London & Westminster, and Places Adjacent, by the Societies for Promoting a Reformation of Manners: By Furthering the Execution of the Laws Against Prophaneness and Immorality, and Other Christian Methods*, London: J. Downing, 1721.
54. *The Thirtieth Account of the Progress made in the Cities of London and Westminster and Places Adjacent By the Societies for the Promoting a Reformation of Manners*, attached to E. Chandler, *A Sermon Preached to the Societies for the reformation of manners at St Mary-le-Bow on Monday January the 4th, 1724*, London: J. Downing, 1724.
55. This was in a population of England of around 6.3 million.
56. Portus, *Caritas Anglicana*, p. 95.
57. H. Shore, 'Gonson, Sir John (1676/7–1765)' ODNB. *Sir John Gonson's five charges to several grand juries: viz. I. To the grand jury of the city and liberty of Westminster, ... April 24, 1728. II. To the grand jury of the said city and liberty ... July 11, 1728. III. To the grand jury of the royalty of the Tower of London, ... July 16, 1728. IV. To the grand jury of the city and liberty of Westminster; &c ... October 9, 1728.*

- V. *To the grand jury of the said city and liberty, ... July 3, 1729*, London: W. Meadows, 1730. Cruickshank claims that by the 1730s Gonson was a figure of fun and known for his sexual obsessions. Cruickshank, *Secret History*, pp. 14, 75.
58. Analysis of Annual Reports 1715–38 in Portus, *Caritas Anglicana*, p. 254.
 59. R. B. Shoemaker, *Prosecution and Punishment: Petty Crime and the Law in London and Rural Middlesex, 1660–1725*, Cambridge University Press, 1991.
 60. Dabhoiwala, *The Origins of Sex*, p. 72.
 61. Hull History Centre, DCU/3/6, Society for Reformation of Manners in Kingston upon Hull minute book (copy), [c.1697–c.1705] we owe this reference to Daniel Reed.
 62. For attitudes to the societies see J. Spurr, 'The Church, the societies and the moral revolution of 1688' in C. Haydon, J. Walsh and S. Taylor (eds), *The Church of England c. 1689–c. 1833*, Cambridge University Press, 1993 and B. S. Sirota, *The Christian Monitors, The Church of England and the Age of Benevolence, 1680–1730*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 2014.
 63. Nash & Kilday, *Cultures of Shame*, p. 88.
 64. M. J. D. Roberts, *Making English Morals: Voluntary Association And Moral Reform In England, 1787–1886*, Cambridge University Press, 2004; M. J. D. Roberts, 'The Society for the Suppression of Vice and its Earliest Critics, 1802–1812' in *Historical Journal*, vol. 26, no. 1 (March 1983), pp. 159–76.
 65. H. Rimke, A. Hunt, 'From sinners to degenerates: the medicalization of morality in the nineteenth century' in *History of the Human Sciences*, vol. 15 no. 1 (2002) pp. 59–88.
 66. *The Works of the Rev Sydney Smith, including His Contributions to the Edinburgh Review*, London: Longman & Green, 1859, vol. 1, pp. 131–8.
 67. A. Wohlcke, *The 'Perpetual Fair', Gender, Disorder and Urban Amusement in Eighteenth-Century London*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2014, pp. 53, 198.
 68. *A Walk to Smith-fields or A True Description of the Humours of Bartholomew-Fair with the many comical intrigues and frolicks that are acted in every particular booth in the fair*, London: R. Hine, 1701.
 69. Portus, *Caritas Anglicana*, p. 69.
 70. Wohlcke, *The 'Perpetual Fair'*, pp. 59–60.
 71. *Ibid.*, pp. 83–4, 99.
 72. *An Historical Account of Bartholomew Fair: containing a view of its origins, and the purposes it was first instituted for*. London: J. Arliss, 1810.
 73. Gibson, *The Church of England 1688–1832*, pp. 158–9. H. MacSturdy (pseud.) *A Trip to Vaux-Hall or a General Satire on the Times*, London: A. Moore, 1737.
 74. *The Third Charge of Whitlocke Bulstrode, Esq. to the Grand-jury, and Other Juries of the County of Middlesex, at the General Quarter-Session of the Peace Held the Fourth Day of October, 1722, at Westminster-Hall*, London: D. Brown, 1723, pp. 16–17.

75. E. Gibson, *A Sermon Preached before the Societies for the reformation of manners*, 6 January, 1723/4, London: J. Downing, 1724.
76. Sykes, *Gibson*, p. 187; St Andrews University, Gibson Mss, 'Mischief of Masquerades'.
77. St Andrews University, Gibson Ms 5212, 'Mischief of Masquerades'.
78. By the end of the century this class-based view of fornication was challenged, William Dodd published an account of the mother of a girl who had been seduced by a peer, who wrote to him: 'at this rate, the laws of rewards should be inverted, and he who is generous and good should be made a beggar and a slave, that industry and honest diligence may keep his posterity unspotted; and preserve them from ruining virgins, and making whole families unhappy' W. Dodd, *The Beauties of History, or Pictures of Vice and Virtue*, London: Vernor and Hood, 1796, pp. 177–8.
79. St Andrews University, Gibson Ms 5212, 'Mischief of Masquerades'.
80. W. Hogarth, 'Masquerade Ticket', 1727.
81. I. Chrissochoidis, 'George I goes to the Masquerade, 1721' in *The Scribblerian*, vol. XLII (2009) pp. 47–9. Jeremy Black's *The Hanoverians, The History of a Dynasty*, London: Hambledon, 2004, pp. 75–6 explains George I's complex relationships.
82. St Andrews University, Gibson Ms 5214.
83. J. Milhous, 'Heidegger, Johann Jakob (1666–1749)', *ODNB*.
84. *Heydegger's Letter to the Bishop of London*, London: E. Matthews, 1724, pp. 4–6. It may also have been that Gibson disliked the common use of Catholic robes for disguises at masquerades: T. Castle, *Masquerade and Civilization: The Carnivalesque in Eighteenth-century English Culture and Fiction*, Stanford CA: Stanford University Press, 1986, p. 63.
85. St Andrews University, Gibson Ms 5213.
86. Sykes, *Gibson*, pp. 189–92.
87. E. Gibson, *The Bishop of London's Pastoral Letter to the People of His Diocese* London: S. Buckley, 1728, p. 2.
88. Cruickshank erroneously assumes this was a pastoral letter from the rector of the St Paul's Covent Garden — *Secret History*, p. 14.
89. A. Strickland, *The Lives of the Queens of England from the Norman Conquest*, London: Lea and Blanchard, 1854, vol. 7 p. 398.
90. D. Onnekink, *The Anglo-Dutch Favourite: The Career of Hans Willem Bentinck, 1st Earl of Portland (1649–1709)*, Aldershot: Ashgate, 2007.
91. Quoted in P. Hammond 'Titus Oates and Sodomy' in J. Black (ed.) *Culture and Society in Britain, 1660–1800*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1997, p. 97.
92. Quoted in <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/molly2.htm> (accessed 25 October 2013).
93. Huntington Library, San Marino, California, Ellesmere Ms 8770, fol. 13.
94. *Ibid.*, Ellesmere Ms 8770, fol. 18.
95. Bentinck.

96. Huntington Library, San Marino, California, Ellesmere Ms 8770, fol. 24–5.
97. *Ibid.*, Ellesmere Ms 8770, fol. 27–9.
98. *Mundus Foppensis of the Fop Displayed Being the Ladies Vindication* ... London: John Harris, 1691. The poem included the lines that a new fashion was for men to wear jewellery:

There's first the dango and the snake
Those dildoes in the nape of neck
That dangle down below to shew
Dimensions of the snake below

And later:

For who that loves as nature teaches
That had not rather kiss the breeches
Of twenty women than to lick
The bristles of one male dear Dick?

I am grateful to the William Andrews Clark Library at UCLA for access to their copy of this rare item.

99. R. Norton, *Mother Clapp's Molly House, The Gay Subculture in England 1700–1800*, London: Gay Mens Press, 1992, p. 48.
100. G. Burnet, *Bishop Burnet's History of His Own Time*, London: William Smith, 1838, pp. 527–8.
101. Temple Scot (ed.), *The Prose Work of Jonathan Swift DD: vol X Historical Writings*, London: Bohn, 1902, p. 355.
102. T. Claydon, 'William III' in *ODNB*. T. Claydon, *William III and the Godly Revolution*, Cambridge University Press, 1996.
103. M McClain, 'Love, Friendship, and Power: Queen Mary II's Letters to Frances Apsley', *Journal of British Studies*, vol. 47, no. 3 (July 2008), pp. 505–27.
104. British Library, Loan 57/69, 140v–41, Mary to Apsley, 9 August [1678].
105. M. McClain, 'Love, Friendship, and Power: Queen Mary II's Letters to Frances Apsley' in *The Journal of British Studies*, vol. 47 (2008), p. 526.
106. Huntington Library, San Marino, California, Ellesmere Ms 8770, fol. 130.
107. K. Sharpe, *Rebranding Rule, The Restoration and Revolution Monarchy, 1660–1714*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013, pp. 467, 478–9, 491.
108. The widely-used poetic name for Queen Mary II from Tullia Ciceronis.
109. Huntington Library, San Marino, California, Ellesmere Ms 8770, fol. 78–9.
110. For Mary as an idealised form of Britannia and nursing mother of the Church see Emma Major, *Madam Britannia: Women, Church and Nation, 1712–1812*, Oxford University Press, 2012, pp. 25–7, and M. Zook *Protestantism, Politics and Women in Britain, 1660–1714*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2013, pp. 125–60.
111. M. Zook 'The Shocking Death of Mary II: Political and Gender Crisis in Late Stuart England' in *The British Scholar*, vol. 1 (2008), pp. 21–36.

112. Ibid., pp. 26, 29.
113. A. Somerset, *Queen Anne: The Politics of Passion*, London: Harper Press, 2012, pp. 361–4. It may be that the bishops' silence was due to the absence of a biblical injunction against female same-sex activity.
114. *The Rival Dutchess or Court Incendiary In A Dialogue Between Madam Maintenon and Madam M.* London: n. p., 1708, p. 8.
115. J. Wesley, *Concise History of England*, London: R. Hawes, 1775, vol. 3, pp. 315–6. See also J. Black, 'John Wesley and History' in *Wesley and Methodist Studies*, vol. 9. no. 1 (2017).
116. W. Busch, 'The King falls into the Hands of Caricature: Hanoverians in England' in A. Kremers & A. Reich (eds) *Loyal Subversion? Caricatures from the Personal Union of England and Hanover (1714–1837)*, Gottingen: Vandenhoeck and Ruprecht, 2014.
117. Wesley's desire to vindicate the Hanoverian succession led him to conclude that King John married Isabella of Angouleme while she was still married to the Count de la Marche, and therefore the marriage was bigamous and invalid. Wesley asked: 'does it not undeniably follow that Isabella never was his lawful wife? Consequently that his children by her were bastards? What right then could they or any of their posterity, the Stuarts in particular, have to the crown of England? Certainly none by birth: even supposing John to have a right to the throne. But he had none. Maud had a prior right, from whom King George is lineally descended.' Wesley, *Concise History*, vol. 1, 189.
118. As Tim Hitchcock reminds us, the 1745 rebellion came later, but the sense of the permanence of the Hanoverian regime was tangible by the 1730s.
119. [J. Trapp], *The Royal Sin or, Adultery Rebuk'd in a Great King*, London, n. p. 1738, passim.
120. *A Kiss, No Excuse for a Great Man's Living in Adultery: Being a Sermon Preached at St. Martin's on Prov. Vii. 13–16–22*, London: W. Webb, 1741, pp. 5–6. This was very much a Tory view of the King. We are grateful to Jeremy Black for this.
121. The King's twenty-five-year relationship with Lady Yarmouth attracted considerable criticism – N. Rudd, *The Latin Poems: The Latin Poems*, Lewisburg, PA: Bucknell University Press, 2005, p. 39.
122. *A Kiss, No Excuse for a Great Man's Living in Adultery*, passim.
123. E. Cobden, *A Persuasive to Chastity, A Sermon Preach'd before the King at St James's on 11 December 1748*, London: J. Warwick, 1748, pp. 4, 7, 13, 15–16. The printed version indicates that two paragraphs on pp. 13–14 were omitted.
124. Quoted in J. Black, *George III, America's Last King*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 2006, p. 145.
125. Ibid., p. 146.
126. The celebrant was the Revd Robert Burt, one of George's chaplains whose debts the prince paid in exchange for conducting the marriage. Burt was vicar of Twickenham in Middlesex.
127. J. Ashworth-Hill, *Royal Marriage Secrets, Consorts & Concubines; Bigamists and Bastards*, Stroud: History Press, 2013, p. 173.

128. G. Stubbs, 'His Highness in Fitz' published by Fores, 1786.
129. Stone, *The Road to Divorce*, pp. 40–4 and D. Andrew "'Adultery a la Mode': Privilege, the Law and Attitudes to Adultery, 1770–1809' in *History*, vol. 82 (1997), pp. 5–23.
130. L. L. Runge, 'Mary Robinson's Memoirs and the Anti-Adultery Campaign of the Late Eighteenth Century' in *Modern Philology*, vol. 101, no. 4 (2004), pp. 567–8.
131. British Library, Add. Mss, 34,453, f. 230.
132. A. Clark, 'Queen Caroline and the Sexual Politics of Popular Culture in London' in *Representations*, vol. 31 (1990); D. Wahman, "'Middle Class" Domesticity Goes Public: Gender, Class and Politics from Queen Caroline to Queen Victoria' in *Journal of British Studies*, vol. 32 (1993); T. L. Hunt, 'Morality and Monarchy in the Queen Caroline Affair' in *Albion*, vol. 23 (1991).
133. E. Carpenter, *Cantuar, The Archbishops in their Office*, London: Mowbray, 1988, pp. 274–6.

Chapter 3 Illicit Sex and the Church Courts

1. They also organised probate of the deceased, and heard disputes over tithes, and otherwise dealt with Church administration. A. Tarver, *Church Court Records: An Introduction for Family and Local Historians*, Chichester: Phillimore & Co Ltd, 1995, p. xiii.
2. For the procedure of courts see R. B. Outhwaite, *The Rise and Fall of the English Ecclesiastical Courts, 1500–1860*, Cambridge University Press, 2006, chapter 1. For an example of such procedure at York see P. Hoskin, S. Sandall and E. Watson, 'The Court Records of the Diocese of York 1300–1858: An Under-Used Resource,' *Yorkshire Archaeological Journal*, vol. 83 (2011), pp. 148–63.
3. P. Hair (ed.), *Before the Bawdy Court: Selections from church court and other records relating to the correction of moral offences in England, Scotland and New England, 1300–1800*, London: Elek Books, 1972, pp. 78–9, 256–7.
4. D. A. Spaeth, *The Church in an Age of Danger: Parsons and Parishioners, 1660–1740*, Cambridge University Press, 2000, p. 61; B. Till, *The Church Courts 1660–1720: The Revival of Procedure*, Borthwick Institute of Historical Research (2006).
5. W. A. Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts of the Archdeaconry of Leicester in the eighteenth and early nineteenth century', *Transactions Leicestershire Archaeological and Historical Society*, vol. LV11 (1981), p. 39.
6. P. Hoskin, S. Sandall and E. Watson, 'The Court Records of the Diocese of York 1300–1858: An Under-Used Resource,' *Yorkshire Archaeological Journal*, vol. 83 (2011), p. 160.
7. The bishops' and archbishops' courts also held appeal functions for their respective lower courts. Only bishops' courts could hear matrimonial cases. For structure and the other types of courts including peculiars and dean and

- chapter courts see Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, chapter 1; Tarver, *Church Court Records*, passim.
8. For litigation patterns generally see C. W. Brooks, 'Litigation, participation and agency in seventeenth- and eighteenth-century England' in D. Lemmings (ed.) *The British and their Laws in the Eighteenth Century*, Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2005.
 9. Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, pp. 236–7; Snape, *Church of England in Industrialising Society*, p. 120.
 10. Canon 109, cited in Probert, *Changing Legal Regulation*, p. 25.
 11. For the full range of office business see Tarver, *Church Court Records*, pp. 32–3.
 12. *Ibid.*, p. 36.
 13. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, p. 11.
 14. E. Griffin, 'Sex, illegitimacy and social change in industrializing Britain.' *Social History*, vol. 38, no. 2 (May 2013), pp. 141–2.
 15. Borthwick Institute of Historical Research [hereafter BIHR] Trans.CP 1730/5. CPI.1047 1731 — 8/4/1731.
 16. BIHR CPH 4586, Articles Exhibits.
 17. BIHR CPH 4586, Agnes Hunter deposition.
 18. Cited by Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, p. 58.
 19. A. Cash, 'The Birth of Tristram Shandy: Sterne and Dr Burton', in P-G Bouce (ed.), *Sexuality in Eighteenth-Century Britain*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1982, p. 207.
 20. Tarver, *Church Court Records*, p. 41.
 21. DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1755/1, Office promoted by Peter Bowlby c. James Robertson 1755–63, Article 6.
 22. DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1755/1, Office promoted by Peter Bowlby v James Robertson 1755–63, William Redhead's deposition 10 April 1755.
 23. BIHR, Ex.CPI 141.
 24. BIHR, CPI 830, libel, article 4.
 25. *Ibid.*, William's defensive allegation. Deponents on his behalf supported this account of him.
 26. Cited in Tarver, *Church Court Records*, pp. 44–5. See also Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts', p. 40.
 27. Oxfordshire Record Office, Dioc. Papers, 98, fols. 24, 26.
 28. Probert, *Changing Legal Regulation*, p. 29.
 29. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, chapter 5.
 30. For an overview of early modern insulting terms see Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, pp. 42–3.
 31. Oxfordshire Record Office, Dioc. Papers, Wilkins versus Elizabeth Jack, MS. c-92, fol 83–4.
 32. For men's concerns about their wives' sexual reputation, see E. Foyster, *Manhood in Early Modern England: Honour, Sex and Marriage*, New York: Longman, 1999.

33. S. M. Waddams, *Sexual Slander in Nineteenth-Century England: Defamation in the Ecclesiastical Courts, 1815–1855*, Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2000, p. 18.
34. *Ibid.*, p. 22.
35. Tarver, *Church Court Records*, p. 114.
36. C. Muldrew, *The Economy of Obligation: The Culture of Credit and Social Relations in Early Modern England*, London: MacMillan, 1998.
37. A. Shepard and J. Spicksley, 'Worth, age, and social status in early modern England', *Economic History Review*, vol. 64, no. 2 (2011), pp. 493–530.
38. Tarver, *Church Court Records*, p. 114.
39. *Ibid.*, pp. 114–15, 124.
40. Waddam, *Sexual Slander*, p. xii.
41. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, pp. 117–8.
42. cited in Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts', p. 39.
43. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, p. 84.
44. Probert, *Changing Legal Regulation*, p. 32; Outhwaite, *Ibid.*, p. 84.
45. Mary Kinnear, 'The Correction Court in the Diocese of Carlisle, 1704–1756', *Church History*, Vol. 59, no. 2 (Jun., 1990), p. 196.
46. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, pp. 114–15.
47. cited in Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts', p. 39.
48. *Ibid.*, p. 40.
49. Oxfordshire Record Office, Oxf. Dioc. papers c.98, ff. 113, 153.
50. BIHR, Chanc.CP 1803/2.
51. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, p. 91.
52. *Ibid.*, p. 91.
53. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, p. 110.
54. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, p. 98.
55. Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts', p. 41.
56. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, p. 102.
57. A.T. Hart, *The Eighteenth Century Country Parson*, Shrewbury: Wilding & Co, 1955; W. M. Jacob, *Lay People and Religion in the early Eighteenth Century*, Cambridge University Press, 1996; W. M. Jacob, *The Clerical Profession in the Long Eighteenth Century, 1680–1840*, Oxford University Press, 2007.
58. J. Wickham Legg, *English Church Life from the Restoration to the Tractarian Movement*, London: Longman, Green & Co, 1914, chapter eight is devoted to this issue.
59. A. P. Jenkins (ed.), *The Correspondence of Bishop Secker*, Oxford Record Society, vol. 57, 1991.
60. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, pp. 120–1, 129.
61. Cited in Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, p. 116.
62. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, pp. 85–6.
63. *Ibid.*, p. 100.
64. Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, p. 23.

65. Outhwaite, *Rise and Fall*, pp. 84, 12–16.
66. Ibid., pp. 83, 95, 98–9.
67. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, p. 126.
68. Probert, *Changing Legal Regulation*, p. 107.
69. e.g. Oxfordshire Record Office, Dioc. papers c.92. Libel, Fortnam c. Fortnam, 1775.
70. For an overview of the scholarship see Probert, *Changing Legal Regulation*, p. 28.
71. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, p. 14, and chapter 1.
72. Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, pp. 167–8.
73. Ibid., p. 27.
74. Oxfordshire Record Office, Dioc. papers c.92. Libel, Fortnam c. Fortnam, 1775.
75. Ibid., Dioc. papers c.97. Libel, Fortnam c. Fortnam, 1775. Deposition of John Carter, Boddington, Northampton, 30 Oct 1775.
76. Ibid., Dioc. papers c.97. Libel, Fortnam c. Fortnam, 1775. Deposition of Mary Scaresbrook, Kirtlington, Spinster.
77. Ibid., Dioc. papers c.92. Libel, Fortnam c. Fortnam, 1775, Article 8.
78. DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1716/1 1716, mere office case, defendant: John Greiveson of Sedgfield, County Durham correction for adultery and fornication; DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1716/2 1716, mere office case, defendant: Anne Reed of Sedgfield, County Durham, correction for adultery and fornication.
79. D. Lemmings, *Law and Government in England during the Long Eighteenth Century: From Consent to Command*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2011, pp. 70–1.
80. Tarver, *Church Court Records*, p. 3.
81. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society*, pp. 111.
82. Joanne Begiato (Bailey), *Unquiet Lives: Marriage and Marriage Breakdown in England, 1660–1800*, Cambridge University Press, 2003, chapter 3.
83. M. J. D. Roberts, *Making English Morals: Voluntary Association And Moral Reform In England, 1787–1886*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004, p. 43.
84. For example see the following cases discussed in more detail in chapter four, cross ref..
85. BIHR, Trans.CP 1707/1 The appealed case went against William and he appealed to the Court of Delegates.
86. Tarver, *Church Court Records*, p. 9.
87. Cited in Tarver, *Church Court Records*, p. 42.
88. Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts', p. 40.
89. Tarver, *Church Court Records*, pp. 27–8.
90. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, p. 34.
91. A. Stott, *Hannah More: The First Victorian*, Oxford University Press, 2004, p. 105.
92. Ibid., p. 130.

93. Ibid., p. 131.
94. Lemmings, *Law and Government*, p. 11.
95. Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, p. 27.
96. Lemmings, *Law and Government*, p. 74.
97. Ibid, pp. 12–13, 74, 77.
98. Hair, *Bawdy Courts*, p. 23.
99. M. Snape, *The Church of England in Industrialising Society: the Lancashire parish of Whalley in the eighteenth century*, Woodbridge: Boydell and Brewer, 2003, pp. 97–8.
100. R. Probert, *The Changing Legal Regulation of Cohabitation: From Fornicators to Family, 1600–2010*, Cambridge University Press, 2012, p. 51.

Chapter 4 The Church, Marriage, and Marital Sex

1. Bailey, *Unquiet Lives*; Foyster, *Marital Violence*; Ingram, *Church Courts*; Stone, *Road to divorce*; Probert, *Marriage Law and Practice*.
2. R. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, ninth edition, London: Sweet, Stephens and Norton, 1842, p. 484. The first edition of Burn was published in 1760.
3. R. B. Outhwaite, *Clandestine Marriage in England, 1500–1850*, Hambleton Press, London, 1995; David Turner, 'Popular Marriage and the Law: Tales of Bigamy at the Eighteenth-Century Old Bailey' 30/1, *The London Journal: A Review of Metropolitan Society Past and Present*, 2005, 6–21.
4. *The book of common prayer and administration of the sacraments, and other rites and ceremonies of the church, according to the use of the Church of England: together with the Psalter, or Psalms of David, pointed as they are to be sung or said in churches*, Cambridge: J. Burges, 1796. For further discussion, see Turner, *Fashioning Adultery: Gender, Sex and Civility in England, 1660–1740*, pp. 54–5. For marriage practices in general see John Gillis, *For Better, for Worse: British Marriages, 1600 to the Present*, Oxford University Press, 1985.
5. K. Barclay, *Love, Intimacy, and Power: Marriage and Patriarchy in Scotland, 1650–1850*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2011; R. Houston, *Bride Ales and Penny Weddings. Recreations, Reciprocity, and Regions in Britain from the Sixteenth to the Nineteenth Centuries*, Oxford University Press, 2014.
6. BIHR. CPI 54, John Cunliffe contra Dorothy Cunliffe, 1701.
7. Probert, *Marriage, Law and Practice*, pp. 22–3.
8. Ibid., p. 21 and *passim*.
9. Burn, *The Ecclesiastical Law*, 1767 edition, p. 399 and 1797 edition, quoted in Probert, *Marriage, Law and Practice*, p. 27.
10. Probert, Ibid., pp. 56–7.
11. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, 1842 edition, vol. 2, p. 455. For confirmation of this based on a wide variety of legal treatises and precedent see Probert, *Marriage, Law and Practice*, p. 48.
12. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, 1842 edition, vol. 2, pp. 433–4.

13. Cited in Probert, *Marriage, Law and Practice*, p. 225.
14. The Act was stricter and more structured in its requirements of parental consent according to Probert, *Marriage, Law and Practice*, pp. 226–7.
15. E. Griffin, 'A Conundrum Resolved? Rethinking Courtship, Marriage and Population Growth in Eighteenth-Century England', *Past and Present* vol. 215 (2012), pp. 1163–4; idem, 'Sex, illegitimacy and social change in industrializing Britain', *Social History*, vol. 38, no. 2 (2013), p. 161.
16. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, vol 2, 1767 edition, p. 386; and 1842 edition, vol. 2, p. 440.
17. Morris, 'Incest or Survival Strategy', p. 235.
18. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, vol. 2, 1767, p. 392, 1842 edition, pp. 446–7.
19. Ibid., vol. 2, 1767, 392, 1842 edition, pp. 446–7.
20. 5 & 6 Will. 4., c 54.
21. P. Morris, 'Incest or Survival Strategy? Plebeian Marriage within the Prohibited Degrees in Somerset, 1730–1835', *Journal of the History of Sexuality*, vol. 2, no. 2, Special Issue, Part 1: The State, Society, and the Regulation of Sexuality in Modern Europe (Oct., 1991), pp. 235–65.
22. BIHR. D/C CP 1720/2 Office versus John Taylor and Alice Taylor.
23. Morris, 'Incest or Survival Strategy', pp. 246, 252.
24. Fourteen of these occurred before 1688.
25. BIHR. Cons.CP 1801/4 Hannah Cutler con James Cutler, nullity by reason of affinity.
26. One person married his half-brother's daughter, another his father-in-law's sister, one was unknown, and one was incest with a blood relative.
27. For close marriage, defined as a union between named kin, see L. Davidoff, *Thicker than Water: Siblings and Their Relations 1780–1920*, Oxford University Press, 2011, chapter 9.
28. Ibid., pp. 230–5, 238.
29. Morris, 'Incest or survival strategy', passim.
30. BIHR. CPH 4329 Office con. William Smith and Susanna Barraclough als. Smith, 1694.
31. BIHR. D/C.CP 1694/5 Office con Herbert Lister and Susannah Herbert als. Lister.
32. BIHR. office c. Jonathan Railey and Susannah Railey (name is also spelled Raley on the records).
33. BIHR. D/C CP 1720/2 Office c. John Taylor and Alice Taylor als. Horsley.
34. Morris noted this too, 'Incest or Survival Strategy', p. 256, and it supports Probert's picture of mass conformity in marriage practice.
35. BIHR. D/C CP 1720/2 Office c. John Taylor and Alice Taylor als. Horsley.
36. DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1741/1 1741, mere office case, defendant: Margaret Davison of Hartlepool, County Durham, correction for incest; DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1741/2 1741, mere office case, defendant: Ralph Davison of Hartlepool, County Durham, correction for incest.

37. DDR/EJ/PRC/2/1733/1 1733, mere office case, defendant: George Carr of Dalton-le-Dale, County Durham correction for incest.
38. BIHR. Cons.CP 1801/4 Hannah Cutler Contra James Cutler, nullity by reason of affinity.
39. Morris, 'Incest or survival strategy', pp. 248, 262.
40. Ibid., pp. 244–4, 265.
41. R. O'Day, *The Family and Family Relationships, 1500–1900: England, France, and the United States of America*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 1994, pp. 40–4. Also see K. Davis, 'Continuity and Change in Literary Advice on Marriage', in R. B. Outhwaite (ed.), *Marriage and society. Studies in the social history of marriage*, London: Europa, 1981.
42. O'Day, Ibid., p. 36.
43. A. Fletcher, *Gender, Sex and Subordination in England, 1500–1800*, New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 1995, p. 114.
44. H. Berry and E. Foyster, 'Childless men in early modern England' in H. Berry and E. Foyster (eds), *The Family in Early Modern England*, Cambridge University Press, 2007, pp. 164–5.
45. I. H. Tague, 'Love, Honor, and Obedience: Fashionable Women and the Discourse of Marriage in the Early Eighteenth Century', *Journal of British Studies*, vol. 40, no. 1 (Jan., 2001), pp. 81–9.
46. W. Wilkes, *Letter of Genteel and Moral Advice to a Young Lady*, London: C. Hitch, 1746, cited in V. Jones, *Women in the Eighteenth Century: Constructions of Femininity*, London and New York: Routledge, 1992, p. 34.
47. J. Begiato (Bailey), *Parenting in England, 1760–1830: Emotion, Identity, and Generation*, Oxford University Press, 2012; Berry and Foyster, 'Childless men', p. 172.
48. 'The trial of Francis William Sykes Esq for adultery with the wife of Captain Parslow of the third regiment of Dragoons in the court of King's Bench before Lord Kenyon, 1789'. In *The Cuckold's Chronicle: being select trials for adultery(sic), incest, imbecility, ravishment, &c.* London: n.p., 1798, p. 331.
49. Berry and Foyster, 'Childless men', p. 164.
50. J. Evans, 'It is caused of the womans part or of the mans part': the role of gender in the diagnosis and treatment of sexual dysfunction in early modern England, *Women's History Review*, vol. 20, no. 3 (2011), p. 443.
51. Ibid., p. 441.
52. Berry and Foyster, 'Childless men', pp. 165, 166.
53. Ibid., p. 180.
54. Following the 1835 act, marriages thereafter of this nature were defined as void and did not require a sentence to establish this. Burns, *Ecclesiastical Law*, vol. 2, 1767 edition, p. 429, and 1842 edition, vol. 2, pp. 500a–500d.
55. Cited in Berry and Foyster, 'Childless men', p. 180.
56. Burns, *Ecclesiastical Law*, vol. 2, 1842 p. 501k.
57. For women's role as members of juries of women who inspected defendant's bodies see L. Gowing, *Common Bodies: Women, Touch and Power in Seventeenth-*

- century England*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 2003, p. 71.
58. BIHR. CPI 169 Elizabeth Tireman con. Samuel Tireman; Cons.AB.95.
 59. BIHR. Chanc.CP 1803/1, Adultery, office, promoted by John Brown, chapel warden of Sowerby c. Revd. Edward Greenwood.
 60. Exodus 20:14.
 61. Cited in D. Andrew, *Aristocratic Vice: The Attack of Duelling, Suicide, Adultery & Gambling*, London and New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013, p. 131.
 62. G. Towerson, *A Explication of the Decalogue of the Ten Commandments, with Reference to the Catechism of the Church of England*, London: J. Macock, 1676, cited in Turner, *Fashioning Adultery*, p. 27.
 63. Joanne Begiato (Bailey), *Unquiet Lives*, Turner, *Ibid.*, pp. 147–9.
 64. J. Akamatsu, 'Revisiting Ecclesiastical Adultery Cases in Eighteenth-century England' in *Journal of Women's History*, vol. 28, no. 1 (2016).
 65. BIHR. CPI 54 John Cunliffe contra Dorothy Cunliffe, 1701. Dorothy's allegation.
 66. Turner, *Fashioning Adultery*, pp. 194–5.
 67. BIHR. CPI 54, John Cunliffe contra Dorothy Cunliffe, 1701.
 68. Turner, *Fashioning Adultery*, pp. 25–6.
 69. e.g. BIHR. Trans C.P. 1748/1 Elizabeth Surtees appealing a cause against George Surtees.
 70. BIHR. CPI 1414, William Chaworth contra Alice Chaworth 1760.
 71. [J. Fawcett] *An Humble Attempt to Form a system of Conjugal Morality: Being the Substance of Six Discourses Addressed to Young Persons of Both Sexes, with a Design to Lead them Through the Becoming Duties of Celibacy and Marriage*, Manchester: C. Wheeler, 1787, pp. 62–3, 70.
 72. Wilkes, *A Letter of Genteel and Moral Advice to a Young Lady*, cited in Jones, *Women in the Eighteenth Century*, p. 30.
 73. S. Lloyd, 'Amour in the Shrubbery: reading the detail of English adultery trial publications of the 1780s', *Eighteenth-Century Studies*, vol. 39, no. 4 (2006), pp. 421–42.
 74. E. Foyster, *Marital Violence: An English Family History, 1660–1857*, Cambridge University Press, 2005, pp. 36, 92.
 75. *Ibid.*, p. 36.
 76. BIHR. Trans.CP 1697/2 Robert Shaw transmitted case appealing Anne Shaw contra Robert Shaw. Deposition of Elizabeth Stephenson.
 77. BIHR. CPI 88 Jane Greaves contra John Greaves, 1704.
 78. Durham University Special Collections, Esther Bowes versus Jonathan Bowes, 1718.
 79. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, 1842 edition, p. 503h.
 80. BIHR. Trans.CP 1688/3 Anthony Fletcher transmitted appeal case from Anne Fletcher contra Anthony Fletcher.
 81. Burn, *Ecclesiastical Law*, 1842 edition, p. 503h.

82. BIHR. Chanc.CP 1803/3 James Lees appealing Margaret Lees contra James Lees, 1803. James Lees's Interrogatories. Actually, exhibited letters from Thomas Jones, the late Manchester attorney who had advised Margaret show that he instructed her incorrectly by telling her that she should remain with her violent husband as leaving him would be a bar against her succeeding in her case. He wrote to the court before he died to state his misguided advice to explain why Margaret had remained living with her husband.
83. BIHR. Chanc.CP 1803/3 James Lees appealing Margaret Lees contra James Lees, 1803. Mary Ball, 12 Dec 1804.
84. BIHR. Chanc.CP 1803/3 James Lees appealing Margaret Lees contra James Lees, 1803. Mary Ball, 12 Dec 1804. Chanc.Ab.51.
85. Cited in Stone, *Road to divorce*, p. 204. Stone saw it as Phillimore acting in a conservative position to stem the changes in legal definitions of cruelty.
86. G. Savage, "'The wilful communication of a loathsome disease': marital conflict and venereal disease in Victorian England', *Victorian Studies*, vol. 34, no. 1 (1991), pp. 35–54.
87. BIHR. CPI 54 John Cunliffe contra Dorothy Cunliffe, 1701.
88. BIHR. CP. I. 2305.
89. S. King, 'Love, Religion and Power in the Making of Marriages in Early Nineteenth-Century Rural Industrial Lancashire', *Rural History*, vol. 21, no. 1 (2010), p. 8.
90. *Ibid.*, p. 10.
91. *Ibid.*, p. 10.
92. *Ibid.*, pp. 11–12, 15–16.
93. For arguments over religion see A. Kugler, *Errant Plagiary: The Life and Writing of Lady Sarah Couper 1644–1720*, Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2002, pp. 62–3.
94. *Ibid.*, pp. 59–62.
95. Zachary's position is constructed from his Personal Response and his Interrogatories. In his interrogatories (a list of questions to be addressed to witnesses) he asked whether he was kind to his wife and allowed several clergymen of the Church of England to visit her regularly and told her she could go over to this church if she wished.
96. BIHR. CPI 699 Anne More contra Zachariah More, 1719 List deponents.
97. Zachary's position is constructed from his Personal Response and his Interrogatories. In his interrogatories (a list of questions to be addressed to witnesses) he asked whether he was kind to his wife and allowed several clergymen of the Church of England to visit her regularly and told her she could go over to this church if she wished.
98. Her uncle also stated that he had evidence she'd given sworn evidence before another court claiming the opposite to her accusations here.
99. BIHR. CPI 699 Anne More contra Zachariah More, 1719.
100. T. Wright (ed.), *Autobiography of Thomas Wright of Birkenshaw in the county of York, 1736–1797*, London: J. R. Smith, 1864.

Chapter 5 Evangelicals, Sex, and Respectability

1. B. Hilton, *The Age of Atonement: The Influence of Evangelicalism on Social and Economic Thought, 1795–1865*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1991, chapter 1. To understand the muddy nature of the term evangelical and evangelicalism see D. Bebbington, *Evangelicalism in Modern Britain, A History from the 1730s to the 1980s*, London: Routledge, 1988, and D. Rosman, *Evangelicals and Culture*, Cambridge: James Clarke & Co, 2012.
2. Hilton, *Ibid.*, p. 8.
3. This account of evangelicalism is derived from Hilton, *Age of Atonement*, A. Stott, *Hannah More The First Victorian*, New York: Oxford University Press, 2004; A. K. Mellor, *Hannah More, Revolutionary Reformer* http://www.ampltd.co.uk/digital_guides/women_morality_and_advice_literature_parts_1_to_3/Hannah-More-Revolutionary-Reformer.aspx (accessed 23 April 2016), M. Hilton, *Women and the Shaping of the Nation's Young, Education and Public Doctrine in England, 1750–1850* London: Routledge, 2007, pp. 138–43, L. Davidoff & K. Hall, *Family Fortunes, Men and Women of the English Middle Class, 1780–1850*, London: Routledge, 2002, chapter 1.
4. Davidoff & Hall, *Family Fortunes*, chapters 1–3.
5. M. Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, London: Allen & Unwin, 1930, pp. 158–9.
6. F. W. B. Bullock, *Evangelical Conversion in Great Britain, 1696–1845*, St Leonards: Budd and Gillatt, 1959, pp. 221–2. Bullock denied the role of sex in the conversions of Whitefield, Hutton, Fletcher, Berridge, Scott, Simeon, John Cowper, Chalmers and McCheyne.
7. S. Keimer, *A Brand Pluck'd from the Burning: exemplify'd in the unparallel'd case of Samuel Keimer, Offer'd to the Perusal of the Serious Part of Mankind, and especially to those who were ever acquainted with, or ever heard of the man*, London: W. Boreham 1718, pp. 16, 29, 54, 71; Anon., *The French prophetess turn'd adamite being a true and comical account of a pretended French prophetess, who on Sunday the 16th of November, did in a very immodest and indecent manner (being inspired with a pretended spirit) undress her self stark naked at the popish chapel in Lincoln's-Inn Fields*, London, E. B., 1707, p. 70. The best discussion of this episode is L. Laborie's *Enlightening Enthusiasm in Eighteenth Century England: Camisards, French and English Prophets (1685–1750)* Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2015 and L. Laborie's 'Philadelphia Resurrected: Celebrating the Union Act from Irenicism to Scatological Eschatology' in A. Hessayon (ed.), *Jane Lead and her Transnational Legacy*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015.
8. A. S. Seligman 'Mary Tofts – the Rabbit Breeder' in *Medical History*, vol. 5, no. 4 (1961), pp. 349–60 and J. Shaw 'Mary Toft, Religion and National Memory in Eighteenth Century England' in *Journal for Eighteenth Century Studies*, vol. 32, no. 3 (2009), pp. 321–38.
9. E. P. Thompson, *The Making of the English Working Class*, London: Penguin, 1978, pp. 406–11.

10. P. Mack, *Heart Religion in the British Enlightenment, Gender and Emotion in Early Methodism*, Cambridge University Press, 2011, p. 142.
11. D. Hempton, *Methodism, Empire of the Spirit*, London & New Haven: Yale University Press, 2005, p. 5.
12. Quoted in T. S. Kidd, *George Whitefield: America's Spiritual Founding Father*, London & New Haven: Yale University Press, 2014, p. 143.
13. B. Curtis Clark & J. Cruickshank, 'Converting Mrs Crouch: Women, Wonders and the Formation of English Methodism, 1738–41' in *Journal of Ecclesiastical History*, vol. 65, no. 1 (2013) pp. 66–83.
14. Mack, *Heart Religion*, p. 128.
15. This up-dated version of Samuel Butler's 'The Tub Preacher' was published in *Genuine and Secret Memoirs, Relating to the Life and Adventures of that Anti-Methodist, Mr. G. W—fi-d*, Oxford: n.p., 1743, pp. 83–5.
16. This was not a form of language monopolised by evangelicals, Dominic Janes has pointed out that Thomas Grey's 'Elegy in a Country Churchyard' includes language that sees Grey's homosexual desire sublimated into a wish to find in heaven the sort of emotional satisfaction that he could not find on earth. D. Janes, *Picturing the Closet: Male Secrecy and Homosexual Visibility in Britain*, Oxford University Press, 2015 p. 61.
17. So much so that the Moravians were disturbed by the scenes, see B. Curtis Clark & J. Cruickshank, 'Converting Mrs Crouch' p. 74.
18. B. McNelly, *Textual Warfare and the Making of Methodism*, Oxford University Press, 2014, pp. 152–3. See also D. A. Johnson, *Women in English Religion 1700–1925*, New York: Edwin Mellen Press, 1983, p. 32.
19. McNelly, *Textual Warfare*, p. 156.
20. *The Amorous Humours and Audacious Adventures of One Wh—d.*, London: M. Watson, 1739, p. 7.
21. M. G. Anderson, *Imagining Methodism in Eighteenth Century Britain: Enthusiasm, Belief and the Borders of the Self*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2012, p. 84.
22. *Ibid.*, p. 18. For Wilkes see S. West, 'Wilkes' squint: synechdochic physiognomy and political identity in eighteenth-century print culture', *Eighteenth-Century Studies*, vol. 33 (1999), pp. 65–84.
23. University of Bangor, Seward Ms journal, 14 August 1739.
24. Anderson, *Imagining Methodism*, pp. 10, 18, 52. See also McNelly, *Textual Warfare*, chapter 5.
25. F. Baker, 'Methodism and the '45 Rebellion' in *The London Quarterly and Holborn Review* (October 1947), p. 328.
26. J. Wesley, *The Desideratum: Or, Electricity Made Plain and Useful by a Lover of Mankind and of Common Sense*, London: Bailliere, Tindall and Cox, 1760, p. vi.
27. Wesley, *The Desideratum*. H. N. Maloney, 'John Wesley and Eighteenth Century Therapeutic Uses of Electricity' in *Perspectives on Science and Christian Faith*, vol. 45 (December 1995). Paola Bertucci, 'Revealing Sparks: John

Wesley and the Religious Utility of Electrical Healing', *The British Journal for the History of Science*, vol. 30, no. 3, (September 2006), pp. 341–62.

28. A. Strong, *The Electric Eel, or Gymnotus Electricus*, London: J. Bew, 1777. The poem included the lines:

Is is not since the favourite dish
And ev'ry matron's standing dish
That dare to see or feel?
Is there a dame who loves the joke
But what hath felt th' electrick stroke
Of this electric eel?
... What makes our first felicity
But this pure electricity
Divested of all fiction:
Motion makes heat, and heat makes love
Creatures below and things above
Are all produc'd by friction. – *The Electric Eel*, pp. 7–8.

29. D. Faber, 'Hysteria in the Eighteenth Century' in H. Whitaker, C. U. M. Smith & S. Finger (eds), *Brain, Mind and Medicine: Essays in Eighteenth Century Neuroscience*, New York: Springer, 2004; L. Syson, *Doctor of Love: James Graham and his Celestial Bed*, London: Alma Books, 2008.
30. <http://www.scienceandsociety.co.uk/results.asp?image=10418741> (accessed 14 June 2014).
31. Wesley, *The Desideratum*, pp. 53, 61–2.
32. *Perfection, A Poetical Satire*, London: J. Bew, 1776, p. 16.
33. Mack, *Heart Religion*, pp. 42, 43, 53.
34. R. Maddox and T. Underhill, 'Untwisting the Tangled Web: Charles Wesley and Elizabeth Story' in *Wesley and Methodist Studies*, vol. 8, no. 2 (2016).
35. McNelly, *Textual Warfare*, p. 166.
36. F. Baker 'The People Called Methodists' in R. Davies and G. Rupp (eds), *A History of the Methodist Church in Great Britain*, London: Epworth Press, 1965, vol. 1, p. 219.
37. H. Ablove, *The Evangelist of Desire, John Wesley and the Methodists*, Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1990, p. 67.
38. *An Attempt to Shew the Folly and Danger of Methodism*, London: n.p., 1809, pp. 54–64, 89–97. This was a weekly publication which was published as a single volume in 1809.
39. D. B. Hindmarsh, *The Evangelical Conversion Narrative, Spiritual Autobiography in Early Modern England*, Oxford University Press, 2007, p. 302.
40. Walpole to Horace Mann, 3 May 1749, in *The Letters of Horace Walpole, Earl of Orford*, London: Richard Bentley, 1840, vol. 2, p. 272. It was in the same letter to Horace Mann that Walpole wrote that Whitefield had not recanted but only canted and that Methodism was a 'religious nonsense'.
41. *Perfection, A Poetical Satire*, pp. 20–1.

42. 'Spa Fields Chapel Minutes: 1778–81', *Two Calvinistic Methodist Chapels 1743–1811: The London tabernacle and Spa Fields chapel* (1975), pp. 46–63. URL: <http://www.british-history.ac.uk/report.aspx?compid=38772> (accessed 18 February 2014).
43. *Sketches for Tabernacle-Frames. A Poem*, London: J. Bew, 1778, p. 132. John Harmon claimed by astrology to have proven that Whitefield was not motivated by his conversion but by an unfortunate conjunction of the planets at the time of his birth, J. Harmon, *Remarks Upon the Life, Character and Behaviour of the Rev. George Whitefield* . . . London: for the author, 1764.
44. Its full title was *Genuine and Secret Memoirs, Relating to the Life and Adventures of that Anti-Methodist, Mr. G. W–fi–d, Likewise Critical and Explanatory Remarks Upon that Inimitable Piece, Intitled God's Dealings with G. Whitefield: Wherein is likewise prov'd (by his own Words) That he has had pretty large Dealings also with Satan. The Whole Interspersed with Observations Instructive and Humorous. Collected and Published by a Gentleman of Oxford* . . . Oxford: for the author, 1742. The author claimed in particular to have spoken to Whitefield's bedmaker.
45. *Genuine and Secret Memoirs*, pp. 16–17, 21–2.
46. *Ibid.*, pp. 38–40. In describing Whitefield's sin as masturbation, the author described it as onanism 'what this was my male readers will readily comprehend; nor will my female ones, I imagine, be at any loss about it; especially such as of them as have been blessed with a boarding-school education.' p. 40.
47. *Ibid.*, pp. 41, 47–8.
48. *Ibid.*, pp. 54–5. On this basis the author suggested that the University of Oxford extend the width of beds to five foot for gentlemen commoners and four feet and a half for servitors.
49. One recent writer has even taken seriously the possibility of Whitefield's demonic possession. Kidd, *George Whitefield: America's Spiritual Founding Father*, p. 30.
50. Westley Hall also embraced polygamy. V. H. H. Green, 'Westley Hall (1711–1776)', *ODNB*.
51. Abelow, *The Evangelist of Desire*, p. 35. In *Perfection, A Poetical Satire* it was claimed that the Wesleys went on circuits because in each place where there was a meeting house there was 'always a slut or two' – *Perfection*, p. 22 fn.
52. R. Heitzenrater, 'Purge the Preachers: the Wesleys and Quality Control' in K. Newport and T. Campbell (eds) *Charles Wesley: Life, Literature and Legacy*, Peterborough: Epworth Press, 2007.
53. Kidd, *George Whitefield*, p. 214; Eryn M. White, 'Griffith, Sidney (c.1720–52)', *ODNB*; Derec Llwyd Morgan, 'Harris, Howel (1714–73)', *ODNB*.
54. T. Smollett, *The Expedition of Humphrey Clinker*, London: J. F. Dove, 1825, p. 297.
55. *A Letter to the Reverend Mr George Whitefield, Occasioned by His Remarks upon a Pamphlet Entitled The Enthusiasm of Methodists and Papists Compared*, London: M. Cooper, 1750, p. 16.
56. Anderson, *Imagining Methodism*, pp. 100–1, 107.

57. Abelow, *The Evangelist of Desire*, p. 36.
58. W. Benbow, *The Crimes of the Clergy, Or the Pillars of Priestcraft Shaken*, London: Benbow, 1823, pp. 35–7.
59. *Ibid.*, pp. 46–7.
60. *Ibid.*, pp. 123–6, 153–6.
61. *Ibid.*, p. 217.
62. Mack, *Heart Religion*, p. 63.
63. K. G. C. Newport, 'Early Methodism and the French Prophets: Some New Evidence' in *Proceedings of the Wesley Historical Society*, vol. 50 (Feb 1996), pp. 127–40.
64. I am grateful to Dr Lionel Laborie for sharing his research on Mary Lavington, based on his research at the John Rylands University Library, Manchester.
65. *The Progress of Methodism in Bristol; or, The Methodist Unmask'd*, Bristol: J. Watts, 1743, p. 20.
66. *The Mock-Preacher: a Satyrico-comical-allegorical Farce. As it was acted to a crowded audience at Kennington-common*, London: C. Corlett, 1739, p. 15.
67. *Ibid.* pp. 15–16. We are grateful to Simon Lewis for sight of his article, 'The Mock-Preacher (1739): More than just an anti-Methodist play?' published in the *Proceedings of the Wesley Historical Society* (2014).
68. Anderson, *Imagining Methodism*, p. 62.
69. *A Letter to the Right Reverend the Archbishops and Bishops of the Church of England, upon Mr. Whitefield's Extraordinary Manner of Preaching the Gospel, his Criminal Presumption, and Enthusiastick Doctrine*, London: J. Brett, 1739. p. 17.
70. D. Hempton, *Religion of the People: Methodism and Popular Religion, 1750–1900*, London: Routledge, 1996, pp. 155–6. BIHR, GB 193, DC.CP.1755/2.
71. *The Love-Feast. A Poem*, London: J. Bew, 1778, p. 28.
72. *Fog's Weekly Journal*, 9 December 1732. We owe this reference to Dr Peter Forsaith.
73. The date may well be very significant. Dr John Morgan-Guy has pointed out to us that following Wesley's Fetter Lane 'conversion' on 24 May of that year, he had spent June–August in Germany, and on returning in September had set about preaching and visiting societies 'in a highly charismatic atmosphere', which included visions, demonic possessions and spiritual healings. Presumably the reference in the letter is to one of these September visitations. The 'charismatic' context may be important; a heightened state of physical and psychological excitement.
74. Warburton to Birch 16 September 1738 in J. Nichols, *Illustrations of the Literary History of the Eighteenth Century, Consisting of Eminent Persons*, London: Nichols and Bentley, 1817, vol. 2, pp. 94–5. Dr Morgan-Guy also observed that heavy and deliberate blood-loss of this kind would have induced the light-headedness and lassitude of the *petit mort* after orgasm, which is at least alluded to in a number of eighteenth-century prints. This could be what Wesley called 'cooling'.
75. Hickes and Collier were leading Non-jurors who had split from the Church of England over the issue of the legitimacy of the succession of William and

- Mary. This was a view that Susanna Wesley shared and was the cause of a dispute between John Wesley's parents. Randy Maddox pointed out to us that John Wesley was in Germany from June to September 1738 so the reference might refer to an earlier period or to Charles Wesley.
76. G. Hammond, *John Wesley in America Restoring Primitive Christianity*, Oxford University Press, 2014.
 77. J. Peakman, 'Introduction' in Peakman (ed.), *A Cultural History of Sexuality in the Enlightenment*, p. 14.
 78. L. Moulin, *La Vie quotidienne des religieux au Moyen Âge: Xe–XVe siècle*, Paris: Hachette, 1978.
 79. 'Math. Rothos.', *A Whip for the Quacks* . . . London: Jos. Marshall, 1727, pp. 19, 29, 33.
 80. Laqueur, *Solitary Sex*, pp. 93–5.
 81. R. L. Maddox, 'John Wesley and Eastern Orthodoxy: Influences, Convergences and Differences' in *Asbury Theological Journal*, vol. 45, no. 2 (1990).
 82. J. Wesley, *Primitive Physic, or an Easy and Natural Method of Curing Most Diseases*, Edinburgh: Thornton, 1846, pp. 21, 42.
 83. K. Keele, *William Harvey*, London and Edinburgh: Nelson, 1965, p. 81. See also J. Cule, 'The Revd J. Wesley, MA (Oxon), 1703–91 "The Naked Empiricist" and Orthodox Medicine' in *Journal of the History of Medicine and Allied Sciences*, vol. 45 (1990), pp. 41–63.
 84. We owe this idea to Dr John Walsh.
 85. Green, *The Young Mr Wesley*, passim.
 86. Quoted in H. Newton Malony, Jr., *The Amazing John Wesley: An Unusual Look at an Uncommon Life*, Downers Grove, IL: Intervarsity Press, 2010, p. 121.
 87. Kidd, *George Whitefield: America's Spiritual Founding Father*, p. 44.
 88. L. Tyerman, *The Life and Times of John Wesley*, London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1870, vol. 1, p. 148.
 89. Kidd, *George Whitefield: America's Spiritual Founding Father*, p. 44.
 90. Tyerman, *The Life and Times of John Wesley*, vol. 1, pp. 145–69 remains the most detailed treatment of the affair.
 91. R. P. Heitzenrater, *The Elusive Mr Wesley, volume Two: John Wesley as Seen by his Contemporaries and Biographers*, Nashville TN: Abingdon Press, 1984, pp. 55–8.
 92. H. Rack, 'John Wesley (1703–1791)', *ODNB*; R. W. Wright, G. Diamond, & P. Budd, 'An Experienced Presence: An Intersubjective Perspective on John Wesley's Early Theology' in *The Journal of Psychology & Christianity*, vol. 23, no. 2 (Summer 2004) pp. 155–64.
 93. Hammond, *John Wesley in America*, pp. 137–9.
 94. T. Underhill, 'John Byrom and the Contexts of Wesley's Shorthand' in *Wesley and Methodist Studies*, vol. 7 (2015), pp. 38–9.
 95. This account of Grace Murray and Wesley is from J. A. Leger, *John Wesley's Last Love*, London: J. Dent, 1910, pp. 70–90, and Abelow, *The Evangelist of Desire*,

- pp. 19–23. Leger's work uses Wesley's own unpublished memoir of the events of 1748 and his own justification of his actions. See also H. Rack, *Rational Enthusiast: John Wesley and the Rise of Methodism*, London: Epworth Press, 1989.
96. A. M. Lyles, *Methodist Mocked*, London: Epworth Press, 1960, p. 114.
 97. Abelow, *The Evangelist of Desire*, p. 37.
 98. [W. Coombe], *Perfection. A Poetical Epistle. Calmly Addressed to the Greatest Hypocrite in England*, London: J. Bew, 1778, pp. 15–16.
 99. V. Tolar Burton, *Spiritual Literacy In John Wesley's Methodism: Reading, Writing and Speaking to Believe*, Waco, TX: Baylor University Press, 2008, pp. 191–3.
 100. J. Banks, *Nancy, Nancy*, Leeds: Penworth, 1984, pp. 45, 85.
 101. For details see J. Innes, *Inferior Politics: Social Problems and Social Policies in Eighteenth-Century Britain*, Oxford University Press, 2009, chapter five 'Politics and Morals', pp. 181–4.
 102. A. Hunt, *Governing Morals, A Social History of Moral Regulation*, Cambridge University Press, 1999, p. 58.
 103. Its provincial early versions are outlined in Roberts, *Making English Morals* and Innes, *Inferior Politics*, chapter five 'Politics and Morals', pp. 188–9.
 104. Innes, *Inferior Politics*, pp. 180–1.
 105. F. C. Mather, *High Church Prophet, Bishop Samuel Horsley (1733–1806) and the Caroline Tradition in the Later Georgian Church*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1992, pp. 64–88.
 106. Hunt, *Governing Morals*, p. 24.
 107. *Ibid.*, pp. 59, 61.
 108. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, pp. 40, 46.
 109. Though even the evangelicals' anti-slavery campaigns were satirised in the popular prints, with Gillray's *Philanthropic Consolations after the Loss of the Slave Bill*, London: H. Humphrey, 1796, showing Wilberforce and Bishop Samuel Horsley cavorting lustfully with two bare breasted black women after their failure to pass an anti-slavery law.
 110. Stott, *Hannah More*, pp. 191–2. E. M. House, *Saints in Politics, The Clapham Sect and the Growth of Freedom*, London: Allen Unwin, 1960. W. Gibson, *Church State and Society, 1760–1850*, London: Macmillan, 1994.
 111. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, p. 17. Hunt, *Governing Morals*, p. 66.
 112. For its provincial antecedents and the way reform movements like this bring together those divided by denomination, politics and geography see Roberts, *Making English Morals*, pp. 17–19, chapter 1. For an account of its membership and activities see Innes, 'Politics and Morals', pp. 190–215.
 113. Innes, *Inferior Politics*, p. 200.
 114. Hunt, *Governing Morals*, pp. 69–70. The Society for the Suppression of Vice was especially supported by evangelicals who enthusiastically prosecuted such things as obscene pictures and naked sea bathing.

115. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, p. 74, fn 53. See also Innes, *Inferior Politics*, p. 202.
116. Stott, *Hannah More*, p. 97.
117. H. More, *Thoughts on the Importance of the Manners of the Great*, London: T. Cadell, 1809.
118. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, p. 59.
119. cited in Hunt, *Governing Morals*, 62; Innes, *Inferior Politics*, p. 186.
120. Gatrell, *City of Laughter*, p. 419.
121. More, *Thoughts*, p. 78.
122. *Ibid.*, pp. xv, 8–9, 17–18, 66–7.
123. *Ibid.*, p. 50.
124. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, p. 52.
125. Hunt proposes that issues around sex, sexuality, masturbation, prostitution, and homosexuality were key concerns in the later nineteenth century because they were related to expanding knowledge about population and a period of military rivalry and thus acute worries about the health, fitness and productivity of the working population. Hunt, *Governing Morals*, pp. 24–5. Yet this is clearly evident in the period from 1790 to 1810.
126. Hilton, *Age of Atonement*, pp. 74, 78.
127. Hilton, *Women and the Shaping of the Nation's Young*, p. 136.
128. Thomas Chalmers, *The Christian and Civic Economy of Large Towns*, New York: Scribners, 1900, p. 85. For further information on Chalmers see Hilton, *Women and the Shaping of the Nation's Young*, pp. 172–3.
129. Hilton, *Age of Atonement*, p. 81.
130. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, p. 3.
131. Hunt, *Governing Morals*, p. 6.
132. For the complex meanings assigned to both family and domesticity see W. Van Reyk, 'Christian ideals of manliness in the Eighteenth and Nineteenth Century', *The Historical Journal*, vol. 52, no 4 (2009) pp. 1068–9.
133. W. Cowper, *The task: a poem, in six books. By William Cowper, ... To which are added, by the same author, An epistle to Joseph Hill, Esq. ... To which are added, ... an epistle. ... and the history of John Gilpin*. London: J. Johnson 1785, p. 93.
134. City of York Archive, GRF/4/1 / Acc 5, Correspondence of William Gray Senior, 21 March, 1776, William Gray junior at York to his father William Gray at Hull.
135. Davidoff & Hall, *Family Fortunes*, p. 89.
136. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, pp. 62–3.
137. *Ibid.*, p. 89.
138. Cited by Ford K. Brown, *Fathers of the Victorians: The Age of Wilberforce*, Cambridge University Press, 1961, pp. 133–4.
139. More, *Thoughts*, p. 50.
140. *Ibid.*, pp. 85–6.
141. T. Gisborne, *Enquiry into the Duties of the Female Sex*, London: T. Cadell Jnr, 1797, p. 331.

142. For an overview of criticisms of the historiography of public and private see Van Reyk, 'Christian ideals of manliness', pp. 1071–2.
143. Roberts, *Making English Morals*, pp. 121–3.
144. For a close study of the family and its involvement in political life see K. Gleadle, *Borderline Citizens: Women, Gender, and Political Culture in Britain 1815–1867*, Oxford University Press, 2009, chapter 7.
145. Gregory, 'Homo Religiosus'; Van Reyk, 'Christian ideals of manliness in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries', pp. 1053–73.
146. Van Reyk, 'Christian ideals of manliness', pp. 1062–5.
147. For overlapping of these aspects see Van Reyk, 'Christian ideals of manliness', pp. 1057–9.
148. For the argument of a very distinctive form of serious Christian manliness see Davidoff & Hall, *Family Fortunes*, pp. 108–13. However, it should be noted that some of the components that they see as specifically evangelical were in fact shaped by broader cultural fashions such as sensibility and domesticity.
149. Though Van Reyk rightly observes that men's sexual licentiousness was condemned earlier in the century, 'Christian ideals of manliness', p. 1057.
150. For the latter point see Hunt, *Governing Morals*, chapter 6.
151. Gisborne, *Enquiry*, p. 4.
152. *Ibid.*, pp. 248–9.
153. *Ibid.*, pp. 12–13, 56.
154. *Ibid.*, p. 343.
155. Mellor, *Hannah More*.
156. Stott, *Hannah More*, p. 216.
157. Cited in Hilton, *Women and the Shaping of the Nation's Young*, p. 140.
158. B. W. Young, 'The Anglican Origins of Newman's Celibacy', *Church History*, vol. 65, no. 1 (March 1996) p. 23.

Chapter 6 Celibacy, 'Conjugal Chastity', and 'Moral Restraint'

1. J. Hecht, "From 'Be Fruitful and Multiply' to Family Planning: The Enlightenment Transition," *Eighteenth-Century Studies*, vol. 32, no. 4 (1999), p. 545.
2. R. Filmer, *Patriarcha: Or the Natural power of kings By The learned Sir Robert Filmer, Bart.*, London: Richard Chiswell, 1680, chapter 1, "That the first kings were fathers of families."
3. 1 Corinthians 7: 8–9. From the King James Bible Online, http://www.kingjamesbibleonline.org/1-Corinthians-7-8_7-9/ accessed 16/3/2015. It is translated as 'For it is better to marry than to be aflame with passion' in E. R. Seeman, "'It is Better to Marry Than to Burn': Anglo-American Attitudes toward Celibacy, 1600–1800," in *Journal of Family History*, vol. 24, no. 4 (October 1999), p. 398.

4. H. Parish, 'It was never good world sence minister must have wyves': clerical celibacy, clerical marriage, and anticlericalism in Reformation England', in *Journal of Religious History*, vol. 36, no. 1 (2012), pp. 55–6. Seeman, 'It is Better to Marry Than to Burn', p. 399. This was perhaps more ambiguous since The Council of Trent had ruled that the character of the priest, that is his sins, did not impair the sacraments he conveyed.
5. Seeman, 'It is Better to Marry Than to Burn', p. 399.
6. *A Few Plain Reasons why a Protestant of the Church of England should not turn Roman Catholic* 1688 cited in S. Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins, Celibacy and Gender in Later Stuart England' in S. Apetrei and H. Smith (eds) *Religion and Women in Britain, 1660–1760*, Farnham: Ashgate, 2014, p. 48. Also see H. Wharton, *A treatise of the celibacy of the clergy wherein its rise and progress are historically considered*, London: H. Clark, 1688, p. 20, who states that tranquillity of mind was needed to contemplate the creator and that it was disrupted by ungoverned passion. Only marriage was likely to satisfy that propensity.
7. Cited in Seeman, 'It is Better to Marry Than to Burn', p. 400.
8. J. Dove, *Miscellaneous Dissertations on Marriage, Celibacy, Covetousness, Virtue*, London: J. Millar, 1769.
9. The Google NGram shows some peaks at times when anti-popery was high – though this needs more consideration.
10. H. Parish, 'Clerical Celibacy, Clerical Marriage', pp. 52, 54, 57.
11. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, preface, and passim.
12. Parish, 'Clerical Celibacy, Clerical Marriage', p. 59.
13. S. Apetrei, 'The Life of Angels': Celibacy and Asceticism in Anglicanism 1660–c. 1700' in *Reformation and Renaissance Review*, vol. 13 (2011), p. 258.
14. *Ibid.*, p. 262.
15. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, p. 25.
16. G. Tully, *An Answer to a Discourse Concerning Celibacy*, Oxford: R. Chiswell, 1688, p. 88.
17. *A Vindication of the Consecration of Archbishop Cranmer, against the Objections of Papists and others . . .*, To which is Added, An Appendix, containing the Thoughts of Dr Prideaux, concerning the Celibacy of the Clergy, London: R. Wilkin & G. Strahan 1721, p. 79.
18. C. Fleming, *The Oeconomy of the Sexes. Or the Doctrine of Divorce, The Plurality of Wives, and the Vow of Celibacy Freely Examined*, London: J. Noon, 1751, pp. 55–6, 58, 65.
19. Anon., *Essay on Celibacy*, London: M. Cooper, 1753, pp. 19, 81.
20. *Ibid.*, p. 85.
21. *Ibid.*, pp. 112, 113.
22. Dove, *Miscellaneous Dissertations*.
23. *Ibid.*, pp. 13, 30.
24. A. Paxton, 'Charles Kingsley's Saintry Trials and Husbandly Duties', *Journal of Victorian Culture*, Vol. 18, no. 2, 2013 pp. 213–5.

25. T. Jones, *Sexual Politics in the Church of England 1857–1957*, Oxford University Press, 2013, pp. 48–53.
26. J. Hawkins, *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*, 2nd edition, Worcester: M. Lewis, 1790, p. 4.
27. Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins', p. 51.
28. Jones, *Sexual Politics in the Church of England 1857–1957* makes this point, 'Stained Glass Closet', p. 134.
29. Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins', p. 48.
30. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, p. 4.
31. Wesley – The term eunuch was not to be taken absolutely literally. An American Methodist preacher sought to live a holy life and in order to do so had himself castrated in 1791. Church leaders saw this as far too extreme and Minter left the Methodist Church. C. Lyerly, 'A Tale of Two Patriarchs; Or, How a Eunuch and a Wife Created a Family in the Church', in *Journal of Family History*, vol. 28, no. 4 (2003), pp. 490–509.
32. *Essay on Celibacy*, pp. 5, 8, 9, 12.
33. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, pp. 6–7.
34. Tully, *An Answer to a Discourse Concerning Celibacy*, pp. 19–20.
35. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, pp. 6, 13, 15, 16, 17.
36. Hawkins, *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*, p. 12.
37. Tully, *An Answer to a Discourse Concerning Celibacy*, p. 22.
38. *Ibid.*, pp. 14–15.
39. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, p. 20.
40. Edward Hawarden is identified as the author of *Four Appendixes to the Book Entitled The True Church of Christ*, by C. C. Strangeman in 'Strange Allies? English Catholicism and the Enlightenment', Unpublished PhD thesis, Southern Illinois University, Carbondale, 2007, pp. 87–90.
41. Four Appendixes to the Book Entitled The True Church of Christ, p. 422.
42. *Essay on Celibacy*, pp. viii, ix.
43. *Ibid.*, pp. iii.
44. *Ibid.*, pp. iii–iv.
45. *Ibid.*, p. v.
46. E. Barry, *Theological, Philosophical, and Moral Essays*, London: J. Conor, 1800, p. 31.
47. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, p. 167.
48. Apetrei, 'Celibacy and Asceticism', p. 270.
49. B. W. Young, 'The Anglican Origins of Newman's Celibacy', in *Church History*, vol. 65, no. 1 (March 1996), pp. 16, 18. Gilbert Burnet attacked celibacy in his *Exposition of the Articles*, 1699, but still retained Article 32.
50. Young, 'The Anglican Origins of Newman's Celibacy', p. 18.
51. *Ibid.*, p. 19.
52. Isabel Rivers, 'Law, William (1686–1761)', *ODNB*.
53. Apetrei, 'Celibacy and Asceticism', p. 265.

54. W. Secker, *A Wedding Ring Fit for the Finger; or the Salve of Divinity on the Sore of Humanity, Laid Open in A Sermon at A Wedding in St Edmonds*, London: T. Parkhurst, 1705 and T. Humphreys, *Marriage an honourable estate: A sermon preached at Driffeld in Gloucestershire, on occasion of the happy marriage of Gabriel Hanger, Esq; and Mrs. Elizabeth Bond*, London: James Crockatt, 1742, cited in Seeman, 'It is Better to Marry Than to Burn', pp. 401, 406.
55. In Seeman, *Ibid.*, p. 402.
56. Apetrei, 'Celibacy and Asceticism', p. 260. For ambiguity among English ministers in the seventeenth century also see Seeman, 'It is Better to Marry Than to Burn', p. 400.
57. There was also a 'quasi-monastic revival' in the late seventeenth century which incorporated demands for the sexual purification of church and nation. Apetrei, 'Celibacy and Asceticism', pp. 248–50, 252–3, 263.
58. *Ibid.*, p. 250.
59. A. M. Lawrence, *One Family Under God, Love, Belonging and Authority in Early Transatlantic Methodism*, Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2011, p. 134.
60. Isabel Rivers, 'Law, William (1686–1761)', *ODNB*.
61. Cited in Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 142.
62. Young, 'The Anglican Origins of Newman's Celibacy', p. 22.
63. J. Wesley, *Thoughts on a Single Life*, London: J. Paramore at The Foundery, 1765, p. 5.
64. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 135.
65. This could lead to the men losing power in the Annual Conferences in America, marking a lowering of their status in the eyes of their religious fraternity. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 152.
66. *Ibid.*, pp. 136–7.
67. *A Vindication of the Consecration of Archbishop Cranmer, against the Objections of Papists and others . . . , To which is Added, An Appendix, containing the Thoughts of Dr Prideaux, concerning the Celibacy of the Clergy*, London: R. Wilkin & G. Strahan, 1721, p. 80.
68. *A defence of the Reverend W.B. Kirwan's conformity to the established church: Also of his letter from Dublin to a friend in the country. In answer to James Patson, a Galway resident. With a confutation of a defence of religious celibacy and concomitant vows; fully proving the state of celibacy a state of sin. By a Member of the Church of England*, Dublin: R. M. Butler, 1789, pp. 33, 34. Also see Barry, *Theological, Philosophical, and Moral Essays*, p. 16.
69. Both cited in H. Rack, "'But, Lord, Let it be Betsy": Love and Marriage in Early Methodism', *Proceedings of the Wesley Historical Association* vol. 53 (2001) pp. 9, 12.
70. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 137.
71. J. Wesley, *Thoughts on Marriage and a Single Life*, Bristol: Felix Farley, 1743, p. 9.
72. *Ibid.*, pp. 7–10. This was a book that was for sale through Farley's contacts in Newcastle on Tyne, London, Bath and Exeter and in Philadelphia.

73. Wesley, *Thoughts on a Single Life*, p. 4. As ever with Wesley, his long life meant he amended his views over time and his writings of the single life, first published in 1743, were revised and republished up to 1785. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 137.
74. Ibid., p. 165.
75. Abelow, *Evangelist of Desire*, p. 56.
76. Ibid., p. 58.
77. From the Pawson Letters, I, cited in Rack, “But, Lord, Let it be Betsy”, p. 7.
78. Seeman, ‘It is Better to Marry Than to Burn’, p. 406
79. Cited in Peter Forsaith, ‘The Correspondence of the Rev. John W. Fletcher: letters to the Revd. Charles Wesley, considered in the context of the Evangelical Revival’, Unpublished PhD, Oxford Brookes University, 2003, pp. 278–9.
80. E. Cook (ed.), *Letters of John Fletcher*, Stoke on Trent: H. Christian, 1999, pp. 37–8.
81. Mack, *Heart Religion*, p. 90.
82. In later times this might have overtones of sexual grooming in his focus and attention on individual young women, with whom he built a strong emotional connection, which we would now see as gaining their trust for the purposes of sexual abuse or exploitation. It is possible that it was more a case of Wesley building upon a patriarchal relationship of male superiority and female inferiority to construct connections that he might have feared in less socially-skewed relationships with women.
83. B. W. Coe, *John Wesley and Marriage*, Bethlehem PA: Lehigh University Press, 1996. Mack, *Heart Religion*, pp. 137–42.
84. *A Review of All the Doctrines Taught by the Rev. Mr John Wesley*, London: E. & C. Dilly, 1772, p. 49.
85. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, pp. 141–3.
86. H. Rack, “But, Lord, Let it be Betsy”, p. 5.
87. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 135.
88. Tully, *An Answer to a Discourse Concerning Celibacy*, p. 9. Tully goes on to argue that there is no perfection in the state of celibacy and that it is constructed by the Catholic Church to facilitate penance and add to the Church’s treasures, p. 13.
89. Ibid., pp. 1–3.
90. Wharton, *A Treatise of the Celibacy of the Clergy*, pp. 2, 4. *Essay on Celibacy*, p. 19 also argues that celibacy is servile.
91. Hawkins, *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*, p. 20.
92. Young, ‘The Anglican Origins of Newman’s Celibacy’, p. 15.
93. Abelow, *Evangelist of Desire*, p. 61.
94. Wesley, *Thoughts on a Single Life*, pp. 8–10.
95. *Original Letters Between the Reverend John Wesley and Mr Richard Tompson, Respecting the Doctrine of Assurance as Held by the Former: Wherein that Tenet is Fully Examined. With Some Strictures on Christian Perfection*, London: Davis and Reymers, 1760, p. 16.

96. Mack, *Heart Religion*, pp. 2–3, 94–5.
97. Wesley, *Thoughts on a Single Life*, p. 8.
98. D. G. Donat, 'The Rev. John Wesley's Extractions from Dr Tissot: A Methodist Imprimatur' in *History of Science*, vol. 39 (2001), pp. 285–98.
99. Laqueur, *Solitary Sex*, p. 40.
100. J. Wesley, *Thoughts on the Sin of Onan: Chiefly Extracted from a Late Writer*, London: n.p., 1767, p. 4.
101. Lyerly, 'A Tale of Two Patriarchs', p. 493.
102. Wesley, *Thoughts on the Sin of Onan*, pp. 15–18.
103. Hawkins, *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*, p. 188.
104. Young, 'The Anglican Origins of Newman's Celibacy', pp. 26–7.
105. Dove, *Miscellaneous Dissertations*, pp. 45–50.
106. Apetrei, 'Celibacy and Asceticism', p. 268.
107. Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins', pp. 47, 58.
108. Paraphrasing Richard Allestree's *The Ladies Calling*, 1673, cited in Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins', p. 52.
109. Apetrei, 'Celibacy and Asceticism', p. 265.
110. Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins', pp. 50–1.
111. *Ibid.*, pp. 42, 58.
112. Cited in Young, 'Anglican Origins of Newman's Celibacy' p. 18.
113. Cited in E. Major, 'The Life and Works of Catherine Talbot (1721–70): "A Public Concern"', in Apetrei and Smith (eds) *Religion and Women in Britain*, p. 166.
114. Interestingly Sarah had read Astell's *Reflections Upon Marriage* and used it to describe her ill-behaved husband. A. Kugler, *Errant Plagiary*, p. 53.
115. *Ibid.*, introduction, p. 20.
116. *Ibid.*, chapter 3 and p. 60.
117. *Ibid.*, p. 60.
118. *Ibid.*, pp. 60–2.
119. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 134.
120. E. K. Brown, *Women of Mr Wesley's Methodism*, New York and Toronto: Edwin Mellen Press, 1983. The author of *Perfection* claimed that some women who pledged themselves to chastity found their pregnancies difficult to explain:

Ev'd holy Sisters, in a Call of Love
 Without Man's Aid, have quicken'd from Above ...
 -*Perfection*, p. 17. And in some cases John Wesley was clearly claimed as the father:
 The Nymph reveal'd, when full nine Months were gone
 A perfect Bantling that resembled John. -*Perfection*, p. 19.
121. Mack, *Heart Religion*, p. 149.
122. Hindmarsh, *The Evangelical Conversion Narrative*, pp. 181–2.
123. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 151.
124. *Ibid.*, p. 133.

125. Ibid., p. 147. For similar motivation see discussion of Hester Ann Roe in Rack, “But, Lord, Let it be Betsy”, p. 8.
126. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, p. 135.
127. Jones, *Sexual Politics in the Church of England*, p. 68.
128. Ibid., p. 57.
129. Seeman, “It is Better to Marry Than to Burn”, p. 398.
130. R. Perry, ‘The Veil of Chastity: Martyr Astell’s Feminism’ in Bouce (ed.) *Sexuality in Eighteenth-Century Britain*, pp. 142, 151–3.
131. W. Kolbrener, ‘Slander, Conversation and the Making of the Christian Public Sphere’ in Mary Astell’s *A Serious Proposal to the Ladies* and *The Christian Religion as Profess’d by a Daughter of the Church of England* in Apetrei and Smith (eds), *Religion and Women in Britain*, pp. 133–4; Ruth Perry, ‘Astell, Mary (1666–1731)’, *ODNB*.
132. Kolbrener, ‘Slander, Conversation and the Making of the Christian Public Sphere’, p. 138.
133. R. Perry, Astell, Mary (1666–1731).
134. Major, ‘The Life and Works of Catherine Talbot (1721–70)’, p. 174 and R. Zuk, ‘Talbot, Catherine (1721–1770)’, *ODNB*.
135. Lawrence, *One Family Under God*, pp. 148, 150.
136. cited in Rack, “But, Lord, Let it be Betsy”, p. 7.
137. Barry, *Theological, Philosophical, and Moral Essays*, p. 13.
138. Ibid., p. 13.
139. Apetrei, ‘Masculine Virgins’, pp. 43–5.
140. *Essay on Celibacy*, p. 78.
141. Ibid., pp. xiii, 22, 43.
142. Hawkins, *Essay on the Law of Celibacy*, p. 191.
143. *A Letter on the Celibacy of Fellows of Colleges: Addressed to the Senate by a Member of the University of Cambridge*, London: J. Johnson, 1794, p. 3.
144. *Essay on Celibacy*, p. 81.
145. Cited in Seeman, “It is Better to Marry Than to Burn”, pp. 407–8, he suggests it was more likely to be seen as a sin in New England.
146. Turner, *Fashioning Adultery*, passim.
147. *Essay on Celibacy*, pp. xi–xiii.
148. Dove, *Miscellaneous Dissertations*, pp. 116, 117.
149. *A Letter on the Celibacy of Fellows of Colleges*, pp. 9, 12.
150. Ibid., pp. 25.
151. This was the case in France too, Hecht, ‘From “Be Fruitful and Multiply” to Family Planning’, pp. 536–51.
152. Tully, *An Answer to a Discourse Concerning Celibacy*, p. 16.
153. Hecht, ‘From “Be Fruitful and Multiply” to Family Planning’, p. 545.
154. Perceptions did not necessarily match demographic reality. Nor did it match practice. Thus in England and France, when celibacy was criticised for limiting procreation, couples tended to marry at a later age and in fewer numbers. At the turn of the century, certainly in England, though temporary

- celibacy was advocated to prevent population outstripping resources, more couples were marrying at younger ages. Hecht, 'From "Be Fruitful and Multiply" to Family Planning', pp. 536, 537.
155. Seeman, "It is Better to Marry Than to Burn", p. 406.
 156. Apetrei, 'Masculine Virgins', p. 44.
 157. *Essay on Celibacy*, p. vi.
 158. *Ibid.*, p. 7.
 159. *Ibid.*, pp. 61–72.
 160. *A Reply to an Interesting Answer to the Rev. Walter Blake Kirwan's Letter . . . Also a Confutation of a Defence of Religious Celibacy and Concomitant Vows, fully proving the State of Celibacy a State of Sin, By a Friend to Procreation*, Dublin: R. Butler, 1789, p. 30.
 161. This is formulated most clearly in the second edition of his essay. T. Malthus, *An Essay on the Principle of Population or, A View of its Past and Present Effects on Human Happiness*, London: J. Johnson, 1803, p. 483.
 162. *Ibid.*, pp. 484–91, 496.
 163. *Ibid.*, p 501.
 164. Barry, *Theological, Philosophical, and Moral Essays*, pp. 13–14.
 165. Hecht, 'From "Be Fruitful and Multiply" to Family Planning', pp. 546, 547, 548.
 166. D. Nash, 'Reconnecting Religion with Social and Cultural History: Secularisation's Failure as a Master Narrative', *Cultural and Social History*, vol. 1, no. 3 (2004).

Chapter 7 The Church, Sodomy, and Same-Sex Desires

1. K. Phillips and B. Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality: A Premodern History*, London: Polity Press, 2011, p. 61.
2. Examples of the ways in which the term sodomy was widely applied can be found in A. N. Shaw, 'The *Compendium Compertorum* and the Making of the Suppression Act of 1536', University of Warwick PhD thesis, 2003. We are grateful to Diarmaid MacCulloch for this reference.
3. For some of this discussion see chapter five of T. Hitchcock, *English Sexualities, 1700–1800*, Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1997.
4. For an accomplished overview of the historiography and current consensus see H. Cocks, 'Homosexuality Between Men in Britain Since the Eighteenth Century' *History Compass*, vol. 5, no. 3 (2007).
5. R. Norton, 'Homosexuality' in J. Peakman (ed.), *A Cultural History of Sexuality in the Enlightenment*, London: Bloomsbury, 2014, p. 65.
6. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, pp. 79–82.
7. R. Norton (ed.), 'The Trial of William Brown, 1726', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 22 April 2000, updated 20 June 2008 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/brown.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).

8. Dabhoiwala, *Origins of Sex*, pp. 128–38.
9. Cocks, 'Homosexuality Between Men' passim.
10. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, pp. 13, 61.
11. Cocks, 'Homosexuality Between Men', p. 871.
12. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, pp. 83–7.
13. Cocks, 'Homosexuality Between Men' pp. 871–6.
14. Dabhoiwala, *Origins of Sex*, pp. 128–38.
15. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, pp. 65–6.
16. *An Account of the Tryal, Examination and Conviction of Several Notorious Persons called Sodomites at Guildhall*, broadside, 1707.
17. Cornwall Record Office, G/1968, Letter Book from Lewis Stephen to Francis Gregor, c. 1710–47, Letter from Lewis Stephens, to, Francis Gregor, 6 July 1745. We owe this letter to our doctoral student, Daniel Reed.
18. R. Norton, *Mother Clapp's Molly House, The Gay Subculture in England 1700–1800*, London: Gay Mens Press, 1992, pp. 54–69. R. Smalbroke, *Reformation Necessary to Prevent Our Ruine: A Sermon Preached before the Societies for the Reformation of Manners, at St Mary Le Bow, January 10th 1727*, London: J. Downing, 1728, p. 30.
19. W. Harris, *The Case of Sodom and Gomorrah... In Two Discourses, The One Preached at Crouched Fryers on the Publick Fast Appointed by Authority, Jan. 9, 1739–40. The Other on a Day of Prayer for a Blessing on Publick Affairs, Octob. 4, 1739*, London: John Wilson, 1740, pp. 3–4.
20. *Ibid.*, pp. 8, 29.
21. R. Norton (ed.), "Lord, Remember Me!", *Homosexuality in Nineteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, enlarged 7 Dec. 2014 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1812myer.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
22. J. Church, *The Foundling, or The Child of Providence*, London: n.p., 1823; *The Infamous Life of John Church, the St Georges Fields Preacher*, London: n.p., 1817; M. Clement, 'John Church (b1780)' in *ODNB*.
23. Old Bailey Online, www.oldbaileyonline.org reference t17211206-20 (accessed 25 May 2015).
24. R. Norton (ed.), "Unhappy Gift from God, 1749", *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 6 January 2011 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1749fawc.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
25. J. Horler, *Memoirs of Mr. Thomas Chubb, Late of Salisbury*, London: J. Fletcher, 1747, pp. 42.
26. T. L. Bushell, *The Sage of Salisbury, Thomas Chubb*, London: Vision Press, 1968.
27. In fact his mother's petition against his sentence pointed out his distinguished ecclesiastical forebears.
28. Dabhoiwala, *Origins of Sex*, p. 130.
29. H. Gladfielder (ed) 'The Indictment of John Purser, Containing Thomas Cannon's *Ancient and Modern Pederasty Investigated and Exemplify'd* in *Eighteenth Century Life*, vol. 31, no. 1 (2007), p. 40. Cannon's work is widely cited by historians as if a copy survived. In fact our knowledge of the contents of the

- book is only possible because sections of it were quoted in the indictment of John Purser, the publisher.
30. Ibid., pp. 40–1, 44, 54.
 31. H. Gladfelder, 'In Search of Lost Texts: Thomas Cannon's *Ancient and Modern Pederasty Investigated and Exemplify'd*' in *Eighteenth Century Life*, vol. 31, no. 1 (2007).
 32. Charles Upchurch, 'Queers, Homosexuals, and Activists in Early Nineteenth-Century Britain?', *Notches (re)marks on the History of Sexuality*, <http://notchesblog.com/2015/07/28/queers-homosexuals-and-activists-in-early-nineteenth-century-britain/> (accessed 3 August 2015).
 33. G. Willett, 'The Church of England and the Origins of Homosexual Law Reform', *Journal of Religious History*, vol. 33, no. 4 (2009), pp. 419–20.
 34. Genesis 19, Leviticus 18:22, Leviticus 20:13, Romans 1:26–1:27, I Corinthians 6:9–6:10. There is a voluminous literature about the translation of Paul's words on sodomy and the debate on the meaning of St Paul's words is extensive beginning with James Boswell's *Christianity, Social Tolerance and Homosexuality, Gay People in Western Europe from the Beginning of the Christian Era to the Fourteenth Century*, Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1980, most recently this position has been examined in M. P. Wilson, 'Should We Translate St Paul's *παρὰ φύσιν* as *Contrary to Nature*? Text versus Received Dogma in the Translation of St Paul' in *Theology & Sexuality*, vol. 20, no. 2 (2014). We are grateful for this point to Diarmaid MacCulloch.
 35. Phillips and Reay, *Sex before Sexuality*, p. 18.
 36. Willett, 'The Church of England and the Origins of Homosexual Law Reform' p. 420.
 37. K. Sands, 'Homosexuality, Religion, and the Law' in *Homosexuality & Religion: An Encyclopedia*, Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 2007, pp. 10–11.
 38. *The Sodomites Shame and Doom, Laid Before them in Grief and Compassion*, London: J. Davies, 1702. Although the republication in 1699 of an account of the Earl of Castlehaven's trial in 1631 commented that in the 1690s England 'the purest religion is professed and where vice and immorality are punished by severe laws' yet 'inhuman, unnatural and beastly offences' still took place. *The Tryal and Condemnation of ... the Earl of Castlehaven ...*, London: n.p., 1699, preface, n.p.
 39. S. Gane, 'Common Soldiers, Same-Sex Love and Religion in the Early Eighteenth-Century British Army' in *Gender & History*, Special Issue: Sex, Gender and the Sacred: Reconfiguring Religion in *Gender History* vol. 25, no. 3 (November 2013), p. 644.
 40. *Hell Upon Earth, or The Town in Uproar*, London: J. Roberts, 1729.
 41. *A Treatise Wherein Are Strict Observations Upon The Destestable and Most Shocking Sin of Sodomy, Blasphemy and Atheism*, London: A. Moore, 1728.
 42. R. Norton (ed.), 'The Trial of Gilbert Laurence, 1730', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 5 January 2001, updated 4 March 2004, <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1730laur.htm> (accessed

- 7 June 2015) and R. Norton (ed.), 'The Trial of John Twyford, 1745', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 26 January 2001 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1745twyf.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
43. R. Norton (ed.), 'An Ecclesiastical Prosecution, 1726', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 31 May 2009, <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1735andr.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015). The transfer of the case from the King's Bench could not have been motivated by the claim of benefit of clergy by Townshend since the benefit of clergy had been specifically denied by the 'Buggery Act' of 1533. We are grateful to Diarmaid MacCulloch for raising this with us.
 44. R. Norton (ed.), 'Sodomastix and Other News Reports, 1728', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 3 March 2005, updated 10 December 2014 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1729news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
 45. Cocks, 'Homosexuality between Men', p. 869. Willett, 'The Church of England and the Origins of Homosexual Law Reform', pp. 420–1.
 46. *The Times*, 13 May 1833, p. 3, quoted in H. G. Cocks, 'Making the Sodomite Speak: Voices of the Accused in English Sodomy Trials, c.1800–98' in *Gender & History*, vol.18, no. 1 (April 2006), p. 95.
 47. J. Kenyon, *The Popish Plot*, London: Penguin, 1974, p. 219.
 48. Guildhall Broadside 6.31 (19 November 1689).
 49. *The Character of a Jacobite*, London: n.p., 1690.
 50. *Hell Upon Earth*, pp. 41–3.
 51. T. Bray, *For God, or For Satan: Being A Sermon Preached at St Mary Le Bow, before the Society for the Reformation of Manners, 27 December 1708*, London: J. Downing, 1709, pp. 20, 30.
 52. *The Destruction of Sodom, Improved as a Warning to Great Britain. A Sermon preached on the Fast-Day, Friday, February 6, 1756 ... By Dr Allen, the morning preacher ...* London: A. Millar, 1756, pp. 24, 25, 28.
 53. *The British Poets, vol. LXII: The Poems of Charles Churchill*, Chiswick: Whittingham, 1822, p. 214.
 54. E. S. Turner, *Unholy Pursuits: The Wayward Parsons of Grub Street*, Lewes: Book Guild, 1998, p. 71. M. Kinservik, *Sex, scandal, and celebrity in late eighteenth-century England*, New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2007.
 55. Norton, *Mother Clap's Molly House*, pp. 122–33.
 56. A. Stewart, 'A Society of Sodomites: Religion and Homosexuality in Renaissance England', in Gowing et al, *Love, Friendship and Faith*, pp. 89, 99–103.
 57. A. Clarke, 'John Atherton' in *ODNB*.
 58. The best treatment of the Atherton case are: P. Marshall, *Mother Leakey & the Bishop: a ghost story*, Oxford University Press, 2007 and R. Norton, *The Life and Death of John Atherton* online at <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/atherton.htm> (accessed 13 April 2014).
 59. See for example, *The political ballance, for 1754. The mock-patriot, for 1753. To which is added, the case of John Atherton, Bishop of Waterford in Ireland, who was*

- convicted of bestiality with a cow and other creatures, for which he was hang'd at Dublin; with a full account of his behaviour after condemnation, and the letters he left before his execution: By N. Barnard, Dean of Ardagb, at the command of the Primate of Ireland, Dublin: R. Lapis, 1754.
60. J. Swift, 'An Excellent New Ballad, or, the True English Dean to be hanged for a Rape.' 1730.
 61. Benbow, *Crimes of the Clergy*, p. 25.
 62. F. Azfar, 'Genealogy of an Execution: The Sodomite, the Bishop and the Anomaly of 1726' in *Journal of British Studies*, vol. 51, no. 3 (2012), pp. 577–9. Wake was himself touched by a scandal in 1734 when one of his servants, who had been charged with sodomy, committed suicide: R. Norton (ed.), 'Newspaper Reports, 1734', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 24 Feb. 2015 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1734news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
 63. Azfar, 'Genealogy of an Execution', pp. 576, 593.
 64. R. Norton (ed.), 'The Trial of Gabriel Lawrence, 1726', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 1 Dec. 1999, updated 20 June 2008 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1726lawr.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015). Lawrence's fellow condemned, Thomas Wright noted the Newgate ordinary 'had been used to go to separate Meetings, yet ye said, that he loved and esteemed the Church of *England*, and was willing to Communicate with the Church, as soon as with Dissenters.' – R. Norton (ed.), 'The Trial of Thomas Wright, 1726', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*. 1 Dec. 1999, updated 20 June 2008 <http://www.rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1726wrig.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
 65. Azfar, 'Genealogy of an Execution', pp. 580, 586. It is unfortunate that Azfar's claims about Gibson seem to rest on claims to know what was in his mind.
 66. E. Gibson, *The Bishop of London's Pastoral Letter to the People of his Diocese; Particularly to Those of the Two Great Cities of London and Westminster*. . . London: S. Buckley, 1728, p. 2.
 67. N. Sykes, *Edmund Gibson*, Oxford University Press, 1926, p. 196.
 68. J. Black, *Illustrated History of Eighteenth Century Britain*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1996, pp. 62–70.
 69. Anon., *The Ten Plagues of England, By a Well-wisher to Great-Britain*. London: R. Withy and Co., 1757, p. 14.
 70. E. Cannan, rev R. Hayden, 'Andre Gifford (1700–1784) in *ODNB*.
 71. We owe information on John Church's Baptist roots to Diarmaid MacCulloch. See also M. Clement, 'Church, John (b. 1780)', *ODNB*.
 72. Benbow, *The Crimes of the Clergy*, p. 20.
 73. Abelow, *Evangelist of Desire*, p. 68.
 74. *Ibid.*, p. 67.
 75. P Forsaith, 'The First Rise of Methodism' in *Proceedings of the Wesley Historical Society* (2016).

76. 10 September 1755: 'Charles Bradbury was indicted, for that he, not having the fear of God before his eyes, but being mov'd and seduc'd by the instigation of the devil, on James Hearne, feloniously did make an assault, and the said James Hearne, did carnally know, and with him, the said James, did commit that detestable crime not fit to be named in a Christian country, called sodomy, April 14.' *oldbaileyonline.org* ref t17550910-42. See also I. McCormick (ed.) *Sexual Outcasts, 1750–1850*, London: Routledge, 2000, vol. 2, pp. 27–125.
77. R. Norton (ed.), 'Newspaper Reports, 1785', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 13 September 2014 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1785news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
78. R. Norton (ed.), 'Newspaper Reports, 1786', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 16 September 2014 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1786news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
79. J. Telford (ed.), *The Letters of John Wesley*, London: Epworth, 1931, vol. 8, p. 275.
80. J. C. Bowmer & J. A. Vickers (eds), *The Letters of John Pawson*, Peterborough: Methodist Publishing House, for World Methodist Historical Society, 1994, vol. 1, pp. 149, 152n.
81. Telford *Letters of John Wesley*, vol. 8, p. 68; M. Lelievre, *Histoire du Methodisme dans les Iles de la Manche*, Paris: Librairie Évangélique; Londres: Theophilus Woolmer, 1885, p. 394.
82. Forsaith, 'The First Rise of Methodism' in *Proceedings of the Wesley Historical Society*.
83. J. Lenton, *John Wesley's Preachers Social & Statistical Analysis of British & Irish Preachers who entered the Methodist Itinerancy Before 1791*, Cumbria: Paternoster Press, 2009, p. 297.
84. Romans chapter 1 v 27 reads: 'And likewise also the men, leaving the natural use of the woman, burned in their lust one toward another; men with men working that which is unseemly, and receiving in themselves that recompence of their error which was meet.'
85. Wesley's.
86. Westminster College, Cambridge, Cheshunt Archive, Thomas Young to Lady Huntingdon, 11 April 1791.
87. Forsaith, 'The First Rise of Methodism'.
88. The committee recommended to Hughes that 'you withdraw yourself entirely from this chapel: and we recommend it to you to retire to some considerable distance from the metropolis, and there spend the remainder of your days' and advised him to 'pray fervently to the God of all grace, that he may humble you deeply under a sense of that sin, which thus awfully cuts you off from a church of Christ on earth; and that he may give you power over every besetting sin for the future, so that you may not live and die deceiving yourself with a false hope, and at last be excluded eternally from the church of Christ in heaven.' 'Spa Fields Chapel Minutes: 1782–3', *Two Calvinistic Methodist Chapels 1743–1811: The London tabernacle and Spa Fields chapel* (1975), pp. 63–72. URL:

- <http://www.british-history.ac.uk/report.aspx?compid=38773> (accessed 18 February 2014).
89. *Gospel Magazine* (May 1777), p. 235. For a discussion of Toplady's extraordinary antipathy to Wesley see G. Lawton, *Within the Rock of Ages. The Life and Work of Augustus Montague Toplady* Cambridge: James Clarke & Co. 1983.
 90. According to Eric Partridge, *A Dictionary of Historical Slang*, London: Penguin, abridged ed., 1972, a 'lad o'wax' was a term applied equally to a cobbler and to a 'poor sort of man' (p. 519), and, as Partridge puts it (p. 1031) 'my cock of wax' was 'a shoemaker's term of address'. These phrases were current in the 1770s.
 91. Quoted in *Thomas Olivers of Tregynon, The Life of An Early Methodist Preacher Written by Himself*, Tregynon: Gregynog Press, 1979, p. 11.
 92. We owe this material on Toplady, Olivers and Wesley to Dr John Morgan-Guy.
 93. Anderson, *Imagining Methodism*, p. 80. It has usually been assumed that Wesley meant that as a married man he would be beyond reproach when it came to his dealings with women.
 94. L. Tyerman, *The Life and Times of the Rev. John Wesley, MA, Founder of the Methodists*, London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1840, vol. I, p. 22.
 95. F. Baker (ed.) *Bicentennial Edition: The Works of John Wesley, Vol. 9 (The Methodist Societies)*, Nashville, TN: Kingswood Press, 1984: p. 278.
 96. ST Kimbrough & O. Bekerlegge (eds) *The Unpublished Poetry of Charles Wesley*, Nashville, TN: Kingswood Bookes, 1988, vol. 1, p. 291. We owe this reference to Linda Ryan.
 97. L. Ryan, 'Child-rearing and Education: The Thinking and Practice of John Wesley and some of his Contemporaries, Evaluated within its Eighteenth-century Context', Oxford Brookes University, PhD thesis 2015.
 98. V. H. H. Green, *The Young Mr Wesley*, London: Edward Arnold, 1961, p. 172.
 99. *Ibid.*, p. 172.
 100. *Ibid.*, *The Young Mr Wesley*, pp. 184–5.
 101. It is unclear whether this was the same Thomas Blair who was convicted of sodomy in February 1743 and was killed by the mob while standing in the pillory for his offence. *London Evening Post*, 15 February 1743. R. Norton (Ed.), 'Newspaper Reports, 1743', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 26 August 2014 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1743news.htm> (accessed 10 June 2015). Blair may have been the same person indicted for sodomy in London in 1743: '14 January 1743, John Deacon and Thomas Blair were indicted, John Deacon for unlawfully and wickedly laying Hands on Thomas Blair, with an Intent to commit the detestable Crime of Sodomy; and Thomas Blair, for unlawfully, voluntarily, and wickedly permitting and suffering the said John Deacon to lay Hands on him the said Thomas, with an Intent to commit the said detestable Crime of Sodomy, Oct. 18th. They were sentenced to be imprisoned for 6 Months, and to stand for one Hour in and upon the Pillory, between the Hours of 12 and 2, at the upper End of Cheapside.' (www.oldbaileyonline.org, refs. t17430114-31; s17430114-1).

102. Horn was himself a friend of Charles Wesley at Oxford and had directly known of the Blair case.
103. C. L. S. Linnell (ed.) *The Diaries of Thomas Wilson DD, 1731–1737 & 1750*, London: SPCK, 1964, p. 81.
104. *Perfection, A Poetical Satire*, London: J. Bew, 1778, p. 8.
105. A. Bray, *The Friend*, London: University of Chicago Press, 2003, pp. 230–4.
106. S. Lewis, *The Topographical Dictionary of England*, London: S. Lewis, 1803, vol. 3, n.p. Even Pevsner noted the design of the monument without comment of its significance: N. Pevsner (rev. E. Radcliffe), *The Buildings of England: Cornwall*, London: Penguin, 1970, p. 97.
107. E. Mavor, 'Butler, Lady (Charlotte) Eleanor (1739–1829)', *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography*, Oxford University Press, 2004.
108. E. Mavor, 'Butler, Lady (Charlotte) Eleanor (1739–1829)', *ODNB*.
109. Their lives were first written about in detail by the Revd John Pritchard in a pamphlet in the 1920s.
110. J. Hicklin, *The "Ladies of Llangollen" as Sketched by Many Hands; With Notices of Other Objects of Interest . . .*, Dublin: T. Cranfield, 1847.
111. Bray, *The Friend*, pp. 234–8.
112. J. Duncumb, *Collections towards the History and Antiquities of the County of Hereford*, Hereford: E. G. Wright, 1804, vol. 1, p. 548.
113. F. Havergal, *Fasti Herefordenses and Other Antiquarian Memorials*, Edinburgh: R. Clark, 1869, p. 40. Havergal implies that the movement was part of a general Victorian clearing out of tombstones and the rescue of the stones was due to the intervention of Lord Saye and Sele, who was archdeacon of Hereford.
114. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, p. 75.
115. Gane, 'Common Soldiers, Same-Sex Love and Religion in the Early Eighteenth-Century British Army'.
116. Mack, *Heart Religion in the British Enlightenment*, p. 77.
117. Abelow, *Evangelist of Desire*, pp. 69–70.
118. K. Newport & G. Lloyd (eds), *The Letters of Charles Wesley, A Critical Edition with Introduction and Notes, 1728–1756*, Oxford University Press, 2013, vol. 1, pp. 338, 342, 346 n2, 348.
119. *Ibid.*, vol. 1, p. 350.
120. Gane, 'Common Soldiers, Same-Sex Love and Religion in the Early Eighteenth-Century British Army'.
121. Without revealing to the publisher that they were the work of a woman. N. Clarke, 'Life of Pea' in the *Times Literary Supplement*, no. 5818 (12 September 2014), p. 7.
122. Mack, *Heart Religion*, p. 154.
123. E. Mavor, *The Ladies of Llangollen*, London: Penguin, 1971. F. Brideoake, 'Extraordinary Female Affection' The Ladies of Llangollen and the Endurance of Queer Community' in *Queer Romanticism*, no. 36–7 (February 2005).
124. Bray, *The Friend* passim; Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, p. 76.

125. H. Cocks, 'Religion and Spirituality' in H. Cocks and M. Houlbrooke (eds), *The Modern History of Sexuality*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006, pp. 162–3.
126. Haggerty, *Men in Love*, p. 18.
127. V. Traub, 'Friendship's Loss: Alan Bray's Making of History' in L. Gowing, M. Hunter and M. Rubin (eds), *Love, friendship and Faith in European 1300–1800*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005, pp. 21–3.
128. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, p. 79.
129. Traub, 'Friendship's Loss', p. 16.
130. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, p. 75.
131. Cocks, 'Homosexuality between Men', pp. 877–8.
132. *Ibid.*, pp. 165–6.
133. *Ibid.*, p. 158.
134. R. Trumbach, 'Sex, Gender and Sexual Identity in Modern Culture: Male Sodomy and Female Prostitution in Enlightenment London' in *The Journal of the History of Sexuality*, vol. 2, no. 2 (1991), pp. 186–203.
135. G. Midgley, *University Life in Eighteenth Century Oxford*, London: Yale University Press, 1996, pp. 88–9.
136. T. Harmsen, 'John Pointer' ODNB; C. E. Doble et al (eds) *Remarks and Collections of Thomas Hearne*, Oxford Historical Society (1911), vol. 9, pp. 2, 7, 13, 34, 42–3, 48, 50, 65, 67, 72. Green, *The Young Mr Wesley*, p. 31.
137. Midgley, *University Life in Eighteenth Century Oxford*, p. 89. Oddly, Julie Peakman seems to mistake Wadham for a public school: Peakman, 'Introduction' in Peakman (ed.), *A Cultural History of Sexuality in the Enlightenment*, pp. 10–11.
138. Green, *The Young Mr Wesley*, p. 33.
139. Dabhoiwala, *Origins of Sex*, p. 131.
140. For more on Swinton in Europe on the Grand Tour, see J. Black, *The British and the Grand Tour*, London, Routledge, 2010 and J. Black, 'Genoa in 1731' in *The Italian Quarterly*, vol. 30, no. 118 (1989), pp. 39–53.
141. Green, *The Young Mr Wesley*, p. 32.
142. Midgley, *University Life in Eighteenth Century Oxford*, p. 89.
143. W. Matthews (ed.), *Dudley Ryder's Diary 1715–16*, London: Methuen, 1939, p. 143.
144. R. Norton (ed.), 'Newspaper Reports, 1790', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 29 September 2014 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1790news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).
145. Capt. Mawson, *The Just Vengeance of Heaven Exemplify'd*, London: Jenkins, 1730.
146. J. Gregory, 'Thomas Secker (1693–1768) ODNB. R. G. Ingram, *Religion, Reform and Modernity in the Eighteenth Century, Thomas Secker and the Church of England*, Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2007, p. 128.
147. R. Norton (ed.), 'Newspaper Reports, 1763', *Homosexuality in Eighteenth-Century England: A Sourcebook*, 7 April 2004, updated 24 February 2005, 19 January 2012, 22 October 2012 <http://rictornorton.co.uk/eighteen/1763news.htm> (accessed 7 June 2015).

148. G. M. Ditchfield and B. Keith-Lucas (eds) *A Kentish Parson*, Stroud: Allan Sutton, 1991, p. 78. We owe this reference to Mike Ashby.
149. The Dutch carried on a particularly vicious campaign against men suspected of sodomy during 1730–1, virtually contemporaneous with the apparent tolerance of transgressive male sexual occurrences in Oxford noted above.
150. Norton, *Mother Clap's Molly House*, pp. 217–19. The guardsman had a French name and it was assumed that he was a Frenchman.
151. H. M. Hyde, *The Strange Death of Lord Castlereagh*, London: Heinemann, 1959.
152. I. McCalman, *Radical Underworld*, p. 206.
153. C. Upchurch, 'Politics and the Reporting Sex Between Men in the 1820s' in B. Lewis (ed.), *British Queer History*, Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2013, pp. 27–9.
154. *Ibid.*, p. 26.
155. *The Annual Register; Or, A View of the History, Politics, and*, London: Rivingtons, vol. 67, 1825, Law Cases section, pp. 5*–6*.
156. There is no record of a John Fenwick as incumbent or assistant curate of either St Peter or St Andrew Byall (which is presumably Bywell, Northumberland), so there may have been some misinformation or event invention.
157. Benbow, *The Crimes of the Clergy*, pp. 8–12, 40, 118–20, 138.
158. *Ibid.*, pp. 229–30, Benbow commented: 'he is now in America, that sanctuary of crime and hot bed of guilt.'
159. Wollaston at first sacked the servant when he told him what had happened, but in time the truth came out. Benbow, *The Crimes of the Clergy*, pp. 238.
160. *A report of the trial of the Reverend Thomas Jephson, for a misdemeanor: at the Cambridge summer assizes, 1823, on Wednesday, July 23, before Mr. Serjeant Bosanquet, and a commons jury*, London: n.p., 1832. Benbow, *The Crimes of the Clergy*, pp. 239–40.
161. M. Chase, 'Benbow, William (1787–1864)', ODNB.
162. I. McCalman, *Radical Underworld: Prophets, Revolutionaries, and Pornographers in London*, Cambridge University Press, 1988, pp. 169, 208.

Chapter 8 Scandals, the Public, and the Clergy

1. A. Clark, *Scandal, The Sexual Politics of the British Constitution*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2003, pp. 1–17.
2. Gatrell's *City of Laughter*, pp. 171, 173.
3. Clark, *Scandal*, pp. 1–17.
4. Anon, *A Treatise Wherein Are Strict Observations Upon The Destestable and Most Shocking Sin of Sodomy, Blasphemy and Atheism*, London: A. Moore, 1728, preface. The author conceded that 'tis certain that the World was never better furnish'd with able clergymen . . . '
5. The twenty sixth of the thirty nine articles of the Church of England stated that 'the unworthiness of the ministers, which hinders not the effect of the sacrament . . . nor the grace of God's gifts diminished from such as by faith,

- and rightly, do receive the Sacraments ministered unto them; which be effectual, because of Christ's institution and promise, although they be ministered by evil men.'
6. G. Herbert, *The Country Parson His Character and Rule of Holy Life*, London: J. B. Dow, 1842.
 7. Spaeth, *The Church in an Age of Danger*, pp. 122–32.
 8. Hone had many targets resulting in him being prosecuted for blasphemy, D. S. Nash, *Blasphemy in Modern Britain: 1789 to the Present*, Aldershot: Ashgate, 1999.
 9. Gatrell's *City of Laughter*, p. 18.
 10. T. Burgess, *Peculiar Privileges of the Christian Ministry considered in a charge delivered to the clergy of the diocese of St Davids*, London: Rivington, 1804, pp. 1, 5–7, 22. H. W. Majendie, *A Charge Delivered to the Clergy of the Diocese of Bangor*, Bangor: n.p., 1817, p. 37.
 11. W. B. Knight, *The Parish Priest: A sermon . . . at the Primary Visitation of Charles Richard, Lord Bishop of Llandaff*, London: Rivington, 1827, pp. 8, 12–14, 16–23.
 12. J. Venn, *Annals of a Clerical Family*, London: Macmillan, 1904, pp. 45–6.
 13. Ditchfield and Keith-Lucas (eds), *A Kentish Parson*, p. 78.
 14. British Library, Add. Mss 22,560, Thomlinson Diary, 3 March, 3, 5, 24, 26 April 1717.
 15. A. Ponsonby (ed.), *English Diaries, A Review of English Diaries from the Sixteenth to the Twentieth Centuries*, London: Methuen, 1923, p. 199.
 16. T. M. Martin (ed.), *Six North Country Diaries*, Surtees Society, vol. 118, 1910.
 17. K. Davison, 'Occasional Politeness and Gentleman's Laughter in 18th C England', *The Historical Journal*, vol. 57, no. 4 (2014), pp. 921–45.
 18. R. Hole, 'Keene, Edmund (1714–1781)', *ODNB*.
 19. K. Thompson (ed.), *Memoirs of Viscountess Sundon, Mistress of the Robes to Queen Caroline . . .*, London: Henry Colburn, 1847, vol. 1, p. 40.
 20. W. Gibson, *Enlightenment Prelate, Benjamin Hoadly 1676–1761*, Cambridge: James Clarke, 2004, pp. 199–200.
 21. J. Kynaston, *A collection of papers relative to the prosecution now carried on in the Chancellor's Court in Oxford, against Mr. Kynaston, by Matthew Maddock, clerk . . . for the charge of adultery alledged against the said Matthew Maddock. By John Kynaston, M.A*, London: n.p., 1764, p. iii.
 22. C. H. Timperley, *Annals of Manchester . . . from the earliest period to the close of the year 1839*, Manchester: Bankes, 1839, p. 42; The National Archives, Treasury Solicitor: Jacobite Rebellion (1745) Prosecution Papers. Assizes and Special Commissions: Samuel Maddock's evidence: TS 20/107/7; TS 20/92/8.
 23. J. M. Crook, *Brazenose the Biography of an Oxford College*, Oxford University Press, 2008, p. 100.
 24. A. T. Hart, *The Life and Times of John Sharp, Archbishop of York*, London: SPCK, 1949, p. 30.

25. A. T. Hart, *Some Clerical Oddities in the Church of England from Medieval to Modern Times*, Bognor: New Horizon Books, 1980, p. 108.
26. *Ibid.*, p. 110. Hewardine seems to have kept his living at least until 1705 when he left it.
27. W. A. Pemberton, 'The Ecclesiastical Courts of the Archdeaconry of Leicester in the Eighteenth Century and Early Nineteenth Century' in *Transaction of the Leicestershire Archaeological and Natural History Society*, vol. LVII (1981–2), p. 42.
28. R. L. Brown, 'The Captain's Brother: Thomas Gronow' in *Morgannwg, Journal of Glamorgan History*, vol. 51 (2007) pp. 45–52. Though matters were left unproven, Copleston disliked his non-residence and attitude in general.
29. We owe this information on Rimbron to Dr John Morgan-Guy: J. Guy, 'An Investigation into the Pattern and Nature of Patronage, Plurality and Non-Residence in the Old Diocese of Llandaff, Between 1660 and the Beginning of the Nineteenth Century', University of Wales PhD, 1983, vol. 2, pp. 785–6.
30. T. Rimbron, *The Domestic Monitor, A Director and Guide to Parents and Children, to Masters and Servants in Religion and the Way to Salvation*, Bristol: Bulgin, 1790, p. 2.
31. *Ibid.*, p. 132.
32. For the importance of print culture in opening up morality and criminality to public discussion see Richard Ward, 'Print Culture, Moral Panic, and the Administration of the Law: The London Crime Wave of 1744' *Crime, Histoire & Sociétés/Crime, History & Societies*, vol. 16, no. 1 (2012), pp. 5–24.
33. He survived the uproar that followed the marriage for seven years. *The Gentleman's Magazine and Historical Chronicle*, vol. 43 (1773), p. 526.
34. R. B. Outhwaite, *Scandal in the Church, Dr Edward Drax Free, 1764–1843*, London: Hambledon Press, 1997, p. 15.
35. R. B. Outhwaite, *The Rise and Fall of the English Ecclesiastical Courts, 1600–1860*, Cambridge University Press, 2006, pp 134–7.
36. *A Letter from Montagu Burgoyne Esq . . . to his Brother Churchwardens in the Diocese of Lincoln Citing a Summary Account of the Prosecution, Conviction and Deprivation of the Rev. Dr Edward Drax Free, Rector of Sutton . . .*, London: Rivingtons, 1830.
37. Murgatroyd's diaries and notes quoted in C. Steedman, *Master and Servant, Love and Labour in the English Industrial Age*, Cambridge University Press, 2007, pp. 112–13.
38. Murgatroyd's diaries and notes quoted in Steedman, *Master and Servant*, pp. 112–13.
39. W. Gibson, *James II and the Trial of the Seven Bishops*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2009, p. 63 and T. Harris, *Revolution The Great Crisis of the British Monarchy, 1685–1720*, London: Allen Lane, 2006, p. 226.
40. Worcestershire Archive and Archaeology Service, Articles of good behaviour against William Durston, clerk, of Ripple, by Revd. John Fleetwood, Archdeacon of the Diocese, 1/1/192/44. We owe this reference to Gillian Ford who is researching the life of Thomas Cartwright.

41. For a discussion of evidence in legal cases, see M. Knights, *The Devil in Disguise, Deception, Delusion and Fanaticism in the Early English Enlightenment*, Oxford University Press, 2011.
42. H. Lancaster, 'Henry Chivers' in D. Hayton, E. Cruickshanks, S. Handley (eds), *The History of Parliament: the House of Commons 1690–1715*, Cambridge University Press, 2002.
43. Clarke and Foxcroft, *A Life of Gilbert Burnet*, pp. 417–8.
44. We owe much of what follows on Blackburne to Daniel Reed's extensive research on his career at York and before his appointment.
45. The most recent, although admittedly unscholarly, attack on Blackburne is found in Matthew Parris's *The Great Unfroaked, Two Thousand Years of Church Scandal*, London: Robson Books, 1998. Nor has Blackburne been well-served by his *ODNB* entry, which merely recounts the evidence: A. Starkie, 'Blackburne, Lancelot (1658–1743)', *ODNB*.
46. The research of Daniel Reed looks certain to conclude this matter, based on the papers of Lewis Stephens who knew Blackburne well. These papers are in the Cornwall Record Office.
47. Bodleian Library, Oxford, Rawlinson Ms. 106 f. 12. Henry Compton, bishop of London, re: Lancelot Blackburne, 25 November 1684.
48. P. Toynbee (ed.), *The Letters of Horace Walpole, Fourth Earl of Orford, volume 11: 1779–81*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1804, p. 334.
49. *The Letters of Horace Walpole, Earl of Orford, vol 2, 1744–53*, London: Richard Bentley, 1840, p. 383.
50. A. Pope, *Sober Advice From Horace, to the Young Gentleman about Town, as Deliver'd in his Second Sermon*, London, T. Boreman, 1735 was published anonymously, claiming to be 'Imitated in the Manner of Mr. Pope' but actually by Pope himself. The piece is discussed in, W. Kupersmith, *English Versions of Roman Satire in the Earlier Eighteenth Century*, Newark: University of Delaware Press, 2007, p. 81. It has also been suggested that Blackburne was the subject of other jibes by Pope, such as in the *Epistle to Cobham* or "*Of the Knowledge and Characters of Men*" (1734), which makes reference to 'a rev'rend sire, whom want of grace, Has made the father of a nameless race' and 'Still to his wench he crawls on knocking knees, And envies ev'ry sparrow that he sees'. See, J. Butt (ed.), *The Poems of Alexander Pope. A One Volume Edition of The Twickenham Pope*, 2nd rev. ed. London: Methuen, 1968, p. 558.
51. *The Farmer's Daughter or the Art of Getting Preferment* London: J. Torbuck, 1737, pp. 4–5. We are grateful to Daniel Reed for bringing this item to our attention.
52. *Ibid.*, p. 35.
53. The poem concludes:
Here view the Dunce each Sabbath-Day,
Divinely preach, devoutly pray;
His yawning Flock with Grief oppress'd,
By holy Drone, lull'd fast to Rest;

- With sacred Rage, whilst honeft *Numps*,
 The Duff from clumsy Cushion thumps
 For which the Farmers freely pay,
 Tithe Pigg and Capons ev'ry Day:
 Whilst honest *Hob* and *Dell* adore,
 Their Priestred Son, and Daughter Wh – re. – *The Farmer's Daughter*, p. 36.
54. 'Whilst ye were brib'd, I only kissed my lass;
 I got a B—ard, yt the land tax pass
 Ye voted foreign troops in British pay;
 I rais'd recruits in my own nat'ral way
 And 'twas but fit, whilst ev'ry speech ye made
 So many subjects to their Deaths betray'd' – *Priestcraft and Lust: or Lancelot to his Ladies. A Epistle from the Shades*, London, W. Webb, 1743, pp. 9–10.
55. Referring to Archbishop Potter and Bishops Hoadly, Burnet and Maddox, the poem claimed:
 'P—r sought learning, H – dl-y Party Strife,
 B—t his lawn begrim'd in prime of life;
 A – ph that falsified his hand and word
 (The emblem of hanged Judas to his Lord) . . . '
56. Catherine Benson was also the sister of Secker's friend, Martin Benson, who was later bishop of Gloucester.
57. E. Major, 'The Life and Work of Catherine Talbot (1721–70): "A Public Concern" in S. Apetrei and H. Smith (eds) *Religion and Women in Britain, c. 1660–1760*, Farnham: Ashgate, 2014.
58. R. G. Ingram, *Religion, Reform and Modernity in the Eighteenth Century*, Thomas Secker and the Church of England, Woodbridge: Boydell Press, 2007, pp. 50–64; A. P. Jenkins (ed) *The Correspondence of Bishop Secker* Oxford Record Society, Vol 57, 1991; J. S. Macauley & R. Greaves (eds) *The Autobiography of Thomas Secker, Archbishop of Canterbury*, Lawrence KS: University of Kansas Libraries, 1989.
59. W. Weber, 'Martha Ray (1742?-1779)' in *ODNB*.
60. Hackman's career can be see in P. Rawlings, 'Hackman, James (*bap.* 1752, *d.* 1779)', *ODNB*; his trial is available at the Old Bailey Online at <http://www.oldbaileyonline.org/browse.jsp?ref=t17790404-3> (accessed 30 December 2013); the Newgate Calendar online also provides useful details, <http://www.exclassics.com/newgate/ng355.htm> (accessed 30 December 2013).
61. Such exposés developed their own language: Sarah Lloyd has shown how shrubberies became not merely a high-charged venue for sex but also a metaphor for the female body: S. Lloyd, 'Amour in the Shrubbery: Reading the Detail of English Adultery Trial Publications of the 1780s' in *Eighteenth-Century Studies*, vol. 39, no. 4 (2006), pp. 421–42.
62. M. Levy, *Love and Madness: The Murder of Martha Ray, Mistress of the Fourth Earl of Sandwich*, New York: William Morrow, 2004.
63. The murder has produced two recent scholarly treatments: M. Levy, *Love and Madness* and J. Brewer, *A Sentimental Murder: Love and Madness in the Eighteenth*

- Century*, London: Harper Collins, 2004. See also J. E. Myers, 'A Case of Murderous Sensibility: James Hackman, Interiority and Masculine Agency in Late Eighteenth-Century England', *Gender & History*, vol. 20, no. 2 (2008), pp. 312–331.
64. Boswell in *St James's Chronicle*, 15–17 April 1779, pp. 88–9.
 65. Brewer, *A Sentimental Murder*, pp. 45–6, 164–70.
 66. St Olave's, Jewry and St Martin's, Ironmonger's Lane was a united benefice rather than two parishes.
 67. Altham claimed that Mrs Wenham wanted Altham 'to roger her'. *The Trial of the Revd Mr James Altham ... for Adultery, Defamation and Obscenity in the Consistorial Episcopal Court of London ... setting forth the whole of the evidence at the astonishing trial*, London: G. Lister, 1785, p. 50.
 68. *Ibid.*, pp. 1–8, 55.
 69. *Ibid.*, p. 43.
 70. *Ibid.*, pp. 18–19, 35.
 71. The second volume was also published by George Lister and was entitled *The Trial of the Revd Mr James Altham ... setting forth the whole of the evidence at the astonishing trial*, London: G. Lister, 1785, vol. 2.
 72. *Trial of the Revd Mr James Altham*, vol. 2, pp. 22–3, 37, 48.
 73. The National Archives, Chancery Commission and Inquisition of Lunacy, C 211/1/A47.
 74. Essex Record Office, T/Z 151/257: Monumental inscriptions at St. Mary, Latton.
 75. *The Monthly Review*, vol. 74 (1785), p. 311.
 76. *The Cuckold's Chronicle: being select trials for adultery {sic}, incest, imbecility, ravishment, &c.* London: n.p., 1798, vol. 1, pp. 25–43.
 77. A. Pollard, 'Madan, Martin (1725–1790)', ODNB.
 78. J. Carey, *Christian Doctrine by John Milton*, Vol. VI: *Complete Prose Works of John Milton*, New Haven: Yale University Press, 1973.
 79. Matthews (ed.) *The Diary of Dudley Ryder, 1715–16*, p. 85.
 80. *Two Dissertations Written by the Late Bishop Burnet, Viz: 1 A Defence of Polygamy ... 2 The Lawfulness of Divorce ...* London: E. Curll, 1731, pp. 5, 11, 12. Burnet made exceptions of women who were married when they were fertile and had entered the menopause or women who had married after the age of 45 when they were assumed to be menopausal and therefore infertile. This was presumably to prevent men from throwing over their wives as they aged.
 81. It may be that the publication was part of Curll's brief experiment with racy literature, which included a poetic guide for new brides called *The Pleasures and Mysteries of the Marriage Bed modestly unveil'd*, published at the same time. P. Baines & P. Rogers, *Edmund Curll, Bookseller*, Oxford University Press, 2007, p. 241. It is also quite clear that Burnet did not advocate polygamy, his discussion of it in his biography of the Earl of Rochester is unequivocal: G. Burnet, *Some Passages of the Life and Death of the Right Honourable John, Earl of Rochester*, London: Richard Chiswel, 1680, pp. 112–3.

82. Turner, *Fashioning Adultery*, pp. 180–1, T. Payne, *The cases of polygamy, concubinage, adultery, divorce, &c. seriously and learnedly discussed* ... London: E. Curll, 1732, it was sufficiently popular to be re-issued in 1736.
83. We are grateful to Professor Howard Weinbrot for the opportunity to read his paper for the British Society for Eighteenth Century Studies Annual Conference in January 2014 entitled 'Johnson's *Rasselas*: Monogamy, Polygamy, and the Marriage Debate'.
84. D. T. Andrew, 'Popular Culture and Public Debate: London 1780' in *Historical Journal*, vol. 39, no. 2 (1996), pp. 405–23.
85. J. Cookson, *Thoughts on Polygamy Suggested by the Dictates of Scripture, Reason, Nature and Common-sense; with a Description of Marriage and its Obligations; a Contemplation of Our National System of Laus Relative Thereto*, Winchester: J. Wilkes, 1782.
86. *A Letter to the Revd Mr Madan concerning the Chapter of Polygamy in his late publication ... by a Layman*, London: Fielding and Walker, 1780.
87. *The Unlawfulness of Polygamy Evinc'd or Observations Occasioned by Erroneous Interpretations of Passages of the New Testament*, London: G. Kearsly, 1780, p. 73.
88. J. Tower, *Polygamy Unscriptural or Two Dialogues between Philalethese and Monogamus in which some of the Principal Errors of the Revd Mr M-d-n's Thelyphthora are detected*, London: Hogg and Watts, 1780, pp. 4–5.
89. *Ibid.*, pp. 8–9, 12, 31–2, 61.
90. T. Haweis, *A Scriptural Refutation of the Arguments for Polygamy Advanced in a Treatise called Thelyphthora*, London: Dilly, 1782, pp. iii–ix.
91. *Ibid.*, p. 101.
92. *Ibid.*
93. R. Hill, *The Blessings of Polygamy Displayed in an Affectionate Address to the Revd Martin Madan*, London: Matthews & Dilly, 1781, pp. 39, 42.
94. J. Smith, *Polygamy Indefensible. Two Sermons Preached at Nantwich, occasioned by a late pamphlet entitled Thelyphthora, to which is Prefixed a Letter to Mr Madan*, London: Hogg, 1781, p. 7. Smith recalled that his ordination vow included the promise to 'drive away all strange and erroneous doctrine'.
95. *Ibid.*, pp. 8, 10, 22, 29.
96. *Ibid.*, pp. 30–3, 43, 44–5; Smith took the view that there were more good and godly women in the world than men, p. 45. Nevertheless, Smith was not immune from misogyny, he claimed 'a bad woman, armed with beauty, is one of the most deadly instruments the Devil can employ against the sons of God.' –p. 53.
97. The comments of the *Critical Review* were included in the advertisement for the second edition of the sermons.
98. *Humourous and Satirical Notes: A sermon on Malt etc*, Ludlow: G. Nicholson, 1801, p. 22.
99. R. Porter, 'Mixed Feelings: the Enlightenment and Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain' in Bouce (ed.), *Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain*, p. 3.

Chapter 9 Sexual Narratives, Obscenity, and the Church

1. J. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books, The Development of Pornography in Eighteenth Century England*, Basingstoke: Palgrave, 2004, p. 1–2.
2. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, pp. 112, 113.
3. Our thanks to David Nash for this observation.
4. R. Porter, 'Mixed Feelings: the Enlightenment and Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain' in Bouce (ed.), *Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain*, p. 3.
5. Tim Hitchcock, *English Sexualities, 1700–1800*, Palgrave, Basingstoke and London, 1997, pp. 28–9.
6. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books*, pp. 6–7, 33, 126, 188, 194.
7. N. Schurer, 'British Erotica Before and After 1700', in *Eighteenth-Century Studies*, vol. 37, no. 3, Critical Networks (2004).
8. H. Cocks, 'Reading Obscene Texts and their Histories', in *Media History*, vol. 18, no. 3–4 (2012), pp. 275, 276.
9. Phillips and Reay citing Bradford Mudge, in *Sex Before Sexuality*, p. 112; also see L. Hunt, *The Family Romance of the French Revolution*, London: Routledge, 1992, pp. 91, 105. Phillips and Reay, *Sex Before Sexuality*, pp. 123–7.
10. Phillips and Reay citing Bradford Mudge, in *Sex Before Sexuality*, p. 112.
11. Cocks, 'Reading Obscene Texts', pp. 281, 283.
12. Discussed in Cocks, 'Reading Obscene Texts', p. 276.
13. Peter Wagner's description of the genre as pornographic is, however, inaccurate. P. Wagner, 'The Pornographer in the Courtroom: Trial Reports about Cases of Sexual Crimes and Delinquencies as a Genre of Eighteenth-Century Erotica' in Bouce (ed.), *Sexuality in Eighteenth-Century Britain*, p. 128.
14. Wagner, 'Pornographer in the Courtroom', pp. 131, 125. For the Curll case of 1727 see I. McCalman, 'Unrespectable Radicalism: Infidels and Pornography in Early Nineteenth Century London', in *Past & Present*, vol. 104 (1984), p. 75.
15. Schurer, *Ibid.*, p. 465.
16. The full title was *peccatum originale philologicé elucubratum, à Themidis alumno. Eleutheropoli, in borto Hesperidum, typis Adami, Evae, Terrae filii*.
17. Which translates as 'In Praise of Sodomy and Pederasty'.
18. This work was translated into English as *The Law Concerning Draped Virginity* in 1680.
19. Karen Hollewand's Oxford doctoral research doubts the authenticity of Beverland's reversal of views and argues that he was simply recanting in order to permit his return to the United Provinces.
20. Beverland is an obscure individual but is best approached through E. J. Dingwall's *Very Peculiar People, Portait Studies in the Queer, the Abnormal and the Uncanny*, New York: University Books, 1962; P. H. Ditchfield, *Books Fatal to their Authors*, London: Elliot Stock, 1894 and A. Chambers, *General Biographical Dictionary*, London: J. Nicholls, 1812, vol. 5, p. 201.
21. P. Davis (ed.), *Selected Poems: John Wilmot, Earl of Rochester*, Oxford University Press, 2013.

22. J. Timbs, *Doctors and patients, or, Anecdotes of the Medical World and Curiosities of Medicine*. London: Richard Bentley and Son, 1876, p.151.
23. J. W. Johnson, 'Did Lord Rochester write *Sodom?*', in *Publications of the Bibliographical Society*, vol. 81 (1987), pp. 119–53; H. Love, 'But Did Rochester Really Write *Sodom?*', in *Papers of the Bibliographical Society of America*, vol. 87 (1993), pp. 319–36.
24. G. Burnet, *Some Account of the Life and Death of John Wilmot, Earl of Rochester*, London: Richard Chiswel, 1680, pp. 133–5.
25. Cited in Davison, 'Occasional Politeness', p. 937.
26. Davison, *Ibid*.
27. This is an important theme of Vic Gatrell's *City of Laughter*.
28. G. Woodward, 'A Minute Regulation of the Opera Step – or an episcopal examination' (Fores, 1796); the bishop was Shute Barrington who had made public his concern at the dangerous impact of revealing French dancers' costumes.
29. http://www.britishmuseum.org/research/collection_online/collection_object_details.aspx?assetId=189022001&objectId=1659946&partId=1
30. http://www.britishmuseum.org/research/collection_online/collection_object_details.aspx?objectId=1536836&partId=1&searchText=clergyman&page=2
31. http://www.britishmuseum.org/research/collection_online/collection_object_details/collection_image_gallery.aspx?assetId=986769001&objectId=3015772&partId=1
32. W. Gibson, 'John Trusler and the Culture of Sermons in Late Eighteenth-Century England', *The Journal of Ecclesiastical History*, vol. 66, no. 2 (April 2015), pp. 302–3.
33. *Ibid.*, pp. 318, 319.
34. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books*, pp. 21–2, 126.
35. *The Book of Rates Now Used in the Sin Custom House of the Church and Court of Rome*, London: Benjamin Southwood, 1674.
36. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books*, p. 135.
37. *Ibid.*, pp. 40 129–32.
38. Cited in C. Haydon, 'Anti-Catholicism and Obscene Literature: The Case of Mrs Mary Catharine Cadiere and its Context', in P. Clarke and C. Methuen (eds), *The Church and Literature: Studies in Church History* vol. 48, Woodbridge: The Boydell Press, 2012, p. 206.
39. *Ibid.*, pp. 211–16.
40. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books*, pp. 12, 128–32, 158.
41. Discussed in Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books*, pp. 149–151. For examples of British responses to Catholicism see J. Black, *France and The Grand Tour*, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003.
42. Hampshire Record Office, COPY/605/1, f. 93–4, 30 November 1760.
43. Gibson, *Enlightenment Prelate*, p. 269. Church briefs were officially church sanctioned requests for the collection of funds for charitable causes.

44. J. D. Walsh, 'Origins of the Evangelical Revival' in G. V. Bennett & J. D. Walsh (eds) *Essays in Modern English Church History*, London: A. C. Black, 1966, p. 157. For the best history of the Moravian Church in England in the eighteenth century see C. Podmore, *The Moravian Church in England, 1728–1760*, Oxford University Press, 1998.
45. Podmore, *Moravian Church in England*, pp. 228–65.
46. Rimius seems to have lost substantial sums of money due to bad investments in London buildings and blamed evangelicals for his plight.
47. *Gentleman's Magazine*, vol. 23 (1753), p. 236.
48. H. Rimius, *A Supplement to the Candid Narrative of the Rise and Progress of the Herrnbutters ...* London: A. Linde, pp. 18, this work was dedicated to the Archbishop of York and, as Rimius pointed out, was printed by the bookseller to the Princess of Wales.
49. A. S. Fogleman, 'Jesus is Female: The Moravian Challenge in the German Communities of British North America' in *William and Mary Quarterly* vol. 60 (2003) pp. 295–332.
50. C. D. Attwood, 'Sleeping in the Arms of Christ: Sanctifying Sexuality in the Eighteenth-Century Moravian Church' in *Journal of the History of Sexuality*, vol. 8, no. 1 (July 1997), pp. 25–51. P. Vogt, 'Zinzendorf Seventeen Points of Matrimony: A Fundamental Document on the Moravian Understanding of Marriage and Sexuality' in *Journal of Moravian History*, vol. 10 (2011), pp. 39–67.
51. P. Peucker, 'In the Blue Cabinet: Moravians, Marriage, and Sex' in *Journal of Moravian History* vol. 10 (2011), pp. 7–37.
52. P. Peucker, '"Inspired by Flames of Love": Homosexuality, Mysticism, and Moravian Brothers around 1750' in *Journal of the History of Sexuality*, vol. 15, no. 1 (Jan. 2006), pp. 30–64. D. R. Miller, 'Moravian Familiarities: Queer Community in the Moravian Church in Europe and North America in the Mid-Eighteenth Century' in *Journal of Moravian History*, vol. 13, no. 1 (2013), pp. 54–75.
53. G. Whitefield, *An Expostulatory Letter, Addressed to Nicholas Lewis, Count Zinzendorff, and Lord Advocate of the Unitas Fratrum*, London: G. Keith, 1753. Whitefield's tract also revealed that the Moravians had huge debts, estimated as about £40,000 which would ruin many of their supporters.
54. Podmore, *Moravian Church in England*, pp. 274, 277.
55. G. Lavington, *The Moravians Compared and Detected*, London: J. Knapton, 1754, p. 179.
56. J. Wesley, *Queries Humbly Proposed to the Right Reverend and Right Honourable Count Zinzendorf*, London: James Robinson, 1755, pp. 27–30.
57. Podmore, *Moravian Church in England*, p. 289.
58. Clark, *Scandal*, p. 110. Perhaps the most significant impact of Moravian sexual attitudes was evident at the end of the eighteenth century when James Gillray, who had been educated in a Moravian school, poured out his prurient satires, many directed at the Church and religion. A. McConnell, S Heneage, 'Gillray,

- James (1756–1815)', *ODNB*, and William Hone the satirical printer rebelled against his father's strict piety and became an atheist before he turned to making seditious attacks on the government in the 1820s.
59. Gibson, *Enlightenment Prelate*, pp. 248–9.
 60. A. H. Cash, *John Wilkes: The Scandalous Father of Civil Liberty*, London & New Haven: Yale University Press, 2006, p. 31. On the basis of the poem, one writer has regarded Potter as a pornographer: A. Edwards, *The Rape of India: A Biography of Robert Clive and a Sexual History of the Conquest of Hindustan*, Michigan: Julian Press, 1966, p. 267 and another as an 'evil genius': P.D.G. Thomas, *John Wilkes, A Friend to Liberty*, Oxford University Press, 1996, p. 4.
 61. 'swiving' was another term for sexual intercourse.
 62. D. Money, 'The Latin Poetry of English Gentlemen' in L. Houghton & G. Manuwald (eds) *Neo-Latin Poetry in the British Isles*, London: Bristol Classic Press, 2012, p. 132.
 63. J. Sainsbury, *John Wilkes, The Lives of a Libertine*, Aldershot: Ashgate, 2006, pp. 90–2.
 64. Cruickshank, *Secret History*, pp. 391–4.
 65. I. McCalman, *Radical Underworld: Prophets, Revolutionaries and Pornographers in London, 1795–1840*, Cambridge University Press, 1988, p. 208.
 66. A. Clark, *Scandal*, p. 30.
 67. Cruickshank, *Secret History*, pp. 512–22.
 68. Outhwaite, *The Rise and Fall of the English Ecclesiastical Courts*, pp. 134–7. Francis Place, the radical politician, ascribed his atheism to viewing as a boy *Aristotle's Masterpiece* and, from that point on, he knew that he did not believe in God. *Aristotle's Masterpiece* was a classical piece of pornography, derived from Ancient Greece but revived and republished in Venice in 1503. As such, it had passed the test of time as a masturbatory aid. It perpetuated a number of myths such as a link between the length of a man's nose and that of his penis, but it also provided advice on how to assess whether a woman was a virgin and how to induce an abortion. For a man like Drax Free, such advice might have been useful. P-G. Bouce, 'Some Sexual Beliefs and Myths in Eighteenth-Century Britain' in Bouce (ed.), *Sexuality in Eighteenth Century Britain*, pp. 29–34.
 69. W. Cobbett, *A Legacy to Parsons* ... London: n. p., 1835.
 70. Gatrell, *City of Laughter*, p. 537.
 71. Clark, *Scandal*, pp. 114, 119, 123, 152, 164, 181.
 72. E. J. Evans, *The Contentious Tithe 1750–1850*, London: Routledge, Kegan and Paul, 1976.
 73. J. Wade, *The Extraordinary Black Book, An Exposition of Abuses in Church and State* London: Effingham Wilson, 1832, p. 55.
 74. See for example, N. Ravitch, *Sword and Mitre*, The Hague: Mouton, 1966.
 75. I. McCalman, *Unrespectable Radicals? Popular Politics in the Age of Reform*, Aldershot: Ashgate, 2008, pp. 86, 88.
 76. *Ibid.*, p. 88.
 77. McCalman, *Radical Underworld*, p. 206.

78. Gattrell, *City of Laughter*, pp. 541, 597.
79. Benbow, *The Crimes of the Clergy*, pp. 2, 3, 7, 77–9.
80. Ibid., pp. 6, 27–8, 111–3; Benbow commented that it was not possible for Hodgson's behaviour towards the children to be called 'seduction' 'for surely a child at her time of life could only be a passive instrument in the hands of one whom she had been taught to look with fearful obedience', p. 27.
81. Ibid., pp. 63–4, 71–4.
82. Ibid., pp. 33–5.
83. R. Probert, J. Shaffer, J. Bailey, *A Noble Affair: The Remarkable True Story of the Runaway Wife, the Bigamous Earl, and the Farmer's Daughter*, London: Takeaway Press, 2013.
84. Benbow, *Crimes of the Clergy*, pp. 65–7.
85. Ibid., pp. 7, 99–102, 141–3, 171–2.
86. C. Manchester, 'Lord Campbell's Act: England's First Obscenity Statute', in *Journal of Legal History*, vol. 9 (1988), pp. 223–41.
87. C. Manchester, 'Obscenity Law Enforcement in the Nineteenth Century', in *Journal of Legal History*, vol. 2, no. 45 (1981), pp. 45–57.
88. D. Foxton, *Libertine Literature in England, 1660–1745*, New York: University Books, 1965, pp. ix, 12–15.
89. V. Gattrell, *The First Bohemians, Life and Art in London's Golden Age*, London: Allen Lane, 2013, p. 45.
90. Ibid., pp. 52–9.
91. Manchester, 'Obscenity Law Enforcement', pp. 45–6.
92. Peakman, *Mighty Lewd Books*, pp. 41–2.
93. Manchester, 'Obscenity Law Enforcement', pp. 45–6.
94. Both cited by M Roberts, 'The Society for the Suppression of Vice and its Early Critics, 1802–1812', in *The Historical Journal*, vol. 26 (1983).
95. Manchester, 'Obscenity Law Enforcement', pp. 46–7.
96. Roberts, 'Society for the Suppression of Vice', pp. 167, 174.
97. Manchester, 'Obscenity Law Enforcement', p. 47.
98. Roberts, 'The Society for the Suppression of Vice', pp. 167, 171.
99. McCalman, *Unrespectable Radicalism*, p. 99; Manchester, 'Obscenity Law Enforcement', pp. 47–8.

Conclusion

1. For the idea of sermons as 'broadcasting' see James J. Caudle, 'Origins of British Political Broadcasting: The Sermon in the Hanoverian Revolution, 1714–1716' in W. Gibson (ed.), *Religion, Loyalty and Seditious: The Hanoverian Succession of 1714*, special issue of the *Journal of Religious History, Literature and Culture*, vol. 2, no. 2 (2016).
2. K. Francis and W. Gibson (eds), *The Oxford Handbook of the British Sermon 1689–1901*, Oxford University Press, 2012.

3. D. S. Nash, 'Reconnecting religion with social and cultural history: secularisation's failure as a master narrative', *Cultural and Social History*, vol. 1, no. 3 (2004), p. 323.
4. For similar kinds of survival of religious beliefs, see Nash, 'Reconnecting religion', p. 308.
5. Nash, *Ibid.*, 324.

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D/C.CP 1694/5 Office con Herbert Lister and Susannah Herbert als. Lister.

office c. Jonathan Railey and Susannah Railey (name is also spelled Raley on the records).

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